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1 INTRODUCTION

Our contemporary world is built on connections, relationships, flow, and the exchange of information: on networks. As the world becomes increasingly interconnected, our thought processes and creative expressions become entangled with technological tools; consequently, our stories and ways of storytelling are also becoming complex and web-like. Books do not truly end at the final page we turn; movies do not conclude with the rolling of credits; video games are not over the moment the player returns to the main menu. Instead, modern narratives often generate their expansive storytelling fields and storyworlds. Franchises such as the Marvel Cinematic Universe, the revitalized Star Wars saga, or the Wizarding World of Harry Potter exemplify highly successful transmedial story structures. Their films, novels, comics, video games, and other media entries continuously interpret each other within a shared universe, sparking new discussions and uncovering new facets as they weave an interconnected, networked reading experience. Nor are such narrative networks confined to fictional entertainment – the same principles underlie phenomena in realms like public relations and politics (consider, for example, the Cambridge Analytica scandal’s multi-platform narrative engineering), investigative journalism,¹ and even the sports industry.² The effects produced in the gaps between different media expressions – along the lines of complex interconnections between forms of storytelling – are precisely what transmedia scholars seek to understand. This dissertation responds to that quest by presenting a methodology to investigate narrative phenomena that unfold across multiple media and stakeholders in a networked fashion. In essence, it asks how narrative theory can adapt to account for stories that sprawl across media and involve active participant engagement, and what analytical frameworks can capture both the structural relationships and the experiential dynamics of such transmedia storytelling.

The research is grounded in established theoretical frameworks of narrative, building substantially on the pillars of classical structuralist narratology – especially the works of Gérard Genette and Roland Barthes – yet it also argues that these were primarily developed for linear, text-based narratives and are insufficient for capturing the multidimensional interplay of codes, interactivity, and network structures that define transmedial dynamics. Genette highlights the ambiguity of the term narrative (*récit*) by distinguishing three interpretations:³ (1) narrative as the discourse or

¹ Renira Rampazzo Gambarato and Lorena Peret Teixeira Tárca, “Transmedia Strategies in Journalism: An Analytical Model for the News Coverage of Planned Events,” *Journalism Studies* 18, no. 11 (2017): 1381–99, <https://doi.org/10.1080/1461670X.2015.1127769>.

² Ethan Tussey, “Transmedia Sports: The National Basketball Association, Emojis, and Personalized Participation,” in *The Routledge Companion to Transmedia Studies*, ed. Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato (Routledge, 2018), <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351054904>.

³ Gérard Genette, *Narrative Discourse: An Essay in Method* (Cornell University Press, 1980), 25–27.

statement – “the oral or written discourse that undertakes to tell of an event or a series of events”;⁴ (2) narrative as the story – “the succession of events, real or fictitious, that are the subjects of this discourse, and to their several relations”;⁵ and (3) narrative as the act of narration – “the event that consists of someone recounting something”.⁶ In textual narratives, such as novels and short stories, the third meaning – the act of storytelling – is often obscured by the medium itself. Of course, every one of these requires a narrating instance, a frame which defines *how* the story is being told, but the synchronous and live act can only be examined in its traces and footprints. Still, how the story being told and how this story creates its fabula (in cases, its story-world) is a much more widely discussed topic in academic studies than the latter aspect.

Transmedia narratives, however, shift this focus. In transmedial storytelling – especially in forms like alternate reality games (ARGs), where story content is disseminated across platforms in real time – the act of narration and the very way the story unfolds become central concerns. Ephemeral and synchronous storytelling gains prominence: for instance, an ARG provides an almost performative, real-time story experience that can only be fully appreciated while it is in progress. In such contemporary cases, Genette’s triad of narrative aspects can be observed in its full potential, as the “event of recounting” becomes tangible and orchestrated across multiple media channels in front of the audience. It is in this context of interactive, participatory storytelling that narratology must stretch beyond its classical confines.

Before advancing to the core of the arguments, it is essential to outline the dissertation’s organizational strategy and clarify its scope. A substantial first third of the dissertation is deliberately devoted to surveying adjacent and foundational fields of inquiry – an overview intended to bring readers who may not be familiar with transmediality up to speed on the necessary background concepts. This initial part (Chapter 2) functions as a “Survey of the Narratological Landscape,” mapping out the evolution of narrative modes and audience roles that lead up to the transmedia paradigm. It examines, in turn, the strategies and interpretive capacities associated with three archetypal modes of the recipient: the reader, the player, and the co-creator. In essence, these roles represent progressively more interactive relationships with the narrative – the reader being a decoder of signs and meanings in a relatively static text, the player being an active decision-maker who takes risks and influences the course of events (as in games), and finally the co-creator being a participant who contributes to the narrative’s (re)generation or continuation, effectively becoming a collaborative author of the story. Crucially, this dissertation does not propose these roles as a fixed, teleological taxonomy of all possible audience types; it does not aim to construct an evolutionary ladder that inexorably leads from reader to player to co-creator. Instead, the typology is used as a heuristic framework to trace how recipient attitudes and reception mechanics have shifted in response to changing media

⁴ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 25.

⁵ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 26.

⁶ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 26.

environments across different eras. The three roles are treated as fluid and overlapping positions that highlight key transitions – from the relatively contained interpretation of a single-medium literary text, through the interactive engagement of games and mixed-media works, to the participatory involvement characteristic of transmedia storytelling. By surveying literature, game studies, and media theory in this manner, the dissertation lays the groundwork for its subsequent analysis. The aim is to familiarize readers with the concepts of narrative interactivity, multimodality, and audience agency before delving into transmedia networks proper.

It must also be noted that this dissertation does not attempt to re-litigate the old “narratology vs. ludology” debate from early game studies – a discourse now widely regarded as overstated and based on a false dichotomy. In fact, scholars have pointed out that this supposed rivalry was essentially a misconstrued controversy that “never really took place”⁷ in the clear-cut way it was often described. Today’s theoretical consensus accepts that narrative and play can coexist and intertwine, rendering the narratology-versus-ludology argument a scientifically overhyped and mythologized episode in retrospect. Accordingly, the present work moves beyond that outdated debate, adopting an integrative perspective that treats interactivity (ludic structures) and narrativity as complementary lenses for understanding transmedial phenomena.

Following this broad survey of narratological and media-theoretical ground, the second half of the dissertation moves from overview to synthesis. Having inventoried the relevant theories and identified the key types of recipients and narrative structures, the study transitions “toward the narratology of transmedia networks” (as indicated by the title of Chapter 3). In practice, this means developing a comprehensive analytical framework tailored to transmedia works and demonstrating that framework through specific case studies. The approach is interdisciplinary, introduced in cumulative layers across several chapters.

First, the dissertation offers a transmedial re-interpretation of classical structuralist narratology. This is illustrated through a close analysis of *EverymanHYBRID*, an alternate reality game that serves as an ideal testing ground for Genette’s and Barthes’s narratological tools in a transmedia setting. By applying structuralist concepts (such as narrative levels, focalization, and temporal ordering) to the fragmented yet interconnected story of *EverymanHYBRID*, the study demonstrates how classical narratology can be adapted to describe and dissect transmedia narratives. Next, building on that structuralist foundation, the discussion incorporates the layer of interactivity, agency, and play – drawing on insights from game studies to address aspects that traditional narratology could not fully capture. This layer is explored primarily through a close reading of the video game *SCP: Secret Files*, which is itself part of a larger transmedia mythos (the SCP Foundation universe). Through the SCP case, the dissertation examines how player agency and game mechanics perform narrative

⁷ See: Gonzalo Frasca, “Ludology Meets Narratology: Similitude and Differences between (Video)Games and Narrative,” *Parnasso*, no. 3 (1999), <https://www.ludology.org/articles/ludology.htm>; Gonzalo Frasca, “Ludologists Love Stories, Too: Notes From a Debate That Never Took Place,” *DiGRA '03 Proceedings*, 2003, 92–99.

functions (for example, how choices or play elements influence the storytelling), thereby extending the narratological framework to account for the player as an active element in the narrative system.

Finally, the last analytical layer examines the structures of narrative networks. The dissertation proposes a methodology for visualizing and interpreting transmedia narratives as networks of interconnected story elements. This step is perhaps the most challenging, as it involves both conceptual and methodological innovation: mapping story fragments (nodes) and their interrelations (edges) across media and then analyzing the patterns and metrics that emerge. To demonstrate this approach, the work delves into the case of *The Beast* – a seminal⁸ ARG created in 2001 to promote Steven Spielberg's film *A.I. Artificial Intelligence*. *The Beast* is a highly complex transmedia narrative spread across websites, emails, phone messages, and real-world events, and is often cited as a landmark in transmedia storytelling. By treating *The Beast*'s sprawling content as a narrative network, the dissertation shows how one can identify hubs, trace the flow of narrative information, and examine structural motifs in the story's architecture, and how these network characteristics inform new interpretive strategies for understanding the narrative. In summary, the analytical progression moves from theory to practice: beginning with classical narratology, layering on the dimension of interactivity (ludology), and culminating in a network-oriented interpretive model for transmedia narratives.

The dissertation aims to contribute to the evolving field of transmedia studies both theoretically (by extending narratology) and methodologically (by providing practical tools for analysis). It must be emphasized that this endeavor is complex and interdisciplinary by necessity: it straddles literature, film, game studies, media studies, network theory, and even data visualization. Inevitably, there are important aspects that fall outside the scope of the current study. For instance, one could raise compelling ethical questions about transmedia storytelling practices – both from the player/participant's perspective and from the author's or puppet master's perspective. Transmedia narratives, especially ARGs and immersive experiences, often blur the line between fiction and reality, which can lead to ethical dilemmas regarding participant consent, emotional impact, and manipulation. (As a telling example, one postmortem account notes that players of *The Beast* became so empowered by the game's problem-solving ethos that they had to be dissuaded from attempting to hunt down the actual perpetrators of the 9/11 attacks, a real-world crusade far outside the game's intentions.⁹) Likewise, the role of the puppet master – the transmedia designer – raises questions about the responsibility owed to participants who entrust themselves to fictional scenarios. These issues of trust, safety, and moral responsibility are undeniably significant; however, they belong more to the domain of media ethics and audience studies than to narratology. A thorough examination of

⁸ Adam Martin, ed., *Alternate Reality Games White Paper* (IGDA ARG SIG, 2006), 6, <http://igda.org/arg>.

⁹ Henry Jenkins, *Convergence Culture: Where Old and New Media Collide* (NYU Press, 2006), 232.

transmedia's ethical dimensions is beyond the primary horizon of this dissertation. Acknowledging their importance, the dissertation sets these questions aside to maintain focus on its central theoretical and analytical goals.

In conclusion, this work aims to sustain and advance the scholarly conversation on how our contemporary media landscape produces narrative content, and how we – as a society, scholars, and practitioners – can consciously navigate this complex terrain of stories. The hypotheses and methods proposed here do not claim to be the final word on transmedia narratology, but rather an opening: a framework to be tested, debated, and refined as we deepen our understanding of networked narratives. The challenges are many, commensurate with the richness of the material, but the potential insights are equally rewarding. By drawing together threads from classical narrative theory, game analysis, and network science, the dissertation aims to illuminate the architectures underlying transmedia experiences and to provide tools for critically engaging with them. The pages that follow undertake this journey through theory and case studies, ultimately suggesting that by examining stories as networks, we may discover new patterns in how tales are told and experienced in the digital age.

2 SURVEY OF THE NARRATOLOGICAL LANDSCAPE

In the upcoming chapters, this dissertation focuses on the most profound relationships between the different elements of a narratological structure. It also aims to, on the one hand, explore the dynamics of three different types of interpreters: the reader, the player, and the co-creator – these roles are gradually building on each other and can represent more and more complex modes of engagement with the narrative –, and on the other hand the research examines these three modes of the recipient during their encounters with three different medial structures: the textual, the intermedial, and a specific type of intermedia: the transmedial.

2.1 THE READER

Herman and Vervaeck emphasize that the reader is not a single, monolithic entity¹⁰ but rather a term that covers a wide range of individuals with distinct pragmatic roles. However, we can still identify some general qualities that characterize the reader's position, which can be best described by investigating its dynamics in relation to the text. Historically, the reader had never been identified as a passive consumer of the narrative per se: it was always conceptualized as a role that actively engaged with the text.¹¹ As structuralist theoreticians like Barthes have argued, the text never fully determines its meaning; instead, it provides a space for the reader to "fill in" with their interpretations.¹²

¹⁰ Luc Herman and Bart Vervaeck, *Handbook of Narrative Analysis*, Frontiers of Narrative (University of Nebraska Press, 2005), 20–22.

¹¹ David Herman et al., eds., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory* (Routledge, 2005), 482–83.

¹² Frank Whitehead, "Roland Barthes's Narratology," *The Cambridge Quarterly* 21, no. 1 (1992): 46–47, 64, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/42971737>.

Umberto Eco, in *The Role of the Reader*, goes one step further when he theorizes about the reader's interactions with the text and argues that even though the recipient needs to cooperate with the text in this semiotic communication, there are also different degrees of cooperation that a message would require. This degree describes the "openness" or "closedness" of a work. On the one hand, a more closed text with a strongly determined message needs an "obedient" reader – Eco argues – while, on the other hand, these works are also more vulnerable to "pragmatic accidents" or misunderstandings.¹³ Conversely, more "open" texts, such as many contemporary experimental or postmodern narratives, intentionally leave gaps and ambiguities, encouraging the reader to participate in the ongoing process of meaning-making actively.¹⁴

Wolfgang Iser (among others) explored the topic of these gaps, or the distance between the literary work and the text, further emphasizing the dynamic nature of the reader and arguing that the recipient is the one who "sets the work in motion" and "causes the literary work to unfold its inherently dynamic character." Underpinning his statements with works of Laurence Sterne and the observations of Virginia Woolf while rooting his theories in Roman Ingarden's phenomenology, Iser argues that the text can only become an artistic or literary work if the reader reveals its potential by interacting with the sentences that constitute it.¹⁵

In the realm of traditional narratology, structuralists, semioticians, and even reader-response theorists argue with some nuanced differences that while it is impossible to craft theories for the material reader that has the text in their hands, it is still possible to conceive an "implied" or "ideal" reader that is constructed through the "marks" left by the author in the text,¹⁶ thus birthing a different kind of reader for the researcher to observe – one that is brought into the world by the author, or in most cases, by the text itself.

Roland Barthes even employs a similar nomenclature in his famous declaration, "the birth of the reader must be at the cost of the death of the Author,"¹⁷ and with the author's death, the text inherits ultimate authority. This ultimate authority is what creates its ideal reader.

In Umberto Eco's case, this ideal entity is called the "Model Reader" – an entity foreseen by the author, whose purpose is to assemble the textual code to be compatible with the recipient of this message. Eco explains that "every type of text explicitly selects a very general model of the possible reader through the choice of a specific linguistic code, a certain literary style, and specific specialization indices," such as the

¹³ Umberto Eco, *The Role of the Reader: Explorations in the Semiotics of Texts* (Indiana University Press, 1979), 3–7.

¹⁴ Umberto Eco, *The Open Work* (Harvard University Press, 1989), 3–4.

¹⁵ Wolfgang Iser, "The Reading Process: A Phenomenological Approach," *New Literary History* 3, no. 2 (1972): 279–82, <https://doi.org/10.2307/468316>.

¹⁶ A great overview of these theoretical constructs can be read in: W. Daniel Wilson, "Readers in Texts," *PMLA/Publications of the Modern Language Association of America* 96, no. 5 (1981): 848–63, <https://doi.org/10.2307/462128>.

¹⁷ Roland Barthes, *Image, Music, Text*, trans. Stephen Heath (Fontana Press, 1987), 142–48.

use of technical jargon only understood by those with specialized knowledge.¹⁸ However, in other cases, these call-outs for the Model Reader are more explicit. For example, they can be constructed through typographical and thematic choices or by directly addressing this Model Reader.

The works that aim to appeal to a wide range of readers, intentionally making the text as straightforward and uncomplicated as possible, to "pull the reader along a predetermined path" of interpretation and "carefully displaying their effects to arouse pity or fear at the due place and at the right moment", ironically become closed texts in their very openness.¹⁹ These texts are closed off to diverse interpretations and resistant to "rewriting" – referring here, of course, to Barthes's concept of the "readerly text".²⁰ In other words, these texts that strive for accessibility and mass appeal end up being more restrictive in the range of possible meanings they allow, as they attempt to guide the reader down a specific interpretive path rather than leaving space for more open-ended engagement with the text.

On the other hand, the "open" texts are not the complete opposite of the closed texts. As Eco argues, an "open" text does not mean it has no limits - it simply means it has less determined paths and more possible trajectories of meaning-making, enabling it to be "writerly texts",²¹ as Barthes would describe them.²² Eco illustrates these works as mazes, but these mazes have finite "spatial" properties that define the ideal navigator: the "open" works are closing off, finalizing a definition for the "Model Reader".

Wolfgang Iser "discusses in his work three types of reader model - historical, linguistic and psychological - before introducing his own concept of the implied reader."²³ Regarding this first category, he looks at Hans Robert Jauss' approach, which considers a reception history to analyze the contemporary reader. According to Iser, this approach reveals a theory that is vulnerable to the affective fallacy, focusing less on the structures of texts and more on the "results" of texts, i.e., the "judgments of readers" rather than the structure of effects.²⁴ Moreover, as empirical as this approach strives to be, with the lack of documentation on contemporary responses to literary works, the reader still needs to infer their interpretation from the actual text.

The second category, the linguistic type of approach, as Iser argues, can be understood through Michael Riffaterre's concept of the "superreader" (translated from the

¹⁸ Eco, *The Role of the Reader*, 7–8.

¹⁹ Eco, *The Open Work*.

²⁰ Roland Barthes, *S/Z*, trans. Richard Miller (Hill and Wang, 1974), 3–4.

²¹ More on this in later chapters.

²² Barthes, *S/Z*, 4–5; Peggy Rosenthal, "Deciphering S/Z," *College English* 37, no. 2 (1975): 134–35, <https://doi.org/10.2307/375059>.

²³ Ben De Bruyn, *Wolfgang Iser: A Companion*, *Companions to Contemporary German Culture* (De Gruyter, 2012), 104.

²⁴ Wolfgang Iser, *The Act of Reading: A Theory of Aesthetic Response* (Johns Hopkins University Press, 1978), 26–27.

French original term, *architecteur*, also known as arch-reader or *archi-reader*).²⁵ This hypothetical construct combines the various actual readers' attempts, thus identifying the work's stylistically significant passages. Again, this concept also aims to create a more objective approach, as Riffaterre's theory focuses on a text's linguistic structure. However, according to Iser, this does not extend to the readers' approaches from different periods, who will notice different style aspects.²⁶

The third type of reader model that Iser discusses – and wants to surpass – is the psychological one. His prime example is Norman Holland's psychoanalytical approach, which seeks to present a theory of literary works as being reduced to a "material to demonstrate the functioning or nonfunctioning of our psychological dispositions", thus arguing that the one's reading of the text is inevitably determined by their private concerns – neglecting the literary quality of the communication and its moments of unfamiliarity, therefore rendering these approaches as unimportant to Iser.

As De Bruyn explains, Iser critiques these theories because they lack "proper documentation" to ground the historical approach in empirical evidence, and they may not account for changes in reader habits over time. Iser appears disillusioned with the search for the "real reader" and instead seeks to define the "implied reader" as an *ideal* construct within his work.²⁷ This often-misunderstood concept is frequently connected to Wayne Booth's construct of the "implied author," which was coined in *The Rhetoric of Fiction*. However, these two terms cannot be regarded as one-to-one parallels, but rather as different aspects of literary communication. The distinction lies in the definition of Iser's term: the implied reader is a "transcendental model which makes it possible for the structured effects of literary texts to be described. It denotes the role of the reader, which is definable in terms of textual structure *and structured acts*".²⁸ This reflects the fact that the implied reader is not just how the literary work's rhetoric mirrors the image of the reader as Booth's "implied author" does with the writer, but rather Iser's term refers to a concept that both emerging from these aforementioned two factors of structure *and* act. So, this does not refer to "an actual reader, to a narratee or a model reader, but to a conceptual model that not only captures the textual but also the mental preconditions of the reading process."²⁹

Iser's reader concept is brought to life with this duality in mind: the implied reader (who is susceptible to the analytical gaze) is being formed by (1) the text, (2) its rhetoric (Booth's work influences this aspect), and (3) the "reader's expectations" or the human mind that implies a "certain way of reading" too (synthesizing Roman

²⁵ Michael Riffaterre, *Essais de stylistique structurale*, Nouvelle bibliothèque scientifique (Flammarion, 1971); David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 482.

²⁶ De Bruyn, *Wolfgang Iser*, 105.

²⁷ De Bruyn, *Wolfgang Iser*, 105–6.

²⁸ Iser, *The Act of Reading* (1978), 107.

²⁹ De Bruyn, *Wolfgang Iser*, 106.

Ingarden's approaches) which is, however, can be described by general schema or stock operations.³⁰

Taking a step backward and diving a bit deeper into the structuralist way of thinking, let us take a closer look at how, according to Barthes, this action radius of the reader can be realized by the recipient of the narrative, depending only on the structure of the text.

In his seminal work, *S/Z*, Roland Barthes analyzed the structure of Balzac's short story *Sarrasine* and concluded that there are two major types of narrative texts, based on their processes when encountering a recipient: the readerly and the writerly. The readerly text presents the reader with a more stable, closed, and determined meaning: the text "tells" the reader what the meaning is, and the reader's task is to absorb this meaning. Barthes refers to these texts as classic texts, and this textual attitude reflects one type of relationship between the reader and the text induced by the latter. The main characteristics of the readerly text are that it has a linear structure with a clear exposition, rising action, climax, and resolution, and it has a unified, coherent, and relatively closed meaning.³¹ Barthes even goes so far as to state that readerly texts "make the reader impotent" because they leave no room for the reader's interpretations. He also talks about the musical score as an analogy – the reader of a readerly text is like the performer of a musical composition, who must faithfully reproduce the composer's intentions.³²

In contrast, the writerly text is fundamentally different in that it does not simply "tell" the reader what the meaning is but instead provides an open-ended and interactive space where the reader can actively participate in the construction of meaning, bringing their own subjective associations, perspectives, and creative capacities into play. When readers encounter a writerly text, they are not simply absorbing a predetermined message but actively deciphering, interrogating, and reconstructing it. This train of thought guides theoreticians towards a more interactive understanding of the relationship between the reader and the text.³³ It even gives rise to thoughts that directly connect the "actions" of the reader to those of the player. However, this is a practical fallacy that we will address in a later chapter that investigates the theories of cybertexts.³⁴

Staying with *S/Z*, Barthes explains how the reader affects the text through their creative engagement with the work, constantly reinterpreting and reshaping the narrative as they read.³⁵ According to Barthes, this process is determined by the five "codes" he identifies in *Sarrasine*'s text: the hermeneutic code, the semic code, the symbolic

³⁰ De Bruyn, *Wolfgang Iser*, 107.

³¹ Barthes, *S/Z*, 4–7.

³² Barthes, *S/Z*, 28–29.

³³ Barthes, *S/Z*, 4–6.

³⁴ Espen J. Aarseth, *Cybertext: Perspectives on Ergodic Literature* (Johns Hopkins University Press, 1997), 3–5, <https://doi.org/10.56021/9780801855788>.

³⁵ Barthes, *S/Z*, 4–6; Rosenthal, "Deciphering *S/Z*," 134–37.

code, the proairetic code, and the cultural code. Let us examine these individually without the lengthy retelling of Barthes' text.

The hermeneutic code refers to the various narrative puzzles, mysteries, and enigmas the text presents, which the reader attempts to decipher, unravel, and resolve through active engagement with the work. The semic code refers to the connotative meanings and associative fields that words can evoke in the reader's mind, beyond their denotative dictionary definitions. The symbolic code points to the deeper structural and conceptual patterns the reader can discern in the text, such as binary oppositions, paradoxes, and underlying philosophical or ideological frameworks that operate beneath the narrative's surface. The proairetic code deals with the reader's anticipation and connection of the story's sequence of actions and events into a coherent plot. Finally, the cultural code is concerned with how the text is situated within broader social, historical, and cultural contexts, upon which the reader must draw to fully comprehend its meaning. This code also addresses the intertextual relationship between the text and other texts, discourses, and cultural artifacts that the reader must be familiar with to grasp the work's significance successfully.

This could mean that Barthes was thinking about the text as a network of code that the reader must decipher, and the possible extent of this code-breaking activity defines how readerly or writerly a specific text is. As this will be apparent, this epistemological structure can already be seen as a precursor to a media-conscious analytical approach to transmedia narrative structures.

However, stepping beyond his structure and delving deeper into the text's developing meaning, we can discern another threshold inside the semiotic realm – the threshold between the plot and the story as narratologists, first proposed by Russian formalists, have long distinguished between the “plot” (syuzhet or discourse) and the “story” (fabula)³⁶ – the plot referring to the order in which events are presented in the narrative text, the story as it is told, “along with all its deviations, digressions, flashbacks, and the whole of the verbal devices”.³⁷ The story or fabula, however, refers to the underlying chronological sequence of events that constitute the narrative, irrespective of how they are arranged in the text. This is “the basic story stuff, the logic of actions or the syntax of characters”.³⁸

From this perspective, when the reader initiates the literary interaction, they decode the surface-level narrative puzzle mechanisms of the plot and reconstruct the story's deeper, emotive, and conceptual underpinnings, thus revealing the sprawling narrative world. The primary plot elements can be regarded as what emerges from the surface of the text. At the same time, the story is formulated in the mind or the interpretative work of the reader in the form of a series of “possible fabula”.³⁹

³⁶ David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 435–37, 566–67.

³⁷ Eco, *The Role of the Reader*, 27.

³⁸ Eco, *The Role of the Reader*, 27.

³⁹ Eco, *The Role of the Reader*, 28.

This process of navigating between the plot and the story, and the reader's ability to do so, is a key element in the interactive dynamic between the reader and the text. This distinction between plot and story has its roots in the theories of Russian formalists Vladimir Propp and Viktor Shklovsky. In the early 20th century, these scholars were key developers of a method anticipating structuralist narratology. This analytical perspective dissected stories, breaking them down into their smallest increments and attempting to identify their constitutive, essential parts. Although Propp's and Shklovsky's work is quite well-known in academic circles, for the sake of continuing the argument, it is worth pointing out that – while a lot of sources cite wrongly⁴⁰ – according to Thomka's research,⁴¹ Tomashevsky⁴² was the first who introduced the terms *fabula* and *syuzhet* as we became to know it in his poetical work while heavily relying on his predecessor, Veselovsky,⁴³ regarding the basis of his terminology, thus rendering these concepts even older than it is usually accounted for.

This approach of storytelling gained traction later on in the circles of structuralists, it especially got the attention of French structuralist Gérard Genette⁴⁴ who further expanded on the implication of this duality, along the lines of temporality, cementing an analytical point of view in narratology that can also be regarded as quite algorithmic and even a process that is a few steps closer to natural sciences, thus it may give the impression of a more objective toolkit in contrast to rhetorical investigations or hermeneutics for example.

Returning to the role of the reader, after a brief exploration of the classical narratological theories on how the text is structured, literary theorists were also concerned with the function, the extent, and the methods of interpretation. In the 1960s and 1970s, a collection of critical approaches emerged, known as reader-response theories, shifting the focus of analysis away from the text itself and toward the active participation of the reader in the construction of meaning.⁴⁵ Although the dissertation does not aim to provide a comprehensive survey of this specific field of literary theory, examining the most essential contributors can productively underpin this research's approach.

Most of the works in the field of reader-response theory point toward the understanding that the reader is a part of a communicational transaction between the text and them, so the text does not or cannot contain a/the meaning inherently. The

⁴⁰ E.g. Andrew L. LaFave and Elizabeth A. Mainz, "Engaging with the *Syuzhet*: A New Methodological Approach to Analyzing and Visualizing Internet Discourse," *Ethnography* 19, no. 2 (2018): 183–203, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1466138117725339>.

⁴¹ Thomka Beáta, "Prózapoeitika vagy narratológia?," *Híd*, no. 11 (1981): 1363–64.

⁴² Thomka cited the original text (without English translation): Boris Viktorovič Tomaševskij, *Теория литературы [poëtika]: Б. Томашевский* (Государственное издательство, 1925).

⁴³ Thomka cited the original text (without English translation): Александр Николаевич Веселовский., *Поэтика. Т. 2, вып. 1, Поэтика сюжетов (1897-1906)* (Типография Императорской академии наук, 1913).

⁴⁴ Especially in: Genette, *Narrative Discourse*; Gérard Genette, *Narrative Discourse Revisited* (Cornell University Press, 1988).

⁴⁵ David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 484–85.

interpretation and narrative information are thus formulated following an interaction, a mental process that directly anticipates a cognitive methodology for narratology.

One of the first contributors to the field of reader-response theory, Louise Rosenblatt, laid the groundwork for many reader-response principles with her transactional theory of reading. In her work, Rosenblatt argued that literary works come into being through a transaction between the reader and the text, each equally indispensable to the production of meaning.⁴⁶ She wrote that “a poem is what the reader lives through under the guidance of the text and experiences as relevant to the text,”⁴⁷ emphasizing that the reader’s active involvement – “under the guidance”⁴⁸ of the textual cues – is what transforms print on the page into literary experience.

Importantly, Rosenblatt does not abandon the authority of the text; instead, she understands reading as an event in which textual structure and personal response continually impact one another. Her distinction between “efferent” and “aesthetic” reading underscores this balance.⁴⁹ Taking on an efferent attitude, the reader focuses on extracting information or utilitarian content from the text (as one might read a manual or news article). In an aesthetic stance, by contrast, the reader attends to the lived-through experience of the text – the emotions, images, and associations that arise in the act of reading. Rosenblatt argues that only the aesthetic mode realizes the complete literary transaction, as the reader allows the text to act as a stimulus⁵⁰ to thought and feeling. In this transactional exchange, the text acts as a blueprint that guides the reader’s responses,⁵¹ but the meaning (“the poem”) emerges through the reader’s experiential engagement with that blueprint. Rosenblatt’s perspective thus recognizes reading as a two-way, active process, even as it stresses the diverse individuality of readers’ lived experiences with the text.

Unlike the New Critics’ theoretical perspective, which views meaning as being determined by the text,⁵² the reader-response theory elevates the reader to at least the level of the text. The understanding derived from the text has personal meaning for the reader because it results from the reader’s previous literary and life experiences interacting with the current lived-through experience of the text. Stanley Fish argues that meaning is not inherent in the text but is constructed by the reader⁵³ – or more specifically, the literary understanding emerges from the reader’s encounters with the textual units and the constant establishment and dismissal of interpretations.⁵⁴

⁴⁶ Louise M. Rosenblatt, *The Reader, the Text, the Poem: The Transactional Theory of the Literary Work*, Paperback ed (Southern Illinois University Press, 1994), 14–15.

⁴⁷ Louise M. Rosenblatt, “Towards a Transactional Theory of Reading,” *Journal of Reading Behavior* 1, no. 1 (1969): 38, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10862969609546838>.

⁴⁸ Rosenblatt, “Towards a Transactional Theory of Reading,” 38.

⁴⁹ Rosenblatt, *The Reader, the Text, the Poem*, 89.

⁵⁰ Rosenblatt, *The Reader, the Text, the Poem*, 11.

⁵¹ Rosenblatt, *The Reader, the Text, the Poem*, 88.

⁵² David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 523–24.

⁵³ Stanley Fish, *Is There a Text in This Class? The Authority of Interpretive Communities* (Harvard University Press, 2003), 42–52.

⁵⁴ David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 485.

Fish examined how a text guides the reader's experience moment by moment, but he later shifted his focus to the communal dimension of interpretation. Fish introduced the notion of interpretive communities,⁵⁵ proposing that readers do not interpret in isolation but as members of communities that "share interpretive strategies [...] and therefore determine the shape of what is read [...]"⁵⁶ Because those communal interpretive conventions ultimately shape one's reading (or, as Fish curiously argues: one's strategy for *writing* texts), Fish contends that what a text means is contingent upon how one is conditioned by the interpretive community to which one belongs. In this view, no interpretation can claim absolute objectivity; instead, the validity of an interpretation depends on the institutional norms and shared understandings of the relevant community.⁵⁷ Fish himself critiqued Wolfgang Iser on these grounds, as according to him, Iser's model still postulates a controlling textual structure (the "implied reader"). Fish suggested that Iser had not entirely escaped the grip of textual determinacy. In one of his essays, Fish argues that Iser's theory, by leaving the text with final authority over interpretation, ultimately downplays the reader's role and reinstates some form of objectivism that genuine reader-oriented criticism seeks to overcome.⁵⁸

Still, Iser's work was one of the most influential in the field of reader-response theory. The key argument, as Fish referred to it as well, was that literature and literary works do not conceal a single meaning that needs to be brought to light through "excavatory" practices, such as the methods of traditional hermeneutics. The text and the actual material reader's reality are demarcated from each other in the sense that neither is accessible to the other: the "true meaning" or the actual world of fiction is never to be accessed from the real world, and at the same time, literary fiction cannot converse directly with our material reality vice versa.

According to Iser – and this was the primary concern of Stanley Fish – literary signals are instructions for the production of the signified:⁵⁹ prescriptions of communication instead of world-constituting elements of a system. Communication and dynamic conversation are the focus of his analyses, and works of fiction become simulations rather than imitations,⁶⁰ orienting the recipient's attention and cognition towards the gaps between the reader and the text, reflecting on the reading process instead of a secluded, secret, decipherable meaning. Ultimately, in a sense, *meaning* and *interpretation* become a never-ending interaction between text and its reader; however, the output will materialize in the mind of the recipient. And being a cognitive (and a

⁵⁵ Fish, *Is There a Text in This Class?*, 161.

⁵⁶ Fish, *Is There a Text in This Class?*, 171.

⁵⁷ Fish, *Is There a Text in This Class?*, 43.

⁵⁸ Stanley Fish, "Why No One's Afraid of Wolfgang Iser," *Diacritics* 11, no. 1 (1981): 3–4.

⁵⁹ Wolfgang Iser, *The Act of Reading: A Theory of Aesthetic Response*. (Johns Hopkins University Press, 1997), 65.

⁶⁰ Gábor Tamás Molnár, "Textuality and Control: The Vocabulary of Cybernetics in Wolfgang Iser's Theories of Interpretation," in *Edition Kulturwissenschaft*, ed. Hajnalka Halász and Csongor Lörincz (transcript Verlag, 2019), 201:442, <https://doi.org/10.14361/9783839447451-017>.

cybernetic⁶¹) process, the literary text cannot claim ultimate authority in this, as Iser also claims that as the mental image of fiction forms in the reader's consciousness, this slides into ideation. This process is fed by knowledge, memory, experience, desire, and other extratextual sources as well.⁶² Retaining Fish's insistence on situated reading, this dissertation shifts its attention from his broader, more (psycho)sociological program centered on interpretive communities and focuses instead on textual cues, systemic structures of storytelling, and medium-specific affordances. On this register, Iser remains indispensable.

Iser's phenomenological approach to reading is closely aligned with that of Hans Robert Jauss, whose reception theory foregrounds the historical dimension of reader responses. Jauss introduced the notion of a "horizon of expectations" (Erwartungshorizont) – the ensemble of cultural norms, assumptions, and interpretive strategies that an audience brings to a work.⁶³ In Jauss's view, literature is a dialogic process:⁶⁴ a literary work's meaning and aesthetic impact are continually formed and re-formed through the dialogue between text and successive generations of readers.⁶⁵ Rather than a static artifact that offers the same view to each reader in each period, a work's significance unfolds over time as readers with differing horizons of expectation encounter it. By reconstructing past horizons and noting shifts in reception, Jauss argues that the meaning of literature emerges from the dialectic of production and reception, in which readers' evolving interpretations are fundamental to literary history.

This dissertation presents a different approach that shifts the focus away from the reading process and its mental procedures. Instead, the methods and paths explored here wind around the medium itself, the mediality, and the underlying code of the narrative information. By centering the analysis on the properties and mechanics of the narrative medium, this research offers a distinct perspective that moves away from the emphasis on the reader's interactive engagement and cognitive operations. The aim is to uncover new insights by examining the materiality and structural elements that shape the transmission and experience of contemporary complex narrative content across various mediums. Classical narratological texts and theoreticians have all argued that reading and encounters with artworks are always interactive and, in a way, transcendent and transgressive activities. However, these approaches rarely account for the text's materiality and the medium's properties that this research is invested in until new mediums become mature enough to present their distinct narratological toolkit and methodologies.

In the 1980s, a new strand of narratological thinking emerged, interested not only in the textual qualities of narratives but also in the narrative medium's specific material

⁶¹ Molnár, "Textuality and Control," 445–46.

⁶² Wolfgang Iser, *The Fictive and the Imaginary: Charting Literary Anthropology* (The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1993), 196–97.

⁶³ Hans Robert Jauss, "Literary History as a Challenge to Literary Theory," trans. Elizabeth Benzinger, *New Literary History* 2, no. 1 (1970): 11–14, <https://doi.org/10.2307/468585>.

⁶⁴ Hans Robert Jauss, *Question and Answer: Forms of Dialogic Understanding*, trans. Michael Hays (University of Minnesota Press, 1989), 118–21, <https://doi.org/10.2307/431492>.

⁶⁵ Jauss, "Literary History as a Challenge to Literary Theory," 8–9.

and mediatic properties. For example, structuralist film theorists, such as Seymour Chatman and David Bordwell (both influenced by Russian formalists and French structuralists), present an analytical framework, particularly for the film medium. Examining the inner processes of this particular medium, they argue that cinema conveys its narrative information through different mechanics: the narrative gaps⁶⁶ and the manipulation of spatiotemporal norms⁶⁷ become essential building blocks of the filmic montage, the immediacy, and synchronicity of the use of visual and auditory channels,⁶⁸ and how cinema represents existents with “immediate synthesis”, and how the objects possess an “intense autonomy”⁶⁹ on screen is all inherently coded into the visual montage of the film. These theories introduce how narratological methods can be developed with a media-conscious attitude.

Here is the point where this specific research comes into play: the dissertation aims to showcase some of the most prominent theoretical arguments that contain the potential for a shift towards a transmedial perspective. Espen Aarseth began his seminal text by describing his struggle to explain his points and arguments properly to an audience of literary theorists.⁷⁰ He struggled to highlight the gaping difference between ergodic and non-ergodic literature, between traditional texts and what he called “cybertexts.”

This difference can be potently summarized if we look at the types of reader interactions required by the two different categories of works. Non-ergodic - or traditional literature requires the reader to traverse the text linearly,⁷¹ while cybertexts introduce a whole new layer of active engagement, where the reader has to invest a non-trivial effort to navigate the text and reveal the narrative structure. The reader of the ergodic text makes decisions during the reading process and has a hand in shaping the narrative unfolding; they become something of a participant, rather than settling only to be powerless receivers of the story.⁷² They make choices and traverse paths, exploring literal and figurative forks along the road of the narrative.

Literary critics and theorists have always argued – as Aarseth explains⁷³ – that the reader is actively constructing meaning in any text (regardless of its ergodic nature) and that there can be no such thing as a truly passive reader. Readers make choices

⁶⁶ Seymour Benjamin Chatman, *Story and Discourse: Narrative Structure in Fiction and Film* (Cornell University Press, 2000), 82–84, 104–7; David Bordwell, *Narration in the Fiction Film* (University of Wisconsin Press, 2007), 243–49.

⁶⁷ Chatman, *Story and Discourse*, 25–27, 79–84; Bordwell, *Narration in the Fiction Film*, 243–49.

⁶⁸ Chatman, *Story and Discourse*, 158–61.

⁶⁹ Chatman, *Story and Discourse*, 220–21.

⁷⁰ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 2.

⁷¹ This linearity can be and always is contested within the academic circles of literary theory. It is important to acknowledge that in an epistemological sense, any kind of literature behave in a non-linear fashion. However, it might need to be emphasized, that the non-ergodicity is coming from the non-linearity of the *reading process* itself, the traversal of the recipient through the narrative landscape.

⁷² Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 3–4.

⁷³ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 2.

in interpretation and fill in gaps, thus creating a non-determined experience. They are always experiencing the text in a linear form, so non-linearity is an illusion.

However, here comes the key distinction between Aarseth's and the cited theorists' and critics' position: unlike the theorists who tended to focus on the subject, on the *what*, he focused on the media, "what was being read *from*".⁷⁴ This is a total departure from the reader's imaginary agency described by the reader-response theory, and it introduces the reader of a cybertext. For whom the inaccessibility of information is not a hermeneutical, linguistic, or interpretative problem but an actual "absence of possibility - an aporia".⁷⁵

So, to return to the initial distinction between plot and story, or between fabula and syuzhet, we can say that with traditional, non-ergodic texts, the reader is tasked with reconstructing the chronological story, however, remains powerless, argues Aarseth, just like a spectator at a sports game: one can "speculate, conjecture, extrapolate, even shout abuse, but he is not a player. Like a passenger on a train, [...] [the reader can] release the emergency brake and step off, but he is not free to move the tracks into a different direction."⁷⁶ In this train of thought, the reader becomes a voyeur, able to explore an unfolding event in a safe and controlled environment. On the other hand, Aarseth continues that the cybertext reader is unsafe and vulnerable to failure and rejection. They are gamblers, players, and explorers.

The advent of new media and the rise of intermedial practices have elevated the complexity of the reader's role. The term "intermedia" was coined by artist and theoretician Dick Higgins in 1966⁷⁷ (and he even reaches back to Samuel Taylor Coleridge as the originator of this artistic concept). In his work, Higgins argued that from an artistic perspective, the only way to develop answers to the questions of contemporary Western culture and democratic politics was through "intermedia", as medium-specific art forms were signs of authoritarian societies. Some art critics opposed these views because the mixing of media and the emerging "relatively non-'specific' technologies"⁷⁸ are signs of the "capitulation of art to capitalist spectacle culture."⁷⁹ Nevertheless, this discussion of the political field around intermediality would lead us down another path, and we only need to examine this opposition or debate to assess that intermedia was rooted in artistic interactions from the outset. For us, it would be more fruitful to follow its development into a media theoretical concept.

Werner Wolf traces the origin of the term "intermediality" to the 1983 publication of German scholar Aage Hansen-Löve,⁸⁰ in which it was defined as the relations

⁷⁴ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 3.

⁷⁵ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 3.

⁷⁶ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 4.

⁷⁷ Dick Higgins, "Intermedia," *The Something Else Newsletter* 1, no. 1 (1966).

⁷⁸ Jens Schröter, "The Politics of Intermediality," *Film and Media Studies* 2 (2010): 109.

⁷⁹ Schröter, "The Politics of Intermediality," 112.

⁸⁰ Wolf Schmid and Wolf-Dieter Stempel, eds., *Dialog der Texte. Hamburger Kolloquium zur Intertextualität* (Gesellschaft zur Förderung slawistischer Studien, 1983).

between literature, the visual arts, and music in Russian symbolism. From this, it began to gain international recognition within the academic community.⁸¹

In analogy to intertextuality, which describes the interplay between literature and the visual arts, intertextuality in its narrower sense refers to a monomedial process (the interplay between texts and textual mediums). In contrast, intermediality has become a term that applies to transgressive movements between media. Unlike “inter-art” and interart studies, “intermediality designates a broader aesthetic and technological field of investigation”.⁸² This would mean that the field of intermediality explores other forms of cultural content beyond what could be called conventional arts (music, literature, fine art), such as performance art, digital poetry, video games, or even non-aesthetic medialities like mass media content.⁸³ However, Jørgen Bruhn in his previously cited book argues, that even the term itself can conjure some misunderstanding around its subject, as the “inter-” suffix rightly suggests, reflects on the field of exploration as a mix between autonomous medialities and modalities, but, he refers to another kind of “mixedness” as his approach would like to avoid a theoretical clash with the concept of heteroglossia⁸⁴ – reflecting on Mitchell’s work⁸⁵ that ultimately every media is mixed media, even literary texts. Bruhn (and even this research) acknowledges that in this sense, there’s no such thing as monomediality (or monomodality), where there is no mixture in the information’s medial coding - such as sensory, perceptual, or semiotic, etc. Mitchell even explains: “[T]he attempt to grasp the unitary, homogeneous essences of painting, photography, sculpture, poetry, etc., is the real aberration.” The purity of media “is both impossible and utopian”.⁸⁶ Moreover, some would even say that a singular medium can only be understood in relation to others,⁸⁷ and they could even be born from each other as they re-mediate the techniques and forms of different mediums.⁸⁸

In the 1990s, K. Ludwig Pfeiffer explored a closely related phenomenon between the mediums. In his work,⁸⁹ he focuses on the process of monomedialization, which can also be conceptualized as a form of cannibalization, as demonstrated through notable examples such as *Joseph Andrews*, *The Bride of Lammermoor*, and *The Maltese Falcon*. The first presented the self-therapy of literature through its painting-like structures and processes, using the novel’s medium to adopt the techniques

⁸¹ David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 252–56.

⁸² Jørgen Bruhn, *The Intermediality of Narrative Literature: Medialities Matter*, Palgrave Pivot (Palgrave Macmillan, 2016), 14.

⁸³ Bruhn, *The Intermediality of Narrative Literature*, 14.

⁸⁴ Mikhail Bakhtin, *The Dialogic Imagination: Four Essays*, trans. Michael Holquist (University of Texas Press, 1981), 41–84.

⁸⁵ W. J. T. Mitchell, “There Are No Visual Media,” *Journal of Visual Culture* 4, no. 2 (2005): 257–66, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1470412905054673>.

⁸⁶ W. J. T. Mitchell, *Picture Theory: Essays on Verbal and Visual Representation* (University of Chicago Press, 1994), 96.

⁸⁷ Kricsfalusi Beatrix et al., eds., *Média- és kultúratudomány: kézikönyv* (Ráció Kiadó, 2018), 283.

⁸⁸ J. David Bolter and Richard A. Grusin, *Remediation: Understanding New Media* (MIT Press, 1999), 47–50.

⁸⁹ K. Ludwig Pfeiffer, *The Protoliterary: Steps Toward an Anthropology of Culture* (Stanford University Press, 2002).

specifically of caricatura, as it creates the experience of observing “striking visual forms, the monstrous, the inhuman aspects of human beings [...]”⁹⁰

The second example illustrates how literature can present operatic tendencies and mechanics: schematic characters, melodramatic situations, immediacy of dialogues, and the musicality of the language all add up to the point that the novel presents how it could “re-present” the medium of opera within the language of its own medium.⁹¹

Finally, Dashiell Hammett’s hard-boiled fiction shows vivid signs of a different kind of medial cannibalization. Pfeiffer points out that, unlike his previous examples, it does not “veer toward painting because the visual impressions of painting would be too static for the rapid change of situations. Nor can it appeal to the seeming expressiveness of music. The implied medium here is film.”⁹² Pfeiffer continues to explain that these effects are to be taken “abstractly, as it were, as a potential of dynamic, suggestive, and yet inconclusive images.”⁹³ During my previous research,⁹⁴ I also managed to shed some light on techniques and processes of how the specific material medium of the book can cannibalize cinema – what I observed, and what might be helpful to emphasize, is that the code of literature can successfully relocate the filmic representation from the space of the imaginary to the symbolic space.⁹⁵ To summarize, Iser’s and Pfeiffer’s arguments all point towards literature being able to mix the medialities in itself; however, that would also mean that other mediums can re-present the mechanics and processes of different media systems.

Minding this mixedness is one of the key elements of intermediality, and from this comes an understanding and an array of analytical tools to describe the intermedial presence and function of specific works. But, in the meantime, it needs to be emphasized that this acknowledgment means that all medialities are the same or they are “mixed in the same way. On the contrary, there are unlimited numbers of different medialities” which can be categorized into “relatively stable groups for pragmatic reasons, like, for instance, different literary genres [...]”⁹⁶

These mixing procedures are divided in Bruhn’s work into two different groups: transformations (or transmutations – sic!⁹⁷) and combinations. The former can be illustrated with adaptations and “medial translations” – like novels adapted into movies or video games that are being adapted into visual novels. During this method, some elements of the source material are transported into the target material’s medial realm. However, some other elements will always be left out or altered in the new media product, as the adaptation process inevitably involves transforming the

⁹⁰ Pfeiffer, *The Protoliterary*, 24.

⁹¹ Pfeiffer, *The Protoliterary*, 33–35.

⁹² Pfeiffer, *The Protoliterary*, 37.

⁹³ Pfeiffer, *The Protoliterary*, 37.

⁹⁴ More on this question in Richárd Fejes, “Materiality and the Struggle Against the Screen: Survival of the Printed Literature,” in *The Book Phenomenon in Cultural Space : A könyvjelenség a kulturális térben* (Tartu, Budapest, 2019).

⁹⁵ Richárd Fejes, “A könyvmédium határai a kortárs mediális kultúrában” (master’s thesis, ELTE, 2018), 58.

⁹⁶ Bruhn, *The Intermediality of Narrative Literature*, 26.

⁹⁷ Bruhn, *The Intermediality of Narrative Literature*, 26.

original work to fit the constraints and affordances of the new medium. The transformation may involve changes in narrative structure, visual style, character representation, and other aspects, resulting in a distinct interpretation or realization of the source material. Nonetheless, these adaptations and translations maintain a connection to the original work, creating an intermedial relationship between the source and target media.

The latter category, combination, covers those medial mechanics when perceivably distinct medialities are being mixed and combined “inside” the product, like a website with embedded pictures and text or an art installation that requires the audience to watch projected images and simultaneously interact with a physical object. Processes that fall in this broader category synchronously present mixed medialities, unlike the transformations that can be regarded as temporal processes. So, from a practical point of view, as Bruhn explains, we can also divide medialities as “temporal transformation” and “synchronous combination”. However, these are pragmatic distinctions rather than essential, he emphasizes, which from an analytical perspective would mean that during an investigation of a literary text, for example, the researcher “may look for either mixes (combination) or traces (transformation)” too.⁹⁸

At this point, it is important to acknowledge the terminological and conceptual disagreements among scholars in this field, as the terms intermediality, multimodality, and transmediality are often used interchangeably. As Dánél and Sándor argue in the previously cited handbook of media and cultural studies,⁹⁹ a more precise delineation can be made between these concepts. Intermediality refers to the transformative movements and interplay of various media modalities within a work. In contrast, multimodality describes the coexistence, cohabitation, and integration of multiple media forms within a single work. This distinction highlights the dynamic and relational nature of intermediality, as opposed to the more static or parallel coexistence of media in multimodality.

Werner Wolf further complicates the terminological conundrum surrounding intermediality in his entry in the *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*.¹⁰⁰ He argues that intermediality is a larger umbrella term encompassing the extra- and intra-compositional relationships between different media modalities.¹⁰¹ In a way, Wolf agrees with Bruhn's descriptions of temporal transformations and synchronous combinations, but he creates a more nuanced perspective. Wolf suggests that transmediality, the migration of content across multiple media platforms, is also a form of “intermedial transposition,” just as the medial co-presence or “plurimediality” within a single work. This complex, multifaceted approach to understanding the interplay of media is similar to the framework developed by Lars Elleström in his work,¹⁰² and it is the direction this research aims to ground itself in as well.

The research at this point could open a quite extensive footnote to explore the complexities and ambiguities surrounding the concept of the medium. This would be a

⁹⁸ Bruhn, *The Intermediality of Narrative Literature*, 26.

⁹⁹ Kricsfalusi Beatrix et al., *Média- és kultúratudomány*.

¹⁰⁰ David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*.

¹⁰¹ David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 252–53.

¹⁰² Lars Elleström, ed., *Media Borders, Multimodality and Intermediality* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2010).

valuable exercise, as the medium is a foundational yet highly contested concept within the field of media studies.¹⁰³ Within this field, multiple, often conflicting, definitions and theoretical perspectives grapple with the fundamental question of what constitutes a medium. Rather than attempting to provide a comprehensive inventory of these differing views, it would be more productive to highlight how this specific research conceptualizes the medium. Here, the medium is defined as a technical, material, and semiotic platform that enables and constrains the production, transmission, reception, and containment of cultural artifacts and information. This understanding rejects the notion of the medium as a neutral channel or vehicle for content. Instead, it recognizes the medium as an active agent that shapes, frames, and fundamentally determines the communication process. In other words, the medium is not merely a passive conduit but an influential force that actively structures and mediates the circulation of cultural signifiers.

Bruhn¹⁰⁴ and Elleström¹⁰⁵ can provide particularly relevant perspectives in this regard. Their definitions are constructed with the contemporary media landscape in mind, making them exceptionally well-suited to explain and analyze intermedial phenomena. However, let us not sidetrack from the main direction of the dissertation, and instead, let us examine how the reader can approach intermediality and how the analytical eye can productively engage with such artifacts.

Consciously recognizing a media product's intermedial mechanisms and processes, the cultural content invites another kind of reader, one with a different attitude on the recipient's end of the communication. In 2011, Asbjørn Grønstad argued that a certain shift in theory can be detected in this field of research, which abandons the logocentrism of the poststructuralists and transforms it into "a kind of neo-phenomenology defined [...] by notions of encounter, experience, or presentation".¹⁰⁶ This dissertation would not argue for Grønstad's statement, however, this observation makes it at least apparent that in the products of our contemporary age, a purely logocentric approach may be exceeded - the reader and the reading process cannot be understood from the classical standpoint of the interpreter of textual or linguistical signifiers: encounter, experience, and presentation all needs to be accounted for in an analysis.

As theorists of intermediality recognize, the reader's encounter with mixed-media experiences requires a perspective that extends beyond the traditional focus on textual meaning and interpretation. Instead, the reader's sensory experience of the work and the phenomenology of intermedial perception become central to understanding the meaning-making processes.¹⁰⁷ This challenges the conception of the reader as a detached hermeneutic subject, highlighting the reader's active and participatory (sensory) role in navigating the multimodal space of the work. Bruhn, in his work,

¹⁰³ David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 288–89.

¹⁰⁴ Bruhn, *The Intermediality of Narrative Literature*.

¹⁰⁵ Elleström, *Media Borders, Multimodality and Intermediality*.

¹⁰⁶ Asbjørn Grønstad, "Is There a Transmedial Dispositif? Aesthetic Epistemes and the Question of Disciplinarity," *The Nordic Journal of Aesthetics* 23, no. 42 (2012): 36, <https://doi.org/10.7146/nja.v23i42.5874>.

¹⁰⁷ Melanie Swalwell, "New/Inter/Media," *Convergence: The International Journal of Research into New Media Technologies* 8, no. 4 (2002): 47–48, <https://doi.org/10.1177/135485650200800406>.

demonstrates this attitude and formulates a methodology to analyze narrative texts by focusing on and “teasing out” their mediality (declaring that this process is very close to Werner Wolf’s analysis of the relationship between literature and music in *The Musicalization of Fiction*¹⁰⁸). With this, he aims to go beyond comparisons of different arts and media. Instead, he diverts the analytical gaze towards the intermedial processes inside the work that often also shed light on media constellations “outside” the text itself.¹⁰⁹ I argue that Bruhn’s focus and methodology present a kind of reader model for such multimodal artifacts, and the theoretician’s approach signifies how the reader of intermedia engages with the artwork and vice versa.

Bruhn proposes a three-step model for analyzing the intermediality of narrative literature. The first step involves taking an overview and creating an inventory of the representations of “media products, mediality types, and mediality aspects” within the text.¹¹⁰ This generates a comprehensive register of intermedial phenomena that require further exploration. The second step involves structuring and ordering this unstructured material while providing interpretative suggestions. For example, Bruhn illustrated these steps through an imaginary literary text representing a plot about a painter’s struggle with an author. Bruhn argued that this medial or artistic tension may also be explored in terms of the level of expression and style, offering more nuanced “readings” or understandings of the work. The final step in Bruhn’s model complements the analytical inquiry with a contextual widening, where the intermedial relationships and dynamics detected in the previous steps are then discussed in a larger cultural, psychological, biographical, theoretical, aesthetic, technical, and/or historical context. This approach shifts away from conventional, text-immanent literary analysis and reading method toward intermedial and transmedial modes of investigation, which are attentive to the complex material, technological, and cultural dimensions that shape the literary work. However, though the analytical methods of Bruhn were primarily demonstrated and discussed in his book through textual literature (e.g. Nabokov, Carver, Wolff, Egan, etc.), this three-step model that stimulates intermedial interpretations can and should also be tested on other narrative forms “like TV series, theater, and computer games”¹¹¹ which is quite close to the aim of this dissertation’s subsequent chapters.

This shift in focus, moreover, recognizes that the reader’s experience of an intermedial text is multifaceted, involving sensory, embodied, and participatory modes of engagement that go beyond the passive interpretation of signifiers. The reader thus becomes an active observer and interpreter of the medial constellations and dynamics within and around the literary work, shedding light on the work’s media ecology and the larger cultural, technological, and aesthetic contexts that inform its production and reception.

¹⁰⁸ Werner Wolf, *The Musicalization of Fiction: A Study in the Theory and History of Intermediality*, Internationale Forschungen Zur Allgemeinen Und Vergleichenden Literaturwissenschaft 35 (Rodopi, 1999).

¹⁰⁹ Bruhn, *The Intermediality of Narrative Literature*, 33.

¹¹⁰ Bruhn, *The Intermediality of Narrative Literature*, 34.

¹¹¹ Bruhn, *The Intermediality of Narrative Literature*, 126.

2.2 THE PLAYER

The evolution of the contemporary media landscape contributed to the emergence of vastly different storytelling methods and mediums to communicate narratives. There are significant differences between modern novels, which code their messages primarily through a text-based medium and structures such as cybertext, forms of interactive fiction, or even video games. The difference between the structures of conveying a narrative message also creates or presupposes a different kind of recipient in a form that can hardly be described solely as a reader but more like a player in the storytelling system. Thus, this subchapter explores how players engage with interactive texts, particularly in ergodic literature¹¹² and video games.

In the previous sections, it has been cited how Espen Aarseth defined ergodic literature while emphasizing the active effort required by players to navigate and engage with a text like this, distinguishing it from traditional literary experiences that rely mainly on “passive” consumption.¹¹³ The visual allegory of the reader being a mere passenger on a train limits their actual decision-making power to a number, which should make us question whether the reader has a range of choices. However, exploring the mechanisms of prototypical hypertexts, such as choose-your-own-adventure books, illuminates the potential for agency, allowing readers to influence the direction of the narrative through their decisions. On the other hand, this still binds the recipient to the textuality of the medium and the traditional structures of literature. This research aims to take one step towards a border crossing between the realms of text readers and game players. For that, the player's role and this receiver structure, as defined in academic literature, need to be discussed to assist in exploring transmedia storytelling networks.

The first seminal work on games and their participants, the player, was done by anthropologists and psychologists who investigated the cultural significance of the act of playing in our communities. One of the most known theorists in the field is Johan Huizinga whose work coined the term “Homo Ludens” or (translated by Huizinga himself as) “Man the Player”¹¹⁴ the playful dimension of the human life that exists beside Homo Faber and Homo Sapiens, and which played an equally important part developing our society as intellect and the use of tools.¹¹⁵ In this early text of Huizinga, the activity, play, in which the player is the participant, was quite broadly defined. According to his definition, play is always a voluntary activity¹¹⁶ carried out within set limits of time and space, followed by specific binding rules, although freely accepted by the partakers. In essence, Huizinga argues, play is a meaningful act that stands outside the immediate practical needs of life, offering a temporary escape and a form of intrinsic satisfaction.¹¹⁷

As for the player, Huizinga considers the player to be someone who engages in this activity with a full consciousness of its nature as play. The player plays with

¹¹² Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 1–2.

¹¹³ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 18.

¹¹⁴ Johan Huizinga, *Homo Ludens: a Study of the Play-Element in Culture* (Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1998), Foreword.

¹¹⁵ Huizinga, *Homo Ludens*, Foreword.

¹¹⁶ Huizinga, *Homo Ludens*, 7.

¹¹⁷ Huizinga, *Homo Ludens*, 1–27.

enthusiasm and a sense of immersion, knowing it is distinct from ordinary life. This consciousness allows the player to blend freedom with discipline, often experiencing a form of rapture and joy ranging from frivolity to ecstasy. As we might see, in this framework, because of the playful elements of literature and the voluntary surrender of oneself to the rules of fiction and storytelling, players and readers, literary texts and games can be hard to discern or have a structurally clear cut between them.

Another well-cited resource on the theory of play is Roger Caillois's work on almost the same topic, where Huizinga's concept is further developed. Caillois expands on what can be called a game or play and creates categories of distinct kinds of playful activities in society. He differentiates four kinds of these: *agon* (competitive activities), *alea* (games of chance), *mimicry* (simulation, make-believe), and *ilinx* (pursuit of vertigo).¹¹⁸ Caillois's work, with its structural classifications, does not distance reading and literary experience from games and playing, which would show us how close these activities are to each other, and it is worth exploring how a text can summon a player for itself rather than a reader.

But again, where do we cross this line, or where should we consider that we are walking on the borders between the role of reader and player? To answer this question, we need to circle back to Espen Aarseth again to identify how he thinks about the recipient of the cybertext.¹¹⁹ As it is apparent, most of the time, he talks about the reader, user, or player with the help of spatial allegories: the regular reader of a non-ergodic text traverses the landscape without requiring nontrivial efforts. Unlike the ergodic texts, where the recipient needs active participation – they must navigate the narrative, take actions, and sometimes fail or fall down while traversing this different kind of storytelling system. This spatial navigation transforms the reader into an active participant, a player who must invest time and effort to unravel the layers of the narrative, thereby blurring the distinction between reading and playing in the realm of cybertext.

One of the earliest types of interactive storytelling structures that are moving along these borders, so the form that still can be easily recognized and analyzed through literary methods, are the text adventures from the 1970s when the internet (or not even the internet but the ARPANET) was a niche tool for computer scientists and researchers. Arguably, the first blockbuster video game was *Adventure*, released in 1977 by Don Woods (who reworked, broadened, and finetuned the original code of Will Crowther).¹²⁰ This text-based simulation created a virtual environment of an underground fantasy world that the player could traverse through directions and commands written as inputs in the program.

For those unfamiliar with this storytelling structure or this genre of video games, the main characteristics of these programs are the almost exclusive reliance on textual methods and the use of a second-person narrator that creates a deeper immersion

¹¹⁸ Roger Caillois, *Man, Play, and Games*, trans. Meyer Barash (University of Illinois Press, 2001), 11–37.

¹¹⁹ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 162–68.

¹²⁰ Aaron Reed, *50 Years of Text Games: From Oregon Trail to AI Dungeon* (Changeful Tales Press, 2023), 75–89.

for the player. When playing, the recipient sees a blank screen where the scenery and locations are described, events and happenings are told, and there's always an input field for the player to type in the next action, the next direction for the narrative. In the 1970s, during the peak popularity of these text adventures, the works were quite limited. The perceived freedom of choice could only be heightened if the creator manually programmed more options into the game. However, these actions still directly influenced the outcome of the narrative, modified the system's behavior, presenting a vast array of different paths to reach certain goals in the game – and the ingenuity of *Adventure* pushed forward the evolution of the traditional reader towards the role of the player, moreover, inspired by the up and coming text adventure genre, towards the role of the co-creator.¹²¹ These early text adventures thus highlight a pivotal moment in the history of storytelling where the boundaries between reader and player began to blur, foreshadowing the complex, interactive narratives that dominate today's storytelling landscape.¹²²

Pointing to the structural model of the cybertext by Aarseth,¹²³ this research argues that this process of role transformation could not have happened without the layering of messaging systems and the presence of the database and simulation. The database, serving as the repository of narrative possibilities and simulation and providing dynamic and adaptive storytelling environments, contributes to transforming the engagement model of narratives from passive consumption to active participation. Aarseth's model comprises four components: "the data, the processing engine, the front-end medium (interface), and the users".¹²⁴

Data contained by the database, and considered here as the first layer of the cyber-texts, can exist in two forms: static or dynamic. For the former, one might look at the world, the rooms, the spaces, the descriptions, and some of the other characters; the latter contains all other variables in the system, like the position of the user, stats, inventory, etc. Earlier text games, like *Adventure*, utilized static data in overwhelming percentage compared to dynamic data, thus offering a more rigid structure but also a clear narrative path that invited players to explore within the defined constraints, thereby engaging in a form of storytelling that was more about discovery rather than unrestricted, free flowing creation. In contrast to this data structure, MUDs or multi-user dungeons had very few restrictions and fixed objects in the environment, thus presenting a cybertext where dynamic data comprise a significant portion of the narrative experience, allowing players to interact with one another and the environment in real-time, effectively cocreating the story as they progressed.

The processing engine "represents the core of the cybertext," Aarseth argues, as this is the module where courses of action are decided based on the rules of the system, the current state of the variables (or the world, in a sense), and the player's inputs.

¹²¹ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 102.

¹²² It is also worth mentioning that the emergence of advanced AI technology, and the era of the easily accessible Large Language Models brought forward a new renaissance of text adventures. Platforms such as Talefy utilize the potential of the text completion methods so they can create the text games that the players in the 1970s were only dreaming: a narrative space where your actions and directions can more or less indefinitely influence the story that's unfolding in front of them much like during a session of tabletop role-playing games.

¹²³ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 104.

¹²⁴ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 104.

This is the layer where calculations are done and the two types of events are generated: user and system events. Depending on what generated the outcome, a player input or an inherent calculation, like the passing of time. This is the module where the representation occurs, too – these mechanisms are responsible for “providing a personal perspective on the simulated world” for the player.¹²⁵ It needs to be mindful of the player’s position and actions to handle the information that needs to be shared.

The third layer, the interface, mediates between the player and the underlying systems, presenting information in an accessible way and enabling intuitive interaction. Thus, it reinforces the player's sense of immersion and presence within the narrative environment. It consists of input and output components that analyze the code coming from the user, transcoding it into a machine-readable message and communicating it and vice versa.

The final layer is the user who is “of course external to the design of the cybertext but not to its strategy.” This strategy, as Aarseth explains, in the early years of the cybertext was close to the conceptualization of an ideal reader by a traditional novel: they could be the ones capable of solving the riddles “and thereby extricate the one definite, intended plotline.”¹²⁶ However, this strategy changed, and the “reader’s role is becoming less ideal [...] and more flexible, less dependable, and freer” – referring here to the MUDs. Thus, closing Aarseth's arguments, the users/players become less of a Sherlock Holmes and more of a corruptible, worldwide reader, a Faust. From this dissertation’s perspective, Aarseth is signifying the opportunity to point out the shift from the player to the co-creator role.

The kiss between Captain Kathryn Janeway and Lord Burleigh of the TV series *Star Trek* that was canonized and immortalized for the academic community by Janet Murray in her seminal work¹²⁷ for the scholars of this field signified the already described evolution of the role of the reader: this sci-fi equipment, the holodeck, created the ultimate dream of an intermedial player. As the concept of holonovels and holosuites might not sound that distant from today’s technological advancements, in a broader sense, one needs to turn to the video game industry¹²⁸ if they’d like to experience agency through interactivity in a storytelling medium.

As we have discussed earlier, the reader becomes a player when they can disembark from the proverbial train and traverse a narrative's multiplicity. This means that the product or message needs to be coded this way to allow actions to be taken and participation with the agency. Video games with multimodal design elements, spanning graphics, sound, and interactive text, create a dynamic space where the player's

¹²⁵ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 105.

¹²⁶ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 105.

¹²⁷ Janet Horowitz Murray, *Hamlet on the Holodeck: The Future of Narrative in Cyberspace*, Updated edition (The MIT Press, 2017), 23–24.

¹²⁸ Of course, this doesn’t mean that there aren’t other narrative systems where players or users can experience agency over the storytelling – as the investigation of these different structures is the very aim of the dissertation – but as mainstream solutions go, video games could be the number one choice in terms of accessibility and availability.

choices can significantly shape the unfolding story, actualizing certain pathways as they collaborate with the game developer to tell one of the stories the game can offer.

This storytelling medium is both unique and in the meantime in debt of countless traditional media: video games are unlike any,

*being the first to combine real-time gameplay with a navigable, on-screen diegetic space; the first to feature avatars and player-controlled surrogates that could influence onscreen events; and the first to require hand-eye coordination skills (except for pinball, which was much more limited and not as complicated).*¹²⁹

From the perspective of the already-discussed approach to the definition of a medium, video games have their own technical, material, and semiotic structures that define the constraints around the production, transmission, reception, and containment of information. However, as an integrative medium, video games merge and utilize the mediums of film, literature, theater, and even visual arts in their processes, thus binding themselves to traditional media and their history, too.

Janet Murray defines four essential properties of digital environments or video games – digital environments are procedural, participatory, spatial, and encyclopedic, collectively enabling the multifaceted interaction and rich storytelling experiences that characterize the intermedia landscape. She also argues that the first two properties create the base for the loosely defined aspect of interactivity, and the latter ones are responsible for the immersivity of these digital realms.¹³⁰ As one can see, Murray argues that one of the constitutive properties of video games lies in their procedurality, which means that predefined rules and structures govern these products and structures. Instead of being a “wire or a pathway”, we are presented with an engine. It was made to “embody complex, contingent behaviors” and not to “carry static information”.¹³¹ This means that according to this approach, video games are multi-layered narrative systems, constantly keeping their messages in flux, presenting narratives as emergent and interaction-based experiences that evolve with each player’s engagement, thus underpinning the central role of the player in intermedial storytelling. Characters and plots are no longer static constructs but are constantly reshaped by the player’s choices, leading to unique and sometimes unpredictable outcomes. In video games, for example, dynamic storytelling maps evolve based on the player’s exploration, as evidenced by the narrative structures in RPGs and adventure games where the spatial arrangement of missions and moral choices directly impact story progression. From this aspect, the notion that video games are participatory mediums is quite self-explanatory at this point. The recipient of the narrative message must initiate the video games’ processes, as this is the only way to secure the actualization of the specific storytelling directions or story beats.

However, it is easy to miss a quite important aspect of interactivity when discussing video games or other intermedia pieces: the player has their skin in the game. The leaps he takes are quite real in that there are non-metaphorical dead ends – as

¹²⁹ Mark J P Wolf and Bernard Perron, eds., *The Video Game Theory Reader* (Routledge, 2003), 11.

¹³⁰ Murray, *Hamlet on the Holodeck*, 72–96.

¹³¹ Murray, *Hamlet on the Holodeck*, 73.

Aarseth also points out when he talks about cybertexts – and there is the direct risk of failure in most video games. When the reader becomes a player in these systems, it is not only them who interacts with the game but also the game reaches out and engages with the player, creating a reciprocal dynamic where the recipient, in a way, is also being programmed by the computer: their decisions, emotions, and even muscle memory are influenced by the feedback loop established by game mechanics and narrative pathways. This blending of agency and immersion underscores the player's vital role in shaping the story, highlighting the intricate interplay between human cognition and digital narratives within intermedia storytelling.

Departing from the properties of interactivity, let us look at the aspects that primarily create the immersivity of the medium. Murray argues that “new digital environments are characterized by their power to represent navigable space.” She follows up this argument by explaining that cinema also presents spaces, and traditional literature operates with environments too; however, only “digital environments” or video games can “present space that we can move through.”¹³² Navigability is the key. The player can directly manipulate their location or the environment, or, more generally, the spatiality of the message. And these navigable spaces can be huge. Mojang's *Minecraft* creates a procedurally generated map of 3.9 billion km² (nota bene: Earth's surface is merely 510 million km²), *Elite: Dangerous* presents a 1:1 replica of the Milky Way galaxy, and No Man's Sky is still dwarfing this with its unfathomable 256 galaxies – 18 quintillion planets that can be explored in the simulation. These unparalleled potentials for spatial exploration deepen the players' immersion, as they rarely encounter superficial limitations or boundaries imposed by the game world.

Speaking of size and vastness, this aspect is directly connected to the encyclopedic nature of digital environments. The ability to store, retrieve, and display vast amounts of data enables video games to create extensive lore, complex ecosystems, and detailed backstories, which further enrich the immersive experience for players. The potential capacity for storing information in video games is equally as baffling as the possible sizes of actual, traversable game maps: according to Murray's calculations, the technology in her time could accommodate 530 000 000 words or 5.3GBs of data on a DVD (which seems a bit of an odd number as regular DVDs are working with 4.7 GB of capacity today), but to see a more hands-on example of the potential of the medium, one should look no further than the recreated simulation of Borges' Library of Babel in a digital environment which builds upon a web-based platform's experiment to recreate this infinite base of “knowledge”. Currently, it contains every possible permutation of 3200 characters, which virtually creates about 10⁴⁶⁷⁷ pieces of books. This is the power of the medium.¹³³

With the convergence of procedural, participatory, spatial, and encyclopedic elements, video games transform narrative consumption and redefine the notion of what narratives can become in the intermedia landscape. Moreover, this changing

¹³² Murray, *Hamlet on the Holodeck*, 79.

¹³³ This exact paragraph (footnotes excluded) can be found in the Library of Babel, too, on page 219 within a book titled *fgo.okqfqwpf* that can be found in one of the infinite numbers of hexagons' wall #2, shelf #4.

attitude also gives rise to a particular intermedial phenomenon: transmedia storytelling.

The term “transmedia” was first introduced by Marsha Kinder in 1991 in her book *Playing with Power in Movies, Television, and Video Games: From Muppet Babies to Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles*. Kinder used “transmedia” to describe a narrative that extends across multiple media platforms, where each medium contributes uniquely to the unfolding of the story.¹³⁴ Kinder’s approach explored these narrative dynamics from a more materialistic or consumerist perspective.

Kinder discusses in his work how children’s media, especially (e.g., television or video games), which “play a crucial role in the child’s entry into narrative,” invoke a “combined mode of spectatorship” that can and needs to navigate within a “commercial supersystem of transmedia intertextuality”.¹³⁵ One of the most important tools of these kinds of supersystems is the “sliding signifier,” which describes those narrative elements, signifiers (primarily characters) that themselves can adapt and change according to their media presence and specific actualization, and can “move fluidly across various forms of image production and cultural boundaries”. This provides an opportunity for the “spectators” to identify with them. The ultimate example of Kinder’s is, of course, the *Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles* franchise, which presents how “new technological development” (such as the video game or other “interactive multimedia”) can construct these “consumerist” spectators who can “more readily assimilate and accommodate whatever objects they encounter”. With the help of these identifiable sliding signifiers and the interactivity-inducing commercial items, such as entertainment systems and video games, Kinder argues that this envisioned new generation of narrative consumers will quickly gain proficiency in recognizing and recombining popular narrative genres, and with that, the skill and need for intertextual reenvoicements.¹³⁶

Kinder’s early work on this understanding of transmediality thus still employed the nomenclature of literary theory, as the concept of intertextuality became the origin of criticism for these supersystems. However, it was intentionally pointed out through John Fiske’s work (who primarily cited Barthes) that intertextuality, instead of anchoring the readers’ actions to the knowledge of specific texts, untangles “in the space between texts.”¹³⁷ This would mean that the “in-betweenness” of transmediality can be traced back to the concept’s earliest mentions. However, in Kinder’s research, these observations are tied to this more classical understanding of the reader’s role: the media products create an intertextual field where the “reader” needs to decode their signifiers while inserting themselves and their identity into the narrative.

It might be worth mentioning at this point that historically, around the late 1980s and during the 1990s, the shifting media landscape and the emergence of devices capable of creating and presenting intermedial works (so not only transmedial but other

¹³⁴ Marsha Kinder, *Playing with Power in Movies, Television, and Video Games: From Muppet Babies to Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles* (University of California Press, 1991), 3.

¹³⁵ Kinder, *Playing with Power in Movies, Television, and Video Games*, 3.

¹³⁶ Kinder, *Playing with Power in Movies, Television, and Video Games*, 16–23.

¹³⁷ John Fiske, *Television Culture* (Routledge, 1999), 144.

“inter-art” forms too), the focus of cultural studies also became interested in the recipients’ attitudes towards the instances of messages where multiple modalities and medialities collided. Miller¹³⁸ and Mitchell¹³⁹ observed the interaction between image and text. They extrapolated from these perspectives that not only the structures of artworks (and messages in general) changed, but also the interpretative strategies of the recipients.¹⁴⁰ However, this present research is concerned more with the former.

The concept of transmedia gained further traction when Henry Jenkins expanded on it in his 2003 article *Transmedia Storytelling* and later in his 2006 book *Convergence Culture: Where Old and New Media Collide*.¹⁴¹ He further explored this field in his articles from 2007 and 2011, which described his courses, thoughts, and talks on this topic.¹⁴² Jenkins also started his arguments from huge media conglomerates, companies like Electronic Arts, franchises such as *Star Wars* or *Indiana Jones*, and prestigious filmmakers. He envisioned in 2003 what he would later elaborate on in his seminal book, the culture of media convergence, a state of the contemporary technological landscape where the consumer must *read* across the media to explore all of the “pleasures” of what the structure can offer.

The vision that the entire entertainment industry is being built with these functions in mind has been fulfilled and is flourishing since the mid-2010s. The success of the MCU, the revived *Star Wars* universe, or even Disney’s sprawling reign as the owner of the most valuable IPs in the world all point toward (or back to) Henry Jenkins’ early observations.

Transmedia storytelling, as he argues, “represents a process where integral elements of a fiction get dispersed systematically across multiple delivery channels to create a unified and coordinated entertainment experience.”¹⁴³ According to him, however, it’s also ideal that these elements or fragments all make their own “unique contribution to the unfolding of the story”¹⁴⁴ while being expanded most often across “as many different media platforms as possible.”¹⁴⁵ In later chapters of this dissertation, it will also become apparent that these fragments can serve various functions in the story(world). Still, this variety applies not only to the narrative elements but also to the reader’s role.

Instances of transmedia storytelling invoke a particular behavior from the recipient – it motivates the consumers to turn into “information hunters and gatherers, taking pleasure in tracking down character backgrounds or plot points and making

¹³⁸ Joseph Hillis Miller, *Illustration* (Harvard University Press, 1992).

¹³⁹ W. J. T. Mitchell, *Iconology: Image, Text, Ideology* (University of Chicago press, 1986).

¹⁴⁰ Miller, *Illustration*, 9, 150.

¹⁴¹ Henry Jenkins, “Transmedia Storytelling,” *MIT Technology Review*, January 15, 2003, <https://www.technologyreview.com/2003/01/15/234540/transmedia-storytelling/>; Jenkins, *Convergence Culture*.

¹⁴² Henry Jenkins, *Transmedia Storytelling 101*, March 21, 2007, http://henryjenkins.org/blog/2007/03/transmedia_storytelling_101.html; Henry Jenkins, “Transmedia 202: Further Reflections,” *Henry Jenkins*, July 31, 2011, http://henryjenkins.org/blog/2011/08/defining_transmedia_further_re.html.

¹⁴³ Jenkins, *Transmedia Storytelling 101*, n.p.

¹⁴⁴ Jenkins, *Transmedia Storytelling 101*, n.p.

¹⁴⁵ Jenkins, *Transmedia Storytelling 101*, n.p.

connections between different texts within the same franchise”¹⁴⁶ through the desire of filling in gaps of the narrative up until the point that this “interpretative” interaction becomes speculation, and speculations “take on a life of their own” in the form of fan fictions,¹⁴⁷ for example.

As for the bottom line, there remains a question: What sets transmedial structures and transmedia storytelling apart from “mythology-modeled story structures,” “radical intertextuality,”¹⁴⁸ and instances of independent world-building? To answer this question, we need to acknowledge all of these – from the multimedia storyworld of Oz to the encyclopedic endeavor of J.R.R. Tolkien – as “historical antecedents” of our subject matter, but to go one step further, this research would propose two aspects that identify transmedia storytelling with adequate precision:

1. The dispersed narrative elements should be explored across different media, and
2. The recipient needs to depart from the role of the reader (with its specific decoding strategies that are primarily suitable for textual works) and shift towards the role of the player and co-creator.

This dissertation will present this path in the subsequent chapters, exploring how transmedia storytelling redefines the relationship between the narrative and the audience, transforming the reader into an active participant in the unfolding of the story.

Transmediality is a cross-disciplinary phenomenon that is present as a theoretical field in academia and as a practice in the creative and cultural industries. As Freeman and Gambarato summarized it well,¹⁴⁹ journalism, marketing, activism, literacy, and historical culture – among others – all profit from the processes that create a specific kind of intermedial experience. It is not a coincidence: the contemporary media landscape “calls for a spread of media.”¹⁵⁰

The widening field of transmedia studies or the topography of transmedia research inquiries can show us that we are observing the discourse’s maturing phase, and its processes are dynamically calling to and forming its transactional elements: the forms of its contents, its mechanics, and its subjects. Jenkins’ first examples of these explicit storytelling structures, among others, were the *Matrix* franchise, the *Star Wars* universe, the *Lord of the Rings* franchise, and *The Blair Witch Project*. These can be described as vast, interconnected storyworlds that are “bigger on the inside”, utilizing the network-like structure to immerse their audiences deep into the experience. All of them, however, excluding maybe *The Blair Witch Project* as it is a more unique

¹⁴⁶ Jenkins, “Transmedia Storytelling,” n.p.

¹⁴⁷ Jenkins, *Transmedia Storytelling 101*, n.p.

¹⁴⁸ Jenkins, “Transmedia 202,” n.p.

¹⁴⁹ Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato, *The Routledge Companion to Transmedia Studies*, ed. Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato (Routledge, 2018), 2, <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351054904>.

¹⁵⁰ Felix Brinker, “Transmedia Storytelling in the ‘Marvel Cinematic Universe’ and the Logics of Convergence-Era Popular Seriality,” in *Make Ours Marvel: Media Convergence and a Comics Universe*, ed. Matt Yockey (University of Texas Press, 2017), 209, <https://doi.org/10.7560/312490-009>.

specimen, establish their narratives through the practices of the reader-like consumer that this research was delving into along the arguments of Kinder.

It shouldn't be surprising that advanced transmedia storytelling systems call for players instead of readers. The core processes of the reader need to be completed with another dimension to be a successful recipient of these materials. Collecting the text, consuming the text, decoding the text, and interpreting the text is not enough to see and feel the overarching structures: as the state of, for example, the *Star Wars* franchise was before the 2012 acquisition of Lucasfilm by Disney, where the novelizations, the movies, the radio dramas and a loosely defined canon all contributed to the same, more traditional media universe. What I would mean by "traditional" media universe is that there's a similar demarcation between transmedia works for readers and players as there is the previously cited difference between traditional literature and cybertexts.

We finally arrive at the prototypical "playerly" transmedia storytelling network: the Alternate Reality Game (ARG). These intricate and immersive experiences are not only assemblages of different media products or just a coherent narrative experience dispersed in different media but an interactive transmedia network that can only operate according to its design if the consumer is an active participant, someone who interacts, a player. To give a brief definition, an ARG is a game involving interactive storytelling where participants solve puzzles and complete activities in a real-world and/or online setting. These games blur the lines between fiction and reality, often incorporating multiple media platforms to create an immersive narrative experience. Players interact with the game by gathering clues from various sources, including websites, social media, email, phone calls, and even live events. The goal is to uncover and piece together the story, often collaboratively with other participants. ARGs can be used for entertainment, marketing, educational purposes, and more, a dynamic and engaging experience that extends beyond traditional gameplay.

One of the first, most famous, and oft-cited Alternate Reality Games is *The Beast*, created to promote Steven Spielberg's film *A.I. Artificial Intelligence* in 2001, which utilized a wide array of media platforms, engaging thousands of players in a complex and immersive narrative world that spanned both the digital and physical realms. The consumers who encountered this participatory narrative first had to traverse the gateway into the storyworld. This so-called rabbit hole was the initial invitation for players to immerse themselves in this experience. For this particular game, the rabbit hole was a cryptic message hidden in a movie trailer, a curious name in the credits segment, and a certain Sentient Machine Therapist, Jeanine Salla. For those intrigued enough by this weird detail, an entirely new world began to unravel after a quick Google search, leading them to websites of fictional universities in the future, phone numbers of hackers, and real-time events specifically designed to deepen their engagement and investment in the narrative. This rabbit hole tactic has since become a defining element of ARGs, serving as a bridge that explicitly transforms the passive reader into an active player, thereby aligning them more closely with the mechanics of a game than with the consumption of a traditional narrative.

As this example presents, ARGs can be used as a marketing tool. However, this storytelling structure can also stand alone as an independent experience or serve educational and different activist purposes. These works are pushing the unique

properties of transmedia systems to the extreme by demanding a heightened level of engagement, offering an ephemeral experience, creating an exceptionally immersive environment through the strategy of blurring the lines between reality and fiction, promoting (collaborative) problem-solving, and rewarding in-depth narrative exploration. These elements combine to craft a fundamentally different form of interaction that transcends traditional media engagement. Through these mechanisms, ARGs transform participants into protagonists within a living narrative, culminating in a truly one-of-a-kind form of storytelling.

2.3 THE CO-CREATOR

The notion of the co-creator encompasses a wide array of contributors, such as fans and other enthusiasts who transform into authors, extending the narrative through creative additions and expansions. These co-creators often contribute new layers of depth and meaning, enriching the original work with their unique perspectives and interpretations by adding new segments or storylines, thereby transforming the textual landscape into an evolving narrative ecosystem. They navigate this space through creative acts, such as producing fan fiction, scripting game modifications, and participating in collaborative story-building episodes.

While this dissertation focuses primarily on the middle (player) or middle-right of the narrative participatory spectrum (reader-player-co-creator), a cohesive argument requires considering nearly the entire range. In this final introductory chapter, we shift our gaze towards the position of the co-creator on this theoretical spectrum. The main characteristics of the reader's role, which include interpretation and creating mental assemblages of texts and media products, and the player's role, which involves hunting, gathering information, solving puzzles, and unlocking narrative segments through non-trivial efforts, are being pushed to their limits so the co-creator can emerge. This expansion challenges their traditional status in communicational transactions: the divide between the sender and the recipient becomes increasingly blurred – or even rendered irrelevant – as the co-creator actively engages in the dialogic construction of the narrative world. By contributing their imaginative input, they transform passive consumption into active participation, forging a symbiotic relationship with original creators.

Here, the text examines how participatory culture fosters co-creative practices, exploring various examples from different media where fans and enthusiasts have seamlessly integrated their creative efforts into the existing narrative framework. The research also explores the implications of this participatory dynamic, examining how it alters the landscape of narrative development and the audience's role in shaping stories. As this dissertation ventures deeper into this topic, it will seek to understand the tools and platforms that facilitate such collaborative endeavors and how they enable a more inclusive and interactive form of storytelling.

The phenomenon of the co-creator is vividly illustrated in participatory cultures surrounding collaborative storytelling projects and platforms, where the boundaries between the creator and the audience blur, giving rise to collective authorship. In the next sub-chapters, we will examine increasingly complex structures medially, where the role of the co-creator can be investigated in its entirety. This participatory culture is exemplified in environments such as Multi-User Dungeons (MUDs), sprawling,

cooperative mythologies like the SCP¹⁵¹ Foundation, where users collaboratively develop and expand serialized and/or network-like fiction, intermedial (mainly practices in the realm of video games) co-creation, like modding and narratives of online games, and finally in transmedial practices like fandoms and fan fictions.

2.3.1 MUDs

Multi-user dungeons are early virtual environments that required players to interpret text-based commands and descriptions and demanded collaborative storytelling, where each participant's actions and decisions dynamically influenced the narrative's progress. Aarseth defined these as systems in which the player's actions contribute to the unfolding narrative, and where producers and users are inherently equal, emphasizing the continuous negotiation between predetermined textual structures and emergent, player-driven events.¹⁵²

The textuality of these systems is crucial here, as it introduces the role of the co-creator, who, as the recipient, not only interacts with the storytelling medium to understand the message but also creates the text itself in an environment where unique social roles can be applied. This dynamic interplay in MUDs exemplifies how player agency can transform procedurally previously set textual frameworks into evolving, collective narrative experiences. Participants in MUDs are not merely following a script but actively contributing to the story's genesis, their input being woven into the larger fabric of the narrative. This fluid exchange pushes the boundaries of authorship, inviting us to reconsider the traditional notions of authorship.

MUDs although more or less presuppose a social system of norms and rules and enforce some technical regulations (hence the procedural aspect), Aarseth argues that the users of a multi-user dungeon are co-creating a structure that is positioning itself closer to literature and poesis than any other type of cybertext:¹⁵³ it is a game, a society and a work of fiction all at once.¹⁵⁴ However, this storytelling structure, while multi-authored, is also synchronous, interactive, and ephemeral – which may resemble a jazz jam session, argues Aarseth.¹⁵⁵

What might be less relevant when investigating media contents, however, becomes increasingly important when exploring communicational practices and meaning-making processes, is the perspective to read MUDs as complex, dynamic societies where players have distinct identities and roles and engage in various events. These virtual spaces offer a plethora of social interaction, mirroring real-world communities. In MUDs, individuals create avatars that reflect their chosen personas, participate in collaborative missions, and attend in-world events, fostering a sense of belonging and shared experience. Murray emphasizes¹⁵⁶ that these digital environments are not just games but are also social systems with their own norms, hierarchies, and cultural narratives, allowing participants to explore and express different facets of their identities. These can provide a vantage point from which the co-creator

¹⁵¹ Secure, Contain, Protect

¹⁵² Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 102–3; Murray, *Hamlet on the Holodeck*, 47.

¹⁵³ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 154.

¹⁵⁴ Murray, *Hamlet on the Holodeck*, 84.

¹⁵⁵ Aarseth, *Cybertext*, 158.

¹⁵⁶ Murray, *Hamlet on the Holodeck*, 117–19.

can be fruitfully distinguished from the player and the reader when encountering certain types of (cyber)texts.

2.3.2 Collaborative Storytelling Projects

Other contemporary forms of co-creator interactions include collaborative storytelling projects, where multi-authored works can easily emerge due to the contemporary media culture and internet connectivity. The SCP Foundation serves as a prime example, where a decentralized community of writers, artists, and fans collectively constructs a vast, intricate universe, contributing to both the narrative depth and the lore with each new entry (or *site* – as in the realm of transmediality, this text is going to refer to its narrative units).¹⁵⁷ Such projects illustrate how the collaborative nature of these storytelling endeavors fosters a democratization of authorship, allowing many voices to shape the evolving narrative landscape.

As a brief introduction, it is worth pointing out the origins of the SCP Foundation's universe and the roots of its practices. As Pallante pointed out in her thesis, the storyworld and the SCP Wiki (the repository where these stories are primarily being kept together) are closely connected to the digital literary genre of fan fiction, a type of writing “in which authors take characters from a source medium, like a book or a show, and write their own stories involving those characters.”¹⁵⁸

Hellekson and Busse, in the introductory chapter of *The Fan Fiction Studies Reader*, approach this question from four perspectives: derivativity, authorial copyright, community, and media rewriting. If we are approaching the question of the origin of fan fiction concerning its derivativeness or “as a response to specific written texts, we can trace fan fiction back to the Middle Ages.”¹⁵⁹ Furthermore:

*If the term requires an actual community of fans who share an interest, then Sherlock Holmes would easily qualify as the first fandom, with fan-written Holmes pastiches serving as the beginnings of fan fiction. Finally, if we look at it as a (sometimes purposefully critical) rewriting of shared media, in particular TV texts, then media fan fiction, starting in the 1960s with its base in science fiction fandom and its consequent zine culture, would start fan fiction proper.*¹⁶⁰

However, it is worth noting that Pallante also brought into the discussion the genre of Creepypasta (a creepy, horroristic twist on the copypasta genre, which refers to large

¹⁵⁷ Megan Erin Pallante, “Secure, Contain, Protect: Building a Digital Folklore Mythos through Collaborative Legend Creation” (Senior Honors Thesis, The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, 2017), 14.

¹⁵⁸ Pallante, “Secure, Contain, Protect: Building a Digital Folklore Mythos through Collaborative Legend Creation,” 8–9.

¹⁵⁹ As a side note, it might be interesting to see how ingrained these derivative works, collective storytelling, and retellings of the same storyworld in our culture – Hellekson and Busse even went as far as tracing back the genealogy of fan fiction to the age of the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*.¹⁵⁹ This approach, however, can only demonstrate the seeds of these works’ constitutive elements as in the age of Homer the function of “author”, let alone there was no such thing as what we currently call “fan”.

¹⁶⁰ Karen Hellekson and Kristina Busse, eds., *The Fan Fiction Studies Reader* (University of Iowa Press, 2014), 6.

texts of digital folklore that are being shared and reshared again and again on different platforms) of the internet age. Blank and McNeill define creepypasta as

*[...] an emergent genre of Internet folklore that involves the creation and dissemination of a particular style of creative horror stories and images. It draws on the disturbing, monstrous, strange, grotesque, and/or unknown while invoking the thematic and structural qualities of legendary narratives, including the use of personal narratives; ritual; ostension; familiar “real” settings, contexts, and ancillary characters; and an accompanying air of plausibility in an effort to elicit feelings of playful uneasiness, paranoia, and genuine fright among audiences.*¹⁶¹

Coming to terms with its origins, let’s shift our gaze to the SCP Foundation and the SCP Wiki. The storyworld and the subsequent database of the collected works originate from an image board post from 4chan’s /x/ page created on 22nd June 2007, which contained a photograph of an anthropomorphic concrete statue accompanied by a short story written by the user The USS Walrus about SCP-173 and its containment procedures. This fictional transcript or report was attributed to a non-existent government organization, the SCP Foundation. The document’s style, the narratorial agent, and its formalities all created a very specific mold that signaled the core essentialities for the upcoming works in this fictional universe.¹⁶²

Not long after this initial submission, the text proved so inspirational that it gained traction, prompting the creation of a separate wiki-like website dedicated to it. From a diegetic perspective, the SCP Foundation, this mysterious organization, has the primary goal of securing, containing, and protecting so-called anomalies all around the world to gather knowledge, tools, and weapons, to defend the world from destruction, to uphold the normality of everyday life. So the ordinary people will not have to live in fear, in doubt, or alienation from their systems of belief.

The entries on the SCP Wiki are typically separate and primarily independent stories, narrated from the cold, amoral stance of a researcher or government official, and presented in the form of confidential documents. However, these entries on the wiki site are written by countless individuals, self-appointed authors of this corpus, whose validation comes primarily from the community itself – partially from administrators and partially from the broader audience of readers. The multiplicity of authorship is also paired with the multiplicity of authority, or the absence of authority over the texts and works: one of the core concepts of the site is it being in almost its entirety licensed under Creative Commons; thus the community leaves access to its creative work open to any further derivative work, be it either another story on the site, a Hollywood movie, or an indie video game project. This open-access approach fosters a collaborative ethos, positioning each contributor as a co-creator who weaves their narratives into the ever-expanding fabric of the SCP universe. Consequently, the SCP Wiki is a quintessential example of how a decentralized storytelling

¹⁶¹ Trevor J Blank and Lynne S. McNeill, “Boiling Over: Creepypasta, Slender Man, and the New Face of Fear in Folklore,” *Contemporary Legends* 5, no. 3 (2015): 5.

¹⁶² Richárd Fejes, “Secure, Contain, Protect: Az SCP Foundation transzmediális univerzumának jelenléte a videójáték médiumában,” *Filológiai Közlöny*, no. 4 (2024): 43.

platform can cultivate a dynamic and participatory creative community. These collective writing projects, such as the SCP Foundation's universe, point toward a direction where the co-creator strives as it is in first-degree contact with literature and textual mediums. Investigating the SCP universe more closely reveals the mechanics between a canon emerging from a collaborative community and a recipient who also becomes a creator of new texts, thereby blurring the lines between the recipient and the author. Understanding this intricate dynamic, similar to MUDs, illustrates the evolving nature of narrative co-creation in contemporary digital culture.

2.3.3 Players of Massively Multiplayer Online Games

The practice of co-creation in more complex media structures can be vividly illustrated within the interactive realms of Massively Multiplayer Online Role-Playing Games (MMORPGs) such as *EVE Online*¹⁶³ and *World of Warcraft*.¹⁶⁴ These games provide insightful case studies that demonstrate the profound impact of player-generated content and community engagement on the storytelling process.

EVE is real. This phrase is not only a bold statement but a sentence uttered countless times by the players of one of the largest, oldest, and most famous MMOGs (Massively Multiplayer Online Games) still running in 2024. The work of Carter and his colleagues reports that this phrase is quite a “widespread colloquialism” that is “used by both *EVE Online*’s players and its developer (CCP Games)”.¹⁶⁵ The reported “realness” of the game refers to the seriousness of the players’ gameplay experience and how online interactions get very real meanings attributed to players.

Firstly, the phrase underscores the players' deep emotional investment and commitment. They experience intense emotions, victories, and losses as if they were happening in real life.¹⁶⁶ In *EVE*, harmful or at least ambiguous playstyles, such as espionage, scamming, theft, and other forms of social player-versus-player competition, are not only permitted but actively encouraged, creating a complex social ecosystem

¹⁶³ “EVE Online is a community-driven spaceship MMORPG where players can play free, choosing their own path from countless options. Experience space exploration, immense PvP and PvE battles and a thriving player economy in an ever-expanding sandbox. Participate in many in-game professions and activities, including war, politics, piracy, trading, and exploration, across 7,000 star systems with hundreds of thousands of other players.” (As described on their homepage: <https://www.eveonline.com>)

¹⁶⁴ “Four years have passed since the aftermath of Warcraft III: Reign of Chaos, and a great tension now smolders throughout the ravaged world of Azeroth. As the battle-worn races begin to rebuild their shattered kingdoms, new threats, both ancient and ominous, arise to plague the world once again. World of Warcraft is an online role-playing experience set in the award-winning Warcraft universe. Players assume the roles of Warcraft heroes as they explore, adventure, and quest across a vast world. Being “Massively Multiplayer,” World of Warcraft allows thousands of players to interact within the same world. Whether adventuring together or fighting against each other in epic battles, players will form friendships, forge alliances, and compete with enemies for power and glory. A dedicated live team will create a constant stream of new adventures to undertake, lands to explore, and monsters to vanquish. This content ensures that the game will never be the same from month to month, and will continue to offer new challenges and adventures for years to come.” (As Metacritic describes the game citing the publisher as a source: <https://www.metacritic.com/game/world-of-warcraft/>)

¹⁶⁵ Marcus Carter et al., “EVE Is Real,” *Proceedings of DiGRA 2015: Diversity of Play: Games – Cultures – Identities*, 2015, 2, <https://doi.org/10.26503/dl.v2015i1.734>.

¹⁶⁶ Carter et al., “EVE Is Real,” 5–7.

where alliances are forged and broken based on both in-game and real-world dynamics. This immersive and participatory nature of *EVE Online* drives players to become co-creators of the narrative, constantly shaping and reshaping the storyworld through their actions and decisions.

Secondly, Carter et al. continue by stating that the phrase highlights how the players perceive the work and professionalism involved in *EVE Online* play as real. Participants often spend significant amounts of time and effort to achieve complex and meaningful goals within the game, treating their roles with a level of seriousness akin to real-world professions. For instance, leaders of large alliances dedicate vast amounts of personal effort and risk burnout, like high-stress jobs outside the game. *EVE*'s ecosystem encompasses various formal and informal roles, including bankers, industrialists, and human resource directors, which require a professional approach, further reinforcing the idea that *EVE* is "real." The social relationships, obligations, and the extensive use of tools like spreadsheets for logistics and combat effectiveness add another layer that mimics professional life. This professional and structured approach to gameplay serves to validate the concept of "EVE is real" through the appreciated and legitimate work done within the game.¹⁶⁷

Thirdly, the phrase emphasizes *EVE Online* players' historical narratives and personal investment, underscoring their deep engagement with the game's history. In *EVE Online*, players create and reflect on past experiences, significantly shaping their current in-game activities and community positioning. This engagement with history is illustrated through initiatives like the 'True Stories' project, where players share their significant in-game experiences, reinforcing the narrative that "EVE is real." As noted by Carter et al., these personal and collective histories are valued because they have real emotional resonance for the players. They allow players to immortalize their actions and achievements within the game's universe, thus rendering the phrase both a statement of the game's influence on its participants and a testament to its immersive storytelling. The historical authenticity and emotional investment highlighted by these narratives strengthen the perception of *EVE* as a real and meaningful space for its community.¹⁶⁸

This multidimensional engagement, however, is not unique to *EVE Online*; similar dynamics can be observed in other MMORPGs, such as *World of Warcraft*, especially during significant events like the Corrupted Blood Incident, which provided profound insights into the interplay between player actions and the evolution of the collective narrative.¹⁶⁹ The Corrupted Blood Incident in *World of Warcraft* is a compelling example of how unintended game mechanics can result in emergent behaviors and narratives, transforming players from mere participants into active co-creators of the game's lore.¹⁷⁰

¹⁶⁷ Carter et al., "EVE Is Real," 10–12.

¹⁶⁸ Carter et al., "EVE Is Real," 7–10.

¹⁶⁹ A quite extensive collection of documents can be found in this document: Jessica Smith, "Guide to the Corrupted Blood Plague Documentation Collection" (Stanford University Library, August 10, 2012), <https://stacks.stanford.edu/file/druid:xy157wz5444/CB%20Collection%20Guide.pdf>.

¹⁷⁰ Selja Tanskanen, "Player Immersion in Video Games" (bachelor's thesis, South Eastern Finland University of Applied Sciences, 2018), 19–21.

The Corrupted Blood Incident of 2005 is one of the most famous events in the history of the online game *World of Warcraft*.¹⁷¹ This incident triggered a highly contagious debuff,¹⁷² a specific high-level raid encounter, which spread outside the raid.¹⁷³ The debuff, Corrupted Blood, was introduced by the end boss¹⁷⁴ Hakkar in the Zul'Gurub raid. Designed to challenge players, Corrupted Blood would periodically inflict significant damage over time on those players' avatars who were infected, and it was supposed to remain confined within the raid. However, the mechanics of the debuff allowed it to jump from players to their pets,¹⁷⁵ and these infected pets could be brought back to populated areas, quickly disseminating the disease unchecked, infecting player characters across the entire virtual world. This bug led to widespread in-game deaths and chaos, significantly disrupting normal gameplay and social interactions.

As the infection spread, different players responded in various ways, contributing to the development of various in-game narratives. Some players took on the role of self-appointed healers, using their abilities to try to cure the infected and contain the outbreak. Others, either out of curiosity or malice, deliberately spread the disease to new areas, amplifying the chaos. Many players fled the populated zones, seeking refuge in less inhabited regions to avoid infection.

These diverse reactions turned a simple glitch into a shared and memorable experience. Players became the co-authors of an improvised, collective narrative that emerged organically from their interactions. The Corrupted Blood Incident became more than just a technical error; it evolved into digital folklore, with stories of heroism, villainy, and survival being recounted and remembered within the community.

¹⁷¹ Mattia Thibault, "A Semiotic Exploration of Catastrophes in Game Worlds," *Linguistic Frontiers* 2, no. 1 (2019): 10–15, <https://doi.org/10.2478/lf-2018-0013>.

¹⁷² A "debuff" in video game terminology refers to a temporary negative effect applied to a character or entity, reducing their abilities, attributes, or performance within the game. This mechanic is commonly used to introduce strategic challenges by impairing specific functions such as movement speed, attack power, or defenses.

¹⁷³ A "raid" in *World of Warcraft* and similar MMOs is a coordinated, large-scale group activity in which multiple players work together to overcome complex, high-difficulty challenges – such as powerful enemies or obstacles – typically requiring communication, strategy, and collective effort beyond standard gameplay. Raids serve as central events for community engagement and often involve unique rewards or narrative progression within the game world.

¹⁷⁴ Bosses and boss battles usually represent a „difficult, singular encounter unlike what the player experiences in the rest of the game.“ Boss characters (or bosses) „are usually significantly stronger than other enemies, often having some significance to the plot of the game's story.“ Andrew Wood and Adam Summerville, "Understanding Boss Battles: A Case Study of Cuphead," *Proceedings of the AIIDE Workshop on Experimental AI in Games*, 2019, 1.

¹⁷⁵ In *World of Warcraft*, pets are non-player entities that accompany a player's character, serving various roles such as combat allies, companions, or collectors' items, and are often integrated into gameplay mechanics to enhance player agency, customization, and social interaction within the virtual environment. They function as both practical in-game tools and as sites for personal expression, reflecting the player's identity and engagement with the game's complex social systems.

The event is studied as an example of emergent gameplay and a case study in virtual epidemiology.¹⁷⁶ The way players narrated and reacted to the incident shows the power of communal storytelling in creating a collective history, transforming a moment of disruption into a unique chapter of shared experiences within the game's universe.

2.3.4 Modders

Collective engagement can also be observed within the vibrant communities of game modding,¹⁷⁷ where dedicated players contribute new content, mechanics, and narratives that can significantly expand or alter the original game, further blurring the line between audience and co-creator. Modders inject their creativity and vision into the game through these modifications, fostering a dynamic and participatory culture that enhances and diversifies the gaming experience.

Thus, modding can be understood as a player-driven process of tweaking, adding, altering, or deleting existing game code to transform their gameplay experience or create entirely new game content. This ranges from simple modifications like character skins or custom outfits to complex overhauls introducing new game mechanics, narratives, and levels, effectively transforming the original game into something different. Modding activities encompass:

1. Exploiting bugs, glitches, programming errors, and inconsistencies in game code;

(for example, the infamous *Wolfenstein Barney Patch*, which utilized a flaw in the code to override *Wolfenstein 3D*'s certain assets to dancing Barney characters¹⁷⁸)

2. designing new objects, creating custom assets, spaces, characters, and narratives;

(It is most prominent in *Sims*, a life simulator where modders were able to include their own creations, objects, and virtual designs in the game to better accommodate their own storytelling needs;¹⁷⁹)

¹⁷⁶ Stuart Oultram, "Virtual Plagues and Real-World Pandemics: Reflecting on the Potential for Online Computer Role-Playing Games to Inform Real World Epidemic Research," *Medical Humanities* 39, no. 2 (2013): 115–18, <https://doi.org/10.1136/medhum-2012-010299>.

¹⁷⁷ „»Mod« is an abbreviation of modification and a term coming out of modders [those who modify – note of the researcher], rather than from academic discourse. In this sense, a mod is any form of noncommercial modification of a proprietary digital game. [...] By installing the mod, specific parts or modules of the original software are replaced or extended." Johannes Fromme, *Computer Games and New Media Cultures: A Handbook of Digital Games Studies* (Springer, 2012), 513–14.

¹⁷⁸ Tanja Sihvonon, *Players Unleashed!: Modding the Sims and the Culture of Gaming* (Amsterdam University Press, 2011), 59, <https://doi.org/10.1017/9789048511983>.

¹⁷⁹ Sihvonon, *Players Unleashed!*, 64–65.

3. using the game engine to create remediated online narratives and machinima,¹⁸⁰ taking advantage of the storytelling capabilities of games;

(There are quite a few notable examples of movies and series created in game engines – machinimas; however, one of the most popular is *Red vs. Blue: a Halo-based* sitcom series by Rooster Teeth Productions;¹⁸¹)

4. total conversion: resulting in entirely new games, for instance, *Counter-Strike*, which started as a mod for *Half-Life* and later became a standalone game;

(Besides *Counter-Strike*, more notable examples of total conversion mods could be *Team Fortress* – another *Half-Life* mod –, *Q-Pong*: which converted *Quake* into a table tennis game; and *International Online Soccer*: which – again – converted *Half-Life* into a multiplayer soccer tournament;¹⁸²)

5. enhancing games through community collaboration, reflecting a blend of private and public activities akin to the open-source movement.¹⁸³

Modding forms an essential part of participatory culture and digital content creation, reflecting the intertwined roles of players as both consumers and co-creators of game experiences. These examples above can successfully demonstrate how modders contribute not just to the aesthetics or mechanics of a game, but also to its evolving narrative landscape, reshaping and expanding even the storyworlds to reflect collective creativity and community engagement. The blend of individual talent and collaborative effort in modding highlights the intricate dynamics between cocreation and intermedia, fostering a multifaceted narrative ecosystem.

2.3.5 The Co-Creator and the Transmedia

In the realm of transmedial processes and storytelling networks, the key elements in narrative transactions are fans. This special kind of co-creator is capable of exercising agency within complex systems, such as transmedia franchises or ARGs in some cases.

As briefly mentioned earlier, in a previous segment, a fan can be defined as an enthusiastic follower or admirer of a particular medium, franchise, or narrative. Fans often engage deeply with the content, participating in fan communities, creating their own content inspired by the original work, and influencing the direction and success of the narrative universe. They are crucial in transmedia storytelling as they consume narrative and help expand and enrich it through their active involvement and passion. This definition will also mean that in this research, fans are being referred to as a subject who has the capability (although not always actualized) to move “beyond textual

¹⁸⁰ “The term machinima refers to the film production practice whereby machinimators use real-time computer graphics rendering engines that are built into games. This kind of practice was started in the 1980s demo scene by gamers (i.e. fans), with, for instance, id Software’s *Doom* and *Quake*.” Fromme, *Computer Games and New Media Cultures*, 493.

¹⁸¹ Henry E. Lowood and Michael Nitsche, eds., *The Machinima Reader* (MIT Press, 2011), 257–73.

¹⁸² Lowood and Nitsche, *The Machinima Reader*, 270–71.

¹⁸³ Sihvonen, *Players Unleashed!*, 57–64.

consumption to produce and circulate transformative fan works (such as fan fiction, fan vids or fan art) to establish and strengthen fan communities of practice”.¹⁸⁴

During the discussion regarding the formulaic genealogy of the SCP Foundation universe, a definition of fan fiction was already presented. Here, it may be sufficient to reiterate certain key notions from these works, which highlight that fan fiction and fan theories serve not only as extensions of the narrative but also as sites of communal negotiation and co-creation, where fans can assert their interpretations, diversify narrative possibilities, and collectively contribute to the storyworld's evolution.

Zsófia Nemesi thoroughly explores¹⁸⁵ how the interactions between the fans and the transmedial world of the TV show *Supernatural* influence the narrative and, consequently, the franchise's universe. Focusing on the most notable occurrences of co-creatorial engagements, we should first look at the 200th episode of *Supernatural* (S10E05), *Fan Fiction*. This episode is a remarkable meta-commentary that acknowledges the existence and significance of fan contributions, integrating them into the story's canon and thereby blurring the lines between creator and audience, while illustrating how fan creativity is recognized and celebrated within the narrative framework. This unique dynamic exemplifies the transformative potential of fan engagement, making fans indispensable co-creators in the transmedia storytelling process.¹⁸⁶

Moreover, fan contributions often lead to the emergence of new content, characters, and plotlines, thus continuously expanding and enriching the transmedia narrative universe in ways that would not be possible through traditional media production alone. In the specific case of *Supernatural*, it is worth noting that the authors of the world and the co-creator fans are not only influencing each other regarding the elements of the story (e.g. which characters are beloved, which characters are not – reacting to these emotions and tendencies by either consciously working towards the supposed requests of the fans, or deliberately going against the fan community with specific narrative decisions), but they are also participating in a discussion on a meta-level, too, where the fan practices are being evaluated, constantly forming the attitude of the runners of the show and vice versa. Of course, the agency of fans¹⁸⁷ and the capability of a transmedia network are always determined by its (initial) design, making it harder or easier for the co-creators to impact the storyworld significantly.

The so-called fan theories could be straightforward examples of the impactful gestures made by the co-creator fan community. Amo and García-Rosa explain that these inputs are “interpretative practices” that emerge from the complex semiotic structure of the vast transmedia networks. These works are “published within the virtual community so that they may be discussed, modified, or ratified by the rest of its members.” However, these creations also make waves on the meta-level of the

¹⁸⁴ Suzanne Scott and Melissa A. Click, eds., *The Routledge Companion to Media Fandom* (Routledge, Taylor & Francis Group, 2018), 1–2.

¹⁸⁵ Zsófia Nemesi, “Transzmediális történetmesélés: Intézményi és rajongói tartalmak az Odaát világában,” in *Transzmédia: Interdiszciplináris tanulmányok*, ed. Richárd Fejes and Lilla Gregor (Kijárat Kiadó, 2020).

¹⁸⁶ Nemesi, “Transzmediális történetmesélés,” 175–76.

¹⁸⁷ Nemesi, “Transzmediális történetmesélés,” 172–76.

storyworld, maintaining the constant dialogue between the transmedia designer/author and the co-creators.¹⁸⁸

These fan theories, as Amo and García-Rosa argue, can be classified into three categories: predictive theories (which “aim to advance and infer possible narrative actions that will be developed in the canon”), explanatory theories (that “includes interpretative proposals that attempt to cover hermeneutical gaps or gaps in the text”), and alternative theories (these are structurally similar to explanatory theories, however, these are “the least common and the most complex, as they offer unique, personal, improbable, and creative visions of the fictional universe. These interpretative proposals defy the limits of interpretation”).¹⁸⁹

In the interaction between fan theories and the authorial figure of the transmedial narratives, there are cases when the impact is undeniable: in *Harry Potter*, for instance, J.K. Rowling has publicly acknowledged how fan theories and feedback have influenced the development of her storylines and characters, thus demonstrating the reciprocal relationship between the creator and the fan community.¹⁹⁰ George R. R. Martin has similarly acknowledged the influence of fan speculations and theories on the *A Song of Ice and Fire* series, despite his reputation for guardedness regarding plot details, illustrating the pervasive impact of fan contributions on even the most closely held narrative plans.¹⁹¹ Finally, the creator's involvement with fan theories can be even more visible in transmedia franchises with the video game as its core: for example, *Five Nights at Freddy's* creator Scott Cawthon has actively engaged with fan theories, often incorporating elements from fan speculations into official game lore, even including the more popular fans and content creators in his games as easter eggs thus confirming his commitment to acknowledging the fan base's creative input and further validating their role as co-creators within the transmedia universe. This iterative exchange underscores the evolving nature of storytelling in the digital age, where the boundaries between producer and consumer are increasingly blurred, resulting in richer and more dynamic narrative ecosystems.

¹⁸⁸ José Manuel De Amo and Anastasio García-Roca, “Mechanisms for Interpretative Cooperation: Fan Theories in Virtual Communities,” *Frontiers in Psychology* 12 (June 2021): 2, <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2021.699976>.

¹⁸⁹ Amo and García-Roca, “Mechanisms for Interpretative Cooperation,” 4–6.

¹⁹⁰ Amo and García-Roca, “Mechanisms for Interpretative Cooperation,” 3.

¹⁹¹ Olivia Harvey, “George R.R. Martin Says Game of Thrones Backlash Won’t Affect How He Writes His Final Books,” *Hello Giggles*, July 16, 2019.

3 TOWARD THE NARRATOLOGY OF TRANSMEDIA NETWORKS

The previous introductory chapter provides a bird's eye view of different constellations of the various roles of receivers and the multiple types of narratives ranging from reader to co-creator and from textual to transmedial. In the upcoming chapters, this research explores several specific narrative phenomena that offer direct insights into transmedia storytelling, expanding the analytical framework of these highly interconnected, networked structures deeply embedded in our contemporary media culture while presenting meaningful roots in classical storytelling traditions. The next chapters bridge the gap between established narrative theories and the expansive potential of transmedia storytelling, cultivating a comprehensive discourse that acknowledges the dynamic evolution of narrative forms in response to technological advancements. By examining the intersection of classical narratology with contemporary transmedia practices, this endeavor enriches the understanding of how stories can unfold across multiple platforms, engaging audiences in participatory and transformative ways.

The research builds its exploratory and experimental framework through three steps: first, it identifies the transmedial aspects of structuralist narratology, with a thorough examination of Gérard Genette's methods; second, acknowledging the new dimensions of agency inherently present in transmedia storytelling systems the research broadens its perspective into the territory of video game studies; third and finally, these analytical methods arrange under a network-conscious approach, exploring the opportunities and possibilities emerging from utilizing the tools and procedures of network theory. Throughout each step, the research presents case studies regarding the subject that are illustrative and hands-on. These works also demonstrate practical applications of the developed experimental methodological framework. Let us begin with the proposed first step...

3.1 APPROACHING TRANSMEDIA DISCOURSE

It should not be surprising that the title of this chapter alludes to Gérard Genette's work, *Narrative Discourse*.¹⁹² This part of the dissertation aims to establish a dialogue with Genette's "low structuralism"¹⁹³ and reflect – as it is proposed in the introduction – on his method's transmedial aspects, so a more formal toolbox can be created in the age of post-classical narratologies. A conversation with structuralist approaches will be a starting point for an advanced media-analytical framework and a powerful companion to contemporary narratological perspectives.

Two further comments should be made. First, there should be at least some explanation about why Genette's work should be at the center of focus. *Narrative Discourse* is a prime example of the genesis of a methodology. His famous arguments (mainly) revolve around Marcel Proust's monumental novel, the *Remembrance of Things Past*. Genette builds his approach on specific works, considering certain

¹⁹² Genette, *Narrative Discourse*.

¹⁹³ Robert Scholes, *Structuralism in Literature: An Introduction* (Yale University Press, 1975), 157–58.

elements of Proust's novel as universal and others as counterexamples. Thus synthesizing his unique methodology from bottom to top.¹⁹⁴ *Narrative Discourse* elegantly creates a comprehensive overview of a complex and intertwining terminological system, which is achieved through the colorful illustrative segments of primary literature. This dissertation, or more specifically, this chapter, aims to accomplish the same while broadening the system of Genette with important modifications concerning transmedia narratives.

Second, it is necessary to point out the corpus or the specific case study for this endeavor, thus creating a parallel structure of *Narrative Discourse*. The reason for Genette's choice was that criticism did not address Proust's work as a unique entity but only to corroborate the contemporary theory, so it was reduced to being an illustration and "vanish into the transcendence of »laws of the genre.«"¹⁹⁵ Moreover, the analyzed novel, according to Genette, is *irreducible*, and it illustrates only itself, rendering it, in a way, encyclopedic in nature.¹⁹⁶

The research will take the ARG called EverymanHYBRID as its main subject in this chapter.¹⁹⁷ This transmedia narrative was actualized between 2010 and 2019. It distributed its contents through various internet platforms such as YouTube, Twitter (now X), and Tumblr, as well as other mediums like e-mail or billboards and live game mechanics, for example, geocaching and in-person events. During the ten years of narrative development, more than 400 sites (narrative units, story fragments) emerged from this storyworld. *EverymanHYBRID* (EMH in short) has been selected as a great candidate if we want to investigate the nature of alternate reality games or transmedia narratives due to their sheer magnitude and scale. However, there comes a disadvantage with this subject, too: while in the 1980s Genette could easily refer to the *Recherche*, as it was a classical, well-known piece of modernist art, this is sadly not the case with such recent transmedia work, let alone this quite new form of storytelling, so because of the size and storytelling methods of these ARG networks it is almost impossible to describe their fictional world linearly.

The *EverymanHYBRID* universe was conceived by creating the YouTube channel and submitting its first video (*Introduction*) on March 21st, 2010. At the same time, a second public platform also appeared on the internet: the @EverymanHYBRID Twitter account. These first fragments of the transmedia narrative (or, again, *sites*, as this research will continue to call them) set up a story of a group of college friends (Vince, Evan, and Jeff) who decided to create content on healthy lifestyle and budget fitness tips. With the first two social media accounts (or *channels*), the EMH simulated a similar trend on social media in their diegetic universe. However, at this point, it wouldn't be clear to any of the followers of their material that these sites are parts of a fictional storyworld. This, the denial of the work's fictionality, is a well-discussed key property of alternate reality games. One of the field's most known researchers,

¹⁹⁴ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 23.

¹⁹⁵ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 22.

¹⁹⁶ In the sense, Edward Mendelson used the term in: Edward Mendelson, "Encyclopedic Narrative: From Dante to Pynchon," *MLN* 91, no. 6 (1976): 1267–75, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2907136>.

¹⁹⁷ The ARG's main YouTube channel and Twitter account can be accessed through here: <https://www.youtube.com/user/EverymanHYBRID> and <https://twitter.com/everymanhybrid>.

David Szulborski explained in his book¹⁹⁸ that this characteristic, the so-called TINAG (*This is Not a Game*) principle is already a part of community discussions among the players of ARGs: there are no pre-defined rules and ways to immerse oneself in the narrative; there are no interfaces or unambiguous elements that define the game space or the thresholds of the story; and although there are gamified elements of ARGs, there are no clear winning conditions either.¹⁹⁹ They are powerful narrative systems that create an immersive world²⁰⁰ integrated into the recipients' "online *and* offline lives"²⁰¹ as well. In this way, not even the recipients immerse themselves in ARGs. Still, the ARG is being immersed or embedded in the "real lives" of theirs, establishing another alternate layer of reality on top of the existing one.

Returning to our specific case study, as EMH's story develops, these accounts authored new videos and status updates. The first plot points are starting to become clear soon: in almost every video, they hide a little "easter egg"²⁰² for their fans and followers. This easter egg is the appearance of Slender Man,²⁰³ a once popular part of the internet folk horror scene and what gained notoriety from other video series²⁰⁴ and internet forums. The presence of this (seemingly) paranormal activity was a way for the protagonists to garner views and publicity. Still, they soon came clear with their hoaxes in the video called *Public Service Announcement* (released on May 20th, 2010). The apropos of this coming out was the appearance of a real paranormal threat, the real Slender Man. Then, from the video called *Joke's Over* (released on August 12th, 2010) the protagonists stopped the production of fitness content and began documenting their encounters with the paranormal in written, filmic, and other forms.

Though Slender Man posed a primary threat during 2010, it turned out, that the main antagonist of the whole storyworld is not this well-known mythical creature but a demonic entity, HABIT, whose first influences on the story can be dated around the late summer of 2010, and its first appearance in text around October 2010. Its first on-screen appearance, however, can be dated as late as May 11th, 2012, with the video

¹⁹⁸ Dave Szulborski, *This Is Not a Game: A Guide to Alternate Reality Gaming* (New-Fiction Publishing, 2005).

¹⁹⁹ Szulborski, *This Is Not a Game*, 1–15.

²⁰⁰ Szulborski, *This Is Not a Game*, 17–33.

²⁰¹ Jane McGonigal, "This Is Not a Game': Immersive Aesthetics and Collective Play," *MelbourneDAC: 5th International Digital Arts and Culture Conference*. Melbourne, 2003, n.p.

²⁰² Easter egg is a term (nowadays primarily used in the context of video games) for hidden features present in media content "that is intentionally put in by the [...] creator and is often made difficult to discover. [...] [T]hey are »extras« for [the recipients] and not essential to the [content] in which they appear." Mark J. P. Wolf, ed., *Encyclopedia of Video Games: The Culture, Technology, and Art of Gaming* (Greenwood, an Imprint of ABC-CLIO, LLC, 2021), 277–78.

²⁰³ Slender Man was created on the *Something Awful* internet forum in a thread of a paranormal photoshop contest. This monster is often depicted as a slender, shadowy figure with no face in a suit, growing black tentacles from its body and it is described as a paranormal entity which kidnaps children by luring them to itself.

²⁰⁴ One of the most prominent series which used the Slender Man mythos is the ARG called *Marble Hornets*. (More on the subject: Alex Mitchell et al., eds., *Interactive Storytelling: 7th International Conference on Interactive Digital Storytelling*, Lecture Notes in Computer Science 8832 (Springer, 2014), 148–55.)

called *Box Six* uploaded by TheGreenFeathers.²⁰⁵ Since late 2010, HABIT has taken over the main antagonist and paranormal threat role, and it has remained the case until the very last site of the EMH universe (*Introductions*; uploaded: Jan 1st, 2019).

As for the structural aspect of EMH's narrative system, it presents a more complicated formula than the near-archetypal story of the battle against a paranormal villain. Of course, the most intriguing aspect is how its medial components connect and interact with each other and how the characters of the EMH universe are represented through these channels, alternating between textual, audiovisual, and corporeal representations. So, we could say that while the complexity and grandiosity of *Recherche* emerge from its textual structures, a similar complexity can be observed coming from the transmedial elaboration, thus mainly from the medial structures of *EverymanHYBRID*, rendering it an expressive case study for demonstrating this part of the dissertation's methodology which builds upon the structuralist approach of narratology.

Transmedial narratology is an under-researched yet emerging part of the interdisciplinary field of contemporary narratological theories. Meanwhile, the problems and questions brought up by transmediality are becoming more relevant in the era of social media and post-truth narratives. Thus, analyzing the structures of transmediality, such as the EMH universe, could help us navigate toward a better understanding of these relevant phenomena. With the proposed three steps outlined in this dissertation, the aim is to present a comprehensive methodological toolkit for approaching Narrative Discourse with clarity. Using Genette's work as a standard could help us create a valuable basis for dialogue around the terminological uncertainties of transmedial narratology. By applying or adapting this literary framework to transmedial phenomena, we can address the challenge of lacking a descriptive toolkit for these vast, networked systems. Jan-Noël Thon and some of his colleagues' agenda is very close to this endeavor: to create a terminological and methodological base for a *genuinely* transmedial narratology, which is *not* "the same as a collection of medium-specific narratological terms and concepts."²⁰⁶

This theoretical criterion is essential to note because it signals the analytical direction of this part of the research and the range of transmedia phenomena discussed here: the focus points are those devices and phenomena present *across multiple* media. Thon agreed with Ryan that the aspects of story/discourse (and we may extend this to syuzhet and fabula, too), characters, events, and fictional worlds can all be considered transmedial properties; however, they do not *operate* the same in every medium.²⁰⁷ I would also argue that the aspects Genette thought structurally important in verbal narratives – even though he primarily approached narrative as a form of "linguistic production"²⁰⁸ – should also be considered transmedial: the order, duration, mood, and voice are almost completely adaptable to a transmedial discourse

²⁰⁵ It should be noted that TheGreenFeathers, curiously, was not part of the core creators of the ARG but only a fan of the transmedia storyworld. This gesture presents the instable and pervasive thresholds of these transmedia narrative systems.

²⁰⁶ Jan-Noël Thon, *Transmedial Narratology and Contemporary Media Culture* (University of Nebraska Press, 2016), 15, <https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctt1d8h8vn>.

²⁰⁷ Thon, *Transmedial Narratology and Contemporary Media Culture*, 22.

²⁰⁸ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 30.

as the structures of signified and signifier are the basis of every communicational act, not just written or oral instances.

This approach, which builds upon Genette's discourse while also departing from the primarily verbal or "linguistic" methodology, is not novel in the broader field of narratology. In film theory, Seymour Chatman,²⁰⁹ David Bordwell,²¹⁰ and others have recognized the connection between structuralist narratology and the transmedial nature of language in film narratives, as well as the applicability of Genette's discourse to cinema.²¹¹ Questions of mimesis versus diegesis (or the problem of showing and telling)²¹² in movies and the temporality of the montage²¹³ are all directly and explicitly connected to Genette's terminological field.

Narratological structures observed, described, and analyzed by structuralists cannot be treated as exclusive properties of verbal narratives but rather as transmedial aspects of storytelling. Thon advocates for a transmedial framework that accommodates medium-specific representations of narration, as demonstrated through his analyses of comics (*Maus*),²¹⁴ films (*Pulp Fiction*),²¹⁵ and video games (*Dragon Age*).²¹⁶ He proposes recognizing narratological concepts as transmedial phenomena while emphasizing that their realizations and analysis vary across media, shaped by the unique affordances of each medium. This approach is what Thon refers to as the concept of medium-specific charity,²¹⁷ where audiences reconcile narrative gaps while respecting medium-specific constraints.

The Genettian discourse revolves around the temporal and spatial dimensions of narratives. Anachrony²¹⁸ and anisochrony²¹⁹ both can be considered temporal aspects, while the notion of distance,²²⁰ perspective,²²¹ and the problems of the narrator are spatial questions (in some cases, in a more abstract fashion).²²² While these dimensions are to be kept while speaking about a transmedial discourse, we should involve a third axis that is obvious in our case and is absent from Genette's: the medial dimension, which is quite significant while discussing ARGs or other transmedia entities.

²⁰⁹ Chatman, *Story and Discourse*.

²¹⁰ David Bordwell, *Poetics of Cinema* (Routledge, 2008).

²¹¹ Especially: Bordwell, *Poetics of Cinema*, 85–133; Chatman, *Story and Discourse*, 146–95.

²¹² Chatman, *Story and Discourse*, 31–34.

²¹³ Again, referring back to Bordwell's chapter: the *Three Dimensions of Film Narrative* in Bordwell, *Poetics of Cinema*.

²¹⁴ Thon, *Transmedial Narratology and Contemporary Media Culture*, 91–94.

²¹⁵ Thon, *Transmedial Narratology and Contemporary Media Culture*, 76–83.

²¹⁶ Thon, *Transmedial Narratology and Contemporary Media Culture*, 105–20.

²¹⁷ Thon, *Transmedial Narratology and Contemporary Media Culture*, 87–122.

²¹⁸ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 35–47.

²¹⁹ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 86–112.

²²⁰ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 162–64.

²²¹ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 185–89.

²²² However transmedial these aspects are, Genette's approach undoubtedly revolves around the different aspects of the grammatical unit of verbs, supposedly elevating the study of narratives to a higher level of scientificity. See: Liisa Steinby, "Time, Space, and Subjectivity in Gérard Genette's *Narrative Discourse*," *Poetics Today* 37, no. 4 (2016): 581, <https://doi.org/10.1215/03335372-3638081>.

Mediality is especially important, for example, when analyzing anisochronies: The speed of narrative time and consumption redefine themselves on a whole other level when considering the “medial gaps” between the sites and fragments of the narrative. But the medial dimension redefines the questions of focalization, distance, and narratorial agency. Moreover, discussing diegesis and mimesis becomes even more complex when considering alternate reality game narratives.

3.2 ANALYZING THE EVERYMANHYBRID ARG WITH A STRUCTURAL-IST APPROACH

The discordance between the time of the story (fabula) and the time of narration (syuzhet) gives rise to various narratological devices, which Genette discusses in depth. The main aspect of asynchronicity between the raw material of the story and its organization is called *anachrony*. An anachrony can point forward (*prolepsis*); take the narration into the past (*analepsis*); take a “sidestep” in the narration, omitting certain information of the current storyline (*paralepsis*); or move the narration to a temporally unidentifiable place in the story (*achrony*). These anachronies, however, are always relative to a specified “first narrative.”²²³ This is the main temporal level from which every temporal discordance is to be defined. Genette illustrated it with Book XIX of Homer’s *Odyssey*, in which Ulysses evokes how he got a certain wound.²²⁴ The idea of the discretization of story elements leads to the idea of symbolizing the “zigzagging” of a narration’s temporality. However, this consideration of discrete elements is especially relevant to the nature of transmedia storytelling, as, in the case of these kinds of narrations, the elements are not entirely selected subjectively. Still, during the analysis, the researcher must consider empirical evidence more closely.

3.2.1 Transmedial Anachronies

As mentioned, ARG sites can be YouTube videos, tweets, blog posts, or even real-world objects. This research argues that while we discuss the possibilities of transmedia narratologies from a Genettian perspective, the anachronies can only be fruitfully accounted for *between* sites and not *inside* the sites themselves, simply because, on the one hand, that would be the realm of a certain media-specific (mono-medial) narratological discourse. On the other hand, this creates an analytical tool to account for the effects of the *act* of storytelling on the narrative. It is important to remember that transmedial mechanics are born between the narrative fragments and from the movement of the hunters and gatherers chasing after these. Moreover, this approach also keeps the temporal complexity of these systems at the forefront of our analyses. It is uniquely important when one investigates a network of mediums and their interactions, such as in the case of transmedia phenomena. ARGs and other works with similar narrative processes always use different mediums to convey the message, and this implies a clash between temporalities – an experience that can originate from Friedrich Kittler’s observations about how different media encodes

²²³ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 48.

²²⁴ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 48.

reality and time,²²⁵ and Wolfgang Ernst's theories on how different media produces their temporalities (Eigenzeit).²²⁶

So, for example, if we take a look at the EMH video site titled “- - -” (June 20th, 2010) intramedially, we can isolate cinematic anachronies: flashbacks and flashforwards. There are embedded clips in the “first narrative” of the video where we can see footage (or a resembling footage) from “*A Day in the Life*” (June 1st, 2010), while in the meantime there are clips edited in from a yet (as of June 1st) unreleased video called “78of76.avi” (August 26th, 2010). Furthermore, clips from the “*A Day in the Life*” video are inserted in four more future videos.²²⁷ These instances can also be examples of transmedial ana- and prolepses because these videos are independent video sites in the EMH universe.

From an analytical perspective, it is beneficial to create a coding system for the sequence of these transmedia anachronies, much like in *Narrative Discourse*, and it is easy to adopt a similar method. Genette uses letters and numbers to describe the anachronies in several segments of the *Recherche*.²²⁸ The letters signify the place in the actual discourse (in the text), and the numbers indicate the chronological order from the perspective of the fabula. By omitting a few sites, we would code the previously discussed series as:

“*A Day in the Life*” **A1**

“- - -” **B1/B2/B3**

“78of76.avi” **C3**

In this sequence, we can see that the middle site (B) could be considered a prolepsis to A1 and even analeptic to C3; however, it can also stand alone as an autonomous development of the narrative.

Complications arise when we are dealing with transmedia anachronies happening not only across different sites but different channels or even different mediums. This becomes visible when the story begins to operate with the “Dr. Corenthal storyline,” which hints at the fact that the misadventures of the protagonists are an alternate iteration of a series of similar events that happened during the ‘70s. In these letters from the past, both the characters and the recipients (players/readers)²²⁹ are getting information on a certain Dr. James Corenthal, MD, who works as a clinical psychiatrist dealing with homicidal and other horrifying deeds of children.

These letters are analeptic to the “first narrative”; however, they are not presented through the same channel as, for example, most of the EMH videos. This brings us to

²²⁵ Friedrich Kittler, “Real Time Analysis, Time Axis Manipulation,” trans. Geoffrey Winthrop-Young, *Cultural Politics* 13, no. 1 (2017): 1–18, <https://doi.org/10.1215/17432197-3755144>.

²²⁶ Wolfgang Ernst, “From Media History to *Zeitkritik*,” *Theory, Culture & Society* 30, no. 6 (2013): 132–46, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0263276413496286>.

²²⁷ The referenced videos are titled „- -, „- . . .“, „77of76.avi“ and „Centralia“

²²⁸ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 38–47.

²²⁹ Depending on what aspects one would like to emphasize, the exact noun that a text uses for the recipient of an ARG can vary. In this sub-chapter, the dissertation will use „player“, while completely aware of the terminological ambiguity it may evoke.

the problem of encoding the medial dimension, labeling them with Greek letters. Thus creating the series below.

“Ashen Waste” (October 23 rd , 2010) A2α
“Evan’s fine. We took him to [...]” (October 23 rd , 2010) B2β
Retrieval of “Box #3” (October 25 th , 2010) C3γ
The first Corenthal Report (October 25 th , 2010) D1γ
“@Fissioninferno Is this [...]” (October 26 th , 2010) E4β
Diagram (October 26 th , 2010) F4δ
“Centralia” (November 4 th , 2010) G5α

There should be a small explanation under this list. This sequence is the curated list of sites around the retrieval of the first letter of Dr. Corenthal by a real-life player of the story with the username FlyingWarhorse. The first site (“*Ashen Waste*”) is a video uploaded to the EMH account where we can follow the protagonists on a road trip on which they happen to find a handwritten letter with real-life coordinates on it. The Greek letter α represents the medium of video. The second site on the list is a tweet posted by Jeff simultaneously with the road trip. The Greek letter β represents the medium of Twitter (now X). The third site is the real-life retrieval of a box that the diegetic antagonist of the EMH universe supposedly left. The box was hidden at the coordinates shown in the “*Ashen Waste*” video. The letter γ here symbolizes the medium of a real-life object. Inside this box, FlyingWarhorse finds the report written by Dr. Corenthal in 1971; thus, chronologically, this is the first in the order. The letter δ that signifies the picture medium should also be noted here. It was uploaded synchronously with the tweet preceding it. Finally, the closing element is another video, progressing the narration further.

With these observations and these additions to Genette’s method, the dissertation states that while there are the same kinds of analepses and prolepses (external-internal, heterodiegetic-homodiegetic, and completing-repeating²³⁰), we need to add intra- and transmediality to these types: there is an intramedial analepsis when

²³⁰ Though, here the paper does not go into details regarding how these properties are happening in some transmedia narratives, let us see a few notable examples. *The Matrix* franchise would be a viable choice to illustrate these. We can talk about external heterodiegetic analepses in the case of *The Animatrix* (2003) anime short *World Record*, in which a separate storyline can be seen dated somewhere before the first movie site. Internal homodiegetic repeating analepsis could be illustrated by the video game *The Matrix: Path of Neo* (2005), where the player can play through the main storyline of the movie series, however, being a video game, it also gives the player more insight, more possibilities, more freedom to roam the virtual premises, thus filling in occasional paralepses. Finally, the case of *Enter the Matrix* (2003) is also worth to note, as this transmedia site works as an internal heterodiegetic (although it could be argued against) completing analepsis as it leads the player into a flashback narrative of two supporting characters of the main storyline.

taking into account the first presented sequence with the video “- - -”, however, we can talk about a truly transmedial external heterodiegetic completing analepsis when we examine the second sequence above with the Corenthal letter as illustration.

At this point, it is important to consider the different methods of creating or signaling these anachronic occurrences. In monomedial narrations, these features are expressed with the help of the medium’s specific narratological toolbox: in textual works it could be expressed verbally, making the flashforwards and -backs explicit; in films, one can utilize the visual dimension, for example, using different tones for different chronological segments, or could use paratextual cues too. However, when we are dealing with transmedial anachronies, the hints, most of the time, are much more implicit, materialistic, and medium-specific.

In the Corenthal sequence, the report is dated to 1971 (which signals the *reach* of the analepses), and the report’s text refers to a character named Evan (who is not entirely the same as the protagonist Evan), thus erecting a bridge between the narrative gaps. An even more important connection between the found box and the narrative of the preceding EMH video is the coordinates written on the paper the protagonists stumbled upon during their road trip. This geographical puzzle is an *enigma* that is much more material than the ones Barthes’ *hermeneutic code* states but not unlike it:²³¹ it constitutes a suspension that contains the promise of a delayed resolution.

In *Narrative Discourse*, Genette coins the terms *reach* and *extent* which are further properties that help differentiate between external and internal types of anachronies.²³² However, with the medial dimension in mind, it is essential to insert an addition at this point, too. This terminological adjustment will help distinguish intra- and transmedial anachronies. So, while the *reach* informs us about the temporal distance (the first Corenthal document’s reach is 39 years) and the *extent* about the duration of the anachrony (a few months of events in the Corenthal case), a third property, *vehicle*, will inform us about the medial nature of the occurrence (in our example, it is the letter, an object which carries out the analeptic effect). If the vehicle of the anachrony is the same as the vehicle of the determined first narrative, then we are talking about intramedial anachrony; otherwise, we are dealing with a transmedial one.

Revising Genette’s terminologies of anachrony is an important step in proving that these phenomena of narrative time are not only observable in the discourse of verbal narratives but also in the transmedia discourse. Moreover, transmedia narratives are even more prone to utilize anachronistic devices because of the fragmented nature of their storytelling structure. In ARGs, we have sites of videos, blog posts, and objects such as a pendrive or a book; in other transmedia franchises, we have whole movie sites (like *The Matrix*) interacting with AAA video games (such as *Enter the Matrix* or *The Matrix: The Path of Neo*). This means that ordering is one of the main strategies transmedia discourses operate with.

²³¹ Barthes, *S/Z*, 28–30.

²³² Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 47–48.

3.2.2 Transmedial Anisochronies

If we analyze the duration of the narrating act and how it relates to the story's time, we are dealing with *anisochronies*. Genette argues that, unlike in the case of anachronies, creating a narrative without anisochronies is impossible.²³³ These devices are responsible for the “rhythm” of the discourse. This rhythm could be categorized into four main categories: summary (where the duration of the story is longer than the length of narration), pause (where the duration of the story is infinitely smaller than the length of narration), ellipsis (where the duration of the story is infinitely greater than the length of narration), and finally scene (where the duration of the story is relatively the same as the length of narration).

This model cannot be easily adapted for transmedia narratives as in the same way as in the case of anachronies, transmedia can only be studied in-between narrative instances to make observations in the realm “above” (or independently of) the mono-medial discourses. If we discuss the Genettian rhythm or the discordance between the duration and the narrative (text), we deal with it in a single medium.

But this does not mean that duration in the sense of rhythm is not a factor in transmedial narratives. More so, it would be wise to rename these devices from the Genettian anisochronies to *rhythm*. The change is necessary because, in this sense, we do not examine the discordance between the narrative act and the length of the story but the frequency of sites in relation to their respective length.

However, it is necessary to acknowledge that at this point, we wander a bit further from both the narratological context of Genette and of transmedial storytelling as the matter of rhythm is strongly related to seriality. So, it is worth noting that while this dissertation is trying to remain inside the confines of a (more or less) narratological field, the methodology (because of transmedial phenomena’s medial complexity) needs to include this aspect of design or publishing strategy too.

First, let us look at the frequency of the sites. It consists of two other factors: the number of sites over time. This can give us widely different results throughout transmedia creations. Let’s see how the Matrix franchise maintained its rhythm during its (official) activity:²³⁴

The Matrix (March 31st, 1999)
Enter the Matrix (May 14th, 2003)
The Matrix Reloaded (May 15th, 2003)
The Animatrix (June 3rd, 2003)
The Matrix Comics (October 2003)
The Matrix Revolutions (November 5th, 2003)

²³³ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 88.

²³⁴ Not considering here sites created by fans or secondary literature building upon the official sites.

The Matrix Comics (Pt. 2) (February 2005)

The Matrix Online (March 22nd, 2005)

The Matrix: Path of Neo (November 7th, 2005)

This shows us that the franchise had two major waves of sites: one during the year 2003 and the other in 2005. The rhythm is uneven, and most of the (official) information was relayed during 2003. This, of course, primarily bears a financial and industrial impact; however, from a narratological perspective, it shows us that during the wave of 2003, the franchise had more opportunity (in a temporal and quantitative sense) to detail its storyworld rather than solely focusing on building its main storyline.²³⁵

In contrast to the Matrix franchise, the EMH ARG operates with a much higher frequency. EMH had 47 sites yearly, higher than Matrix's 1.3 average sites. Of course, the difference is inherently coming from their respective transmedia structures: EMH is an ARG, which creates an immersive, almost real-time experience for its audience; the Matrix, on the other hand, is a transmedia franchise that works with more standard formats (such as movies and comic books) and standard publishing processes, thus not focusing primarily on the aspect of overwhelming immersion and player interactions but on the in-depth storytelling.

Another notable difference between the two franchises is how constant their ways of storytelling are. While the Matrix franchise had three waves of site publishing, and between these waves, there were years without any submission, EMH never had a year without a site. It doesn't mean there were no momentary hiatuses in content; it means that EMH had not lost its momentum in a narratological sense on the yearly scale, establishing a vastly different experience.

This directs us toward a transmedial property of narratives, which does not have a parallel case in *Narrative Discourse* as intramedial narratives are uninterrupted and continuous. This dissertation proposes the term *fluidity*, which describes how transmedia sites are being distributed over the course of their actualization, focusing on the duration of the hiatuses in the distribution of their separate sites. However, when discussing fluidity, one should state the scope of the examination, too, of course. For example, on a yearly scale, EMH is more fluid than the Matrix franchise. But, if we analyze EMH weekly and Matrix on a yearly basis, we won't get the same impression regarding fluidity. From this perspective, ARG narratives tend to be more fluid than other transmedia franchises, as stated above.

Finally, another key property of the sites should be discussed here regarding the subject of rhythm. Besides the production value of the two previously mentioned transmedia instances, the sites also differ in length. So, while the Matrix franchise is operating with movies with an average of 134 minutes of running time and games operating with an average of over 8 hours of gameplay,²³⁶ EMH offers 4 minutes on average

²³⁵ This is further underpinned by the fact that the comics, *The Animatrix*, and *Enter the Matrix* all introduced supplementary and world-building content primarily rather than concentrating on the next steps of storytelling in a chronological sense.

²³⁶ According to <https://howlongtobeat.com/>.

per video site in the first year. Separately speaking, the Matrix franchise offers longer engagement per site than EMH does, thus making it visible on another level how these narratives obey different design principles.

This brings us to examine how the frequency and the length of the sites can be related, bringing into play the *narrative movements* of Genette.²³⁷ However, these are assessed on a transmedial level. The result brings us closer to a categorization method for transmedia creations, forming four different theoretical forms of narrative information distribution:

Frequency of sites: low – Length of sites: low <i>(Some web-based ARGs such as Cat Ghost²³⁸)</i>
Frequency of sites: high – Length of sites: high <i>(TV series with regular transmedia tie-ins)</i>
Frequency of sites: high – Length of sites: low <i>(Most ARGs, for example, EMH)</i>
Frequency of sites: low – Length of sites: high <i>(Most transmedia franchises, for example, the Matrix)</i>

As we can see, only two categories have exact and more definable examples: the third and fourth. The former mirrors most ARGs' structure as they operate with short, easily consumable fragments of information. The game-based, video-based, photographic, object-based, textual, and website-based sites render the ARG accessible for the audience and more immersive than other transmedia narratives. EMH, *Marble Hornets*, *ILoveBees*, and *The Beast* are all based on this distribution structure (to mention a few works that multiple theoreticians have already investigated).

The fourth category, however, works with the opposite design principle: the sites are published with low frequency, while in the meantime, they are much more engaging and demand more concentrated time from their audience. The examples we could bring here are the Marvel Cinematic Universe or the previously mentioned Matrix Universe.

The other two did not clearly outline what specific forms they could describe, but we can point out some examples in these categories. First, the low frequency – moderate length can define, for example, those ARGs that are hardly regular in their submissions, and even when they publish a fragment of information, it is following the more consumable forms. The illustration here was another YouTube-based transmedia series, *Cat Ghost*, which produced roughly 15 video sites (with very low average duration) and 9 (relatively short) games tied in the narrative universe throughout the first

²³⁷ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 94–95.

²³⁸ The video sites can be accessed through the *Cat Ghost* channel:
<https://www.youtube.com/@CatGhost> (last accessed: 2025. 08. 14.)

iteration's (or saga's – as the creator calls it) 3 years. This creates a different kind of player experience: the games immerse the player into the storyworld, but it does not make the illusion of synchronicity or parallelism as strong as the EMH's diary-like format. Transmedia creations with this structure could perhaps be labeled as storytelling systems *with* ARG elements.

The final category, which could be defined as high in frequency and long regarding the length of sites, is again challenging to outline as a single form of transmedia storytelling. This structure could describe a hypothetical creation with a regular flow of longer narrative fragments. For example, a TV series with rich transmedial capacities, like the Norwegian-created but internationally adapted and Facebook-distributed *Skam*. The show's concept is to show the everyday lives of a group of teenage students. The video sites are submitted irregularly on Facebook in sync with the actual happenings that are taking place in the storyworld. So, if the site depicts events at night, the clips will also be uploaded during the night. Besides the video sites, the protagonists' fictional social media accounts also present more narrative fragments; thus, following the updates on Instagram or Facebook can give the consumer more insight into the storyworld. The format of *Skam* heavily relates to the second distribution structure on the list as it generates content with high frequency, and the duration of these sites was arguably lengthier than that of general ARGs.

		Frequency of site	
Length of site	Low	Artworks with ARG elements (<i>Cat Ghost</i>)	ARGs (<i>EverymanHYBRID</i>)
	High	<i>Skam</i>	Transmedia Franchises (<i>Matrix</i>)

1. Table - Summary of distribution structures

The temporal devices operating in a monomedial discourse cannot be utilized directly when encountering transmedial narratives. With the revision of Genettian terminology, we could sketch up a methodological toolkit that helps to grasp the vast systems of these kinds of narrative artworks. During this revision, we saw that the typology of anachronies could be more or less adapted to the transmedia discourse by adding another, medial dimension. However, when we consider anisochronic devices, the adaptation from verbal narratives (or from monomedial) to transmedial is not as smooth: the discordance between the duration of the story and the length of the narrative is only making sense in the discourse of a single medium. The duration and frequency of transmedia narratives are problematic on another level, which is related to Victorian serials and, for example, TV series.²³⁹

²³⁹ The problematization of rhythm was not born with the emergence of transmedia narratives. Reflecting on interruptions, discontinuations, and the division of narrative was also present in literature during the 18th century. (More on this transmedia feature in: Tom Keymer, "Reading Time in Serial Fiction before Dickens," *The Yearbook of English Studies* 30 (2000): 34–45, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3509240>; David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 527.) Furthermore, it is also important to draw the attention to the fact that while the analysis of the serialized fiction might be primarily a philological investigation, transmedial narratives, however, convey their narrative information by expanding into the realm of the act, synchronous unfolding and often ephemerality, thus exploring

3.2.3 Spatiality of Transmedia Narratives

Stepping away from the temporal dimension of the Genettian discourse, we encounter the spatial aspects of the narrative. These elements are the different notions of narrative instances:²⁴⁰ the place of the person or narrator in the discourse, the mimetic distance of storytelling, the points of view, and the narrative levels.²⁴¹ The spatiality of monomedial works can be dissected with the help of their respective narratological methodology. When considering literary texts, we focus on discerning the relative level of the narrative instance – where is it located compared to the first narrative, and where can we place the narrator's person in this system? Identifying these factors, we position them inside Genette's frame of reference for extra- intra-, hetero-, or homodiegesis. Besides the positioning of the narrative instance, we also analyze the perspective of this instance, thus moving from an external examination to an internal one. Here, Genette determines the type of speech the instance utilizes at certain times: narrated, transposed (uttered transposed or inner transposed), or immediate speech; and also describes how the narrative instance "sees," or how the events are *focalized*. It could be either a nonfocalized narrative (where the narrative instance knows more than the character), internal focalization (when the narrative instance knows approximately the same as the character), or externally focalized narrative (when the narrator knows less than the character).

These classifications, however, could be easily contested, as numerous narratologists already have. The problem of focalization was often the focus of Genette's critics. Mieke Bal broadened the term, arguing that the focalizer is not a singular entity but a unit in a hierarchy that also consists of *focalizing* (as an act) and the *focalized* (as a subject).²⁴² This is a crucial point to be made, as this points out the contrast between "who sees?" and "who speaks?" (or even: "who evaluates?").²⁴³

The problem of focalization or point-of-view is enhanced when we consider the medium of the film. The movies have a multi-channel toolbox to express focalization: information can be visual and auditory.²⁴⁴ This means that the act of focalizing can not only be done with the help of a verbal medium but also with the capabilities of the camera and perhaps of the nonverbal nature of music. This dissertation won't go into much detail regarding the vast literature on film narratology as that reaches beyond the confines of this research.

publishing strategies of the fragments (in its broadest sense) cease to be a mere philological interrogation and becomes part of the narratological discourse.

²⁴⁰ In a footnote of the English version of *Narrative Discourse* the translator explains in a brief detour the genealogy of the author's choice and use of the term "instance" as something to be synonymously used for the "narrative situation". (Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 31.) To avoid the potential risk of misinterpreting this latter term in this dissertation, in the trans-medial discourse, the broader and less loaded "narrative instance" will be used.

²⁴¹ Genette only considered the problems around „voice" to be a matter of the narrating instance (Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 213–15.). This dissertation discusses the narrating instance with the addition of distance and perspective too while excluding the temporal dimension of the narrating act.

²⁴² Mieke Bal, ed., *Narrative Theory* (Routledge, 2004), 272–73.

²⁴³ Rimmon-Kenan explains it in a very illustrative way: Shlomith Rimmon-Kenan, *Narrative Fiction: Contemporary Poetics* (Routledge, Taylor & Francis Group, 2011), 73–76.

²⁴⁴ Chatman, *Story and Discourse*, 158–59.

A further dimension that will be explored later is the question of interactivity and action. This extra layer is becoming increasingly relevant if one is dealing with games, or more precisely, video games. The growing discipline of game studies has focused on how games and their narratives have been focalized in the past ten years and how player interaction can be fitted into this structure. These issues will be brought up again in the next chapter. Still, it is already apparent how important and intertwined agency and interactivity are when encountering transmedia narratives and narratorial figures.

3.2.4 Transmedia Narratives from a Distance

It is evident that when we examine the narrative instance of an ARG, we can talk about it from two approaches. First, we can take into inventory the countless situations on the level of the narrative system's different channels and sites. This way, we are talking about a collection of diverse narratological situations, moods, and methods of focalizations. Literary, cinematic, and ludological narratology approaches can be applied separately in these transmedia systems. However, this does not guide us toward the narratology of a comprehensive transmedial approach. Instead, it would only show us that ARGs operate with various mediums and forms of storytelling, rendering these works as curiously complex systems without being able to provide coherent interpretations.

The truly transmedial approach would be if we consider the whole network of the ARG as one system or as one narrative instance. With this in mind, we can approach creating an inventory or description from two distinct directions: one from the standpoint of the narrative and one from the player's perspective. This means that there are aspects to account for on the level of the story or the plot; this might prove to be the analysis of more inert or passive entities, which is closer to the subjects of more classical narratological methods. The other standpoint of this systemic approach would be exploring from the recipients' points of view how one interacts with the ARG network and how one can affect it, so we would focus on the "game" aspects of the alternate reality games. Again, these questions pave the way for the dissertation's upcoming chapters and highlight that the methodologies of (video) game studies and network-conscious theories will gain even more significance.

As a preliminary result, it is worth demonstrating how the structuralism-inspired approach already constructed can give valuable insights into advanced narrative techniques. Starting from the narrative viewpoint, the first challenge is that it is rather complex to talk about ARGs' narrative instances in a unified and inclusive manner. However, measuring the impact of singular situations is possible, thus mapping the system's collective properties.

EMH mainly contains seven competing narratorial figures and five major platforms (such as YouTube, email, and Tumblr) to be utilized by these "voices." Throughout the narrative, the player encounters instances of internally and externally focalized sites; however, there are no examples of nonfocalized ones: we never see with "vision from behind."²⁴⁵

²⁴⁵ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 189.

The distance varies widely: we encounter immediacy when watching most of the video sites of the main EMH channel – with just a few exceptions, the development of the plot is represented directly in these videos. Of course, it is worth noting that sites like “*No hysterics. Not yet.*” give us opposing examples as in videos like these, the narrative instance provides us with more distant and transposed instances when, for example, describing past events which are not represented in any other, more mimetic forms. The more distant narratorial situations are produced mainly through textual platforms like Twitter and Tumblr. Sites on these sites most of the time allow players to gain indirect insights or reports on previous events of the diegesis, hardly creating an intense mimetic experience.

The most mimetic and immersive experiences can be achieved while using the real world as the medium of the story. During the live phase of EMH, there were numerous occasions when the narrative instance took place in the actual real world of its players. The retrieval of Box #3 was mentioned previously as a pivotal moment in the narrative. It was an organic part of the plot, which was found by a player, “FlyingWarhorse,” on 25th October 2010 at the coordinates 40°18’05.1” N 74°52’24.8” W. The box was a hollowed-out book containing three defaced pictures, a business card, a paper with a coded message, another folded paper, and the previously mentioned piece of the *Corenthal Report*.

These objects were not merely representations of the storyworld. They were bits and pieces of it. They bore direct significance and direct connections with the ARG's plot and characters. These material items *were* the storyworld. If we consider the object itself a narrative instance, then the distance of this is closer than any literary artifact can ever be.

Looking at the various distances of the numerous narrative instances, we can measure the fluctuation of this factor in the ARG system. Moreover, one could also make observations about the total number of different distances in the whole narrative, thus pointing out the proportions of immediacy. This is a model that this research has not created yet but might be worth exploring in the future.

On the other hand, we can examine the specific narrative instances’ voices regarding their involvement in the narrative – rendering them hetero- or homo-, extra- or intra-diegetic -, thus describing the narrative levels, and in the meantime, we can make observations on the actual instance who/what owns the narratorial power. While the former gives us a more microstructural analysis, the latter can give us a macrostructural overview, as the owners of narrative instances exist across the different mediums (transmedially) in the ARG network.



Figure 1: Percentages of Narrative Instance Affiliation²⁴⁶

The sites of an ARG can be affiliated with certain characters of the storyworld. This analysis was done with the 419 identified sites of EMH.²⁴⁷ With this data, we can create a holistic overview of the narrating characters projected onto the ARG system to observe the size of authority and the importance of these different narrative agents. Specifically, let's take the example of the EMH system (Figure 1). We can tell that the main antagonist, HABIT, has the most significant portion as the owner of narrative instances; however, what should be also pointed out is that the category called 'Other' is ranking as the third most significant "character" to own narrative instances. It should be noted that under this label, the research categorized all those narratorial agents that were not part of the core fictional character pool; instead, they are agents from outside the fictions: like FlyingWarhorse or other actants of the outside world. This should indicate that the EMH system is rendering the actual, extradiegetic, extrafictional dimension to play an essential role as owners of narrative instances – questioning the borders between "outside reality" and fiction.

²⁴⁶ Figures that are referred to here in the form of QR codes are parts of the digital appendix for this dissertation. The overview page can be reached at <https://afejesrichard.github.io/elte.transmedia/> (last accessed: 2025. 08. 14.), and the entirety of the code is repositated at Zenodo. (Richard Fejes, *Afejesrichard/Elte.Transmedia: Digital Appendix - Narratologies of Transmedia Networks*, version v1.3, Zenodo, released August 13, 2025, <https://doi.org/10.5281/ZENODO.16859520>.)

²⁴⁷ Please note that these sites were not given weights to account for potential differences in their respective narrative durations. In this example, experiment, only the number of sites had been accounted for. This presents a more limited but still significant overview of the storytelling system.



Figure 2: Fluctuation of Dominating Voices (Affiliation-based)

Apart from the holistic analysis and visualization of the owners of narrative instances, inspecting their fluctuation in a diachronic fashion is worthwhile. This way, it is possible to create diagrams (Figure 1 and Figure 2) of how the system changes its focus from one voice or character to another. The first fluctuation diagram shows how the voices were consolidated during the ARG: from the more chaotic and “polytonal” early years, the narrative reduced to using only three or four voices towards 2017 and 2018.



Figure 3: Fluctuation of Dominating Voices (Expressed in Percentages)

The second fluctuation diagram (Figure 3) used the same input data of the numbers of sites; however, here, the narratorial dominance is presented proportionally to the ARG’s calendar years, thus showing the size of the portions the owners of the narrative instances represent at a certain point in time. The consolidation of voices is even more visible from this perspective. Moreover, we can learn from this visualization

about the changes in the main protagonists: from 2010 to 2011, Jeff was the one who dominated the transmedia discourse of the EMH core group. However, the decrease in importance around 2011 coincided with the growth of the voice of the “others.” From this, we can hypothesize that the shift in narrative power was set in motion by opening the ARG system for more enhanced consumer interactions.

These are just a few examples of how to think about and analyze alternate reality games and transmedia storytelling instances from a systemic perspective, building upon the theoretical principles of classical narratology and showing analyses from the narratorial point of view.

As a final dimension, the flow of information could also provide valuable knowledge on how narrative instances are structured. First, the notions of distance and voice were explored on a transmedial level. Next, it is worth looking at the channels that distribute all the different types of narrative information.



Figure 4: Fluctuation of Channel Usage (Separately Counted)



Figure 5: Fluctuation of Channel Usage (Expressed as Percentages)

In this sense, channels are the uniquely defined platforms of transmedia entities that publish the sites. This means that a channel could be either a Twitter account on the internet or Twitter itself, depending on the specific nature of the transmedia system. For example, in the EMH network, we consider YouTube, Twitter, emails, the real world, etc., as channels. When we take the Matrix transmedia franchise, the channels could be comics, video games, and movies.²⁴⁸ More complex transmedia entities (like ARGs) require an inquiry into how the narrative instances are distributed through the different channels, too. It could provide deeper insight into the narrative network's structure.

These diagrams illustrating channel fluctuation display the transmedia network's medial properties (Figure 4). It is easily discernible that Twitter (in the early years) and YouTube are the two dominant channels for the sites. However, the latter has become the primary information-distributing platform, rendering the ARG a video-heavy narrative. Reading Figure 4, it is apparent that while Twitter's textual channel is declining rapidly in terms of the number of sites, YouTube has produced a steadier flow of sites throughout the narrative.

It is also possible to produce an illustrative diagram of channel fluctuation, which depicts what portions the different channels represent compared to the whole at a certain point in time (Figure 5). Here, instead of observing the absolute numbers of sites distributed by a specific medium, we can study the changes in importance more effectively. From this perspective, YouTube's dominance is indisputable. But what should also be considered is that interestingly, towards the endgame of the story-world, the textual channels are coming back, creating another wave of multimodality similar to how it was during the 2010-2011 period of EMH.

These visualizations and the taxonomy of consumer actions do not exhaust every possibility in the realm of transmedia discourses' analysis. However, these methods

²⁴⁸ In this example the channels are almost entirely coinciding with the mediums the sites represent, however, this might not be useful during the analysis of every transmedia project.

for studying the spatial dimension of these narrative systems can provide a valuable toolbox for further research and discussions.

Genette's terminology can be regarded as an efficient basis for developing a transmedial approach: the notions of anachronies and anisochronies have proved valuable in adapting to this postclassical environment. Moreover, certain aspects of the Genettian mood and voice could also make them suitable for studying transmedia entities. To conclude this segment, it is essential to recognize the importance and utility of a theoretical perspective that not only examines the transmedia system's monomedial narratologies in isolation but also, simultaneously, produces analyses with the aid of a more holistic, truly transmedial approach. The research will build upon further layers that can refine and crystallize this comprehensive methodology.

3.3 THE PLAYER OF THE TRANSMEDIA DISCOURSE

All transmedial works – especially ARGs – base their meaning-making processes on user interactions and participation²⁴⁹ from non-fiction works,²⁵⁰ through transmedia journalism,²⁵¹ music,²⁵² and sports,²⁵³ to fictional genres²⁵⁴ and the building of transmedial storyworlds.²⁵⁵ By mentioning these transmedia instances, we have only scratched the surface of this field. However, I argue that because the most essential commonalities of these works are interactivity,²⁵⁶ meaningful user actions, and interconnectedness of separate fragments of information, to create a comprehensive analysis, we need to turn to a relevant field for methodologies to elevate our current toolbox. While structuralist narratologies have provided a productive analytical framework for adaptation, video game studies represent the next sensible approach to build upon the first step of our methodological experimentations, keeping in mind that transmedial narratives are not video games, but rather interactive storytelling

²⁴⁹ Two distinct terms that both involves user engagement, however, on different level. For quick reference see: Joakim Karlsen, "Transmedia Documentary: Experience and Participatory Approaches to Non-Fiction Transmedia," in *The Routledge Companion to Transmedia Studies*, ed. Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato (Routledge, 2018), 25–26, <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351054904>.

²⁵⁰ Karlsen, "Transmedia Documentary."

²⁵¹ Renira Rampazzo Gambarato, "Transmedia Journalism: The Potentialities of Transmedia Dynamics in the News Coverage of Planned Events," in *The Routledge Companion to Transmedia Studies*, ed. Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato (Routledge, 2018), <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351054904>.

²⁵² Paola Brembilla, "Transmedia Music: The Values of Music as a Transmedia Asset," in *The Routledge Companion to Transmedia Studies*, ed. Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato (Routledge, 2018), <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351054904>.

²⁵³ Tussey, "Transmedia Sports."

²⁵⁴ Colin B. Harvey, "Transmedia Genres: Form, Content, and the Centrality of Memory," in *The Routledge Companion to Transmedia Studies*, ed. Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato (Routledge, 2018), <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351054904>.

²⁵⁵ Mark J. P. Wolf, "Transmedia World-Building: History, Conception, and Construction," in *The Routledge Companion to Transmedia Studies*, ed. Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato (Routledge, 2018), <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351054904>.

²⁵⁶ Gundolf S. Freyermuth, "Transmedia Storytelling: Twelve Postulates," in *Clash of Realities 2015/16: On the Art, Technology and Theory of Digital Games: Proceedings of the 6th and 7th Conference* (Transcript, 2017), <https://doi.org/10.1515/9783839440315-009>.

systems that share many commonalities regarding their communication processes.²⁵⁷

It is worth noting that the field of game studies is a multidisciplinary domain heavily influenced by frameworks and methods of various academic areas. In the earlier years, game studies were closely connected – as was previously mentioned – to sociology and classical cultural studies. The works of Johan Huizinga and Roger Caillois are valid examples of this, as these authors regarded games as foundational concepts for society and civilization. Later, psychology,²⁵⁸ media theory,²⁵⁹ gender studies,²⁶⁰ narratology, and literary theory²⁶¹ also contributed to the maturing of this field. So the tools that game studies can provide can prove to be as nuanced or granulated as the subject requires. The coming sub-chapters first present how the study of video games can grasp a transmedial storyworld with its specific methods using the SCP universe as a case study. Second, they hone in on the particular problem of *action* in video games and how this analytical approach can be applied to transmedia works – these arguments and observations will be presented through EMH.

It is easier to imagine transmedia works as bustling urban landscapes:²⁶² vast and complex spaces in which, to navigate successfully, we might need the help of maps or other supplementary devices. Like real-world metropolises, a transmedia work also presents its landscape as a superstructure comprising various buildings and other architectural formations. Streets, avenues, sidewalks, bridges, and railroads interconnect these structures. However, even the largest cities are standing alone and lifeless without the people, their movements, their relationships – the culture they form among these walls. Of course, neither of these three (cities, citizens, and their culture) exist in a vacuum: all of these influence one another as the people's way of life forms how they are engineering their cities, and even urban landscapes impact people's lives the other way. This way of life, emerging signs, and forms of existence are the transmedial storyworlds that emerge from the network of mediums and their messages.

As the complexity of the road system defines how easy it is to get around the city, transmedia works can also develop into a narrative structure that is difficult to navigate for the recipient – the twists and turns and the lesser-known shortcuts represent the non-triviality of these narrative structures. The parks, high-rises, and apartment

²⁵⁷ Moreover, a transmedia storytelling system can occasionally *contain* video games within its network.

²⁵⁸ Bob Rehak, "Playing at Being: Psychoanalysis and the Avatar," in *The Video Game Theory Reader*, ed. Mark J P Wolf and Bernard Perron (Routledge, 2003); Christian Roth et al., "Playing In or Out of Character: User Role Differences in the Experience of Interactive Storytelling," *Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking* 15, no. 11 (2012): 630–33, <https://doi.org/10.1089/cyber.2011.0621>.

²⁵⁹ Souvik Mukherjee, *Video Games and Storytelling: Reading Games and Playing Books* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2015).

²⁶⁰ Sara M Grimes, "'You Shoot Like A Girl!': The Female Protagonist in Action-Adventure Video Games," *Proceedings of the 2003 DiGRA International Conference: Level Up 2* (2003).

²⁶¹ Aarseth, *Cybertext*; Markku Eskelinen, *Cybertext Poetics: The Critical Landscape of New Media Literary Theory*, International Texts in Critical Media Aesthetics, v. 2 (Continuum, 2012); Astrid Ensslin, *Literary Gaming* (MIT Press, 2014).

²⁶² Fejes, "Secure, Contain, Protect: Az SCP Foundation transzmediális univerzumának jelenléte a videójáték médiumában," 41–42.

blocks are all different mediums that presuppose different attitudes of the recipient and that code narrative information along the rules of different languages and other systems of signifiers and signifieds. The navigational infrastructure influences the citizens' ability to efficiently traverse this urban landscape – or, in other words, the quality and properties of the network define what the recipient can gather as knowledge of the storyworld. Finally, the jurisdiction, signposting, and the reaches of a municipality are also becoming important when one studies transmedia works and their respective storyworlds: *is this narrative information still connected to the same storyworld? Are these characters (or existents) the same as the ones mentioned before?*

So, after the illuminating metaphor of the metropolis, let us strip away all the allegorical layers. Hopefully, it becomes visible that in this research, I argue that transmedia works are barren, empty, and even pointless structures without the storyworld. The vibrant urban culture emerges from how the citizens *use* the environment. To understand how a city and its architectural artifacts function, we need to analyze those using it and their behavior patterns – and vice versa. This examination of storyworlds will complement the “building-focused” gaze so the perspective that strives to be holistic regarding these transmedia networks will not fall short of these efforts.

3.3.1 Storyworld Across Literature

Fictional universes or worlds established by the semantics of fiction are deeply rooted topics of literary theory. Marie-Laure Ryan, who became one of the most prominent theorists of transmedia narratology in the early 1990s, created a comprehensive work on the theory of fictional and possible worlds.²⁶³ Ryan primarily originates her arguments of world construction from literary or verbal narratologies, which are underlined by her shorter definition of the narrative universe: “the semantic domain of the *text*.”²⁶⁴ Her analysis explores the semantic framework through which texts construct fictional realms, focusing specifically on the interaction between the actual world (AW), textual actual world (TAW), and textual reference world (TRW), which she describes as the central system of textual reality surrounded by alternative possible worlds (APWs).

Ryan's work interrogates prior narratological theories,²⁶⁵ referencing Tzvetan Todorov (four types of semantic modal operators²⁶⁶), Bremond's approach to narrative actions as logical sequences,²⁶⁷ and Doležel's system of narrative modalities.²⁶⁸ These frameworks align with her focus on *accessibility relations*—rules determining how one realm connects to another within a fictional narrative system. For Ryan, these devices are vital in defining the modes of engagement that texts propose to readers, encouraging them to mentally construct richly layered narrative domains.

In broad strokes, Ryan presents an extensive landscape of narratological theories addressing how semantic tools establish interpretive frameworks. These frameworks,

²⁶³ Marie-Laure Ryan, *Possible Worlds, Artificial Intelligence, and Narrative Theory* (Indiana University Press, 1991).

²⁶⁴ Ryan, *Possible Worlds, Artificial Intelligence, and Narrative Theory*, 112.

²⁶⁵ Ryan, *Possible Worlds, Artificial Intelligence, and Narrative Theory*, 109–12.

²⁶⁶ Tzvetan Todorov, *Grammaire du Décaméron* (Mouton, 1969), 46–49.

²⁶⁷ Claude Bremond, *Logique Du Récit* (Éditions du Seuil, 1973), 86.

²⁶⁸ Lubomír Doležel, “Narrative Modalities,” *Journal of Literary Semantics* 5, no. 1 (1976): 7, <https://doi.org/10.1515/jlse.1976.5.1.5>.

in turn, enable fictional domains to form in the mind as readers collect and organize various narrative clues. At this point, though, the key field of application was not exactly the transmedia discourse.

In 2004, however, Lisbeth Klastrup and Susana Tosca provided one of the earliest definitions of *transmedial worlds*, bringing more classical theories closer to the field of this present research:

*Transmedial worlds are abstract content systems from which a repertoire of fictional stories and characters can be actualized or derived across a variety of media forms. [...] [A]udience and designers share a mental image of the “worldness” (a number of features of its universe). The idea of a specific world’s worldness mostly originates from the first version of the world presented, but can be elaborated and changed over time. Quite often the world has a cult (fan) following across media as well.*²⁶⁹

The key concepts of later theories hardly deviate from the groundwork that Klastrup and Tosca did. First, it highlights the abstract nature of these systems, meaning that a storyworld is not contained by a singular storytelling entity or narrative instance. Still, rather it can be detected as an abstract phenomenon emerging from networked “content systems”.

Second, this definition already approaches the subject as a cognitive structure formulated and shared between authorial agents and recipients. This notion returns in later texts of, for example, Marie-Laure Ryan and Jan-Noël Thon²⁷⁰ who at least on the one hand cannot seem to be able to satisfyingly grasp storyworlds without the analysis of human cognition (on the other hand, the focus on narrative structures and their strategies are also constitutive in the attempt of creating a comprehensive analytical methodology for transmedial narratives²⁷¹).

Thirdly, as Thon also points out,²⁷² Klastrup and Tosca in their paper keep the definitive elements of a “world” in ambiguity – they argue that a transmedial world’s constitutive elements are the “mythos” or the “establishing conflicts” and characters, the “topos” or the setting of the world”, and the “ethos” or the “explicit and implicit ethics of the world”.²⁷³ These notions of “worldness”, however, according to Thon,²⁷⁴ while agreeing with the partial utility of focusing on this aspect during an analysis, “reintroduces a rather normative twist into their concept”, driving the discourse towards questions of “faithfulness” and loyalty towards certain core elements of a

²⁶⁹ L. Klastrup and S. Tosca, “Transmedial Worlds - Rethinking Cyberworld Design,” IEEE, 2004, 409, <https://doi.org/10.1109/CW.2004.67>.

²⁷⁰ Marie-Laure Ryan and Jan-Noël Thon, eds., *Storyworlds across Media: Toward a Media-Conscious Narratology* (University of Nebraska Press, 2014), <https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctt1d9nkdg>; Thon, *Transmedial Narratology and Contemporary Media Culture*.

²⁷¹ Thon, *Transmedial Narratology and Contemporary Media Culture*, 1–11.

²⁷² Jan-Noël Thon, “Converging Worlds: From Transmedial Storyworlds to Transmedial Universes,” *Storyworlds: A Journal of Narrative Studies* 7, no. 2 (2015): 23, <https://doi.org/10.5250/storyworlds.7.2.0021>.

²⁷³ Klastrup and Tosca, “Transmedial Worlds - Rethinking Cyberworld Design,” 413.

²⁷⁴ Thon, “Converging Worlds,” 23.

narrative instead of approaching this phenomenon with equality and democratization in mind.²⁷⁵ A property that is even a direct cause for the “cult (fan) following across media” that is highlighted by them. Interestingly enough, there are use cases, for example in the realm of ARGs, where “worldness” and the faithfulness of a material is crucial for avoiding misinterpretation and to understand the narrative more efficiently.

Throughout the texts on storyworlds and narrative universes, it seems unavoidable to refer to these mental models without allegories of spatiality. Actions, events, existents, relationships, and interactions define a storyworld’s mythos, topos, and ethos – texts sometimes use the rhetoric that the recipient or the interpreter of a narrative universe needs to *navigate* this fictional *landscape*. Furthermore, David Herman also argues in his encyclopedia entry (“Storyworld”²⁷⁶) that

*the grounding of stories in storyworlds goes a long way towards explaining narratives’ immersiveness, their ability to ‘transport’ interpreters into places and times that they must occupy for the purposes of narrative comprehension. Interpreters do not merely reconstruct a sequence of events and a set of existents, but imaginatively (emotionally, viscerally) inhabit a world in which things matter [...] – both for narrative participants and for interpreters of the story. More than reconstructed timelines and inventories of existents, then, storyworlds are mentally and emotionally projected environments in which interpreters are called upon to live out complex blends of cognitive and imaginative response.*²⁷⁷

It is key to highlight that besides the allegories of spatiality, the measure of how involved the subjects of the narrative and the recipients (interpreters) also are. They are “inhabiting the world,” which is, on the one hand, directly referencing their materiality and, on the other hand, enhancing their potential agency, which, of course, can largely vary depending on the affordances of the mediums that contribute to the communicational transaction.

In the case of transmedia storytelling systems, I argue that an elevated level of agency and interactivity is inherently part of the mechanics of these structures. This is why it is important to regard the recipients of a transmedia narrative as players (at least, and co-creators if this agency reaches a different status) instead of mere readers.

²⁷⁵ Bevan et al. discuss in their survey of the relevant literature what democratizing capabilities do storyworlds and immersive narratives have. For more see: Bronwyn Bevan et al., “Food for Thought: Immersive Storyworlds as a Way into Scientific Meaning-making,” *Journal of Research in Science Teaching* 59, no. 9 (2022): 1607–50, <https://doi.org/10.1002/tea.21768>.

²⁷⁶ David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 569–70.

²⁷⁷ David Herman et al., *Routledge Encyclopedia of Narrative Theory*, 570.

3.3.2 SCP Foundation: Interactions Between a Video Game and its Story-world

This next section showcases the previously mentioned interconnectedness between the different elements of transmedial narrative networks. As Klastrup and Tosca highlight three main aspects of transmedial storyworlds: the so-called worldness of such narrative formations are examined in terms of mythos, topos, and ethos, they also move away from the analysis posited by the authors as textual and examine the imaginative construction that can be abstracted from medial realizations from a trans-discursive or transsystematic perspective – which is a constitutive property of transmedial works, of course. They consider those fundamental conflicts, events, stories, rumors, backstories, and mythical objects as the mythos of transmedial worlds, without knowledge of which the recipient cannot productively interpret the different points of the plot. A good example is the basic conflicts and backstories of the various ethnic groups and races in *The Lord of the Rings* universe. Without knowledge of these, the recipient would find it much more difficult to adjust to the moral forces of a scene where, for example, orcs and elves are pitted against each other.²⁷⁸ The topos of the transmedial storyworld are those locations and historical periods that evoke the medial realization (i.e., the creation constituting the transmedial world) that is considered original (ur-actualization). Other elements of the narrative universe may move away from the original location or historical period. Still, if the relation and navigation are clear, we have not stepped out of that world in a topos.

The third aspect of worldness is perhaps the most difficult to grasp: the ethos of the transmedial storyworld. This is the set of ethical and moral codes that define the norms of the broad narrative system – what is considered good, what is considered bad, how a character behaves, and what is no longer appropriate to the characters' personalities – making this the most complex dimension of information to identify at both the macro and microscopic levels. It encodes whether Sauron or Aragorn represents the positive modality in *The Lord of the Rings* trilogy. Still, equally, ethos points to whether an actor's action is in line with the storyworld or can be interpreted as an out-of-character/out-of-world performance.

The triad of mythos (temporality, historicity), topos (topography, set design, mise-en-scène in the broad sense), and ethos (i.e., morality), by reading the realizations of transmedial storyworlds, calls to life an abstract (and sometimes even actual) architecture that is most reminiscent of Henry Jenkins' concept of narrative architecture.²⁷⁹ This sub-chapter presents this architecture in the fictional universe of the SCP Foundation and the video game *SCP: Secret Files*²⁸⁰ and how this architecture interacts with the tone, style, and means of expression of the transmedial storyworld realizations. Moreover, this case study will also present through selected excerpts how one can read the field of the storyworld that emerges around a video game and in what ways can medial actualizations influence or rewrite segments of a fictional universe. This method of “reading” (or analysis) also focuses on the material (or digital) forms of the triad of myth, topos, and ethos.

²⁷⁸ Klastrup and Tosca, “Transmedial Worlds - Rethinking Cyberworld Design,” 413–14.

²⁷⁹ Henry Jenkins, “Game Design as Narrative Architecture,” in *The Game Design Reader: A Rules of Play Anthology*, ed. Eric Zimmerman and Katie Salen (MIT Press, 2006).

²⁸⁰ Game Zoo Studio, *SCP: Secret Files*, Pixmain, released September 2022, PC.

A Walk Around the SCP Foundation

On June 22, 2007, a text by an anonymous author (later found to be written by the user The USS Walrus), accompanied by an image of an anthropomorphic concrete statue, appeared on the “/x/” sub-page of the Internet platform 4chan, a platform for paranormal-themed posts. The post's content is the containment protocol of a phenomenon/artifact/entity, SCP-173:²⁸¹ a technical document transcript describing what this dangerous entity can do, why it is dangerous, and where and how it can be stored.²⁸² The fictitious report states that SCP-173 should be kept in a confined space under all circumstances. If necessary, at least three people should enter the room at the same time. Two of them should keep their eyes on the entity at all times: the SCP-173 does not move as long as there is someone to observe it, but once this is no longer the case, it can change its location at lightning speed and start killing the people around it. This document, whose language so suggestively evokes the style of documents classified by governmental agencies,²⁸³ created one of the largest collaborative storyworlds on the internet – a transmedia universe: the SCP Foundation. After the popularity of the few paragraphs of writing on 4chan, the community soon created many similar works. As the popularity of the format spread, so did the need to organize them into a collection, and the SCP Foundation wiki page was born.²⁸⁴

The meta-history of the database is not worthy of a lengthy review in the context of this dissertation. Still, it is worth noting that the site, a repository of SCP documents (mockuments), has remained in the hands of the community from its inception to the present day. A leitmotif in the meta-history of the SCP Foundation is its Creative Commons policy, which is to be genetically perpetuated and is given a prominent place and role as the fictional universe grows.²⁸⁵

However, before we get to the workings of the database, it is worth first getting acquainted with the myth of the SCP Foundation, because the storyworld, as we have already discussed, interacts strongly with the structure, style, and form of the implementations, and thus with the central unit of the universe, the SCP wiki. A fictional foundation of mythical size and operation. It is an institution operating clandestinely and at a worldwide level, functioning above governments and jurisdictions to detect, contain, and control so-called anomalies – entities and phenomena that threaten with physical or psychological harm or undermine consensually accepted natural laws. These anomalous objects (and subjects) are identified, categorized, stored, and isolated from the world by the Foundation and are called SCPs. According to their mission statement,²⁸⁶ the SCP Foundation maintains normality so that the world's

²⁸¹ The canonical document on the transmedial universe, hosted by the SCP Wiki, can be viewed here:

<https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/scp-173> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 24.)

²⁸² This, and the history of the SCP Foundation universe, is also commemorated on the SCP Wiki, see <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/history-of-the-universe-part-one> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 24.).

²⁸³ Pallante, “Secure, Contain, Protect: Building a Digital Folklore Mythos through Collaborative Legend Creation,” 29–41.

²⁸⁴ <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 24.).

²⁸⁵ For more information, see <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/licensing-guide> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 24.).

²⁸⁶ For more information, see <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/about-the-scp-foundation> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 24.).

civilian population can go about their daily lives without fear, distrust, or disruption of their faith and to ensure humanity's autonomy from supernatural and extraterrestrial influence. The acronym “SCP” in the Foundation reflects this aspiration: secure, contain, protect.²⁸⁷ The SCP Foundation's extranational activities are historically supported by a mysterious internal organization called the O5 Council at the highest decision-making level.²⁸⁸ The day-to-day work of the Foundation is supported by staff graded from A (highest clearance) to E (lowest clearance), including isolation specialists, researchers, security experts, military personnel, and other administrative staff.²⁸⁹ In addition to the organizational structure of the staff, the geographical distribution of personnel is also important from a global perspective: areas and sites that house the isolated anomalies or perform other important organizational functions.²⁹⁰ Interestingly, just over 100 of these areas and sites are listed in the central database – including one in Hungary, code-named SITE-228.

The SCP Foundation's fictitious organizational structure is as rigorously structured as that of its creations: the (mostly) highly formalized SCP description documents. An average entry describes the behavior and background of a single SCP in varying degrees of detail; these sites are now organized in the SCP wiki collaborative platform, which contains over 7,000 descriptions. The main unit of the database is divided into series, each containing up to a thousand published stories: Series I contains the texts of anomalies coded SCP-001 to SCP-999, Series II contains those coded SCP-1000 to SCP-1999, and so on. A given SCP story can use any “free” code number, but always only within that series. Once all the numbers in a series are used up, the Wiki administrators open the next one. Currently, the corpus is at Series VIII.

The average sites also follow the formal structure required by the story world,²⁹¹ i.e., the rigorous structure of governmental documents: the SCP code number is at the top of the page, followed by the anomaly classification on the next line. The SCP Foundation distinguishes three main classes, in addition to which it lists four others as primary and describes four additional non-standard classes. The main three plus four classes are Safe, Euclid, Keter, Thaumiel, Neutralized, Apollyon, and Archon. The database uses the so-called Locked Box Test below to illustrate the classification differences between them:

- If you lock it in a box, leave it alone, and nothing bad will happen, then it's probably *Safe*.
- If you lock it in a box, leave it alone, and you're not entirely sure what will happen, then it's probably *Euclid*.

²⁸⁷ But in addition, SCP can also refer to the procedure itself: special containment protocol. That is a special isolation method that minimizes the influence or risk of a particular anomaly.

²⁸⁸ For more information, see <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/o5-command-dossier> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 24.).

²⁸⁹ For more information, see <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/security-clearance-levels#toc7> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 24.).

²⁹⁰ For more information, see <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/secure-facilities-locations> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 24.).

²⁹¹ Pallante, “Secure, Contain, Protect: Building a Digital Folklore Mythos through Collaborative Legend Creation,” 19–41.

- If you lock it in a box, leave it alone, and it easily escapes, then it's probably *Keter*.
- If it is the box, then it's probably *Thaumiel*.
- If you can't fit it in a box and it's about to end the world, then it's probably *Apollyon*.
- If you could have locked it in a box but chose not to, it's probably *Archon*.²⁹²

Following classification, the documentation of the SCP continues with the Special Containment Procedure. This section describes what precautions must be taken to keep the anomaly safely contained. At this point, the reader is still unaware of why the documented SCP is dangerous (or special); this section merely foreshadows the narrative that generally follows. Indeed, the procedure description is followed by a detailed account of the anomaly.

One of the primary and most striking stylistic features of the SCP Foundation's transmedia world is the clinical gaze, the cold, scientific tone that pervades most elements. The detailed description of the SCPs (and, indeed, the narrative instance of the entire documentation) is presented as the report of an initiated staff member addressing the initiated readers of the Foundation. This stylistic attitude, reflected in the wiki's instructions to its authors, defines the SCP Foundation as an institution. The Foundation evokes a figure of Lovecraftian cosmic horror,²⁹³ which strikes terror not through direct action but through its indifference to humanity. The institution is transnational, pervasive, cold, emotionless, objective, and mysterious. It does not create a horrifying atmosphere through adjectives but rather through the sheer power of scientific metrics.

The transmedia world, the mythos, extends beyond the confines of the main wiki into various other realizations, including YouTube videos,²⁹⁴ comics,²⁹⁵ and musical works.²⁹⁶ This is made possible by the administrators of the SCP Wiki, who have granted permission to publish the texts under the Creative Commons BY-SA 3.0 license.²⁹⁷ This license allows anyone to freely use and adapt the content on the platform, even for profit. This openness has resulted in the creation of numerous video

²⁹² <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/object-classes> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 24.).

²⁹³ For more on the transmedia analysis of the Lovecraftian universe, see Van Leavenworth, "The Developing Storyworld of H. P. Lovecraft," in *Storyworlds across Media: Toward a Media-Conscious Narratology*, ed. Marie-Laure Ryan and Jan-Noël Thon (University of Nebraska Press, 2014).

²⁹⁴ For example, the *SCP Explained - Story & Animation* channel: <https://www.youtube.com/@SCP> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 25.).

²⁹⁵ For example: Akira, *SCP Foundation: Iris through the Looking Glass. 1*, with Sidu (Seven Seas, 2020).

²⁹⁶ For example, the goa album *SCP Foundation* by Sychoplasm (more information: <https://psychovision.bandcamp.com/album/album-sychoplasm-scp-foundation> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 25.)), or Edward Ikor's *Cognitohazard: An Ambient SCP Foundation Album*.

²⁹⁷ One important exception to this is SCP-173, which marks the origin of the whole universe, or more precisely the sculpture (Izumi Kato: *Untitled 2004*) and its photograph, which appears as an illustration in the document. The artist has not allowed the sculpture to be reproduced under the CC BY-SA 3.0 license – the "original" photo has been removed from the wiki, and those who wish to create further works based on the SCP can do so under the usual licensing conditions in the *SCP-173 Redesign Collab Hub* database.

games, which have been steadily growing in number over the past decade, with a significant inflection point being the release of the free-to-play horror game *SCP - Containment Breach* by Joonas Rikkonen.²⁹⁸ Furthermore, Steam, the gaming platform and marketplace, lists 83 games inspired by the SCP universe.²⁹⁹

Among these is the game anthology *SCP: Secret Files*, developed by Game Zoo Studio and published by Pixmain in September 2022, which is the subject of this case study. This work, offering approximately 4 to 5 hours of gameplay, develops five stories embedded within a frame story. It is particularly noteworthy that it elaborates on five different SCP stories (mostly adapted from the wiki) using the video game medium. Still, each of the five stories employs a distinct style and diversely uses the language of video games. Despite their stylistic multiplicity, all five narratives (and the overarching frame story) remain firmly within the SCP Foundation's transmedia universe.

According to the frame story, the implied player³⁰⁰ assumes the role of the first-person avatar³⁰¹ of an MIT doctoral student discovered by one of the SCP Foundation's recruiters while writing a dissertation in a bistro. The brief introduction establishes the relationship between the player and the avatar through a limited, clickable branching dialogue sequence. After the introductory episode, the recruiter hands over an envelope, displayed on the screen, which provides the player with the first objects carrying narrative information – an element and gesture highly emphasized throughout the game. The envelope, addressed to Karl Astana, contains a job offer as an archival assistant in the SCP Foundation archives.

Interacting with the Mythos of the SCP Universe

As *SCP: Secret Files* interacts with the transmedia universe through its anthology format and recreates the SCP Foundation's world across several narratives with varying styles and functions, it is worth exploring how different aspects of this world come into play through gameplay and interpretation. The video game as a medium will also be especially versatile when formulating relationships with the formative events and defining moments of the broadly understood storyworld.

During the introductory sequence, after the player assumes the role of Karl Astana, the avatar,³⁰² they descend into the underground archive or laboratory, which serves as the setting for the frame story. Here, the voice of an intradiegetic narrator³⁰³ explains the institution's purpose to the player (or Karl), seamlessly integrating the “upstream” side of the reception model into the fictional world right from the beginning

²⁹⁸ Joonas Rikkonen, *SCP – Containment Breach*, Blitz BASIC, Joonas Rikkonen, released April 2012, PC.

²⁹⁹ See <https://steamdb.info/search/?a=app&q=scp&type=1&category=0> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 25.).

³⁰⁰ Richárd Fejes, “‘Would You Stop Changing My Games?’: Structures of Narrative Discourse in Video Games,” in *Multidisciplinary Perspectives on Narrative Aesthetics in Video Games*, ed. Deniz Denizel et al. (Peter Lang, 2021), 258.

³⁰¹ Rune Klevjer, “What Is the Avatar? Fiction and Embodiment in Avatar-Based Singleplayer Computer Games” (doctoral dissertation, University of Bergen, 2006), 87.

³⁰² The dissertation uses the term avatar to refer to the virtual embodiment and boundaries of the player's agency, based on Rune Klevjer's terminology. See: Klevjer, “What Is the Avatar? Fiction and Embodiment in Avatar-Based Singleplayer Computer Games.”

³⁰³ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 248–49.

of the game.³⁰⁴ The game constantly evokes and references the mythos of the SCP universe during the gameplay of the five embedded stories and the frame story. As the player progresses through the overarching narrative – Karl's story – they are directly immersed in the material-centered world of the storyworld, which heavily relies on and builds upon the objects and artifacts of the SCP Foundation.

After the descent, the player enters an archive that documents the organization's work. Karl's first day involves workplace orientation and employee onboarding activities. Moreover, the game at this point also introduces the Foundation's virtual interface (which the player can interact with) that recreates, first, the symbolic system (the representation of a globe intertwined and interconnected by the sites of the Foundation), second, the iconography (such as the logo), and thirdly, the simulated communication channels, including chat rooms and user login interfaces embedded into the virtual UI as a second level of mediation, are all rhyme to the operational mechanisms of the SCP universe's primary actualization: the wiki. This online community of creators and authors primarily interacts via forums,³⁰⁵ comment sections, and other online channels, so representing these devices in the game simultaneously evokes the "meta-myth" of the SCP universe and the SCP Foundation's obsession with the archive.³⁰⁶

In addition to this function, the game also brings into play the transmedia storyworld of the SCP universe by using the vocabulary and terminology of the world's mythos. For example, the embedded narrative centered around the anomaly SCP-7457³⁰⁷ adheres to the organization's conventions by using codenames and follows the experiences of "D-class" personnel³⁰⁸ with the serial number D-503, incorporating another essential mythic element into the game's narrative. While the hypodiegetic narrative³⁰⁹ closely mirrors the transmedial universe in its formal aspects, the framing of this narrative further reinforces the myth of the organization's scale and structure.

The sequence begins with a shift of the narrative instance from Karl Astana's first-person perspective to the virtual platform. From there, the player navigates an e-learning curriculum within the diegetically represented platform, learning D-503's story in the context of corporate onboarding training. After this situational shift, the player's avatar transitions to the main character of the hypodiegetic story, bringing the perspective back to a first-person view.

³⁰⁴ Fejes, "“Would You Stop Changing My Games?”,” 258.

³⁰⁵ <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/forum:start> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 26.).

³⁰⁶ It is worth noting that, in addition to the aforementioned intradiegetic platform, much of the game builds on the myth of archiving – making it a perfect fit for the genre Melissa Kagen labeled *archival adventuring*. Exploring the links between works belonging to the SCP Foundation's storyworld and archival adventuring could be the subject of further investigations. See: Melissa Kagen, "Archival Adventuring," *Convergence: The International Journal of Research into New Media Technologies* 26, no. 4 (2020): 1007–20, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1354856519847875>.

³⁰⁷ In the official, canonical database, the same codename covers a completely different SCP: <https://scpwiki.wikidot.com/scp-7457> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 26.).

³⁰⁸ "D-class" personnel is the term used to describe inmates who are generally considered expendable by the storyworld. They are usually trusted with tasks that involve the most dangerous anomalies.

³⁰⁹ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 227–34; Genette, *Narrative Discourse Revisited*, 84–95.

In the embedded narrative, the “volunteer”, D-503, works daily inside the anomaly designated SCP-7457. This SCP is described as a relatively large desert area that inexplicably generates garbage. D-503 is tasked with collecting this garbage and incinerating it. Over a few weeks in the narrative, the player wakes up in a locked, cell-like room, completes puzzle-like tasks that provide feedback on D-503's mental state, and then ventures out into the desert to collect trash using various tools. This sequence emphasizes several elements of the constituting mythos: the isolated location, unexplained phenomena, and the exploitation of presumably unwilling test subjects all take center stage in this story.

The second embedded narrative ties directly to the SCP Wiki database and, by extension, to the mythos of the transmedia universe. This story unfolds at Pony Station³¹⁰ and revolves around an anomaly, SCP-701.³¹¹ According to fictional records first uploaded to the wiki in 2009, SCP-701 is a manuscript of a 17th-century revenge drama, *The Hanged King's Tragedy*. The SCP Foundation's description states that nearly 40% of the drama's productions resulted in catastrophic incidents during or after the performance. The events are described in five phases, from 7–14 days before the performance to its aftermath. Initially, the document details the mental breakdown of the contributing actors, the quotation of nonexistent passages, and escalating aggression, culminating in chaos during the performance, including murders, riots, and suicides. A human figure wrapped in linen and iron chains reportedly appears on stage during this climax.³¹² This “micromythos” of SCP-701 is faithfully rendered within the gameplay, allowing players to witness the chilling story unfold and even take part directly.

The third storyline, SCP-1762,³¹³ adapted into the game, connects to the SCP Foundation storyworld similarly to SCP-701. Using the document recorded on the SCP Wiki as a narrative foundation, it presents a new, previously untold story within the SCP universe. This narrative unfolds with the player, simultaneously utilizing and reshaping the mythos of the transmedia universe. Through this adaptation, the video game adds another significant event with considerable impact on the SCP Foundation's lore, expanding the mythos derived from the wiki.

The penultimate hypodiegetic chapter of the anthology emerges during the monotonous archival work of the frame story, presented as a document that leads the player into the plot. In this narrative, the player assumes the role of another D-class personnel, with the ID D-6744, as their avatar. Their assigned task is to neutralize the

³¹⁰ This location does not exist in the SCP Wiki database, so it is an important example of elements that the game (the actualization of a transmedia storyworld) adds to the already established, but constantly evolving universe.

³¹¹ tinwatchman, “SCP-701,” in *SCP Wiki*, 2009, <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/scp-701>.

³¹² It is worth noting that the anomaly, labeled SCP-701, was inspired by Robert W. Chambers' *The*

which also involves a mind-altering, maddening work of art in its story. This motif was later adopted by H. P. Lovecraft in his own stories (Howard Phillips Lovecraft, *The Call of Cthulhu & Other Stories* (Arcturus Publishing Ltd., 2018).). The interconnection between Lovecraftian cosmic horror and the SCP Foundation universe, again, deserves separate research endeavors.

³¹³ OZ Ouroboros, “SCP-1762,” in *SCP Wiki*, 2014, <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/scp-1762>.

anomaly of an 8-year-old girl, designated SCP-239,³¹⁴ by invading her mind. This chapter explores a conflict with epistemological undertones, focusing on the player's empathy toward the child. Notably, it incorporates canonical story elements integral to the SCP Foundation: D-class personnel, researchers, the decision-making O5 Council, and SCP-239 herself. The chapter builds a self-contained narrative on this foundation, taking creative liberties while remaining true to the mythos.

The final embedded story incorporates the anomaly SCP-426³¹⁵ into the body of the video game narrative. This SCP, a toaster with mind-controlling capabilities, is integrated directly into the gameplay thematically and mechanically. Thematically, the toaster's influence is experienced from a third-person perspective, and mechanically, the mental coercion the toaster induces is represented as the gameplay requires the player to perform certain button presses to advance the narrative.

After this hypodiegetic sequence, the player returns to the first narrative level, to the computer terminal – which initially connected the frame story to the embedded layers – which at this point prints the opening paragraphs of SCP-426's entry from the SCP Wiki almost verbatim, further solidifying the game's ties to the database and its broader mythos.

After completing all five hypodiegetic chapters, the game delivers a final twist, reinforcing its connection to the SCP Foundation mythos. Karl Astana enters a secluded office, receiving a phone call from a mysterious woman. She reveals that Karl is, in fact, an amnesiac agent of the organization and a member of an elite squad known as MEGA-5. The caller identifies herself as Marion Wheeler, the leader of MEGA-5 and the protagonist of the short story *We Need to Talk About Fifty-Five*,³¹⁶ which can be found on the SCP Wiki. This revelation provides a final layer of narrative complexity and directly ties the frame story back to the SCP Foundation mythos.

Surveying the Topos of the SCP Universe

As a second aspect, it is worth exploring how a video game can relate to, reinterpret, and evoke the topos of a transmedia storyworld. Beyond successfully activating the mythos of the SCP universe in a multifaceted way, *SCP: Secret Files* effectively actualizes and interacts with the elements of the topos as well.

During the opening minutes of the frame story, a main title-like sequence unfolds as the player descends into a vast underground complex. The structure is reminiscent of the endless archives featured in *Raiders of the Lost Ark*:³¹⁷ numbered structures resembling shipping containers line the walls, stretching into infinity. Some

³¹⁴ Dantensen, "SCP-239," in *SCP Wiki*, 2008, <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/scp-239>.

³¹⁵ SCP-426 is described by the SCP Wiki as an ordinary toaster, which has a strong psychological effect on any individual who is in its vicinity or who even mentions the object. According to its primary description, no one can talk about the object in any other way than in first-person. Even the wiki entry is written from the toaster's point of view. Secondly, anyone who is more exposed to the effects of SCP-426 will soon imagine himself to be a toaster, after which he will try to reach into sockets or stuff himself with bread, endangering his own life (for more on this see Flah, "SCP-426," in *SCP Wiki*, 2010, <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/scp-426>).

³¹⁶ qntm, "We Need to Talk About Fifty-Five," in *SCP Wiki*, 2015, <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/we-need-to-talk-about-fifty-five>.

³¹⁷ *Raiders of the Lost Ark*, directed by Steven Spielberg (Paramount Pictures, 1981), 115m.

containers have transparent walls, revealing scientists conducting experiments or showing strange, unknown creatures attempting to escape their confinement. This imagery – numbered enclosures and isolated spaces – not only mirrors the disconnected documentation style of the SCP Foundation database but also reinforces the mythos of the SCPs encoded by their numerical identifiers. The introductory sequence seamlessly connects the spatial and thematic elements of the topos to the transmedia universe.

After the descent, the player exits an elevator and finds themselves in a brutalist underground corridor, where they regain control of Karl. The thick concrete walls, air-lock systems with extreme security protocols, and the omnipresent SCP iconography immediately evoke the topos of the SCP transmedia world, as depicted primarily in the wiki database. This atmosphere is further amplified in the first interactable or explorable space, where the player encounters a bulletin board filled with informational leaflets and other flyers – all designed to immerse the player in the SCP universe. These include pages resembling classified documents, photographs of locked doors, and images of other enigmatic artifacts. Interactable, rotatable objects and documents reinforce the frame story and various embedded chapters, recoding and enhancing the topos engaging and tactilely.

Upon reaching your character's designated workstation, the game shifts the perspective from the walk through the office complex to an immersive interface representing the SCP Foundation's archival platform. At this point, the first-person view transitions to focus solely on the organization's internal system, seamlessly delivering a wealth of narrative information. This approach avoids extradiegetic information dumps or other alienating techniques, instead integrating details – such as the global location of SCP objects or major concurrent events in the fictional universe – directly into the interface. The platform's main page includes features such as an e-mail client, file manager, and a chat application, alongside a rotating globe with a continuous stream of news on the button in the style and aesthetic of 24-hour news channels like CNN or Al Jazeera, firmly embedding the user within the mythos and ethos of the SCP Foundation while also reinforcing its topos.

The second hypodiegetic narrative, centered on the anomaly SCP-701, further elevates the complexity, as this story already employs a framing structure. The sequence begins with Bella Lawrence lying in a hospital bed while recounting the events that happened to her during a mission where the SCP Foundation agent tasked her, codenamed “Bald Eagle,” to recover a “black box” from Room 705 on the seventh floor of the site called Pony Station. The operation was aimed to unveil the details of an unknown incident at Site 74, and the black box was believed to hold critical information about the mysterious events that transpired there. The gameplay entails the player navigating the rooms of the multi-story complex through Bella’s memories while occasionally returning to her hospital setting and interrogation. These spaces – comprising utilitarian labs, offices, dressing rooms, and abandoned or ominous environments – emphasize the topos of the SCP Foundation’s transmedia universe, combining the eerie and uncanny with the official and institutional.

Similarly, the third chapter, focusing on the anomaly SCP-1762, reinforces the topos of the SCP Foundation. The final moments of this narrative feature the central object of the chapter – a cardboard box, SCP-1762 itself – locked within a plexiglass

container. Seeing this artifact in a shadowy, laboratory-like setting further underscores the SCP Foundation's emphasis on control and containment. This guarded laboratory environment, a quintessential setting within the SCP mythos, is a powerful visual and thematic representation of the Foundation's pervasive authority and meticulous approach to security.

The final hypodiegetic chapter revisits the topos of secret operational facilities, prisons, and laboratories, with the narrative unfolding in an underground penitentiary where experiments are conducted on prisoners (D-class personnel). This chapter is divided into two primary scenes. In the initial sequences, the player's character navigates the cell block shared with other prisoners, where it is possible to interact with guards, objects, and fellow inmates. From there, the player progresses through a corridor to an elevator leading to the lower levels of the prison complex. Exiting the elevator, the player passes through a detector and enters a room dominated by a large screen, where Dr. Havel, a researcher, communicates via video link to provide instructions for the experiment. The player is tasked with observing SCP-426 – a toaster contained within a glass case – for a specified duration. The character is guided through a decontamination chamber and a long corridor to reach the observation room. Upon completing the observation, the player reports to Dr. Havel before being escorted back to their cell. Shortly afterward, SCP-426's effects manifest on the player's avatar, ultimately resulting in the character's death. This cycle is repeated with three different characters, reinforcing over and over the SCP Foundation's storyworld through spaces characterized by detectors, cells, grids, and the cold austerity of concrete and stone, including the decontamination chamber and underground facilities.

The overarching frame story of *SCP: Secret Files* and the hypodiegetic narratives embedded within it collectively expand the SCP universe, all while maintaining consistent engagement with the topos: the spatial structure, rhetorical style, and atmospheric elements of the mise-en-scène remain cohesive throughout. This is achieved despite each embedded chapter utilizing distinct visual aesthetics, different gameplay mechanics, and a procedural toolbox. This striking diversity and richness of the video game are further emphasized if we shift our gaze towards the element of ethos.

(Re)writing the Rules – Encounters with the Ethos of the SCP Universe

Beyond the temporal and topographical elements, the third foundational aspect of a transmedia world is its ethos. This unifying force ties together the rules of the world and the previous two aspects, encapsulating the spirituality and core principles of the storyworld. The ethos defines the world's higher and lower-level ideas, shaping its identity. Within the SCP Foundation universe, this ethos prominently features themes such as mystery, alienation of the human subject, estrangement, cosmic horror, and the unsettling reality of human experimentation. In *SCP: Secret Files*, this ethos is preserved, recoded, and revitalized through various narrative strategies and procedural techniques. Conversely, the ethos influences the players' and the recipients' behavior, expectations, or cognitive processes.

One striking example is early in the frame story when the player arrives at the underground archive. At this point, the player must retrieve a "Level-1" access card from an unmanned security booth, immediately highlighting the absence of interpersonal relationships. This lack of human presence persists in the subsequent environments.

As the player traverses the sterile corridors of the complex, they might catch a glimpse of a distant colleague walking by, yet their face remains obscured. The numerous office spaces the player traverses are conspicuously devoid of visible occupants or activity. This atmosphere of isolation is further enhanced when the narrating situation shifts to Karl's assigned workstation, transitioning the focalizing gaze to the simulated organizational platform. As previously explored, this interface reinforces the ethos of the SCP Foundation through its iconography that telegraphs the organization's global presence, pervasive influence, and supranational nature while also evoking an academic, investigative behavior in the player.

In addition to the visual codes of the platform, the archival work done through it – the whole textual dimension of the frame story – creates a link with the ethos of the storyworld: Karl Astana interacts with faceless, sometimes even anonymized figures in written form – chatting, checking documents, participating in online courses – all of which reinforces the aspect of the community of the SCP Wiki,³¹⁸ and even the specific, cold, scientific look and feel of the documents in the database. The different game elements and associated operations within the interface convey the encrypted documents' objective style and atmosphere.³¹⁹ Regarding the game mechanics, this job is represented by mainly a drag-and-drop gesture on a particular document, but this only serves to further emphasize the impersonality and monotony of the organization's work through the language of procedurality which, in another way, seems to be in contrast with the content of these documents, such as the ceramic vessel that functions as a human womb (SCP-660³²⁰), or the incredibly tough cherry tree (SCP-143³²¹), whose petals are razor-sharp blades that pose a life-threatening threat, to name but a few.³²²

In addition to the visual code of the framework story and the virtual interface that plays an essential role in it, the hypodiegetic chapters also exploit the possibilities of graphic representation, thus reviving the ethos of the SCP Wiki (and with that, the center of the storyworld), i.e. the multiplicity of wiki authors, the internal variance of writing styles, which is reflected in the stylistically, procedurally fragmented, anthological structure of the game. The first embedded story of the anthology, for example, is completely different from the representation experienced in the frame story: in contrast to the realistic representation of the archive as a space and the interface, the coloring and representation of the hypodiegetic is done with cel-shading

³¹⁸ More on this in Christian Wagner, "Wiki: A Technology for Conversational Knowledge Management and Group Collaboration," *Communications of the Association for Information Systems* 13 (February 2004), <https://doi.org/10.17705/1CAIS.01319>.

³¹⁹ The 5 stories embedded in the frame story are all documented cases addressed for archival, which (in most cases) the SCP Foundation expects Karl to record and organize in the appropriate way.

³²⁰ For more information, see <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/scp-660> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 27.).

³²¹ For more information, see <https://scp-wiki.wikidot.com/scp-143> (last accessed: 2024. 11. 27.).

³²² See more on this tool in Weimin Toh, *A Multimodal Approach to Video Games and the Player Experience* (Routledge, Taylor & Francis Group, 2019), 75–98, <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351184779>.

technique,³²³ which effectively reduces the resolution of the color transitions of the three-dimensional models to such an extent that they remind the viewer of a drawn or painted aesthetic quality.³²⁴ The comic-like visuality, on the one hand, distances the viewer from the hypodiegetic level, emphasizing that the player is witnessing the narration of an already documented series of events; on the other hand, it draws attention to the technology and the language of the video game medium, thus amplifying the aforementioned community-driven, anthology-like construction of the SCP Wiki database (and the SCP Foundation storyworld).

Although the embedded episode about Bella Lawrence does not have the same, well-differentiated visual direction as the previous example, it makes heavier use of the tools of conventional horror films and games from the first moment: predominantly dark spaces dominate the explorable spaces, which can be only illuminated by a flashlight; sudden, sharp sound and light effects are also aiming to scare the player; and finally, bizarre, surreal, horror-like images, texts and visuals help to convey the main narrative – the character also has to participate in several escape sequences which are not in line with conventional walkthrough simulator investigation narratives³²⁵ that describe the majority of the gameplay. The gameplay is interrupted and terminated if the player makes a mistake in these high-stakes sequences. This chapter heightens the tension of the play experience, highlighting the horror aspects of the SCP Foundation storyworld, putting all this in stark contrast with the monotonous archival view and attitude of the frame story.

The visual world of the embedded narrative of the anomaly SCP-1762 is reminiscent of the typical watercolor illustrations of children's literature, with the plot unfolding partly in a comic book style and partly in a three-dimensional but highly stylized space. The hypodiegesis also reinforces this by using drag-and-drop game mechanics on several occasions: whether it is the packing of a bag, the splicing of a torn message, or the grabbing of a damaged origami dragon, these sequences bring the objects and characters of the narrative closer to the player in a way that evokes the intimacy associated with storybooks and picture books, as well as the specific associations with the medium that can be linked to children's literature, both from the child and adult side.³²⁶

The same effect is reinforced by the fact that, in one of the first interactive moments of the chapter, the player is drawn into a rhythm game, through which he can directly

³²³ For more technical details see Martin Spindler et al., "Enhanced Cartoon and Comic Rendering," *Eurographics*, 2006, n.p.; Raul Reyes Luque, "The Cel Shading Technique" (module dissertation, Wrexham Glyndwr University, 2012).

³²⁴ Some other video games that use cel-shading technology are Nintendo EAD, *The Legend of Zelda: The Wind Waker*, Nintendo, released December 2002, Gamecube; Ubisoft Paris Studio, *XIII*, Microids, released November 2003, PC; Clover Studio, *Ōkami*, Capcom, released April 2006, PlayStation 2. All of which employ this distinctive stylistic device for a well-defined purpose.

³²⁵ See Rosa Carbo-Mascarell, "Walking Simulators: The Digitisation of an Aesthetic Practice," *Proceedings of 1st International Joint Conference of DiGRA and FDG*, 2016; Hugo Montembeault and Maxime Deslongchamps-Gagnon, "The Walking Simulator's Generic Experiences," *Press Start* 5, no. 2 (2019): 1–28.

³²⁶ See Elisabeth Parsons, "Starring in the Intimate Space: Picture Book Narratives and Performance Semiotics," *Image & Narrative*, no. 9 (October 2004).

assume the role of the main focalizer,³²⁷ Daniel, and thus becomes a participant in the flute practice through mechanical inputs. The notes must be 'sounded' by pressing the appropriate key at the correct time, which is familiar to other games in the same rhythm genre. A visible scoring panel represents the measure of success and precision of the player. A similar mechanical attachment to the game's world can be found in the sequence where Daniel plays catch with the dragon. From a first-person perspective, it is up to the player to decide how hard and in which direction to throw the given baseball by physically moving the mouse or controller.

In terms of variance, the last hypodiegetic chapter shows no exception. The chapter is about the anomaly SCP-426. As mentioned above, the character interacts with a computer terminal at the beginning of the story. However, beyond the fact that the terminal effectively introduces the story that is followed by a textual description of the anomaly's isolation procedure, the anachronistic transition sequence guides the player towards an equally anachronistic graphic and design style which is closest to the 2(.5) dimensional role-playing games' aesthetics which are produced in the *RPG Maker* engine.³²⁸ The chapter comprises three separate sequences: roughly all three sequences follow the same plot structure in the same location but from different characters' points of view. During the play, we get to know the characters D-081 (Jason Grias), D-082 (Dorothy Wilson), and D-083 (Adam Moria) as stylized characters portrayed from a third-person perspective but focalized from a first-person perspective.

The chapter's aesthetics and core gameplay mechanics mostly resonate with the aforementioned *RPG Maker* engine, as well as classic third-person role-playing games such as *EarthBound*³²⁹ or *Chrono Trigger*.³³⁰ although it technically does not use pixel graphics, the models in the chapter are granular, angular, and even the human characters are built from cubes. The use of color, for example, goes beyond the technological capabilities of the NES, SNES, or N64, however, the palette and the color transition resolution that is used in the hypodiegesis are limited, the music and sounds are stylized computer-generated noises, bleeps and bloops, and even the control scheme is simple and familiar to resemble these classic consoles better.

However, even though the game mechanics, the focalization, the visuals, and the historical genres evoked may seem distant and alienating to the player – not to mention that this is the first segment where the player controls a non-first-person avatar – these devices once again evoke the anthology-like structure of the SCP Foundation storyworld. Moreover, because the chapter brings into play a more traditional video game language, it emphasizes the aspects that make a game a game, namely interactivity and interaction, which can intensify the sense of involvement and immersion for the player. In doing so, the chapter evokes, in addition to the anthological and communal ethos, the immersive nature of the storyworld that comes from role-

³²⁷ Genette, *Narrative Discourse Revisited*, 72–78.

³²⁸ Latest version is Gotcha Gotcha Games et al., *RPG Maker MZ*, Gotcha Gotcha Games, released August 2020, PC.

³²⁹ HAL Laboratory and Ape Inc., *EarthBound*, Nintendo, released August 1994, SNES.

³³⁰ Square Enix, *Chrono Trigger*, Square, released March 1995, SNES.

playing in the SCP universe (see the rules and guiding principles of the wiki's collective creative project).

During the hypodiegetic episode of SCP-426, three consecutive characters die as a result of the player's direct inputs: in the first, a drag & drop mechanic forces the player to plug a wire into an electrical socket, causing the character to suffer a fatal electric shock; in the second, repeated button presses cause the character to stuff himself with bread until his abdominal wall ruptures; and finally, slightly differently from the previous two, the sequence of actions leading to death is represented by a cutscene (the player slashes his stomach open with a screwdriver), but in this case, just like in the previous ones, the player is forced to perform the fatal sequence of actions leading to their death in the form of button presses.

Unlike previous hypodiegetic narratives, the player actively guides their character towards an always repeating, inevitable horror through direct inputs. This is further emphasized by the game's procedural, narrative, and audiovisual repetition. By observing the psychosis induced by SCP-426 from the outside (in both visual and narrative terms), the game establishes a sense of utter helplessness in the recipient – a type of horror that also fits perfectly with the ethos of the SCP Foundation's fictional universe. Of all the previous hypodiegetic narratives, it is, thus, surprisingly, the most stylized chapter that captures this aspect of the storyworld the best.³³¹

Drawing mainly on the theory of Klastrup and Tosca, the chapter explored how and by what means video games can recreate, evoke, conjure, and expand the worlds of transmedial universes. The video game *SCP: Secret Files*, its hypodiegetic narratives, the interconnecting frame story, its diverse mechanics, and its visual repertoire are all relevant to this exploration. *SCP: Secret Files* demonstrated how the media complexity of video games could be linked to a collaboratively evolving transmedia storyworld of immense scale.

First, the mythos of the SCP Foundation are reinforced and brought into play by the documents and objects in the chapters on SCP-701 and SCP-239, which are direct calls back to the actions of the SCP Wiki articles and other writings. Second, the multiple representations of the fictional organization's global presence and the constant representation of the transmedia 'brand' in the mise-en-scène evoke the topos of the fictional storyworld with extraordinary power but also provide the recipient with a high degree of immersion in the three-dimensional explorable spaces, in contrast to the primarily written documents of the SCP Wiki.³³² Finally, the ethos that provides a distinctive mood and atmosphere for the universe can be reproduced and reinforced in every aspect of *SCP: Secret Files*, from the narrative to the different control schemes to the visuals: the anthology as a structure faithfully represents the fragmented nature of the storyworld, the narrative and aesthetic closedness of documents and other realizations; the overarching mechanics of walking simulators (or,

³³¹ For further discussion on this topic see Chad Habel and Ben Kooyman, "Agency Mechanics: Gameplay Design in Survival Horror Video Games," *Digital Creativity* 25, no. 1 (2014): 1–14, <https://doi.org/10.1080/14626268.2013.776971>.

³³² More on this engagement in Gordon Calleja, *In-Game: From Immersion to Incorporation* (MIT Press, 2011), 73–92, <https://doi.org/10.7551/mitpress/8429.001.0001>.

drawing on Kagen's terminology, archival adventuring) highlights investigation and inquiry as a viable and important strategy of the recipient; and the almost all-encompassing darkness, the lingering feel of mystery, and the presence of the paranormal, cosmic horror that transcends our world, are all perfectly lined up to strengthen this aspect of the SCP Foundation's world.

The chapter also pointed out that video games are sometimes not just single works that can be interpreted in themselves but can be parts of a larger fictional universe, and this is where the methodologies of game studies can offer a productive new perspective that takes into account the game mechanics, narratological functions and strategies, and visual representation at the same time. So, these highly interactive storyworld elements can also be accounted for in a holistic framework.

3.3.3 Action and Agency in Transmedia Narratives

Transmedia narratives, particularly ARGs, rely heavily on user interactions, actions, and participation. As emphasized multiple times in the previous chapters, decoding and receiving narrative information involves various activities and movements according to the mediums' mechanics contained within the storytelling network. As was already discussed, how storyworlds emerge from the fragments (and the whole) of a transmedia narrative and how one can identify and interpret them, there is still a question that remains unexamined: how can and does the player (or recipient) act in these systems? How should one approach the challenges of analyzing the actions of the user?

The interdisciplinary field of game studies already has extensive literature on agency and interactions. The main approaches to these questions are the entities of *avatars* in computer games³³³ and the effects of player actions on the storyworld of a video game.³³⁴ The latter was discussed in the previous chapter. However, the former needs to be defined more specifically. From a structural(ist) point of view, encountering a video game always establishes a narrative-communication connection between the creator of the virtual environment and the player where the information can flow between one another.³³⁵ The field and theories of communication models are extensive and diverse. It certainly would not be wise to try and take into inventory all linguistic frameworks – what can be considered as a unifying aspect of all these from Aristotle to Frank Dance is the notion of stating the existence of at least one sender “node”, one receiver “node” in the system with various transactions happening between them while also being influenced by external circumstances.

I argue that video games can be best understood – from the perspective of this specific research – by using Chatman's framework and developing it one step further to suit this field of investigation. The key elements in this specific model are the

³³³ Marcus Carter et al., *Avatars, Characters, Players and Users: Multiple Identities at/in Play*, 2012.

³³⁴ Jan-Noël Thon, *Computer Games, Fictional Worlds, and Transmedia Storytelling: A Narratological Perspective*, 2009, 6; Fraser Allison, “Whose Mind Is the Signal? Focalization in Video Game Narratives,” *Proceedings of DiGRA 2015: Diversity of Play: Games – Cultures – Identities*, 2015, <https://doi.org/10.26503/dl.v2015i1.731>.

³³⁵ Fejes, ““Would You Stop Changing My Games?,”” 257–58.

developer, the implied developer, the narrative information, the avatar, the implied player, and the player.

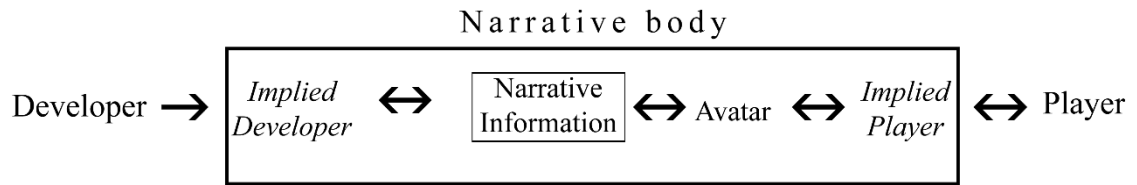


Figure 6: The narrative structure of video games derived and adapted from Chatman's model of narrative-communication situation.

As I have stated elsewhere

[f]rom left to right: the developer is the abstract figure who creates the virtual environment of the work. Thus, this particular component should be placed outside the narrative framework. The term implied developer depicts those “invisible” narrative functions described by other authors as implied creator, intrigant, graphiator, or grand image-maker (Backe & Thon, 2019).³³⁶ This element is responsible for disseminating and (re)presenting the narrative information. This unit can delegate power and authority to narratorial agents (e.g., a narrator per se). However, this delegation is only optional, so there are no “narrator” or other similar elements in the diagram. To grasp it more easily, the implied developer is a collective term for (almost) every act and operation of narrative information.³³⁷

This dissertation employs the term “narrative information” because it aligns with Gérard Genette's emphasis on the “information” aspect of the phrase rather than using “representation.”³³⁸ However, it is important to distinguish this from Genette's terminology, as he was primarily concerned with verbal forms of expression – a topic I have already addressed.

The video game is a highly integrative, multimodal meta-medium that allows it to incorporate all other “major presentational media,” such as spoken and written texts, sounds, images, etc.³³⁹ Still, they also operate with the inputs or actions of the recipient (player). Eskelinen describes this latter as the completed scriptonic element³⁴⁰ derived from Espen Aarseth's terminological system on ergodic literature, or one can

³³⁶ Further explanations and definitions of these terms, which Backe and Thon cited see: Aarseth, 1997, p. 127 (*implied creator, intrigant*), Toby Miller and Robert Stam, eds., *A Companion to Film Theory* (Blackwell, 1999), 46. (*grand image-maker*) and Marion, 1993, p. 36 (*graphiator*) (Backe & Thon's translation).

³³⁷ Fejes, ““Would You Stop Changing My Games?,”” 257–58 (edits had been made for easier understanding).

³³⁸ Fejes, ““Would You Stop Changing My Games?,”” 258.

³³⁹ Hans-Joachim Backe and Jan-Noël Thon, “Playing with Identity Authors, Narrators, Avatars, and Players in The Stanley Parable and The Beginner's Guide,” *DIEGESIS* 8, no. 2 (2019): 4; Sebastian Domsch, *Storyplaying: Agency and Narrative in Video Games* (Walter de Gruyter, 2013), 4.

³⁴⁰ Markku Eskelinen, “The Gaming Situation,” *The International Journal of Computer Game Research* 1, no. 1 (2001): n.p.

refer to it as interactivity or, what this dissertation prefers, the actional dimension, which may sound a less loaded term.

Circling back to the initial argument, the term “narrative information” in this context is not to be applied only to the verbal transmission of meaning (as Genette primarily used it) but to every aspect of this multimodal structure. So, narrative information here is not used to emphasize the opposition between language and imitation but between *mono-* and *multimodality*, emphasizing the *transmedial nature* of information.

This narrative information stands in the middle of communication between the developer and the player, emphasizing the transactional relationships with the avatar and the collective of the implied developer (indicated by the bidirectional arrows in Figure 6). It is imperative to pinpoint this detail as when one examines the narrative framework of video games – or even transmedial works³⁴¹ –, one must always consider, besides the implied developer, how the implied player and/or the avatar also modulates the narrative information (more or less) by her actions in the virtual environment.³⁴²

This is where we arrive at the figure of the avatar; the entity that directly interacts with the narrative information is the avatar of the (implied) player. This embodied doubling of player agency is the primary modulator of the communication’s “player side”. Avatar, as a prominent element in the field of video games, is discussed in numerous studies from many perspectives. Still, I work³⁴³ with the definition of Rune Klevjer’s doctoral dissertation:

*[a]n avatar is an instrument or mechanism that defines for the participant a fictional body and mediates fictional agency; it is an embodied incarnation of the acting subject. It is dependent on the principle of the model, and acts as a dynamically reflexive prop in relation to its environment. Its capabilities and restrictions are based on the objective properties of the model, and these capabilities and restrictions define the possibility-space of the player’s fictional agency within the game. The avatar therefore defines the boundaries of embodied make-believe.*³⁴⁴

Embodiment is one of the most important features of the avatar: this element, which constantly interacts with the narrative information and the implied player, embodies every aspect of the playerly influence and is also (partially) responsible for

³⁴¹ It is worth noting that according to the definition this research is working regarding the term *avatar*, in interactive narratives such as the different forms of transmedia storytelling, these mechanisms are present and acting in the same way as in video games: instruments that define the restrictions and capabilities of the “possibility-space” of the player’s fictional agency. However, unlike video games, the avatar can entirely coincide with the extrafictional recipients’ body in transmedia narratives.

³⁴² Modulating the narrative information, however, does not have to mean true and absolute agency for the player: even if the player does not have power over the narrative outcome, they are still able to “transform the perceptible form through input”. Domsch, *Storyplaying: Agency and Narrative in Video Games*, 8.

³⁴³ Fejes, “‘Would You Stop Changing My Games?,” 258–59.

³⁴⁴ Klevjer, “What Is the Avatar? Fiction and Embodiment in Avatar-Based Singleplayer Computer Games,” 87.

transmitting narrative information.³⁴⁵ Do not forget: the avatar's affordance is enforcing as many narrative acts on the player as the other way around.³⁴⁶

Finally, the implied player and the real-life player are in a similar relationship as the implied developer and the real-life developer. The former is the collective term for the different aspects of player-presence inside the narrative framework (or diegesis), so the implied player is the entity that is, on the one hand, directly responsible for implementing the inputs of the player, and on the other hand, receiving the communication from the other entities of the gaming situation. So, one could say that the implied player is the closest thing to the literary *narratee*.³⁴⁷

Focalization of Avatars and Points of Action

Making choices, taking actions, and acting upon certain scenarios in video games is a structurally identical process to experiencing and participating in transmedia storytelling systems. To reiterate, avatars are the mechanisms that provide the recipient, the player, and the user with a fictional body to channel agency. This indicates that the analytical toolbox must consider methods to fully investigate action, agency, and avatars to fully grasp transmedia networks.

These movements need to be accounted for on three levels: these works can operate with avatar actions in a monomedial setting, so when the actio radius is more or less confined within a single site; second, one can observe actions that connect multiple sites and multiple platforms, an example could be the activation of *migratory cues* as Mark Ruppel refers to these cross-nodal phenomena,³⁴⁸ but more on these later; thirdly, recipients can take actions in certain cases that impacts the whole story-world, for example taking part in a decision which decides the fate of a character or an outcome of a conflict.

Jan-Noël Thon, in one of his earlier works, presents a multidimensional framework to interrogate player perspective in video games, taking inspiration from literary and film narratologies such as Chatman's and Uspenskij's theories. According to this, the methods of focalization can be defined on three axes: the spatial (which includes the point-of-view and location), the actional (which tells us, for example, where the player can interact with the interface), and the ideological (which tells us about how the various events are being evaluated in the storyworld) axis.³⁴⁹ Location, point-of-

³⁴⁵ Only partially, because the narrative information's "outputs" (from the player's perspective) can also be manifested on the interface, which functions mostly as paratext. For a more in-depth analysis of the interface, see Andreas Gregersen and Torben Grodal, "Embodiment and Interface," in *The Video Game Theory Reader 2*, ed. Bernard Perron and Mark J. P. Wolf (Routledge, 2009). For more on the issues of the interface, see Alesja Serada, "Phantom Affordances in Video Games," *Galactica Media: Journal of Media Studies*, Computer Games: Grammars of Interfaces, no. 4 (2019): 86–107.

³⁴⁶ If the player's avatar, for example, cannot jump or can only move backward, that is also transmitting the narrative information (thus contributing to the meaning-making processes) to the recipient.

³⁴⁷ Genette, *Narrative Discourse*, 259–62.

³⁴⁸ Marc Nathaniel Ruppel, "Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries" (University of Maryland, 2012), 61–71.

³⁴⁹ Jan-Noël Thon, "Perspective in Contemporary Computer Games," in *Point of View, Perspective, and Focalization: Modeling Mediation in Narrative*, ed. Peter Hühn et al. (Walter de Gruyter, 2009), 279–80.

view, and the rhetorics of a subject have vast literature to rely on; however, the actional axis is an extra layer to consider when analyzing transmedia narratives. This perspective deals with interactivity and agency, which sets it apart from most literary and cinematic works.

Video game spaces allow the implied player or the player's avatar to interact with them through the mediation of an interface using avatars.³⁵⁰ When one considers these interactions, that is the moment when it is easy to realize that the transmedia work's narrative instance inherently contains the dimension (or perspective) of action as well. This is the aspect that Britta Neitzel refers to as the "point of action" in the realm of video games. She argues that we can draw three basic distinctions when discussing the relationship between the spatial distribution of the action and the game space.

Firstly (as Thon also points out), the point of action can reside either within (intradiegetic point of action) or outside the diegesis (extradiegetic point of action), which means that the action the player invokes with the avatar could either be ascribed to a certain character or object in the game's world, or not.

Secondly, we can identify concentric and eccentric points of action, meaning that the action invoked can be executed in (or on) one location only in the game space or implemented at multiple locations. For example, an FPS³⁵¹ game's "jump" action can be described as concentric because it can only affect the player's avatar. However, the more universal actions in, for example, real-time strategy games are eccentric in nature: a great example could be the Orbital Drop Shock Trooper units in Halo Wars, in which these supporting game elements could be dropped almost anywhere on the playing field.

Finally, the point of action can be either direct or indirect. This property refers to how the avatar interacts with the game objects. We can talk about direct points of action, for example, in the case of a third-person shooter in which a button is pressed instantly and directly makes the avatar move (or shoot) in a certain direction. However, when we consider the case of real-time strategy games,³⁵² the point of action is

³⁵⁰ Thon, "Perspective in Contemporary Computer Games," 287.

³⁵¹ Abbreviation for first-person shooter games. These games are video games that emphasize combat and action from a first-person perspective, where players experience the game world through the eyes of the protagonist. Gameplay typically involves navigating 3D environments, using various weapons to defeat enemies, and completing objectives, emphasizing reflex-based shooting mechanics and spatial awareness.

³⁵² Real-time strategy (RTS) games are a type of video game in which players control units and resources in real-time to achieve specific objectives, typically by defeating opponents. Unlike turn-based strategy games, where players take turns making moves, actions in RTS games happen simultaneously, requiring quick thinking and strategic decision-making under pressure.

indirect because we cannot influence how our troops should make their moves or shoot at enemy units.³⁵³

In the case of ARGs (and other transmedia works), narrative meaning emerges from the system through actions taken by the recipients. Drawing from Neitzel's classification, these actions can be positioned in a three-directional taxonomic system: the point of action (PoA) can be either direct or indirect, intra- or extradiegetic, and con- or eccentric. Taking the example of EMH, or more specifically the retrieval of the previously discussed Box #3, we can determine that FlyingWarhorse's point of action was intradiegetic, as it can be ascribed to a character he "played" his avatar in a sense. It was also a concentric point of action, as this specific box could not have been retrieved at another location in the game space. Finally, the retrieval was a direct point of action, directly manipulating his avatar (in this case, it coincides with his own body).

Another interesting action could be (if we discuss ARG networks in a wider sense) the recipients' data mining, puzzle-solving, and wiki-creating activity. These actions are all extradiegetic (as, for example, the figuring out of a coded message cannot or hardly can be ascribed to an intradiegetic character or object), eccentric (as, for example, the archiving method of a set of events can be implemented on multiple occasions), and direct (as, for example, the process of data mining in a source code is directly done by the recipient).

However, if we step away from alternate reality games and look at *The Matrix*'s transmedia franchise, we encounter a different structure of actions system-wise. The player's avatar, which interacts with the video game *Enter the Matrix*, is making an action that is – from the transmedia discourse's point of view – extradiegetic (as playing the game itself does not affect the Matrix universe³⁵⁴), concentric (as the action playing with the *Enter the Matrix* can only be done at this specific transmedia "location"), and direct (as the action of the play is directly influenced by the recipient itself).

All these actions can be described as constituting elements of a narrative instance even though these are not controlled mainly by the diegesis of the fictional universe but by the recipients interacting with the storyworld. This means that to analyze a transmedial entity's narrative instances, we must combine the holistic observations regarding the classical approaches (who speaks, who sees, where the situation is located), and the similar systemic observations of player (avatar) actions (who is acting, where it is acting, how it is acting).

Where Action Meets the Environment and the Narrative Act

Individual actions done through the device of an avatar can be categorized and analyzed using the framework presented in the previous sub-chapter. This can already lead the researcher to valuable conclusions regarding their subjects as, for example,

³⁵³ Richárd Fejes, "A transzmédia-diskurzus," in *Transzmédia: Interdiszciplináris tanulmányok*, ed. Richárd Fejes and Lilla Gregor, Digi Poszt (Kijarat Kiadó : I.T.E.M. Alapítvány, 2020), 196.

³⁵⁴ This statement can be contested based on how gestures like reenactment and fan reinterpretations can be understood as an intradiegetic process, but for the sake of this argument, it is more fruitful to regard this action as extradiegetic.

FlyingWarhorse's case points out how complete immersion can be achieved if the architect of the transmedia network tailors the actions required at key story beats by the recipient to be an intradiegetic, concentric, direct point of action. From another point of view, departing from the strict fictional framework, I would also argue that fake news and political campaigns can successfully subvert a recipient's opinion if they (or their avatars – in the widest of contexts) can be put into positions where their points of action would have these same properties as FlyingWarhorse's.

However, it would be naïve to assume that meaning only emerges from the recipient's applied actions and is not formed and re-formed when these actions are put into the context of the environment and when the narrative itself or the transmitter of this narrative information also extends its direct impact onto the recipient.

Analyzing *The Beginner's Guide*,³⁵⁵ a highly suitable game to study, as it demonstrates extreme levels of self-referentiality (relating to metafictional works) and literary likeness, thus posing as a perfect candidate for demonstrating a narratological framework, I argue³⁵⁶ that a video game's meaning emerges from the triangular framework of space, action, and narration.³⁵⁷ This work is a walking simulator,³⁵⁸ a genre that is a perfect example of literary games.³⁵⁹ These games highlight the spatial and narrative capabilities of the medium besides its interactivity.

The narratorial part of the framework refers to any act that can be connected to a classical agent of narration, a narrator. It mainly identifies these with verbal acts: fictional paratexts, vocal/oral narrators, or subtitles – when the narrative information flows “towards” the recipient. The spatial dimension was highlighted in cases of environmental storytelling when objects, locations, and arrangements of existents are largely responsible for meaning-making. Finally, this video game analysis emphasized the actional dimension in the cases of avatar operations, pointing out that this is the only part of the narrative process when the information flows from the side of the implied player toward the implied developer.³⁶⁰

This approach is practical when the research subject is solely a video game (and even a highly literary one). However, in the case of this dissertation, the relevant part is where these lines are blurred between player/avatar action and spatiality and player/avatar action and narratorial acts. This fuzziness emerges from the fact that the connections between the endpoints of this triangle present a continuum: “there are events where the narratorial and the spatial dimensions are affecting the

³⁵⁵ Davey Wreden, *The Beginner's Guide*, Everything Unlimited Ltd., released 2015, PC.

³⁵⁶ Fejes, ““Would You Stop Changing My Games?””

³⁵⁷ Fejes, ““Would You Stop Changing My Games?”” 255–57.

³⁵⁸ For more on the genre of walking simulators see: Montembeault and Deslongchamps-Gagnon, “The Walking Simulator's Generic Experiences”; Mona Bozdog and Dayna Galloway, “Worlds at Our Fingertips: Reading (in) What Remains of Edith Finch,” *Games and Culture*, May 2, 2019; Jesper Juul, “The Aesthetics of the Aesthetics of the Aesthetics of Video Games: Walking Simulators as Response to the Problem of Optimization,” 12th International Conference on the Philosophy of Computer Games, Copenhagen, August 13, 2018, www.jesperjuul.net/text/aesthetics3/.

³⁵⁹ Terminology of Astrid Ensslin. For more, see: Ensslin, *Literary Gaming*.

³⁶⁰ Fejes, ““Would You Stop Changing My Games?”” 266.

meaning-making processes hand in hand, or there are certain cases when the lines between the [actional] and narratorial action are being blurred.”³⁶¹

Actional and spatial processes overlap when the avatar’s interaction with the game’s space is limited or directed somehow. Thus, it becomes hard to discern whether the recipient’s actions or the effects of the environment have a bigger impact on meaning-making. For example, when the environment obstructs narrative information, the avatar can access it standardly. Still, it is revealed when the player modifies the game’s behavior via cheat codes (thus increasing the avatar’s affordance). It is apparent that actional and spatial dimensions influence the interpretation hand in hand.³⁶² Similarly, in cases when an ARG requires the players to uncover a hidden box in a remote forest or when they need to navigate a maze of hyperlinks and online platforms for the same end, we witness the interplay between action and environmental design.

Actional and narratorial dimensions can also overlap in video games (as demonstrated in the paper) and expand on these arguments in ARGs. We can observe this phenomenon when the actions of the recipient (or its avatar) are indiscernibly close to the acts of a narrator. In *The Beginner’s Guide*, the player finds themselves on a flat surface with towering monoliths above them during one of the sequences. There is, however, only one way to move upwards: to take a long flight of stairs into one of these monoliths. While the player is making their way upwards, an environmental mechanic kicks in, which reduces the avatar’s speed to a fraction of its original. Making it seemingly impossible to climb the stairs. At this point, the verbal narrator of the game helps the player with the promise to modify this game behavior if they press the ‘enter’ or the ‘use’ key. After this enunciation, the avatar’s speed is restored to its original if the player presses the mentioned buttons.³⁶³ So, it is not easy to discern, in these cases, whether the player (avatar) or the narrator restores the avatar’s speed. That is the essential principle of actional-narratorial transgressions: the meaning-making process is simultaneously influenced by the actional and the narratorial dimensions. Regarding transmedia narratives, these overlaps thus can be observed in story beats where there is a requirement to follow certain instructions: in EMH, more involved recipients were participating in a fictional series of challenges overseen by the antagonist, Habit. To progress and keep their status in the storytelling system, the players, at some point, had to organize a demonstration in their local community for a fictional cause. It cannot be clear whether these happenings were the effects of the figure acting as a narrator (Habit) or the actions of the recipients who organized these events.

It is imperative to understand that while interactive storytelling systems, be they video games or transmedia narratives, cannot be fully grasped and establish a holistic interpretation without taking player (avatar) action into account, it is equally important to consider how actions interfere with other movements of the narrative information, for example, environmental design and acts of narration.

³⁶¹ Fejes, “‘Would You Stop Changing My Games?,”” 269.

³⁶² Fejes, “‘Would You Stop Changing My Games?,”” 269–70.

³⁶³ Fejes, “‘Would You Stop Changing My Games?,”” 273.

4 TRANSMEDIAL WORKS AS NARRATIVES OF THE NETWORK

On March 23, 2021, a 400-meter-long container-hauling vessel called the Ever Given was wedged sideways into the walls of the Suez Canal, blocking it completely due to technical problems and human errors. As a result, experts reported that over 200 container ships had queued up around the blockage after just two days. Rough calculations also suggest that the global economy suffered a loss of \$9.6 billion daily because of this issue.³⁶⁴ One might even use this example as the perfect illustration for the butterfly effect: A tiny ship fails to navigate through a narrow canal, creating a deep wound in the body of the global supply chain.

However, the economy and the global movement of goods and services are not the only networks that tightly connect the planet's community. We experience our ways of communication, the ways we share knowledge, the ways our culture influences and is influenced, the ways we think about (geo)politics, and the whole experience of our lives as interconnected and interdependent. Manuel Castells defines this paradigm as the Network Society.

According to Castells, our social structure constantly shifts from hierarchical constructs to dynamic systems. This is fundamental in the Information Age,³⁶⁵ represented by the exponentially increasing importance of "micro-electronics-based communication technologies and genetic engineering."³⁶⁶ Castells argues that networks are tools and the core fabric of our contemporary society. They are not only sets of interconnected nodes but also the stock market, poppy fields, diplomatic relationships, disinformation operations, and social media.³⁶⁷

At the heart of all this, information technology is the enabler. As Castells expands on this:

*"[...] the new communication system radically transforms space and time, the fundamental dimensions of human life. Localities become disembodied from their cultural, historical, geographical meaning, and reintegrated into functional networks, or into image collages, inducing a space of flows that substitutes for the space of places. Time is erased in the new communication system when past, present, and future can be programmed to interact with each other in the same message. The space of flows and timeless time are the material foundations of a new culture that transcends and includes the diversity of historically transmitted systems of representation: the culture of real virtuality where make-believe is belief in the making."*³⁶⁸

³⁶⁴ Richard Meade, "Suez Blockage Extends as Salvors Fail to Free Ever Given," Lloyd's List, March 25, 2021, <https://www.lloydslist.com/LL1136246/Suez-blockage-extends-as-salvors-fail-to-free-Ever-Given>.

³⁶⁵ Manuel Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society* (Wiley-Blackwell, 2010), i–xliv.

³⁶⁶ Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*, xlv.

³⁶⁷ Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*, 500–502.

³⁶⁸ Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*, 406.

The mechanics of the Network Society are conceptualized as an open, transnational structure that can expand without limits and facilitate the communication and distribution of all forms of cultural expression,³⁶⁹ rendering it the ideal constellation for innovation,³⁷⁰ efficiency, and globalization.³⁷¹ On the other hand, no matter how expansive they are, networks are not inclusive. Some territories (observed through the economy's dynamics) cannot be integrated into the global architecture, leading to inequalities.³⁷² These inequalities are also accounted for by Castells when he examines the individualization of labor, which creates flexible arrangements for the individual. However, it increases the difficulty of controlling faulty workforce processes due to the Network Society's decentralized mechanics.³⁷³

The absolute impact of the dynamic, self-organizing, non-deterministic contemporary network paradigm³⁷⁴ is perceptible in every aspect of our lives. Manuel Castells is not the only theorist who explores the influence of networks on the world: Albert-László Barabási similarly sees networks as the fundamental, global structure to understand contemporary society³⁷⁵ and grasp the critical role of technological advancements.³⁷⁶ The universe, from a microscopical to a macroscopic scale, obeys the principles of the network.³⁷⁷ If we understand and map out this interconnectedness, we can unmask vulnerabilities, trace power dynamics, and offer insights into various complex systems. If one understands how networks behave, it makes it easier to navigate the complexity around us.

Networks also transform cultural expressions and how we think about messages and information transfers. Our storytelling methods directly represent structures of interconnectedness, societal shifts, and the logic of the network. Stories shift towards becoming open structures that can expand flexibly, integrating new nodes and elements into their systems. Elevated complexity becomes a constitutive feature of contemporary narratives where different platforms and different story fragments contribute to the fabula: analyzing the impact of hubs and central nodes becomes essential to grasping and understanding the message; observing the marginalized parts of these systems might contribute to a more nuanced interpretation when one encounters transmedia works. Furthermore, acknowledging Castell's arguments about our culture of "real virtuality",³⁷⁸ where digital communication networks make virtuality a fundamental part of reality, we would develop a further understanding of the appeal and prominence or pervasiveness of immersive environments such as ARGs and other transmedia forms of storytelling.

³⁶⁹ Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*, 405.

³⁷⁰ Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*, 384.

³⁷¹ Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*, 501–2.

³⁷² Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*, 108–10.

³⁷³ Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*, 178–80.

³⁷⁴ Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*, 73–76.

³⁷⁵ Albert-László Barabási, *Linked: The New Science of Networks* (Perseus Pub, 2002), 7–8.

³⁷⁶ Barabási, *Linked*, 53–54.

³⁷⁷ Barabási, *Linked*, 5–6.

³⁷⁸ Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*, 355–58.

But let us go one step further and emphasize the pervasive nature of transmedia storytelling networks: Russia's disinformation efforts and operations,³⁷⁹ the recent emergence (and downfall) of Călin Georgescu in Romania,³⁸⁰ the narratives (of medical staff, of vaccination, of safety measures) of the COVID-19 pandemic, and immersive experiences that are effectively used in cultural and sociological education³⁸¹ among others, show that these kinds of narrative networks directly and seriously influence our lives and proves to be either an efficient tool or a weapon in adequately trained hands.

As the final and, in some sense, the most important feature or layer of the transmedia systems, the subsequent chapters will investigate how it is possible to grasp these complex structures not only by their parts but as a sum, as a whole. After identifying narratological mechanics and accounting for the interactivity of these storytelling systems, it is important to develop an approach that describes, interprets, and recognizes the properties of the network itself.

4.1 HOW THE CLOUDMAKERS SAVED THE WORLD

The Beast ARG, as it was stated previously, was one of the most groundbreaking endeavors of interactive narratives in the early years of 2000. The sprawling network of more than 30 in-game web pages, live events, telephone calls, and other happenings connected to the storyworld was one of the first storytelling systems that successfully utilized the emerging aspects of the network society.

Though the narrative's exhaustive summary is beyond this dissertation's scope, a small introduction is needed to ease the topic's contextualization for the reader and to perceive the peculiar connections between the motifs and themes of the story and its medial and narratological structure. The plot for the VUPs started in the distant future (2142) when a certain Evan Chan was found dead onboard a boat called *The Cloudmaker*. After the news of his death, Jeanine Salla (referred to as a sentient machine therapist in the trailer for the movie) took on the task of investigating the circumstances of Evan's mysterious passing. As VUPs set their feet inside the rabbit hole of The Beast, they also assumed the role of a detective: examining a vast network of websites, interrogating human and non-human characters, and exploring the political and social landscape of this fictional future. As the players unearth more and more about the plot and the storyworld, it becomes clear that the death of Evan Chan was indeed a murder and that the direct culprit was a sex robot called Venus, created by the fictional manufacturer, Belladerma. However, the murder investigation of Evan

³⁷⁹ Elina Treyger et al., *Russian Disinformation Efforts on Social Media*, Combating Foreign Disinformation on Social Media Series (RAND, 2022); Flemming Splidsboel Hansen, *Russian Hybrid Warfare: A Study of Disinformation*, with Dansk Institut for Internationale Studier, DIIS Report, 2017: 06 (DIIS, Danish Institute for International Studies, 2017).

³⁸⁰ Mimi Mihăilescu, "How Călin Georgescu's TikTok Tactics Rewired Romanian Politics," The Loop, November 28, 2024, <https://theloop.ecpr.eu/how-calın-georgescus-tiktok-tactics-rewired-romanian-politics/>.

³⁸¹ Patrick Jagoda et al., "From Alternate to Alternative Reality: Games as Cultural Probes," in *Alternate Reality Games and the Cusp of Digital Gameplay*, ed. Antero Garcia and Greg Niemeyer (Bloomsbury Academic, 2018); Anthony Pellicone et al., "Alternate Reality Games for Learning: A Frame by Frame Analysis," in *Alternate Reality Games and the Cusp of Digital Gameplay* (Bloomsbury Academic, 2018).

Chan uncovers a convoluted network of actors behind and around the killing: looking into the coroner's report, e-mails, and other documents, it became clear that a certain Enrico Basta had been the previous (and abusive) owner of Venus, who ordered Kate Nei (an AI expert) to reprogram the robot so Basta can directly control and influence its actions.

The rabbit hole in which the VUPs tumbled down as they began their collective investigation of Evan Chan's murder was much deeper and wider than just the storyline of Venus and Enrico Basta. In this storyworld, VUPs could encounter different pro- and anti-AI parties, political movements, militias, influential companies, manufacturers, hackers, and AI programs. For example, a portion of the ARG was dedicated to a rogue AI, Loki's storyline. Loki was an AI subroutine who resided in the Catskill Seaview Clinic in New York, where people sought help removing their nightmares. Loki soon found fascination and enjoyment in hacking into and eating people's nightmares and thus became an *oneirophage*. The AI then began searching for more nightmares, even in the minds of others, not just patients of the Catskill Clinic. It was found responsible for multiple suicides, and it was also directly involved in the deaths of several AIs as well. In the end, the VUPs devised an inventive trap for the oneirophage – using the (since obsolete) Yahoo Group's database feature to assemble a massive index of bad dreams submitted by hundreds of the most dedicated VUPs, the Cloudmakers (as they called themselves) worldwide. They managed to overload and thus defeated Loki.

Without trying to present a full description of the complex storyline system, it might be useful to point out that during the active period of the ARG, Laia Joanna Salla, Jeanine Salla's granddaughter, was the diegetic, internal guide for the VUPs, quite like John Watson's character to Conan Doyle's Sherlock Holmes. During the game, Laia's webpage – especially *The Story So Far* subsection³⁸² – served as a hub to recap important information unearthed by the Cloudmaker community and what was significant for the diegetic persona of Laia.

The storyworld of *The Beast* presents the ethical and social problems of integrating self-conscious robots and algorithms with artificial intelligence into our everyday lives.³⁸³ This question is presented through a highly familiar narrative structure – the detective story, a murder investigation. However, the main vehicles for the narrative were not the traditional media of printed books but instead webpages (and their contents – images, texts, audio, animations, etc.), offline events, phone calls, and flyers, so the story utilized more immersive and transgressive storytelling devices and mediums.

As the VUPs traversed the narrative, they had to use their deductive, analytical, problem-solving, IT, and even their creative writing skills to progress and uncover the secrets of the storyworld. The only way to find new paths and open up, virtually speaking, locked doors in the network, the VUPs had to take advantage of their collective

³⁸² It can be viewed through the Wayback Machine. (<https://web.archive.org/web/20080724173901/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/thestory.html> last access: 2024. 01. 04.)

³⁸³ A topic that curiously and interestingly enough became even more relevant today with the advancements in AI technology.

expertise and competencies, forming a hivemind with the people involved in *The Beast*. This massive user base has amassed significant knowledge about events, people, and locations. As they contributed to guides, forum threads, wikis, and blogs, they slowly explored every site of the transmedia universe. Through these accounts – created in synchronous and asynchronous ways – we can reconstruct a map of the storyworld, making it possible to learn more about transmedia storytelling systems like these.

4.2 EENJOY – ELTE EXCITING NEW JOURNEY OF YOURS: AN EDUCATIONAL ARG

Another minor case study should also be discussed in this research, Eötvös Loránd University’s EENJOY (ELTE Exciting New Journey of Yours).³⁸⁴ On the one hand, this project presents a case study where the author has applied the partial research outcomes of this doctoral work on transmedia storytelling in practice; on the other hand, as this is an ongoing project, it may be wise to use it as an important albeit somewhat extensive footnote to this work.

EENJOY is being funded by the National Research, Development, and Innovation Office³⁸⁵ as part of a larger consortium involving three universities, two private companies, and one university publisher. Currently, besides EENJOY, other projects are being developed under the same umbrella; however, the primary mission of every one of these endeavors is to support the transformation of higher education with new, novel, and innovative (primarily digital) approaches.

EENJOY is a university-wide ARG and gamification platform launched at ELTE, designed to orient and integrate first-year students by disseminating the university’s culture, history, traditions, practical and clerical knowledge, and vital information through playful challenges within a narrative framework. In other words, it is a game with a serious purpose, aligning with the concept of a “serious game” – a game created for an objective beyond mere entertainment (in this case, student induction and community building).

Without opening up an entirely different discussion, it needs to be clarified that in the context of this dissertation, serious games are defined as digital or non-digital game-based systems deliberately designed with a primary purpose beyond entertainment, employing the structures, mechanics, and affordances of gameplay to achieve specific educational, training, or behavioral objectives. While entertainment-oriented games prioritize player enjoyment as an end in itself, serious games harness enjoyment instrumentally to facilitate knowledge acquisition, skill development, attitudinal change, or problem-solving in domains such as education, health, or civic

³⁸⁴ Official one-pager can be reached at: Murai László, “EENJOY – Hallgatói élményt és elköteleződést támogató alternatívvalóság-játék az ELTE-n,” *Eötvös Loránd Tudományegyetem Digitális Oktatásfejlesztési Kompetencia Központja (DOKK)*, 2024, <https://www.dokk.elte.hu/kutatasi-temak/murai-laszlo-eejoy-hallgatoi-elmenyt-es-elkotelezodest-tamogato-alternativvalosag-jatek-az-elte-n/>.

³⁸⁵ Project ID: 2022-1.1.1-KK-2022-00003, total budget HUF 5 722 906 621, funding amount HUF 4 751 687 013. The project is implemented with the support of the National Research, Development, and Innovation Fund, with a duration from April 1, 2023, to March 31, 2027.

engagement.³⁸⁶ From an interdisciplinary perspective, their design integrates insights from psychology, pedagogy, communication, and computer science to align game mechanics with desired learning or behavioral outcomes, ensuring that the game's narrative, feedback systems, and challenge structure support the transfer of competencies into real-world applications.³⁸⁷

In educational applications, serious games may take the form of simulations, immersive narrative environments, or collaborative problem-solving spaces, often leveraging interactive storytelling and system-based modeling to foster active, experiential learning.³⁸⁸ Crucially, their design situates learning goals within a meaningful and engaging ludic framework, creating what Cai et al. describe as “authentic contexts” in which learners can safely explore, experiment with, and apply new concepts. In this sense, serious games occupy a hybrid space between play and purposeful instruction, where entertainment value is not incidental but a core driver of sustained engagement in the learning process.

Although EENJOY serves as an illustrative case of an educational ARG (or a serious game) in action, I will not delve into a detailed analysis of its implementation and outcomes in this dissertation. The project is still ongoing and evolving, and comprehensive evaluation data are not yet available. Focusing too closely on this in-progress case could yield premature or biased conclusions. Instead, I use EENJOY primarily as an example while directing my analytical attention toward the broader theoretical and design principles that underpin such initiatives.

Scholars Shira Chess and Paul Booth affirm that ARGs provide “an ideal space to structure educational challenges”,³⁸⁹ encouraging students to be creative and collaborative in the process. Indeed, educational ARGs seem to have emerged as a subset of the serious games movement. Many of these ARGs target college students and academic communities, integrating gameplay with learning objectives in ways conventional curricula often cannot.³⁹⁰ The narrative and puzzle elements imbue learning activities with a sense of purpose and adventure, while the authentic context (e.g., campus spaces, university lore) gives the experience practical relevance. For example, at the University of Chicago, Patrick Jagoda's team at the Fourcast Lab³⁹¹ has developed first-year orientation ARGs such as *The Parasite*³⁹² and *Terrarium*,³⁹³ which used collaborative play to disseminate information, build student skills, and crowdsource solutions to campus challenges. These games function as immersive

³⁸⁶ Ute Ritterfeld et al., eds., *Serious Games: Mechanisms and Effects* (Routledge, 2009), 6–10.

³⁸⁷ Richard Van Eck, ed., *Interdisciplinary Models and Tools for Serious Games: Emerging Concepts and Future Directions* (Information Science Reference, 2010), 13–18, <https://doi.org/10.4018/978-1-61520-719-0>.

³⁸⁸ Yiyu Cai et al., eds., *Simulation and Serious Games for Education* (Springer Singapore, 2017), v–viii, <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-10-0861-0>.

³⁸⁹ Shira Chess and Paul Booth, “Lessons down a Rabbit Hole: Alternate Reality Gaming in the Classroom,” *New Media & Society* 16, no. 6 (2014): 1004, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444813497554>.

³⁹⁰ Patrick Jagoda et al., “Worlding through Play: Alternate Reality Games, Large-Scale Learning, and ‘The Source,’” *American Journal of Play* 8, no. 1 (2015): 83.

³⁹¹ Read more about the lab at: <https://fourcastlab.com/> (last accessed: 2025. 08. 10.)

³⁹² <https://fourcastlab.com/parasite/> (last accessed: 2025. 08. 10.)

³⁹³ <https://fourcastlab.com/terrarium/> (last accessed: 2025. 08. 10.)

orientation programs, not only conveying facts about the university but actively building a sense of community and belonging among participants. Such projects illustrate how an ARG can operate as a serious game in a higher education context – aligning game mechanics and narrative with the serious purpose of student integration.

EENJOY was conceived in the same spirit and structural lineage. Framed explicitly as a university-wide ARG, EENJOY’s design mirrors the motivations of a serious game: it seeks to “integrate students into the community and disperse important (and less critical) information among them through playful challenges tied together by an overarching narrative. In EENJOY’s fictional storyline, students embark on a fictionalized historical adventure, uncovering the secrets of a lost university faculty (the Faculty of Alchemy), even as they complete real-life tasks like exploring campus facilities or mastering administrative procedures. This dual coding – where every in-game quest corresponds to an actual beneficial activity – exemplifies how ARG mechanics can serve serious pedagogical goals. The fun of solving a mystery or winning points is harnessed to motivate engagement with otherwise mundane orientation activities.

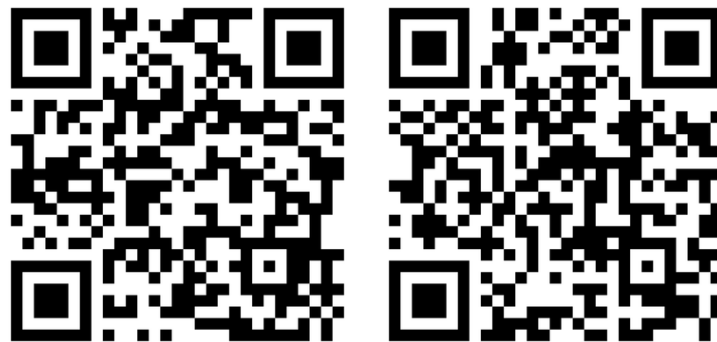


Figure 7: The QR codes above navigate to two introductory videos of EENJOY (in Hungarian language),³⁹⁴ repositied in Zenodo for better understanding: a project introduction (left) and a technical presentation of the platform (right).

The underlying theory is that by gamifying student onboarding in a narrative context, we can enhance student retention, self-efficacy, and community connection – a hypothesis supported by research on serious games and gamification in education. Educational games have been shown to increase learners’ self-efficacy, reduce learning anxiety, and improve motivation when their goals align with the learners’ intrinsic and extrinsic objectives.³⁹⁵ Studies also demonstrate that serious games can foster a sense of empowerment and sustained engagement through participatory design processes that involve target communities from the outset.³⁹⁶ Furthermore, evidence from educational simulations suggests that higher self-efficacy is strongly correlated with task motivation and successful learning performance, especially when learners operate in collaborative, authentic, and narratively meaningful environments.³⁹⁷ In practice, early student response to EENJOY was enthusiastic – within days of its

³⁹⁴ A video of the project introduction with English subtitles can be watched here:

https://youtu.be/_5rCmwURxwM (last accessed: 2025. 08. 10.)

³⁹⁵ Van Eck, *Interdisciplinary Models and Tools for Serious Games*, 112–13.

³⁹⁶ Ritterfeld et al., *Serious Games*, 280–82.

³⁹⁷ Cai et al., *Simulation and Serious Games for Education*, 83–84.

actual launch (in August 2024),³⁹⁸ 10% of the freshman cohort had actively engaged with the platform, hinting at the promise of this approach.

Structurally, it is essential to highlight that this project diverges from the previously examined, more intricate ARG storytelling systems, such as *The Beast* and *Everyman-HYBRID*. Yet, it demonstrates complexity in other respects. EENJOY's central concept is to present self-contained narrative worlds for every iteration, where an iteration (or season) can only be as long as the academic semester. With every new academic year and every new group of incoming students, EENJOY creates a separate and entirely new storyworld for its participants, offering a unique experience each year. In terms of narrative distribution, EENJOY primarily communicates its story through its centralized digital gamification platform, which is accessible only with a university login. During the active phase, participants encountered both “quests” – verifiable³⁹⁹ activities tied to the ARG's storyline – and regular, non-narrative “challenges.” Completion of these tasks or puzzles earned participants INS (Inspirational Points), a digital currency that can be used in the Marketplace.

Structurally speaking, the framing narrative of the ARG was constructed to superimpose a fictional layer onto the everyday reality of university life. Crucially, the system was designed to reward players who chose to engage more intensively with the storyworld by granting them access to unique, one-time experiences that were unavailable through casual participation. In its initial seasons (0 and 1), the plot revolved around the Faculty of Alchemy – an institution deliberately erased from ELTE's collective memory – which, in the seventeenth century, had devised a forbidden artifact capable of capturing the immortal souls of university employees and preserving them within a pocket dimension or metaverse. This “Cloud,” created under the direction of the faculty's first dean, Ignác Lauschbrünn, offered a distorted promise of the afterlife, but at a moral cost that the university's leadership ultimately rejected. Lauschbrünn was cast out, and the Faculty of Alchemy was disbanded. Yet rather than disappearing, Lauschbrünn forced his way into the Cloud's metaverse, where he continued to cause violent hostilities so intense that they produced ripples in the external world. To prevent further damage, the Cloud was sealed into hibernation and subsequently forgotten. The activation of EENJOY, however, inadvertently reawakened both the artifact and Lauschbrünn's destructive agency, making it the students' responsibility to resist and contain this adversary.

Rabbit holes into this storyworld took the form of cryptic clues printed on tarot cards, distributed during student events by diegetic characters — cultists and followers of the erased Faculty of Alchemy, self-styled as the “researchers” of the Scarlatum sect. Alongside these on-site performances, entry points were provided on Instagram (via publicly available videos) and through hyperlinked quests hosted on the central gamification platform. Conceptually, the project experimented with a dual hub-and-

³⁹⁸ The project officially started with a pre-pilot (internally referred to as Season 0) in April 2024, which ended by the end of the academic year, so it could not be regarded as a full-fledged launch with the intended attitude of its potential recipients. Season 1, the first full season, launched at the end of August 2024.

³⁹⁹ Activities and progress in this system depend on the validation of the platform. Incentives are distributed to participants who have verified their solutions to specific tasks and puzzles on the digital platform.

spokes structure,⁴⁰⁰ where the most accessible medium (Instagram) and the bespoke challenge website (eenjoy.elte.hu) functioned as central distribution hubs, from which recipients were drawn outward into interpretative “spokes.” These spokes, however, were deliberately designed with the educational aims of a serious game. For instance, one quest introduced students to Microsoft SharePoint through a fictional archive of forbidden knowledge and case files; another guided them to the university’s Senate decisions by embedding them in a mission to uncover a fictional Senate transcript; and yet another taught the workings of the University Library by framing its archival practices as a semi-narrative, guided exploration of historically significant documents.

Quests on the platform (which either in their descriptions or solutions pushed the narrative forward) required non-trivial efforts to solve a puzzle or find an answer to a riddle. These efforts ranged from reading through fictional documents, looking for keywords and key phrases, to live events where participants encountered the characters of the storyworld and received passwords or other essential instructions. Apart from the more centralized structure of the storytelling system, the transmedia narrative followed the structure of other case studies and contemporary ARGs: the participants were invited to investigate a hidden storyworld, converse with characters in the real world, collaborate to put together their expertise, and take part in online and offline events to advance their understanding of the narrative.

To date, the motivation of the participants has dwindled: although we’ve been able to acquire approximately 10% of the target audience, only around 1% remained active until the end. This directs the project team to rethink the structure of EENJOY. While investing more in researching the target demographic, we will enhance the accessibility of the narrative world by establishing a more predictable and sustainable pacing for its transmedial fluidity, while also educating participants on transmedia literacy.

In this sense, EENJOY functions not merely as an institutional initiative, but as a living laboratory for exploring how serious games and transmedial methodologies can be adapted to the specific cultural, practical, and pedagogical contexts of higher education. While its first iteration has revealed both promising engagement patterns and structural challenges, these outcomes are themselves instructive for the broader discourse on transmedia storytelling in educational settings. The iterative redesign process planned for subsequent academic years presents a unique opportunity to test, refine, and operationalize the narratological frameworks developed in this dissertation. In this way, EENJOY is positioned not only as an applied outcome of the research, but as a potential longitudinal case study capable of evidencing how narrative-driven gamification can foster student integration, agency, and a sustained sense of communal belonging in the university environment, thereby contributing to this dissertation’s broader argument that transmedial networks, when deliberately designed for participatory engagement, can unite narratively rich structures with the capacity to generate meaningful social and communal outcomes.

⁴⁰⁰ More on this in Chapter 5.3.1.

4.3 THINKING WITH NETWORKS

This is not a dissertation in mathematics or information science. The use of networks and the methods of network theory are being employed with a humanistic or interpretive approach in mind; therefore, it is beyond the scope of this text to present a comprehensive theoretical introduction to networks and network theory. However, specific definitions and principles must be understood so that the flow of the methodological argument can move forward. Networks are extremely useful and essential concepts for understanding the mechanics of transmedia storytelling. However, these upcoming arguments often simplify the core scientific concepts, focusing on epistemological structures and the logic of networks rather than providing comprehensive mathematical descriptions. This dissertation seriously considers these scientific concepts; however, they will inevitably be reinterpreted as we apply them to subjects of the humanities.

Networks, as discussed, and as – among others – Castells and Barabási argued, are entities that pervade our entire lives. These complex structures surround us, permeating the domains of technology, science, and nature.⁴⁰¹ It has become one of the most critical tasks for our society to understand how these systems work, making it easier to navigate our world. Finally, with advancements in information technology, it has become feasible to collect, assemble, share, store, and analyze data generated by hundreds to billions of interacting components.⁴⁰²

A network is an inventory of a system's components and their interactions. Typically, the elements are referred to as nodes, and links or edges represent the interactions between them.⁴⁰³ These links or interactions can be directed or undirected processes. This way, we can distinguish between directed networks (where all links are directed) and undirected networks (where none of the links are directed), as well as networks that contain both types of links.

By default, these catalogs are databases and data tables that are not to be confused with their visualized form. Several research questions can be more easily answered if we can visually perceive hundreds or thousands of interactions at once with the help of carefully selected visualization methods. Closely related nodes, important hubs, clusters, and morphological patterns can be pointed out effectively through visual inspection. However, there are studies when one could encounter networks that are too complex to understand their properties through this method, and that is when we need to turn to the tools of network science to reliably complement the visualized model (e.g., protein-protein interaction network of yeast).⁴⁰⁴

The methodological layer described here builds upon the interdisciplinary nature of network science, utilizes its practical and theoretical affordances to “cross-disciplinary fertilization,”⁴⁰⁵ and emphasizes the fact that even structuralist narratologies

⁴⁰¹ Albert-László Barabási, “Introduction,” in *Network Science* (Cambridge University Press, 2016), 5–6.

⁴⁰² Barabási, “Introduction,” 7.

⁴⁰³ Albert-László Barabási, “Graph Theory,” in *Network Science* (Cambridge University Press, 2016), 5.

⁴⁰⁴ Barabási, “Graph Theory,” 27.

⁴⁰⁵ Barabási, “Introduction,” 10.

considered narrative texts not as singular items but as a web of signifiers, parts of a galaxy of texts,⁴⁰⁶ and “networks with a thousand entrances.”⁴⁰⁷

This association between narratives and networks can be understood not only on the level of semiotics but also on the level of media configurations, as Henry Jenkins argued in his seminal work. To reiterate, in *Convergence Culture*, he argued that new storytelling structures are emerging in our contemporary media landscape. These structures create “complexity by expanding the range of narrative possibility rather than pursuing a single path with a beginning, middle, and end”.⁴⁰⁸ Although Jenkins, in his chapter on transmedia storytelling, focused on how narratives reacted to different emerging (mainly participatory) attitudes of the audience, it is clear that this shift also brings about more elaborate media configurations. It must be transparent that contemporary storytelling instances also develop metaphorical and literal network structures. So, examining transmedia works as networks is downright unavoidable.

Marc Ruppel, one of the first scholars to recognize the need for a novel approach to these complex and vast narratives, elaborated in his doctoral dissertation on the need to create a methodology for approaching transmedia narratives as network structures. He introduced his arguments through three “divergent goals” of “studying the network dynamics and orientations of transmedia fiction:”⁴⁰⁹

1. to classify and study transmedia and to identify its definable characteristics (e.g., genre, motifs, etc.);
2. to expose and develop transmedia network tropes “that help to articulate the language of the intricate and highly complex series of interwoven sites”;
3. to use the visualized networks to understand “a hermeneutics of transmedia meaning”.⁴¹⁰

Besides the points that Ruppel makes, it would also be essential to point out that identifying and examining these narratives as networks can

1. be a valid and fruitful way to commence comparative research of transmedia storytelling systems;
2. help develop digital literacies, thus giving key insights about how to gain back control over the narratives of our societies;
3. provide schematics and tools for public businesses to create advanced marketing or PR strategies or use these guidelines and blueprints for future endeavors.

During the previous chapters, it was established that transmedia narratives consist of self-contained fragments of a story that contribute to, expand, or deepen the storyworld. However, this level of fragmentation can vary from narrative to narrative.⁴¹¹ Emerging from this fragmented nature of transmedia systems, the

⁴⁰⁶ Barthes, *S/Z*, 5–6.

⁴⁰⁷ Barthes, *S/Z*, 12.

⁴⁰⁸ Jenkins, *Convergence Culture*, 118–19.

⁴⁰⁹ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 138.

⁴¹⁰ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 138.

⁴¹¹ Andrea Phillips, *A Creator’s Guide to Transmedia Storytelling: How to Captivate and Engage Audiences across Multiple Platforms* (McGraw-Hill, 2012), 15–16.

reader/viewer/user/player (or VUP⁴¹²) is expected to perform a more active role as traversing these scattered elements requires non-trivial efforts from them. The “multi-platform” calls for the revision and revitalization of classical narratological theories and observations, the interactivity and non-trivial traversal calls for the survey of the interdisciplinary field of game studies, and finally, this chapter arrives at the questions and issues raised by the interconnected nature of these fragments. It seeks answers within the realm of network theory.

Structurally speaking, it was also discussed previously that transmedia narratives emerge from interconnected bits and pieces – these self-contained story elements are referred to as *sites* that are being transferred to the recipient with the help of the *channel*. These latter constructs are heuristically chosen units that can either be the actual medium that the site uses (for example, in the case of a comic book, it can easily be regarded the comic book as a medium that coincides with the channel as its vehicle), or it can also be a platform where the narrative information is distributed (for example, if one would like to analyze an ARG which heavily builds on YouTube videos, it might be more productive to regard the different YouTube users as the channels of the separate videos as this information might have bigger impact on the VUP’s interpretation).

As for the former, *sites* are the narrative units of transmedia storytelling systems. These can be *complete* (e.g., a book, a film, a video game, a YouTube video) or *incomplete* (e.g., a few pages, segments from a video clip) sites. However, it must be noted that a site usually exists in multiplicity: a video consists of thousands of frames, but a YouTube video can also be part of a bigger unit, such as a playlist.⁴¹³ The definition of a site can differ according to our research question (just like the definition of a vertex) – we can consider a webpage a site, while other times, we define sites as sub-pages or objects on a website. However, it should not be confused with the vehicles or channels that semiotically determine the sites.

Just like sites can be imagined and visualized as vertices of a network, in transmedia narratives, one can also account for the relationships between these units. Taking on Ruppel’s terminology, we call these connections *paths*. Or, to be more precise, a path indicates, on the one hand, the movement of the VUP and, on the other hand, the movement of meaning-making processes. As this movement between sites is a defining trait in transmedia narratives, paths (or edges) are almost without exception directed. A large portion of meanings and interpretations can only be extracted if a reading does not only consider autonomous, individual sites but also their different kinds of connections. Without these connections, only a “loosely realized set of sites” remain that “share a common language or code”.⁴¹⁴ In transmedia storytelling systems, there are two groups of paths to distinguish: *hermeneutic* and *media-oriented*.⁴¹⁵ The former describes site connections through semantics, interpretations,

⁴¹² Stephen E. Dinehart, “Transmedial Play: Cognitive and Cross-Platform Narrative,” *The Narrative Design Exploratorium™*, May 14, 2008, <http://www.narrative-design.org/2008/05/transmedial-play-the-aim-of-na.html>.

⁴¹³ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 38–40.

⁴¹⁴ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 136.

⁴¹⁵ Ruppel argues that one can categorize ties between sites as strong and weak edges. As he discussed, the former is describing connections of a causal-sequential nature as well as

and cognitive processes. Hermeneutic paths (edges) are more questionable from a network theoretical perspective; however, these ties give a more fleshed-out or in-depth overview of the whole narrative system. We can consider, for example, a path to be hermeneutic when one site's content references another.⁴¹⁶ On the other hand, medial paths are connections that emerge between sites through more material means, medial mechanics, or embedding. Most of the time, these paths can be considered legitimate edges by the standard definitions of network science. Thus, they provide more tangible information about the structure at hand. For example, if one site's content provides a hyperlink to another site's content, that can be considered a medial path between them. These paths can sometimes also be visualized with the help of web crawlers and other automated tools.

After defining a transmedia storytelling system's vertices and edges (sites and paths), it becomes possible to create data tables containing information about the network's individual points. Depending on the specific research, various information can be recorded in these tables: the ID number of a site (to be easily identifiable by later data processing methods), the title, the type, the media channel, the publication date, etc. On the other hand, an edge table should also be created to record several properties, such as the type of path between the two sites, the date the path was established, the direction of the path, etc.

Most of the time, however, transmedia storytelling systems are ephemeral instances (especially ARGs⁴¹⁷), meaning that the distribution of the meaningful fragments is being done in real-time, and the VUPs and the system interact with each other likewise – establishing an organic and cybernetic process. On the one hand, this property heightens the amount of interactivity inside the system. Further, it enhances immersion, but in the meantime, it creates a challenge for researchers, as this ephemerality makes the “post-mortem” analysis more difficult. During the academic investigation, live events, private (and direct) messages, and other elusive artifacts can only be accessed with the help of audience recollections, personal recordings, and other

paths drawn by intersectional cues (which will be discussed later in this study): edges that require a high level of internal knowledge. The latter, weak edges are describing paths emerging from direct and intermedial cues (these are also being discussed later in this study): “edges that require relatively low levels of knowledge in order for connections to be made.” This categorization, however, approach the matter from the perspective of the subject of cognition. The categorization this study proposes is upholding a technical-medial perspective, as the analysis focuses on structure and not on the consumer. Although, the cognitive perspective is not to be discarded entirely, as storyworlds and transmedia universes exist through the cognition of the audience. For Ruppel's arguments see: Ruppel, 123–24.

⁴¹⁶ In exceptional cases, there can be identified references between sites without seemingly any kind of deeper hermeneutical (without the gesture to reinterpret each other's narrative content) connection. These connections may enhance the “notoriety” or the familiarity of the sites in play; these sites can “hype” each other. However, as superficial as they may seem from a narratological point of view, these connections always generate additional narrative information by tightening the connection between two sites, thus indirectly inducing a more complex array of possible interpretations.

⁴¹⁷ Alan Hook, “The Game Did Not Take Place - This Is Not A Game and Blurring the Lines of Fiction,” in *Alternate Reality Games and the Cusp of Digital Gameplay*, ed. Antero Garcia and Greg Niemeyer (Bloomsbury Academic, 2018), 59.

means of archival enterprises. Extracting valid information is crucial to reconstructing a dynamic transmedia network.

The case studies of this dissertation were reconstructed with the help of both primary (still accessible sites in the post-mortem phase) and – in a sense – secondary sources (meta-sites such as wikis on the subject, witness accounts, etc.). The Internet Archive had partially archived the sites of *The Beast* ARG; however, it should be noted that a lot of the sites' visual contents (such as the flash animations) did not remain accessible for the scholars of the present. But, again, with the support of the Internet Archive's initiative, an in-depth chronological overview can be accessed. One of the VUPs wrote this document during *The Beast*'s active phase, Adrian Hon.⁴¹⁸

The reconstruction of the sites and paths of EMH relied heavily on the wiki page written and edited by the VUPs' community.⁴¹⁹ One of the most useful pages is the chronological overview of almost every interaction and fragment in the EMH transmedia storytelling system. However, it was far from complete. Fortunately, social media profiles, sites, and other online sources are accessible. Only a few videos were removed from YouTube due to copyright issues, but those could also be found on other websites: they were reuploaded by the fans of the narrative.

4.4 VISUALIZING TRANSMEDIA SYSTEMS

Creating the network table and visualization (or map) of a transmedia storytelling system may be a herculean task for the researcher, considering the main properties of these narratives. To illuminate the scope of these projects, let us look at the case study at hand: *The Beast*. This being an alternate reality game further complicates the endeavor as the genre creates more obstacles for the scholar: ARGs are not only medially dispersed, multimodal, and convolutedly branching narratives but a highly interactive, highly ephemeral experience too, building on the experientiality of the here and now. ARGs are well-known for utilizing site-specific performances, live events, and unique communicational practices. *The Beast* is no exception in that it is an archeologically problematic artifact.

Having chosen a specific method of investigation, a researcher has to consider the tools they will use, why, and finally, what processes this method predetermines. As this project considers transmedia storytelling systems as a networked narrative of some kind, it would be wise to choose a tool that assists network analysis and network visualization, as these could complement the regular interpretative methods of narratology and the observations made through (video) game studies.

⁴¹⁸ The Guide X: A Tale of the A.I. Trail can be accessed through this archived link: <https://web.archive.org/web/20020802064140/http://www.cloudmakers.org/guide/> (last accessed: 2025. 01. 04.)

⁴¹⁹ It can be accessed at: <https://everymanhybrid.fandom.com/> (last accessed: 2025. 01. 04.)

One of the most widely used network visualization software utilized by researchers and experts in various fields is Gephi, an open-source software for exploring and manipulating networks and network-related data.⁴²⁰ As it states, Gephi uses a 3D render engine for visualization and presents quite a wide array of features for analysis. Users can make calculations on their data and filter them, cluster their network, and create dynamic visualizations for various reasons (e.g., visualizing temporal processes in networks).

Although this present work did use Gephi initially at the early phase of the research, after all the potentially relevant data were collected, Gephi did not prove to be a tool that is flexible enough to unearth and visualize all the core aspects of a transmedia narrative. Gephi's visualization system, as it turned out, was relatively simple for such complex structures as the ARGs at hand. As the research was analyzing every site and path of the system, data such as the owner of a site, the information of who could be the narrative element affiliated with, or even the types and modes of connections between certain sites proved to be highly important during the phase of data interpretation. These pieces of information should be highlighted and underlined in the visualization – thus, the visual signs could also be an important part of the narrative's interpretation.

Instead of Gephi, the software Cytoscape proved to be a superior choice in this analysis. This tool is also an open-source solution for network analysis. However, this software was developed primarily to visualize molecular interaction networks and biological pathways and integrate these networks with annotations, gene expression profiles, and other state data.⁴²¹ It is interesting to note that Cytoscape was originally designed for biological research, but it proved to be invaluable for other analyses of complex networks. Furthermore, besides offering almost every feature that Gephi can provide, it is a much more flexible platform in terms of its visualization capabilities: almost every aspect of the visualization can be modified and customized, thus opening up more possibilities for researchers to visualize and analyze network data more accurately. It must also be mentioned that Cytoscape has a vast built-in marketplace of plugins curated by its user base, further widening the range of features in the software and creating a most versatile application for academics.

Choosing the right tool provides the proper environment for analyzing the data accumulated from *The Beast's* “reading” process. The data structure for describing the nodes of the network (that is, the sites) was the following:

- ID – a unique integer given to the specific sites counting from 0.
- Label – a unique title of the specific site: in cases with a distinct name, the label would be that (e.g., YouTube videos). In textual content without explicit titles, the first words became the label. In other cases, a title that can easily identify the site was given to the node in this data structure.

⁴²⁰ Mathieu Bastian et al., “Gephi: An Open Source Software for Exploring and Manipulating Networks,” *Proceedings of the International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media* 3, no. 1 (2009): 361–62, <https://doi.org/10.1609/icwsm.v3i1.13937>.

⁴²¹ More details can be read on Cytoscape's main website: https://cytoscape.org/what_is_cytoscape.html (last accessed: 2025. 01. 04.)

- Owner (when applicable) – this is the field to note if a narrative entity can be identified as the owner of the specific platform containing the narrative element (e.g., the administrator of the website, the owner of a YouTube channel, the owner of a photograph, etc.).
- Affiliation (when applicable) – this field states who the narrative entity with which this specific narrative element (site) can be affiliated is. This can be the same as the site owner or even someone who “hijacked” the site for the duration of this narrative unit (e.g., the YouTube channel owner is a certain character; however, another character hacks into the channel and uploads a video).
- Type – the (loosely defined) form of the narrative element or site (e.g., webpage, post, sound, e-mail, event, puzzle, etc.).
- Platform – the vehicle of the narrative information (e.g., internet, television, e-mail, real life, etc.).
- Start_time – the date when the site became an integral part of the network. This field does not necessarily describe when the narrative element was created but when it first connected to the rest of the network.

Parallel to creating the alternate reality game’s node table, the paths had to be identified and logged in a separate data table. These paths were always directional edges in the network. However, data structure separated three kinds of connections:

- Embedding – a site was considered to be embedded into another site if the source site's vehicle contained the target site's vehicle (and/or its entire content) (e.g., a text document can be downloaded from a webpage) or the source site has a direct hyperlink to the target site embedded in its content.
- Referring – a site was considered to refer to another site if the content of the source node epistemologically referenced the content (or partial content) of the target (e.g., the text of a webpage mentions the existence of a video file but it does not have a direct link to it).
- Serial – a path was considered to be a serial connection between two nodes if the source node (and/or its content) was in some way its serial predecessor of the target node (and/or its content) (e.g., the type of the path between two subsequent blog posts or emails is serial).



Figure 8: examples for node tables and the actual network visualized. From left to right: EMH Node Table, The Beast Network Tables, The Beast Network Visualization.

The data structure of the investigation, so the first step of the research process in its first experimental form, is a framework of heuristic choices. During the design of this descriptive system, the primary consideration was to define the sites' and their contents' narratological properties to answer questions such as who/what is narrating, who/what is narrated; who/what is focalizing, who/what is focalized; what kind of interpretational attitude does the site presuppose; with what kind of medial code does the site relay its information; and what can we assess about the dynamics of the narrative network? This data structure helps the researchers conduct further examinations and experiments on previously explored instances of transmedia storytelling.

The different types of paths can also provide the researchers with novel information about how the narrative data is structured. Investigating the connective tissue between certain story beats tells a lot, for example, about the various interactional capabilities of the storytelling network: it generates an entirely different medial dynamic if a site promotes the hermeneutical interrogation of its text than in those cases when a sequence of videos are "laid out" for the VUPs in sequential order in the form of a pre-existing playlist.

Following this academic excavation process, the map of *The Beast* proved to be a system of

- 618 sites:
 - 590 of them can be considered canonically part of the ARG.
 - 28 of them were discovered as sites by fan contributors.
- 2063 paths:
 - 1988 can be considered a canonical passage of meaning-making.
 - 75 are the paths to and from the sites by fan contributors.

It should be stated, however, that the completeness of this excavated network or this cartographic outline of the ARG cannot be seen as the perfect representation of the whole storytelling system. This sense of imperfection is due to the ephemeral nature of this form of narrative. Still, even if one looks into other structures (or genres) of transmedial stories, there will always be some uncertainties regarding their sites and paths.

Reconstructing the storytelling structures of *The Beast*, its sites and paths, its contents, and various narratological dynamics is an overwhelming endeavor. As mentioned above, creating a full and perfect model or outline for a transmedia narrative is rarely feasible because of these systems' ephemerality. This nature of ephemerality originates from different aspects of the storytelling form under investigation. Some of the sites of these narratives, especially when talking about ARGs, introduce live events as parts of the storyworld, thus creating real-life sites where VUPs can be immersed to varying degrees. Examples could be scavenger/treasure hunts, geocaching events, site-specific performances, and even rallies for diegetic, fictional causes.⁴²² These real-life and synchronous events pose a challenge even to document, let alone reconstruct from archived information.

Utilizing the Internet as the primary source for narrative information has become increasingly common in transmedia storytelling. However, the archiving of the World Wide Web and the ability to access content within this dynamic and often fluctuating landscape present significant challenges for transmedia researchers. Scholars who may lack either the necessary IT skills or the methodological training to conduct thorough narratological analyses must tackle these two distinct issues to effectively engage with the evolving nature of digital narratives.

Also, there is always narrative information to account for (with varying importance) that will stay invisible to the academic gaze: private and unpublished e-mails with diegetic characters, direct messages, or experiences of in-person happenings are just a few examples that show that there will always be this “dark matter” and “dark energy” when the researcher tries to map out and analyze an entire transmedia storytelling system. However, just like in cosmology, I argue that the “narratological bodies” that cannot be “detected” directly can always be inferred from the information

⁴²² Activism and participating in activities like rallies and demonstrations are surprisingly frequent elements of ARG networks. A great example – apart from *The Beast* itself – would be the ARG SEED. In more detail: Jagoda et al., “From Alternate to Alternative Reality: Games as Cultural Probes.”

provided by the sites “around it”. Therefore, the most important relationships and elements cannot be hidden from analysis.

4.4.1 Transmedial Paratextuality

Another challenge during transmedia analysis (and not just when applying a network-conscious approach) is defining the contours or edges of the narrative system. In more straightforward cases, unambiguous markings and clear paths around the sites are always available. For example, in the case of *Project Moken*,⁴²³ the transmedia documentary retelling of the sea nomad culture of the Moken is done through sites and experiences directly tied to the central webpage of the work. In more complex cases, however, such as ARGs, the researcher needs to demarcate the subject of their research decisively, and sometimes, they would also need to use other interpretative strategies to identify the borders of a narrative: the key principle of this form of storytelling is the TINAG doctrine, or the This is Not a Game principle – this tells us that there should not be any explicit signs of fictionality, however, the storyworld (its mythos, topos and ethos) should be recognized so the VUP will not stray too far from the intended sites.

In the case of *The Beast*, the terminology used by the sites and the characters and locations they referred to was always consistent: the Salla or Chan family names, or references to the Bangalore World University, were always proven to be definitive trail markers for the VUPs to follow. EMH was an ARG that heavily relied on YouTube and Twitter in its active phase. Here, the accounts and the official channels were always considered to be “seals of approval” by the community, and any new sites introduced by unknown channels had to be “approved” by these central entities in the forms of referencing or other medial and hermeneutical modes (by paths directed from approved sources towards channels and sites not yet approved).

On the other hand, the borders of a transmedia network can also be defined and identified by analyzing the paratexts of the story. Paratextuality, as a term, as Genette defined it in the 1980s,⁴²⁴ was primarily applied to literary works. According to him, it is a type of transtextual phenomenon that connects a text to other texts and that grounds the text in a material, historical, sociological, interpretational context that provides “the text with a (variable) setting and sometimes a commentary, official or not which even the purists among readers, those least inclined to external erudition, cannot always disregard as easily as they would like and as they claim to do.”⁴²⁵ To rephrase it bluntly, paratexts are everything that surrounds the text: for example, the author’s name, the cover page, the size of the book, the preface, the table of contents, and so on.

Paratextuality is a liminal phenomenon: these are always transitional artifacts, vestibules,⁴²⁶ or airlocks between the world of fictionality and the outside world. These devices communicate with the readers even before diving into the work. Paratexts, as

⁴²³ Karlsen, “Transmedia Documentary,” 27–32.

⁴²⁴ Gérard Genette, *Paratexts: Thresholds of Interpretation* (Cambridge University Press, 1997), <https://doi.org/10.1017/cbo9780511549373>.

⁴²⁵ Gérard Genette, *Palimpsests: Literature in the Second Degree*, Stages, v. 8 (University of Nebraska Press, 1997), 3.

⁴²⁶ Genette, *Paratexts*, 2.

Genette argues, can be considered both external (as, for example, the cover is not explicitly part of a novel's plot) and internal (as, for example, the table of contents of a novel is already feeding information about the storyworld for the reader) to the work.

Paratextual artifacts are primarily functional and intentional:⁴²⁷ table of contents helps the reader navigate in a book, the cover protects the pages, and they also serve as a promotional surface for publishers, footnotes provide additional information for the thorough recipient, prefaces give space for the author to help contextualize their work, and typographical choices can also have various functions from increasing brand recognizability to enhancing readability.

However, these transitive tools of a literary work, as Genette argues, are always subordinate to the so-called main text. "The paratexts is only an assistant, only an accessory of the text", he explains, and "if the text without its paratext is sometimes like an elephant without a mahout, a power disabled, the paratexts without its text is a mahout without an elephant, a silly show."⁴²⁸

According to Genette, the properties of these devices are governed by their five dimensions or five basic questions that allude to linear communication models:⁴²⁹ spatiality, temporality, substantiality, pragmatics, and functions. Regarding the paratext's spatiality, one can identify peritexts and epitexts, or elements located exactly as the text and elsewhere. Interrogating temporality describes the paratexts' timing in relation to the original text – these can be created prior to, at the same time as, or later than the original text. Substantiality considers the actual form and modality of the device. Questions of pragmatics identify the communicational situation of the paratext: who is the sender, who is the addressee, what is the sender's degree of authority, and grasps the illocutionary force of the paratext (for example, giving the reader some orientation on how to read – "This is a novel", or informing the recipient about the position of the work in a series of items – "First volume").⁴³⁰ Finally, the fifth dimension presents the function of the paratextual device; contrary to the pragmatics, it identifies not the communicational situation but the actual utility or purpose of the specific element (for example, a preface presents the literary work, and a novel's title can connote its style or even its genre).

Video game scholar Jan Švelch argues that Genette's concept of paratextuality transcends the realm of literary works, and these phenomena are rather cultural than literary, and how it is manifested is also culture-specific.⁴³¹ He also points out an emerging scholarly interest in paratextuality in a wider range of cultural products – digital texts, ebooks, film, and television all have their paratextual elements to account for. It is beyond the scope of this dissertation to conduct an extensive survey of paratextual research. However, transmedia narratives are just as relevant

⁴²⁷ Genette, *Paratexts*, 6–9.

⁴²⁸ Genette, *Paratexts*, 410.

⁴²⁹ Genette's text was thoroughly investigated by Jaroslav Švelch. In his work there are important observations about reframing paratextuality in the context of video game studies. For more: Jan Švelch, "Paratexts to Non-Linear Media Texts: Paratextuality in Video Game Culture" (Univerzita Karlova v Praze, 2017).

⁴³⁰ Genette, *Paratexts*, 9–11.

⁴³¹ Švelch, "Paratexts to Non-Linear Media Texts: Paratextuality in Video Game Culture," 64–70.

products of our culture as movies and video games. Thus, it is sensible to identify the paratexts of these works, too.⁴³²

Of course, there are key differences between Švelch's and Genette's frameworks. He redefines paratextuality as a secondary phenomenon, complementing the main text in his work. Instead, he argues that "it is an inseparable facet of textuality" while acknowledging that certain cultural contexts exist where paratexts "indeed play a secondary role to the main text." Here, I would add that Švelch's wording is not fortunate – paratextuality is not just an inseparable facet of *textuality* but also *mediality*. I would even go as far as coining the term *paramediality* to refer to these phenomena.

Švelch also finds that Genette (understandably) inductively describes paratextual phenomena with terms and concepts that inherently resonate with codex books the best. The five dimensions of Genette, for Švelch, feel underdeveloped in some cases, and it is also less capable of grasping more complex media technologies and distribution channels.⁴³³ Moreover, the functional dimension consists of questions related to book-publishing practices. Švelch suggests five alternative basic functions of paratextuality: referential, instructional, interfacial, corrective, and revelatory. Afterward, he gives the same treatment to the other dimensions as well: Švelch expands on the categories of authorship for video games, identifies four categories of substantiality to accommodate multimodality (semiotic, sensorial, technical/material, and factual/cultural), and he combines two dimensions into a spatiotemporal one treating these as continuums where paratextual elements can be located before or after the game's launch and concerning the game's surface.⁴³⁴

Acknowledging the causes of Švelch's efforts to establish a new framework to study paratextuality, this research takes on his methodological system, as in his works, he argued that there is a necessity to move away from the hegemony of the literary text and the practices of book publishing, while also recognizing the socio-cultural aspects of paratextuality, broadening the range and reach of applicability. As video games benefit from this new approach, transmedia does as well.

4.4.2 The (Non-)Existence of Paratextuality in Alternate Reality Games

Let us circle back to the core topic of this chapter: visualizing transmedia storytelling networks requires overcoming many challenges, one of which is defining the borders of a subject. In other words, how can we tell which elements are part of the narrative and which are external to it? This is where analyzing paratextuality can orient the academic gaze.

In transmedial works, one, on the one hand, encounters monomedial paratextual elements. For example, if the system involves books, comics, and movies, then the paratexts of these specific mediums can be accounted for. On the other hand, however, there are paratexts specific to a transmedia network, such as promotional

⁴³² Švelch, "Paratexts to Non-Linear Media Texts: Paratextuality in Video Game Culture," 56–59.

⁴³³ Švelch, "Paratexts to Non-Linear Media Texts: Paratextuality in Video Game Culture," 33.

⁴³⁴ Švelch, "Paratexts to Non-Linear Media Texts: Paratextuality in Video Game Culture," 73–84.

materials,⁴³⁵ which media can widely vary (for example, these can be in the form of YouTube videos, newsletters, e-mails, flyers, or movie posters), merchandise (as Marsha Kinder famously argues),⁴³⁶ fan contents,⁴³⁷ social media platforms which provide opportunities to engage with the fellow VUPs,⁴³⁸ museum exhibits,⁴³⁹ reviews, etc.

While fulfilling their textual (or medial) functions as Genette or, more like Švelch describes, these paratextual entities also help the VUP and the researcher orient themselves in the transmedial network. Besides providing another layer of interpretation for the work, these elements also present information regarding the system: an online discussion thread can clarify the storytelling processes of a transmedia work by the community of the recipients; merchandise can strengthen the iconography of a storyworld; promotional materials can help streamline the navigation of the VUP in the system.

However, identifying or discussing paratextuality in ARGs can prove problematic academically. This transmedia storytelling genre, as previously stated, builds upon the denial of its fictionality (“This is not a game” principle). Thus, the creators must frame everything connected to the network as diegetic but non-fictional. This would mean that there are little to no paratextual phenomena that can be observed in these works. There are no clear indications of advertisement or actual promotion in promotional materials. In social media discussions, characters from the storyworld can also be present and participate in the conversation. Fan content can also be directly integrated into the storytelling system. So, with these gestures, the paratextual quality of these elements arguably ceases to exist.

It is worth noting that two main types of paratextual devices can still be used as compasses to orient oneself as a VUP or researcher: trail markers and secondary “literature”. The latter refers to texts, discussions, videos, and other publications that are created about the specific ARG. These include academic articles, explainer videos, or even community-made wiki databases. These paratextual elements have a huge impact on interpreting the storyworld, and they also provide information to help readers grasp the vast storytelling network. These secondary works are created alongside or after an ARG is concluded, and they primarily help those who can be considered external to the work.

⁴³⁵ Raúl Rodríguez Ferrándiz, “A Genettian Approach to Transmedia (Para)Textuality,” in *The Routledge Companion to Transmedia Studies*, ed. Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato (Routledge, 2018), 431–32, <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351054904>.

⁴³⁶ Matt Hills, “Transmedia Paratexts: Informational, Commercial, Diegetic, and Auratic Circulation,” in *The Routledge Companion to Transmedia Studies*, ed. Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato (Routledge, 2018), 293–95, <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351054904>.

⁴³⁷ Hills, “Transmedia Paratexts,” 290.

⁴³⁸ André Jansson and Karin Fast, “Transmedia Identities: From Fan Cultures to Liquid Lives,” in *The Routledge Companion to Transmedia Studies*, ed. Matthew Freeman and Renira Rampazzo Gambarato (Routledge, 2018), <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351054904>.

⁴³⁹ Hills, “Transmedia Paratexts,” 292–93.

Ruppel also argues for identifying paratextual phenomena in transmedia narratives. According to his terminology,

paratextual elements function as external migratory cues,⁴⁴⁰ cues that exist outside of the internal fiction of two or more sites and ensure superficial connection between them. Here, connectivity is achieved broadly through brand markers, logos and other extra-fictional means of marking an artifact uniquely. These textual markers, importantly, do not possess any causal relationship with the actions, events and characters in the fiction itself.⁴⁴¹

However, these elements are not the only ones that can be regarded as paratexts while also modulating the flow of the narrative for the VUPs. I also argue that in certain forms of transmedia storytelling, such as ARGs, it is difficult to discern which components are “extra-fictional” and “intra-fictional.” What is important is that these medial (again, departing from the term “textual”) markers are not directly involved with actions, events, or characters.⁴⁴²

Trail markers, on the other hand, are in-game cues or elements that have minor storytelling purposes; however, these paratextual elements guide the VUPs in the convoluted network of the ARG and also confirm that they are still on the right track and encountering the storyworld. Regarding their form, they are expected to blend the real world with the in-game universe to maintain immersion but still serve the abovementioned functions. Great examples of trail markers are highly recognizable iconographic elements of the storyworld (such as logos and signs) or names and representations of characters and places. In the case of a specific ARG of ELTE University in Budapest, after the players were invited to a special real-world event by a cryptic message, the attendees could make sure that they were in the right place by encountering the iconographically unambiguous characters who were wearing red scarves and white robes. However, the same principle, of course, can also be adapted to digital platforms.

Rabbit holes (or trailheads, entry points) of an ARG can be considered a special trail marker. As briefly explained in the first few chapters of this dissertation, these elements of the storytelling system are sites that are accessible without prior knowledge of the storyworld, and they are also designed in a way that piques the interest of any potential VUP. They often pose as a call to action: an invitation, a plea for help, or a description of a dangerous situation that needs intervention.⁴⁴³ Examples can range

⁴⁴⁰ In Ruppel's discourse, *migratory cues* are explicit signals directing users from one platform to another within a transmedia narrative, marking the paths they should follow to understand the story unfolding. For more details, please see the subsequent chapters.

⁴⁴¹ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 71–72.

⁴⁴² Defining paratextuality in transmedia systems like this can also be contested, as in some cases, the presence of an „extra-fictional” element or the way it is presented can be directly involved with the narrative. If, for example, the EMH logo is found on an abandoned building, it might also carry important meaning from a storytelling perspective, besides behaving as a trail marker.

⁴⁴³ Szulborski, *This Is Not a Game*, 47–48.

from URLs or e-mail addresses shown in TV shows briefly⁴⁴⁴ to reward the observant VUPs to flyers and items handed out in public with peculiar information to look up.⁴⁴⁵

4.4.3 Vulnerabilities of the ARG Network

The immersive strength of ARGs comes from the TINAG principle, the common design direction building on not declaring the narrative's fictionality. However, the VUPs implicitly learn the system's pathways to immerse themselves in the storyworld. This seamless transition through the outer edges of the magic circle creates a unique experience for the recipients of an ARG or any transmedia narrative that follows a similar design. Yet, the ease with which people can connect through their actions, investigations, or fan-like contributions makes it vulnerable to disrupt, derail, or alter the intended experience and plans of an author or authorial group. VUPs are often invited to influence the storyworld through roleplay or other acts, encouraged to "hack" the network, to look behind the veils, inspect source codes and data mine digital sites, and look for clues where no one would think there is one. VUPs are expected to interact with and participate in the story to some extent. However, it must be noted that although ARGs and most transmedia narratives are more democratized modes of storytelling, there are the so-called puppet masters who bring to life, coordinate, and (if needed) regularly adjust the system to accommodate the interactions.⁴⁴⁶

The act of these transgressions between creator and non-creator (it is unclear whether the transgressor is a VUP of the narrative), which tries to position external creations as a "canonical" part of the storytelling system, is called gamejacking.⁴⁴⁷ It is a practice that is generally frowned upon by the VUPs' community (and oftentimes even the puppet masters themselves)⁴⁴⁸ as it drives the narrative away from the creators' intentions, possibly lowering the quality of the storytelling experience. These actions can be more frequently observed in the cases of grassroots ARGs,⁴⁴⁹ narratives created by small teams or individuals who operate on smaller budgets, thus using tools and platforms that are easier to access and copy. These storyworlds heavily rely on social media platforms such as X (previously known as Twitter), Facebook,

⁴⁴⁴ Elizabeth Bonsignore et al., "Alternate Reality Games as Platforms for Practicing 21st-Century Literacies," *International Journal of Learning and Media*, 2013, 9.

⁴⁴⁵ Bonsignore et al., "Alternate Reality Games as Platforms for Practicing 21st-Century Literacies," 10.

⁴⁴⁶ Martin, *Alternate Reality Games White Paper*, 9; Bonsignore et al., "Alternate Reality Games as Platforms for Practicing 21st-Century Literacies," 2; Burcu S. Bakioğlu, "Alternate Reality Games," in *The International Encyclopedia of Digital Communication and Society*, ed. Robin Mansell and Peng Hwa Ang (John Wiley & Sons, Inc., 2015), 1–5, <http://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/9781118767771.wbiedcs052/full>.

⁴⁴⁷ Combining the words "game" and "hijacking." It might be interesting to compare gamejacking to fan practices or even epigones of classical literature in future studies. At its essence, similar practices are as old as fiction or authorial authority.

⁴⁴⁸ In some cases, there are in-universe clarifications or call-outs for gamejacking, such as in: <https://x.com/SEVENTRIALS/status/13320966935412736>. Further examples for commentary on this issue: Puzzling Matters, "The Sun Vanished And Gamejacking: The Genius Of @LostSunNews," *Puzzling Matters* (blog), July 18, 2018, <https://puzzlingmatters.wordpress.com/2018/07/18/the-sun-vanished-and-gamejacking-the-genius-of-lostsunnews/fake-a-dream>, "Seeking Clarity on Gamejacking," Reddit Post, *R/ARG*, October 23, 2023, www.reddit.com/r/ARG/comments/17epe4g/seeking_clarity_on_gamejacking/.

⁴⁴⁹ Martin, *Alternate Reality Games White Paper*, 15–18.

YouTube, and other free services such as Gmail. But there are also examples in larger, higher-budget systems like *I Love Bees* and *The Beast*.

The problem, as the community seemingly has a consensus, does not come from contributing with one's original (fan) work to the storyworld but posing without clarification as a site created by the puppet masters. In the case of EMH, the main antagonist, for example, had his voice stylized using uppercase letters in their messages and tweets. Gamejackers created accounts with usernames similar to those of the antagonist (@SEVENTRIALS) and started to imitate this character's voice. In *Ben Drowned*, an ARG about a *Legend of Zelda: Majora's Mask* NES cartridge which is haunted by a malicious spirit,⁴⁵⁰ it was reported by the community that a whole new storyline was created by a gamejacker,⁴⁵¹ using the same design approach as Jadusable (the puppet master of the original creation) just five years after *Ben Drowned* ended. If this spinoff had been created during the active phase of the ARG, it would have received more backlash from the VUP community.

These examples point out that the accessibility and the immersive nature of ARGs come with the price of vulnerability to gamejacking. Although these transgressive acts have the potential to divert the attention of the recipients and lead them on a storyline that the creators did not intend, there is rarely any case where the community (or the characters, the storyworld, or puppet masters themselves) would not police these attempts and denounce these, drawing a clear border around the vast and blurry outlines of the network of a transmedia creation.

4.5 DYNAMICS OF TRANSMEDIA NETWORKS

In his work, Marc Ruppel highlights and focuses on two main approaches to analyzing transmedia storytelling systems: commodity-based and operation-based. For the former, he draws attention to Marsha Kinder's discourse on transmediality, a form of interdisciplinary study that, besides semiotic cues, does not neglect the storytelling systems' elements' "economic *properties*" either. As another theorist quoted by Ruppel explains, these serial forms of production are linked "through a network of cross-promotion," and they are "rarely pure when we buy a newspaper, watch a television programme, go on a Web site or pick up a magazine, advertisers have projected themselves into the content."⁴⁵² Theoreticians see all elements of these interconnected products of this approach as serving a single megatext⁴⁵³ to enhance the effects of its marketing and elevate this superproduct's success. This approach's focus, however, is far from the points of this and even Ruppel's dissertation, according to him

⁴⁵⁰ More on this ARG: John Sanders, "'You Shouldn't Have Done That': 'Ben Drowned' and the Uncanny Horror of the Haunted Cartridge," *Gamevironments*, no. 9 (2018): 135–69.

⁴⁵¹ https://jadusable.withinhubris.com/Jadusable_Wiki:News_Archive (last accessed: 2025.01.12.)

⁴⁵² David Marshall, "The New Intertextual Commodity," in *The New Media Book*, Reprint, ed. Dan Harries (British Film Institute, 2004), 70–71; as Ruppel quoted his thoughts in: Ruppel, "Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries," 21.

⁴⁵³ Jennifer M. Proffitt et al., "Plugging Back Into *The Matrix*: The Intertextual Flow of Corporate Media Commodities," *Journal of Communication Inquiry* 31, no. 3 (2007): 247, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0196859907300955>.

*the language of transmedia research depends on these types of operations, as they allow us to see the ways that by reading individual iterations of meaning we can understand the whole of the trans-media expression.*⁴⁵⁴

This observation states that transmedia systems are interconnected webs of narrative information tied together by certain movements between their sites. Understanding this is essential to developing a deeper understanding and a narratological toolset for analysis.

Regarding the operation-based approach, Ruppel draws on Henry Jenkins' seven principles of transmedia storytelling.⁴⁵⁵ These practices and analytical directions frame the questions of transmedia narratives from a media-theoretical and cultural perspective. To be more specific, rather than focusing on the interpretation of the sites in relation to their position in the system, Jenkins is more concerned with the "dynamics of their circulation, the literacies they reflect and the cultural understandings they require."⁴⁵⁶

While Ruppel has an in-depth understanding of the commodity-based approach, I argue that he follows Jenkins' flow of thought, focusing on the movements and traversal methods in transmedia storytelling networks. In his work, he proposes

*the basis of a methodology for analyzing transmedia networks based on the recognition of what I call migratory cues, external (i.e. brand markers) and internal (i.e. located through story) linking mechanisms present in many transmedia projects that allow for the exchange of narrative information from site-to-site.*⁴⁵⁷

Migratory cues refer to signals and prompts for the VUPs of a transmedia system, which evokes an active cognitive act of "shifting" narrative content from one site and "blending it with the content of another."⁴⁵⁸ This postulates an activity that requires participation and creates a dynamic that prompts the audience to form a mental image of a network. These cues are also smaller internal elements of a site – for example, a website can contain multiple migratory cues in the form of pictures or textual references. They can, thus, take the form of

*virtually anything [...] from objects to characters to events to even a word written in a seemingly unremarkable passage of a novel.*⁴⁵⁹

⁴⁵⁴ Ruppel, "Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries," 26.

⁴⁵⁵ Henry Jenkins, "The Revenge of the Origami Unicorn: Seven Principles of Transmedia Storytelling (Well, Two Actually. Five More on Friday) — Pop Junctions," Henry Jenkins, December 12, 2009, http://henryjenkins.org/blog/2009/12/the_revenge_of_the_origami_uni.html; Henry Jenkins, "Revenge of the Origami Unicorn: The Remaining Four Principles of Transmedia Storytelling — Pop Junctions," Henry Jenkins, December 12, 2009, http://henryjenkins.org/blog/2009/12/revenge_of_the_origami_unicorn.html.

⁴⁵⁶ Ruppel, "Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries," 26.

⁴⁵⁷ Ruppel, "Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries," 47.

⁴⁵⁸ Ruppel, "Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries," 62.

⁴⁵⁹ Ruppel, "Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries," 62.

These cues always represent the potential for interpretative movement of the VUPs within the transmedia narrative between two or more sites. Ruppel's text considers them the primary means of combining, expanding, and recontextualizing narrative information by the recipients.⁴⁶⁰ Recognizing that these patterns are waiting to be activated by the community of the VUPs, it must be noted that they are not always guaranteed to fulfill their intended tasks. Ruppel also argues that noticing these cues inside a site is not sufficient enough to consider the migratory cues functional, as it is required that after this initial recognition of the prompt, the VUP must actively blend the information from the source site⁴⁶¹ with the target site – so the migratory cue's potential will remain to be only a potential until the cognitive work is done on these sites and “these actions are confirmed through the content of the site (or sites) the cue is directing to [...].”⁴⁶²

This process of gathering narrative information from a source site and deploying this knowledge in the target site, contrasting or contesting it, is called *projection*.⁴⁶³ After a migratory cue is successfully located, projected, and followed, Ruppel argues, “it creates a potential rupture in the event plane of the story of both the source and the target sites.”⁴⁶⁴ For example, in EMH, there were instances when one of the protagonists, Evan, was behaving strangely (e.g., in the video *Ryan & the SEVENTRIALSOFHABIT*,⁴⁶⁵ he was talking to a chair with a knife in his hand). However, this site's narrative was ultimately disrupted only two years later when a site (the video *MOVING IN*⁴⁶⁶) was published on YouTube, confirming his malicious possession by the main antagonist of the storyworld, Habit.

Following Ruppel's arguments, migratory cues can be uni-directed (or un-reciprocated) or bi-directed (or reciprocated) regarding their directionality property.⁴⁶⁷ The former are more frequent than the latter: these are elements in a site that, if activated by the VUP, won't find another cue leading back to the site that guided them to this subsequent one. If the community, for example, successfully solves a puzzle and finds out the link to a hidden webpage through a peculiar phone call, this website might not have any reference to this initial call. However, there are other cases where this bi-directional dynamic can be observed. During *The Beast*, there was a special event at MIT University on 2001.04.30, where the students could discuss with some members of the movie's crew. After they wrapped up, they also distributed the business card of Jeanine Salla among the audience, which contained a puzzle that pointed toward an online folder that contained fictional case study documents of Jeanine's AI patients. One of these documents, Loki's case study, had references to

⁴⁶⁰ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 63.

⁴⁶¹ “The term source used here refers to the site from which the migratory cue was first located and processed as such.” Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 66.

⁴⁶² Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 65.

⁴⁶³ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 66.

⁴⁶⁴ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 68.

⁴⁶⁵ https://youtu.be/SR4-aYKe33I?si=UWw_VCkiw0lHTUOp (last accessed: 2025. 01. 14.)

⁴⁶⁶ https://youtu.be/GmLZ_Kqq9bs?si=Z0XTHB01hJT5lyLa (last accessed: 2025. 01. 14.)

⁴⁶⁷ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 70.

a still unknown website (Catskill Seaview Clinic), which also contained mentions of Loki, thus reciprocating the migratory cue of the online directory.⁴⁶⁸

There are cases where certain sites do not contain further migratory cues. These are considered *termination points* by Ruppel, which represent the end of a particular pathway.⁴⁶⁹ He also notes that directionality is affected by the temporality of a transmedia network. As was emphasized in the previous chapters, transmedia narratives are dynamic structures that also develop through time: sites become connected, new sites emerge, and parts of the system become isolated. Ruppel also acknowledges these changes, mentioning that migratory cues

*can also be determined by the transmedia network's distribution time i.e. the external mechanism which divides a transmedia narrative into temporally distinct but not usually chronological units through the staggered availability of sites ready for consumption. A cue found in the initial sites completed by transmedia creators and producers and distributed by publishers for audience consumption, for example, may not contain cues that explicitly connect other sites. Consequently, a cue's potential connectivity grows in proportion to the number of sites available at the time of its site's composition.*⁴⁷⁰

4.5.1 Internal Migratory Cues: Typology

From another point of view, apart from the directionality of the cues, Ruppel argues that there are four different types of internal migratory cues, or – to reiterate – signs that are “signaled, developed and completed within the logic and continuity of the fictional storyworld itself.” Of course, the demarcation would not be this clear in most cases, as paratextuality in transmedia narratives (external migratory cues – as Ruppel explains) can produce meaning hand in hand with intratextual devices. Another key difference between external and internal migratory cues in Ruppel’s terminology is that while external cues reveal themselves by their mechanics (a logo is intentionally printed on the door of an on-site in-universe event), internal cues present themselves gradually, they are becoming more and more apparent as the VUP familiarize themselves within the confines of the narrative network – even so as they should be considered “*story elements first and connective elements second.*”⁴⁷¹

The first type of these internal migratory cues is the intersectional cues. These are points internal to a site where the narrative, the world, or the site itself bifurcates and overlaps with another site, thus establishing this connection between them. Ruppel warns us, however, that these are not to be confused with translational or adaptational endeavors, such as novelizations, because they should only be regarded as “momentary reflective collusion between two sites in a transmedia network.”⁴⁷² Whether they are locations, objects, or other story elements, “in combination with discourse elements such as shot compositions from a film being repeated in a

⁴⁶⁸ For a more detailed description of this sequence, see: <https://web.archive.org/web/20010608224359/http://www.cloudmakers.org/guide/index2.shtml> (last accessed: 2025. 01. 14.)

⁴⁶⁹ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 71.

⁴⁷⁰ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 71.

⁴⁷¹ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 87–88.

⁴⁷² Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 89.

graphic novel,” they require the recipient to possess the deepest knowledge of the storyworld and the narrative system from their perspective to identify.⁴⁷³ The VUP must know (at least) both of the site's discursive compositions. Ruppel's example is an intersectional cue that takes the form of a shot composition in one of the Star Wars movies (*Revenge of the Sith*), which is reflected in a subsequently released comic book (*Hidden Enemy*⁴⁷⁴).⁴⁷⁵ This extraction of narrative information enhances the understanding of a specific character's actions (Quinlan Vos), thereby realizing the interpretive broadening potential of the cue. A similar example could be seen in the EMH transmedia system (that convolutedly enough reaches out to storyworlds external to EMH – such as *TribeTwelve* and *MLAndersen0* – who were all part of the Slenderman “extended universe” or webring at the peak of its popularity): in the video *Three's company*, one of the protagonists, Vinnie, lures Shaun Andersen into a trap under the influence of the supernatural antagonist. Shaun, as a character, and the house, as the location, become key intersectional cues, as his figure ties this site to MLAndersen0's video “HELLO,” and subsequently, the house as a location ties the site to TribeTwelve's video “Severance,”⁴⁷⁶ expanding and detailing the storyworld of EMH.

Ruppel defines a second type of internal migratory cue as “direct internal cues.” Which “function through the deployment of website URLs, phone numbers, book titles and other related means of directly pointing toward one medium in another.”⁴⁷⁷ These important processes are essential to transmedial storytelling as direct internal cues are devices that embed or incorporate different mediums (and their material function⁴⁷⁸) into each other: phone numbers in websites (see the Primattech Paper Company example in NBC's *Heroes*⁴⁷⁹), video games into YouTube videos (see the example of *CatGhost* which enhances the storyworld's videos' interpretation through companion video games that are embedded in the YouTube descriptions as links⁴⁸⁰), or a real-life location into a video (as the example of TheGreenFeathers demonstrated in EMH). According to Ruppel's observation, sites with this kind of cue often function as rabbit holes for the recipients.

Thirdly, intermedial clues, or the kind of Internal migratory cues that transcode one site's mediality into another. Unlike the direct internal cues, these devices require more effort from the VUP, as they are not as seamless in their movement (the target

⁴⁷³ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 90–91.

⁴⁷⁴ John Ostrander, *Hidden Enemy Part 1 of 3*, with Jan Duursema, Republic 81 (Dark Horse, 2006).

⁴⁷⁵ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 91–95.

⁴⁷⁶ <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YGbvzdKBIPQ> (last accessed: 2025. 01. 25.)

⁴⁷⁷ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 98.

⁴⁷⁸ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 98.

⁴⁷⁹ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 103–4.

⁴⁸⁰ The games and the website that contained them are now unavailable. However, Reddit user AestheticGamer thankfully archived all of these in Google Drive. Next, it should be uploaded to the Internet Archive for safer storage. Their Reddit post can be accessed here with additional information on the games and the series: https://www.reddit.com/r/creepygaming/comments/1876v2l/heres_an_archive_of_all_the_old_cat_ghost_games/ (last accessed: 2025. 01. 25.). Another source of information can be the Wiki database of the series that can be accessed here: https://catghost.fandom.com/wiki/CatGhost_Wiki (last accessed: 2025. 01. 25.)

site cannot be reached by a single click or a phone call, for example); they “present us with no attempts at transposing the signifiers of a particular site.”⁴⁸¹ In other words, intermedial clues are instances of a site inside another. However, they are not immediately linked together in any way. In the TV series *Lost*, the show’s fans later discovered a fictional book, known as the “Bad Twin,” in the real world. However, this book was not referenced by the site (in the episode where it appears⁴⁸²) with a link to an e-book; instead, it was visually presented in its entirety in its physical book form.

Ruppel recognizes that this medial (or literary) mechanic is not without precedent: Werner Wolf describes a similar process with the terms *overt* and *covert intermediality* in his work.⁴⁸³ This device presents either in a distinct or indistinguishable form the integration of a source medium’s signifiers in the target medium. In these cases where such hybridization happens, one would often find a new genre or a new form of art (as it happened with, according to Wolf, opera – drama and music – or sound film – visual elements, text, and music).⁴⁸⁴ However, it must be noted that Wolf’s terminology and theory revolve around semiotic analysis rather than narratology: identifying gestures of overt and covert intermediality would only help better understand how individual sites function. Ruppel’s terminology and analytical concept of intermedial cues provide another tool for narratological analysis in transmedia storytelling systems.

Finally, a fourth connection between two sites can also be described as causal-sequential. Ruppel here even avoids describing this mechanic as a migratory cue. However, this process also needs to be accounted for in transmedia systems, as – he continues to argue – there is a strong meaning-making effect in chronology. In his text, he invokes E.M Forster’s famous example, “The king died and then the queen died,”⁴⁸⁵ on which it is easy to demonstrate the strength of sequentiality – it “gives rise to a sense of a certain causality responsible for” a series of events.⁴⁸⁶ Ruppel also argues that as the VUP receives narrative information in a certain sequentiality, the preceding sites always define or at least influence the subsequent ones.⁴⁸⁷ On the other hand, I would add that the sense of sequentiality also tightens the coherence of the narrative network and gives interpretative support for the recipient in every case to fall back on if any ambiguity or uncertainty arises.

⁴⁸¹ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 107–10.

⁴⁸² Season 2, Episode 13, *The Long Con*.

⁴⁸³ Werner Wolf, “Intermediality Revisited: Reflections on Word and Music Relations in the Context of a General Typology of Intermediality,” in *Word and Music Studies* (Brill, 2002), 23, https://doi.org/10.1163/9789004334069_003.

⁴⁸⁴ Wolf, *The Musicalization of Fiction*, 39–41.

⁴⁸⁵ E. M. Forster, *Aspects of the Novel* (Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1985), 86.

⁴⁸⁶ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 116.

⁴⁸⁷ Emma Kafalenos, “Reading Narrative Causalities: Functions and Functional Polyvalence,” in *Narrative Causalities* (Ohio State University Press, 2006).

To conclude and to reiterate, when Ruppel establishes a framework for his research for transmedia narratives, he identifies four (or three plus one) types of internal (in the sense of being diegetic to the storyworld) cues that induce four different kinds of movements for the recipients in the narrative system. This analytical approach (completed by the external migratory cues) provides a significant base for critics to provide fruitful readings for vast storytelling systems.

4.5.2 A Sidenote on Cue Typology and Classical Narratology

Ruppel's typology regarding the migratory cues (and the group of hermeneutic type paths) of the transmedia network is rooted in a media theoretical approach. However, one should not overlook the fact that there is a direct predecessor to the method of identifying and encoding narrative elements based on their role, significance, and impact on the story. Roland Barthes, in *S/Z*, experimented with a method closely related to Ruppel's attempt, but in a more classical literary context: on the one hand, he introduced an underlying "network" of codes in literary texts while, on the other hand, coined⁴⁸⁸ the differentiation between two kinds of literary texts – the readerly (lisible) and the writerly (scriptible).

Although it is worth noting that transmedia storytelling structures without exception move away from the former (a product to be consumed by the recipient; it is irreversible, "totalizable, and unified into a coherent whole based on the signified."⁴⁸⁹) towards the latter (a work that is "infinitely plural and open to the free play of signifiers and of difference, unconstrained by representative considerations, and transgressive of any desire for decidable, unified, totalized meaning"⁴⁹⁰) this sub-chapter's discussion understandably revolve around Roland Barthes' structures of literary codes.

Intersectional cues, the overlap of broadly defined knowledge structures between sites inside a storyworld, can be broken down into smaller granularity while incorporating Barthes' terminology. First, hermeneutic codes "which sets out 'the various (formal) terms by which an enigma can be distinguished, suggested, formulated, held in suspense, and finally disclosed'"⁴⁹¹ can be closely connected to fragments of a puzzle, a mystery in the transmedia storytelling system.⁴⁹²

Second, semic codes, or the "matter of picking up secondary meanings (semes) carried by words, in their relationship with other segments of the text,"⁴⁹³ can be seen in cases where migratory cues are identified in a more associative manner, where the path between the sites is established through the connotation of their elements.⁴⁹⁴

⁴⁸⁸ Barthes, *S/Z*, 4.

⁴⁸⁹ Barbara Johnson, "The Critical Difference," *Diacritics* 8, no. 2 (1978): 4, <https://doi.org/10.2307/465127>.

⁴⁹⁰ Johnson, "The Critical Difference," 4.

⁴⁹¹ Whitehead, "Roland Barthes's Narratology," 47.

⁴⁹² In *The Beast*, for example, the enigma of what happened between the minor characters of Enrico Basta and Kate Nei at a certain time in the storyworld was resolved in a video posted much later for the VUPs to watch. Tying some of the sites owned by Kate Nei to this video through an intersectional cue that behaves similarly to Barthes' hermeneutic code.

⁴⁹³ Whitehead, "Roland Barthes's Narratology," 47.

⁴⁹⁴ Again, in *The Beast*, a website could only be accessed or discovered if the VUPs explored the connotative field of the word "mother".

Thirdly, cultural codes, which “are references to a science or a body of knowledge,”⁴⁹⁵ can also contribute to the “intersectionality” of a migratory cue, creating or enhancing connections between sites where the fragments interpret and call to each other through their cultural references. Presenting parallels between biblical figures and characters in certain story elements, referencing mythical figures, or even pop cultural icons, are prime examples of how cultural codes can serve as migratory cues in transmedia storytelling.

Finally, and quite undeniably, the proairetic code, the code of actions that provides a “preliminary sense of what is going on, and whither the action is tending,”⁴⁹⁶ is the classical structuralist narratological take on the causal-sequential migratory cue. This may not require further elaboration; it may simply need to be emphasized how closely connected and continuous the theoretical field of narratology is, from Barthes’ approach to a post-classical one.

In a slightly different way, symbolic codes can also be identified in networks of transmedia storytelling. Although Barthes defined this structural element ambiguously,⁴⁹⁷ it is understood⁴⁹⁸ that these components open up discourses around underlying multiplicities, oppositions, and archetypal meanings. I argue that paths between sites unlock these hidden motifs and patterns, allowing the VUPs to explore and re-interpret the narrative by establishing connections between characters, locations, or events. In doing so, one might unveil universal structures, such as power struggles or questions of guilt or innocence. In this case, it is not the individual sites and individual cues that evoke Barthes’ terminology, but instead the constellations of them.

Again, the terminology of *S/Z* cannot and should not be applied to transmedia storytelling networks in a holistic sense. However, it is worth noting that the cognitive or theoretical structures are closely related, emphasizing the transferability of classical narratological knowledge in the interdisciplinary domain of transmediality.

5 READINGS OF TRANSMEDIA NETWORKS

Networks pervade almost every aspect of our contemporary lives. Our ways of gathering information on the world around us have adapted to the structures of the network society. Moreover, structuring information and composing narratives reflect a sense of all-encompassing interconnectedness. Unsurprisingly, the World Wide Web is one of the most complex and prominent structures in our contemporary life, which might have the most significant impact on our society. Understanding this convoluted and vast entity would be impossible without the tools of network science.

⁴⁹⁵ Barthes, *S/Z*, 20.

⁴⁹⁶ Whitehead, “Roland Barthes’s Narratology,” 48.

⁴⁹⁷ Barthes, *S/Z*, 19.

⁴⁹⁸ Whitehead, “Roland Barthes’s Narratology,” 48.

5.1 CONTINENTS OF THE WORLD WIDE WEB

In 2000, Broder et al. created the famous visualization of the Internet,⁴⁹⁹ using web crawlers to capture 200 million pages and 1.5 billion links between them. According to their findings, the World Wide Web exhibits a scale-free structure, as coined by Barabási, meaning that the distribution of nodes with the same (in and out) degrees does not follow the bell curve of the Gaussian distribution, but instead follows the structure of a power law. In layman's terms, instead of having a large number of nodes with an average degree size, many nodes connect to very few others, and there are a small number of nodes with high connectivity.⁵⁰⁰ These networks, of course, come with their strengths and vulnerabilities.

On the one hand, scale-free networks, such as the Internet, demonstrate high resilience against failures and errors: The hubs of these structures guarantee safety in case a considerable number of nodes become compromised – the connection between the segments will not falter. For example, if a non-strategically advanced attack disables a handful of routers connected to the Internet, its functionality will still be secure.⁵⁰¹ Also, the speed with which information can spread through these scale-free networks should be considered an advantage compared to random networks. The hubs provide quick and efficient access to many subsequent nodes.⁵⁰² This connectivity also gives rise to the property of the small-world phenomenon in scale-free networks: nodes in these settings are only a few “jumps” away, much like our contemporary society's social network, where everyone is just a few handshakes away from each other.⁵⁰³

On the other hand, however, targeting hubs with attacks or failing to address hubs would quickly present a cascading error for the entire network. These strategically important points are the supporting beams for, for example, the Internet, electricity networks, or aviation networks.⁵⁰⁴ Moreover, apart from being susceptible to external attacks, scale-free networks are also vulnerable in a sense to internal inequalities: it is one of Barabási's core concepts that in structures like these, it is always observable that the “rich get richer,” or in other words, the more connected hubs will grow further in importance and connectedness, leaving less chance for the smaller nodes to develop and grow. This painfully and fundamentally determines the dynamics of our academic circles if we look at the network of citations: the more connected and well-known authors (and papers) will have a higher chance to increase their metrics. In contrast, the lesser-known nodes in this system have a high chance of going unnoticed by the larger community.⁵⁰⁵

Apart from identifying the World Wide Web as a scale-free network, Broder et al. also presented some well-distinguishable sub-structures of the Internet through their visualization method. They argued that the web has a strongly connected component

⁴⁹⁹ Andrei Broder et al., “Graph Structure in the Web,” *Computer Networks*, no. 33 (2000), [https://doi.org/10.1016/s1389-1286\(00\)00083-9](https://doi.org/10.1016/s1389-1286(00)00083-9).

⁵⁰⁰ Barabási, *Linked*, 70.

⁵⁰¹ Barabási, *Linked*, 118–19.

⁵⁰² Barabási, *Linked*, 134–38.

⁵⁰³ Barabási, *Linked*, 185–88.

⁵⁰⁴ Barabási, *Linked*, 155.

⁵⁰⁵ Barabási, *Linked*, 66, 69, 169.

(SCC) as the structure's core, which can be observed as an intermediary element between the IN and OUT components. The former “consists of pages that can reach the SCC but cannot be reached from it,” while OUT “consists of pages that are accessible from the SCC, but do not link back to it [...]” Finally, a fourth component, the TENDRILS, was also identified as the unit that “contain pages that cannot reach the SCC, and cannot be reached from the SCC.”⁵⁰⁶

This became known as the “bow-tie structure” of the World Wide Web, a form later contested by a 2014 article that revisited this early analysis using the Common Crawl Foundation’s data of over 3.5 billion web pages and 128.7 billion links,⁵⁰⁷ a sample nearly 18 times larger than the one from 2000. Meusel et al. argue that the “bow-tie structure” was largely an artifact created by the immanent nature of the crawler algorithm that Broder et al. used almost 14 years ago, and it is not an intrinsic property of the Internet. Moreover, while they could confirm the existence of an SCC component,⁵⁰⁸ the large structure did not prove to be following a power law distribution according to their new statistical calculations: the in-out degree distribution turned out to be following a distribution that cannot be described either as a power law or a heavy-tailed distribution – data on this is seemingly inconclusive.⁵⁰⁹

5.2 IS NARRATIVE A NETWORK?

(In)Famously enough, one of the key figures of the Stanford Literary Lab, Franco Moretti,⁵¹⁰ formulated one of the most influential and oft-cited works of distant reading and literary analysis with a network-conscious approach.⁵¹¹ Moving on from real-life networks of computer science (such as the Internet), sociology (such as structures of social media), and engineering (such as road, aviation, and electricity networks), Moretti argued that, in a sense, literary works could also be regarded as networks in a more metaphorical but at the same time, equally fruitful manner.⁵¹² This approach would point toward a more quantifiable literary analysis methodology, something closer to science than the discipline was ever before.

Stripping down networks to their essentials, Moretti explains that just as they consist of vertices and edges, “a plot [consists] of characters and actions” – characters can be regarded as the nodes of a network and their interactions as the edges.⁵¹³ These connections can then be made by explicit or implicit gestures, either by two characters directly speaking or being present in each other’s company. This methodological

⁵⁰⁶ Broder et al., “Graph Structure in the Web,” 310.

⁵⁰⁷ Robert Meusel et al., “Graph Structure in the Web --- Revisited: A Trick of the Heavy Tail,” *Proceedings of the 23rd International Conference on World Wide Web*, ACM, April 7, 2014, 427–32, <https://doi.org/10.1145/2567948.2576928>.

⁵⁰⁸ Meusel et al., “Graph Structure in the Web --- Revisited,” 431.

⁵⁰⁹ Meusel et al., “Graph Structure in the Web --- Revisited,” 429–30.

⁵¹⁰ Not to make the mistake of calling him the “founder” of the Lab, as this particular initiative’s origin could be traced back to Matthew Jockers and to his *collaboration* with Moretti. See more: Matthew Jockers, “Thoughts on a Literary Lab,” Blog, *Matthew L. Jockers*, January 4, 2013, <https://www.matthewjockers.net/2013/01/04/defining-a-literary-lab/>.

⁵¹¹ Franco Moretti, “Network Theory, Plot Analysis,” in *Distant Reading* (Verso, 2013).

⁵¹² Franco Moretti and Stanford Literary Lab, *Network Theory, Plot Analysis*, 2011, 2, <http://litlab.stanford.edu/LiteraryLabPamphlet2.pdf>.

⁵¹³ Moretti and Stanford Literary Lab, *Network Theory, Plot Analysis*, 3.

experiment then goes on in Moretti's pamphlet to be applied to Shakespeare's *Hamlet* while also accounting for the shortcoming of not calculating with weights and directedness of the edges. The paper argues that by analyzing this manually created visualization of the plot (or more like the characters' social network), one could already draw meaningful conclusions about the narrative processes: "The tragedy, is all there."⁵¹⁴

Moretti's arguments become weaker as he ventures into quantitative investigations of a network consisting of only a few nodes (twenty compared to the Common Crawl's 3.5 billion) and starts to explain that a power law distribution can describe the structure. It has been discussed that to avoid significant bias regarding identifying such quantitative distributions, one should have a sample size of over 200.⁵¹⁵ I argue, however, that if one considers the findings of the pamphlet as experiments and explorations and regards the use of the network-scientific terminology as some metaphor, Moretti intriguingly demonstrates how new interpretative opportunities may arise from visualizing the underlying structures of a literary work.

Relationships and interactions between literary characters, spatially and temporally entangled narrating situations, and complex event sequences can all be interpreted as networks to visualize. In the case of interactive and digital fiction, this applies tenfold, as Marie-Laure Ryan (among many others) already explored this aspect of these storytelling phenomena.⁵¹⁶ Even literary processes that insemminate the emergence of literary artifacts, such as the network of authors, dynamics of publishing, and the tectonics of canonicity, all take the form of complex networks that organize these procedures. Therefore, I argue that narratives are network-like structures in their own right.

5.3 ANALYZING TRANSMEDIA NETWORKS

Moretti's narrative (and more metaphorical) and Ruppel's medial network visualizations were both created manually, with a certain degree of heuristic decision and bias, in contrast to Broder et al.'s and similar investigations of quantitative data gathering. During my research, the 618 and 873 nodes for *The Beast* and EMH were recorded mostly by hand, but there were attempts to involve more algorithmic methods to map the stories' transmedia landscape. In the case of *The Beast*, I heavily relied on the service of the *Internet Archive*, which – with the help of their crawlers – besides the actual archived snapshots of web pages, offers a site map as well, which is an archived structural overview of a specific site, providing accurate information of subpages even in cases where the subpages themselves were not archived properly. This is especially valuable for researchers who are interested in transmedia narratives that are heavily web-based and long-defunct.

The connections between the nodes were established according to the types of processes explained above. Again, as hands-on examples, *The Beast* was identified with 2063 edges and EMH with 1062. Although these tables were initially imported into the

⁵¹⁴ Moretti and Stanford Literary Lab, *Network Theory, Plot Analysis*, 4.

⁵¹⁵ G Pickering et al., "Sampling Power-Law Distributions," *Tectonophysics*, no. 248 (1995): 10.

⁵¹⁶ Marie-Laure Ryan, *Narrative as Virtual Reality: Immersion and Interactivity in Literature and Electronic Media*, Parallax (Johns Hopkins University Press, 2001), 242–70.

more well-known Gephi network visualization software, Cytoscape ultimately provided the home for their final forms. Both of these maps of transmedia storytelling networks were further enhanced for visual inspections: the layout was processed through the *prefuse* force-directed layout algorithm,⁵¹⁷ which – not focusing on a complete assessment of every aspect of the mathematics and methods of this tool – in simple terms a 2D physical simulation that regards nodes of a network as points of mass, and edges as springs in this dynamic network, while using the Barnes-Hut astronomical approximation to speed up n-body force calculations.⁵¹⁸

Using different layouts in network visualizations helps find answers to a specific research question. To point out hierarchically or structurally more important nodes and segments of a vast network, it is essential to grasp, in some cases, tens of thousands (if not more) nodes at a single glance, or in other words:

*The goal of visualization is to aid our understanding of data by leveraging the human visual system's highly tuned ability to see patterns, spot trends, and identify outliers. Well-designed visual representations can replace cognitive calculations with simple perceptual inferences and improve comprehension, memory, and decision making. By making data more accessible and appealing, visual representations may also help engage more diverse audiences in exploration and analysis.*⁵¹⁹

In short, we can harness the knowledge from faster pattern recognition if we can efficiently visualize complicated networks instead of struggling to read them in their initial “hairball” state. The challenge remains in choosing the best layout for the hypothesis that encodes the information we need to identify and analyze in these data sets.⁵²⁰ To this end, one might select a single *layout* technique, a hybrid one, or even one created by a neural network to find the most optimal presentation.⁵²¹ Marc Ruppel visualized the transmedia networks of *Lost* and *Heroes* in his dissertation using the Fruchterman-Reingold model.⁵²² However, this specific force-directed method was not available during my research, so I relied on the *prefuse* tool with modifications: the node sizes were differentiated by their value of betweenness centrality, their colors correspond with the type (medium) of the specific narrative information, and even the connections between them were made visual – when one site embeds another, it is represented by a solid line; when one site refers to another, it is represented by a dashed line; and finally, when one site is sequentially connected, the line is segmented by arrows in between the source and target.

⁵¹⁷ Jeffrey Heer et al., “Prefuse: A Toolkit for Interactive Information Visualization,” *Proceedings of the SIGCHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, ACM, April 2, 2005, 421–30, <https://doi.org/10.1145/1054972.1055031>.

⁵¹⁸ Jeffrey Heer, “The Barnes-Hut Approximation,” *Jheer.Github.io*, 2017, <https://jheer.github.io/barnes-hut/>.

⁵¹⁹ Jeffrey Heer et al., *A Tour through the Visualization Zoo*, n.d., 1.

⁵²⁰ Heer et al., *A Tour through the Visualization Zoo*, 1.

⁵²¹ Csaba Both et al., “Accelerating Network Layouts Using Graph Neural Networks,” *Nature Communications* 14, no. 1 (2023): 6, <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-023-37189-2>.

⁵²² For more: Thomas M. J. Fruchterman and Edward M. Reingold, “Graph Drawing by Force-directed Placement,” *Software: Practice and Experience* 21, no. 11 (1991): 1129–64, <https://doi.org/10.1002/spe.4380211102>.

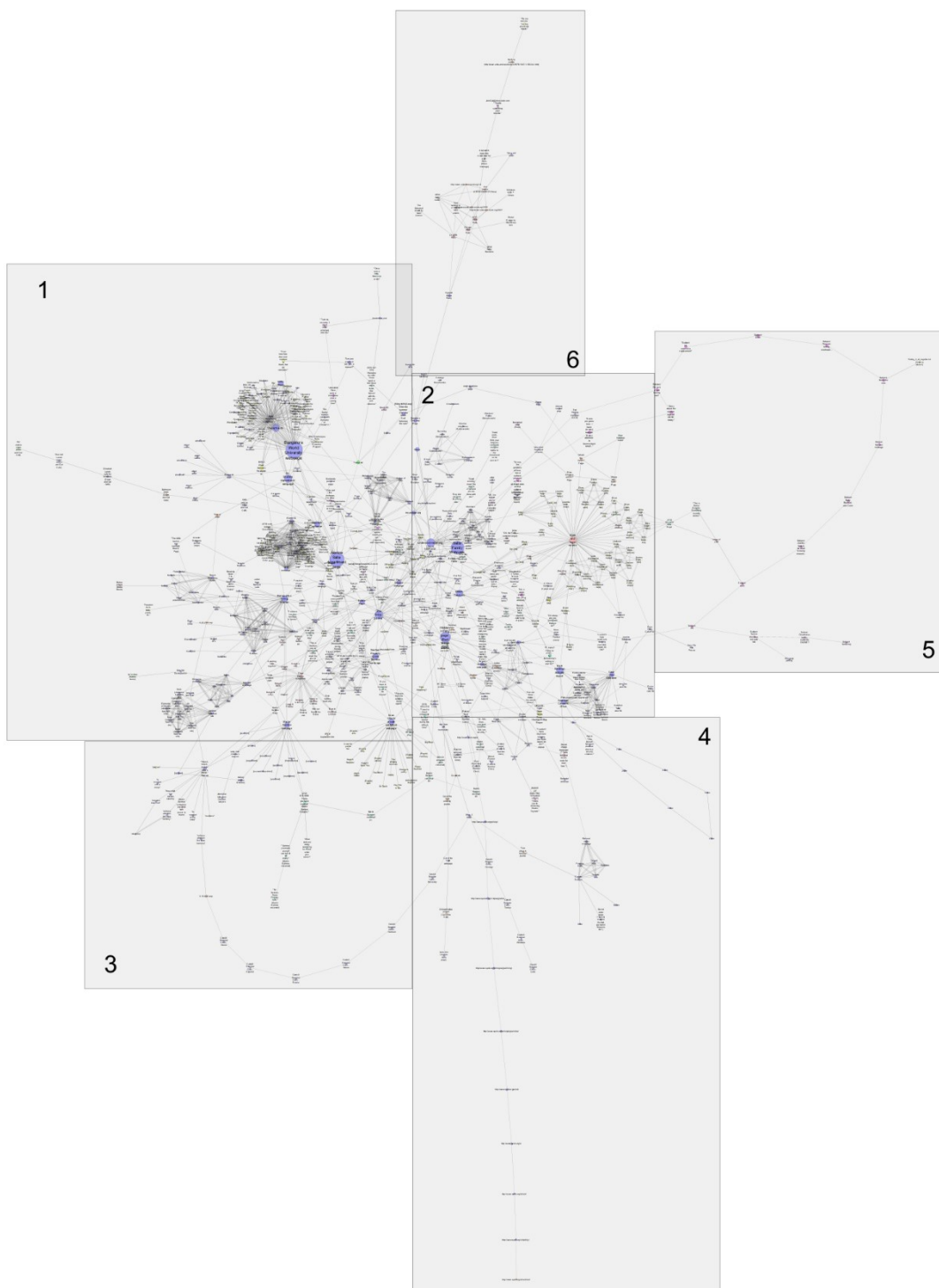




Figure 9: Visualization of the node table of *The Beast* in Cytoscape.⁵²³

After the node and edge table have been visualized (Figure 9), the first impression this artifact will make on the researcher is the ability and analytical instinct to segment the vast network into meaningful chunks, thereby attempting to initiate a meaningful interpretation process. The emergence of these clusters or neighborhoods is a direct result of the force-directed layout, which relies on the quantitative data of our nodes.

As I mentioned, the size of the nodes was affected primarily by their betweenness centrality. This calculation measures the specific node's influence and position in the network. Again, avoiding positioning this dissertation in the theoretical field of mathematics and statistics, it needs only to be stated at this point, for the sake of simplicity, that one could consider a node (x) central to the network if another node's (y) shortest path to the third (z) passes through x.⁵²⁴ As node x occurs on an increasing number of "shortest paths" between other nodes, the node's centrality also increases. The value that emerges from this type of investigation is the nodes' *betweenness centrality*. There are different types of centralities as well in network science: for example, closeness centrality (which defines "independence" – gaining its value from the number of direct connections with other nodes) and eigenvector centrality (which values a specific node's connection to other "important" nodes).⁵²⁵ All of these have their real-life applications: betweenness centrality provides essential insights for telecommunication and informational technologies, for example, as it provides information about the flow of information; closeness centrality helps analyze

⁵²³ The inserted images of the transmedia network are screenshots from Cytoscape, however, a more detailed close-up is available through the attached QR code.

⁵²⁴ Linton C. Freeman, "A Set of Measures of Centrality Based on Betweenness," *Sociometry* 40, no. 1 (1977): 36, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3033543>.

⁵²⁵ Saikou Y. Diallo et al., "Identifying Key Papers within a Journal via Network Centrality Measures," *Scientometrics* 107, no. 3 (2016): 1007–8, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11192-016-1891-8>.

transportation networks;⁵²⁶ and finally, eigenvector can highlight the size of a node's importance regarding its influential position in the system as it "has been applied to social networks for purposes such as predicting academic positions for faculty members whose positions require publishing."⁵²⁷ However, this latter metric is only helpful if the links between nodes are weighted in a non-equal manner.

In the present research, betweenness centrality was chosen as the primary metric for the nodes during analysis, as there was no initial weighing of the links between the nodes. Moreover, the investigation was looking for primarily the narrative elements that demonstrated a higher control over the flow of information in the storytelling system – these points of high influence, I would argue, can be either interpreted as trailheads in transmedia networks, phase gates between chapter-like segments of the story, or sites where the most important interactions need to take place by the VUPs.

Other measures capture different notions of importance, but they are less suited for tracing this kind of narrative mediation. First, looking at the *degree*⁵²⁸ of a node counts the number of direct connections each node has. Nodes with high degree are immediate "hubs" in the network, often representing popular or highly referenced story pieces. However, a high-degree node is not necessarily a bridge between distinct narrative threads – its links may all point to within one cluster or storyline. A higher degree metric highlights locally well-connected nodes, but it can miss the *structural* importance of a node that links otherwise unconnected story segments. In *The Beast*, for example, a site might have numerous links or references to adjacent nodes (e.g., a digital encyclopedia). Still, that site does not necessarily control the narrative flow between different parts of the plot. A smaller-degree node might be more crucial if it is the only link between two clusters of content – a nuance that inspecting the degree alone would overlook.

Second, closeness centrality measures how "close" a node is to all others by computing the average shortest path distance to every other node. A high closeness score indicates a node from which information can reach the entire network very rapidly.⁵²⁹ In a narrative context, a node with high closeness centrality might sit near the center of the web of story pieces, meaning a player could navigate from that node to any clue in only a few steps. This speaks about the efficiency of access, but not necessarily *mediation*. Closeness does not distinguish whether the node actively brokers between otherwise distant parts of the story – it only assures that the node is on average not far from any given piece. In a transmedia work that is fairly well-connected, many nodes might have similar closeness, and a major hub and a crucial bridge could both appear "central" by this measure. What closeness misses is the *qualitative role* of a

⁵²⁶ Dr Jan Scheurer and Dr Sergio Porta, "Centrality and Connectivity in Public Transport Networks and Their Significance for Transport Sustainability in Cities," World Planning Schools Congress, Mexico City, 2006.

⁵²⁷ Diallo et al., "Identifying Key Papers within a Journal via Network Centrality Measures," 1008.

⁵²⁸ Sometimes referred to as "degree centrality". See: Mark E. J. Newman, *Networks: An Introduction*, Reprinted (Oxford University Press, 2016), 168.

⁵²⁹ Hsiao-Hui Chen and Udo Dietrich, "Normalized Closeness Centrality of Urban Networks: Impact of the Location of the Catchment Area and Evaluation Based on an Idealized Network," *Applied Network Science* 8, no. 60 (2023): 4–5, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s41109-023-00585-0>.

node as a necessary transit point. A site could be centrally located (high closeness) but redundant in the sense that multiple paths exist around it; such a node is not a singular narrative choke-point that this analysis is looking for. Betweenness, by contrast, zeroes in on nodes that uniquely connect different regions of the narrative graph, presenting a higher value for a narratological inquiry.

Third, eigenvector centrality⁵³⁰ assigns importance to nodes based on the influence of their neighbors.⁵³¹ A node scores high if it is connected to many other highly central nodes. In narratological terms, this measure tends to favor nodes embedded in the densely interconnected core of the narrative – for instance, a primary story hub that is referenced by many other essential plot nodes. Such a node is no doubt significant (e.g., a main character’s website linked to many key events might rank highly), however, eigenvector centrality can undervalue the bridges of peripheries: a connector between a major arc and a minor arc might connect to only one or two crucial nodes, thus not scoring high by eigenvector criteria, even though it performs an essential linking function. In *The Beast*, for instance, the “Red King” hidden page – a clue trail connecting an isolated subplot back into the main narrative – may not have had many influential inbound links, but it was the only gateway for that subplot’s information to enter the broader story. Eigenvector centrality would not flag this page’s importance, whereas betweenness centrality correctly identifies it as a critical mediator of story information. In short, eigenvector highlights overall prestige or influence within a well-integrated cluster, whereas betweenness highlights brokerage between clusters.

Circling back to this analysis’s metric, in the case of *The Beast*, the top 5 nodes with the highest value of betweenness centrality were

1. The fictional Bangalore World University’s webpage, the primary gateway, rabbit hole, and trailhead that led first into the narrative, as a considerable number of real-world cues prompted curious members of the audience to begin their explorations here;
2. Jeanine Salla’s (one of the protagonists of the story) department page, which leads to a diverse set of information and serves as one of the largest hubs in the network;
3. The Salla Family page: the website that ties together the characters closely entangled with Evan Chan (the murder victim) personally and serves as a “Story so far” platform for VUPs to catch up on the most recent developments;
4. The hidden page of the Red King, one of the key antagonists of the story, who is constantly leaving a trail of clues for the VUPs;
5. And the BWU’s News Network, which, rather than offering static information about the storyworld, provided a dynamic platform that advanced the narrative, simulating the flow of time as the ARG unfolded.

⁵³⁰ Newman, *Networks*, 169–72.

⁵³¹ H. Robert Frost, “A Generalized Eigenvector Centrality for Multilayer Networks with Inter-Layer Constraints on Adjacent Node Importance,” *Applied Network Science* 9, no. 1 (2024): 3–4, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s41109-024-00620-8>.

So far, the three most important nodes seem to fulfill the research's hypothesis: the sites with the highest betweenness centrality values represent informational hubs, centers for narrative distribution. Following this assumption, the network visualization is set up with a tenfold difference in size between nodes. After this treatment, the prefuse force-directed process, with 1000 iterations, using the default spring length of 100 and the default node mass of 5, created the layout shown above.

This is a minor detour, but it is worth mentioning at this point that Ruppel began his analysis of the transmedia network of *Heroes* by identifying its scale as *scale-free*.⁵³² I argued that drawing this loaded conclusion from such a small-scale network might be counterintuitive and inaccurate, so this research will not attempt to make the same assumptions. However, it is worth noting that, very similar to scale-free networks (neither the network of *Heroes* nor the Beast's system), the Beast's system also does not present many nodes with an “average” degree. In both systems, one can observe a small number of “highly connected” nodes with an elevated degree value and a significant amount of nodes with a low degree value (Figure 10).⁵³³ This recognition would tell the narratologist that we encounter a storytelling network where one could identify high-impact nodes, which, if removed, would significantly modify the possible modes of telling the story, influencing the narration overall.

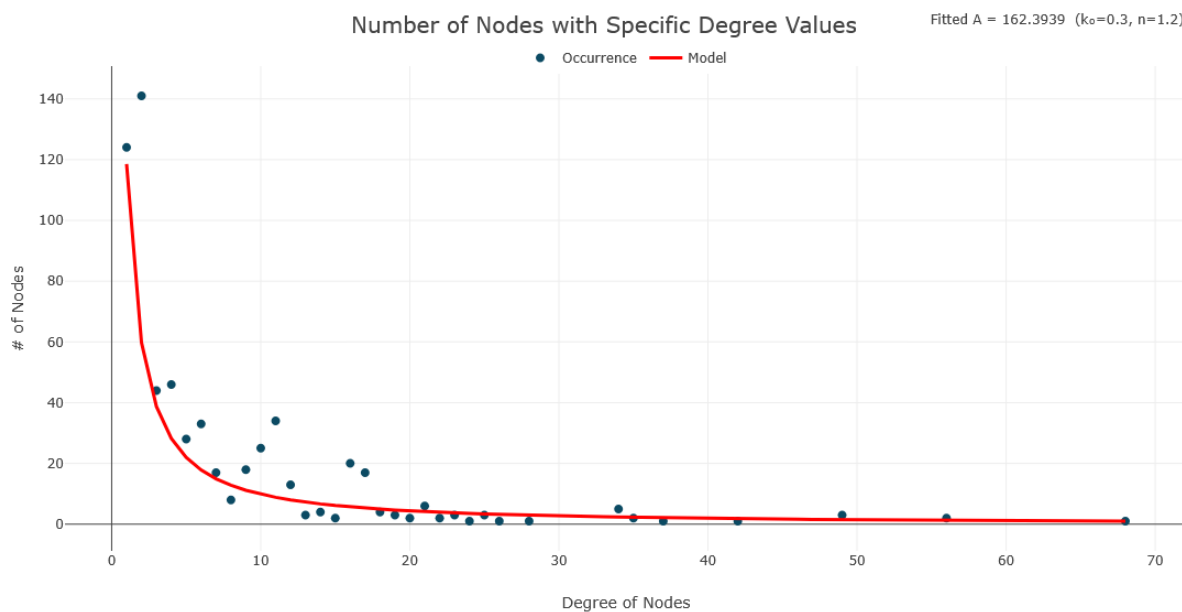


Figure 10: Point diagram of the number of nodes with a specific degree value in the system of *The Beast* with a corrected power law model ($k=0.3$; $n=1.2$) superimposed onto the chart.

Circling back to the visualization's analysis, I would argue that six segments of *The Beast* can be identified: a central part that can be segmented into two units (annotated as 1 and 2) and four parts that could be understood as peripheries (annotated

⁵³² Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 236–39.

⁵³³ It must be stated that it is apparent on the diagram below that the network's values deviate from the power law model too much to identify it as scale-free unambiguously. However, visually, it still shows a significant difference from a Gaussian distribution.

as 3, 4, 5, and 6) of the system.⁵³⁴ The former contains the nodes with the highest betweenness centrality values (35,297), while the latter's most relevant node has a value of 2,906.

The storylines of these segments or zones also reflect this data. The nodes in the area, signified by the number 4, represent multiple smaller narrative arcs. First, the most prominent storyline is the one around a fictional webshop called the *Rational Hatter*, which provides clues to the VUP about, on the one hand, the kidnapping of one of the suspects, the robot companion, Venus, and on the other hand, some indirect narrative fragments about David, both the protagonist of the movie *A.I. Artificial Intelligence* and a whole AI initiative in the storyworld.

⁵³⁴ The segments presented as colored annotation boxes in the diagram should be read as the semi-transparent orange (2) slices off those areas from the other numbered zones.

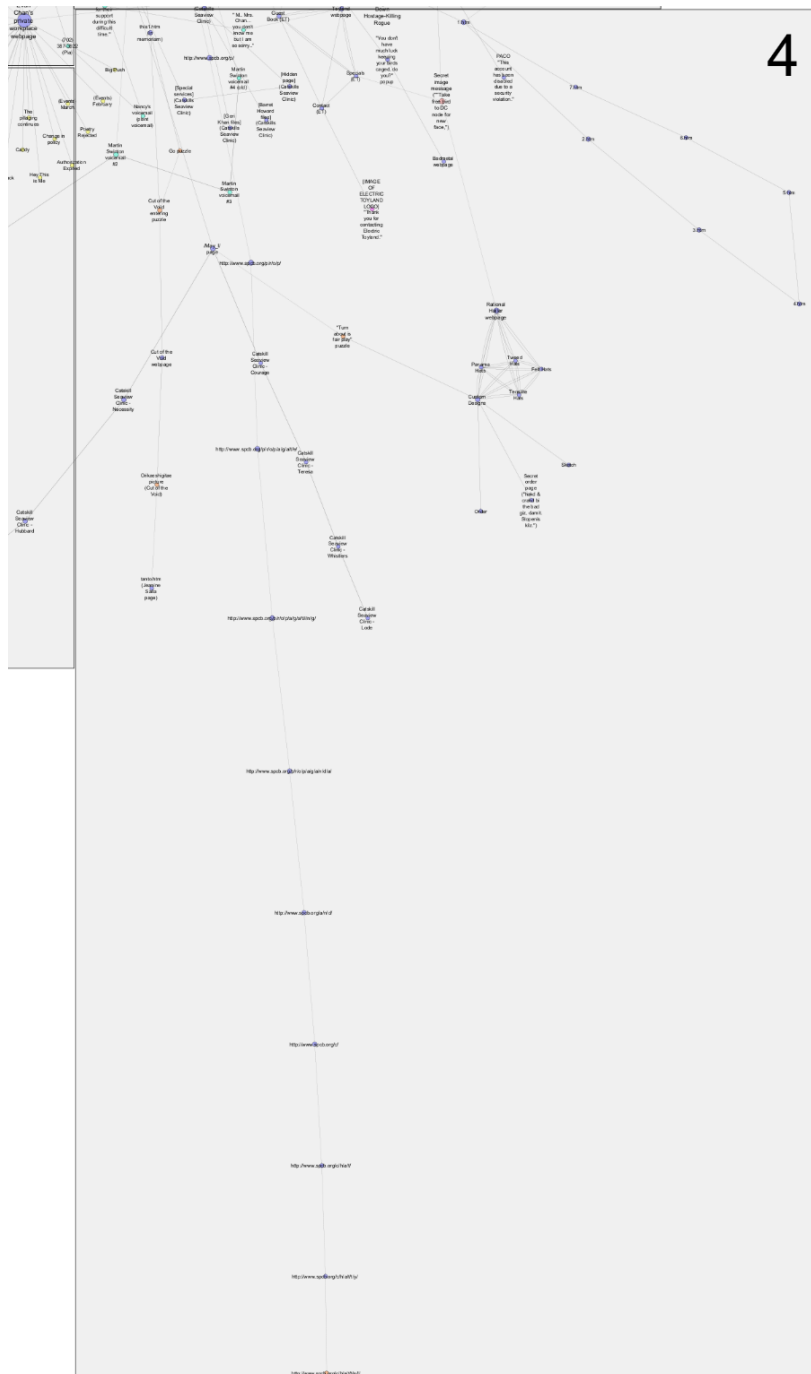


Figure 11: Close-up view of Zone 4.

Second, we can account for several “appendages” being “spooled down” from a few smaller network hubs. One is a series of URL puzzles (see the long string in the diagram that reaches out towards the very borders of the network) left by the Red King hidden in the official webpage of the Sentient Property Crimes Bureau (or SPCB – the agency which serves as a special kind of law enforcement unit focusing on crimes committed by robots and AIs), which leads to a coded little diary entry of his that sheds a different light on a story event. (It informs the VUPs that a poll in which the VUPs could also participate was rigged after all.) Another bundle of nodes is to be associated with the Catskills Seaview Clinic, a therapeutic institution for those with mental disorders, where AI therapists also work with their inpatients. The sites in this

zone are primarily either case files of these patients or separate fragments of a single interview between one of the patients (Monica Swinton) and a liaison of a very powerful corporate entity, Cybertronics. Again, this latter segment of the narrative should not be a surprise, as it is positioned on the periphery of *The Beast*'s network, as Monica Swinton's character arc only has a significant impact on David's backstory.

None of these is essential or non-reconstructable narrative information that cannot be retrieved from other sites. However, it connects the ARG's transmedia network to the movie, migrating specific elements of the mythos (e.g., the SPCB). In other words, it behaves as the peripheries or borderlands of the ARG network. On the one hand, establishing or confirming the narrative connection between these story arcs increases the credibility of the force-directed layouts of these maps, as this shows that thematically closely related site communities are indeed grouped together topologically as well. On the other hand, using a network-conscious approach, the researcher could visually spot significant connections between independent sites in a trans-media storyworld – or, in this case, even specific groups of sites that point outward of this narrative network.

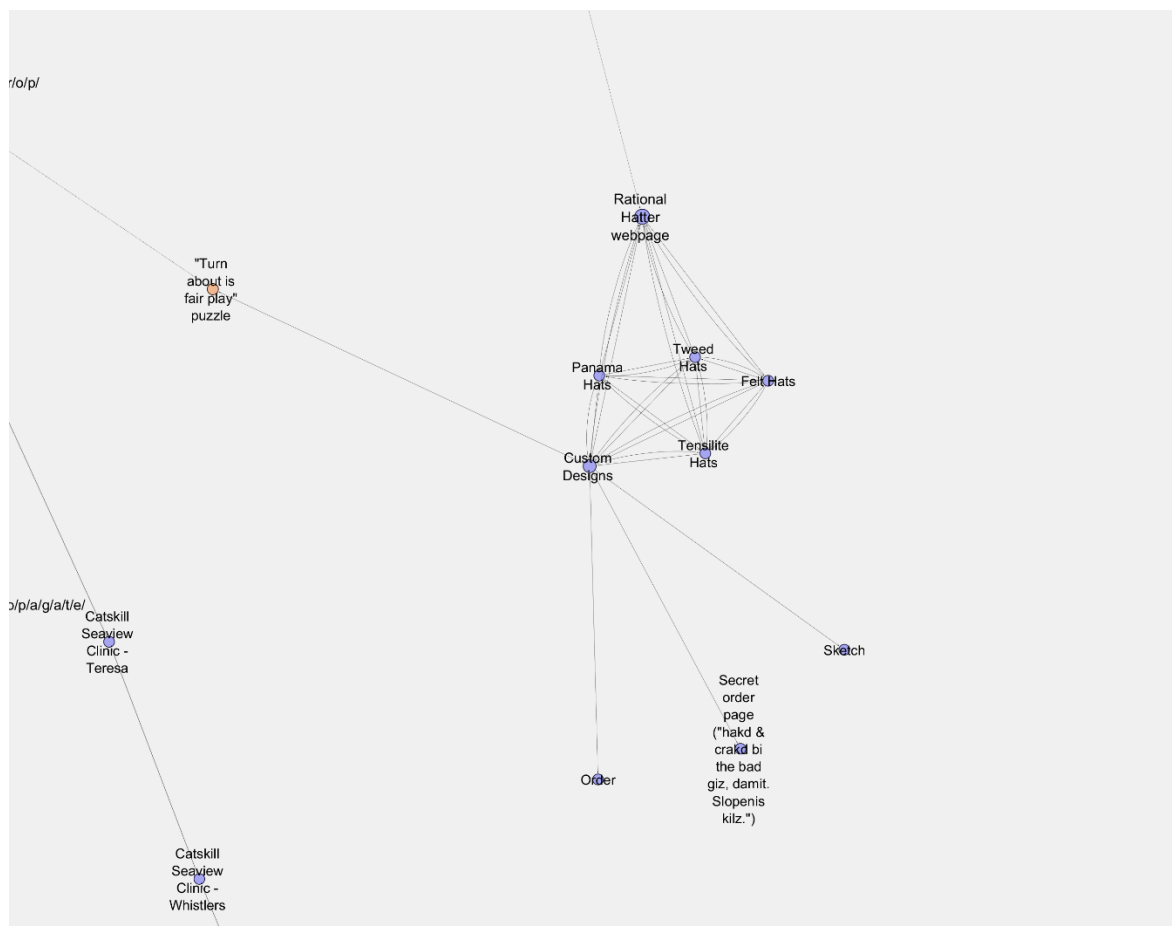


Figure 12: Close-up view of the Rational Hatter webpage site's subsystem in Zone 4.

Zone 5 contains one major storyline that characterizes this segment. One of the central hubs (both from narratological and network standpoints) of the storytelling system, the Salla Family Homepage served as a continuously updated platform for narrative recaps and in-character commentary of Laia Joanna Salla, the granddaughter

of Jeanine Salla, the wife of the murder victim, Evan Chan with whom she also had a special relationship. Apart from the constant updates about the ARG's story, the character, Laia, also sent narrative fragments directly in e-mails (and some attachments) to those who had subscribed with their addresses on the Salla Family Homepage.⁵³⁵ In the network visualization image, the main path traced in this specific zone is the sequence of these messages (almost in their entirety) and the structure of how the story unfolds.

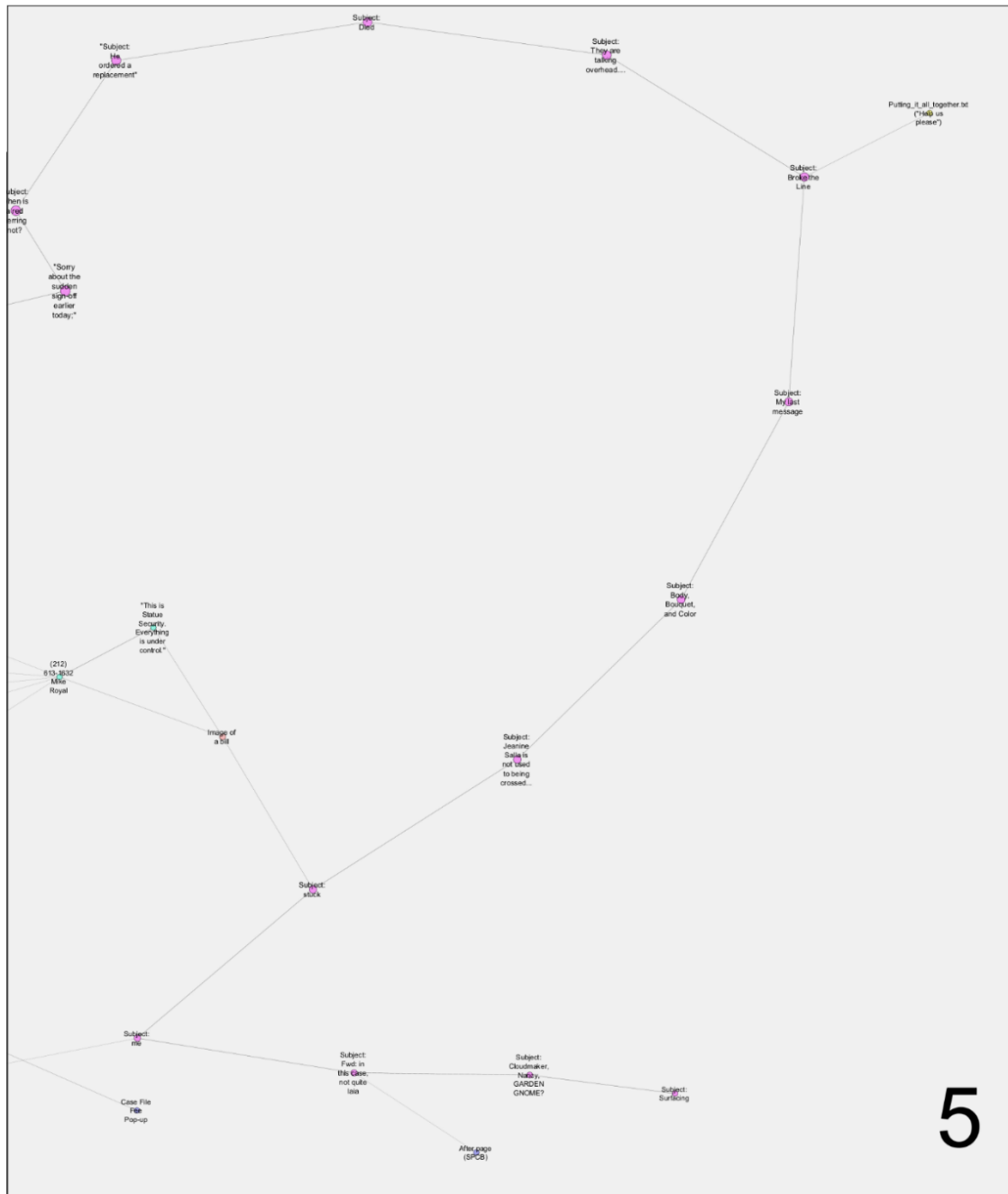


Figure 13: Close-up view of Zone 5.

From the first weeks of the ARG until the last, the subscribed players received communication from the diegetic person, Laia, through this avenue. Her messages were

⁵³⁵ See the bottom of the page here: <https://web.archive.org/web/20020907024235/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/default2.htm> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 09.)

about her suspicions and led directly to Evan Chan's murder and the culprit.⁵³⁶ However, they turned more into poetic introspections of her past,⁵³⁷ and soon, she became involved in the most recent developments of the ongoing investigation to find out the whole truth about the events surrounding the tragic event.⁵³⁸

The network visualization diagram can also identify this symbolic arc of Laia's story in her emails: the first few sites (or messages) are still close to the central zones numbered 1 and 2. Her first two e-mails can still be considered parts of these segments. Laia's third e-mail, however, jumps the metaphorical (and heuristic) threshold with a message that closes with the line:

*Word on the street is there's an upsurge in hacker activity over the last couple of days. Maybe it's like hacker mardi gras, and we've just chased off some frat boys. I hope so. All for now—*⁵³⁹

So, right at the point when the new group of narrative agents, hackers, were introduced to the VUPs, the e-mails started to forge their own, more independent path in the storyworld. This is where Laia's character received the motivation to act in her efforts.

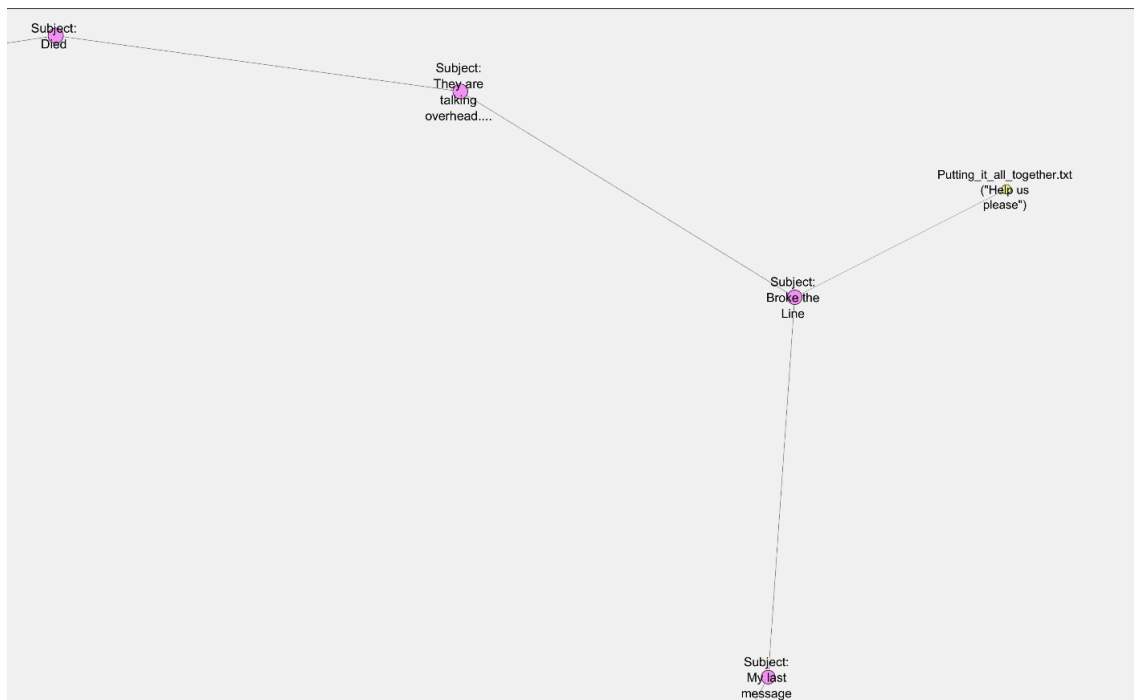


Figure 14: Close-up view of the structural fork in the e-mail thread of Zone 5.

⁵³⁶ For example, see: <https://web.archive.org/web/20020603194349/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/Mail-4-17.htm> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 09.) and <https://web.archive.org/web/20020603194643/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/Mail-4-24.htm> (last accessed 2025. 02. 09.)

⁵³⁷ For example, see: <https://web.archive.org/web/20020707074744/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/mail-5-22.htm> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 09.)

⁵³⁸ For example, see: <https://web.archive.org/web/20030213091643/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/Mail-6-26.htm> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 09.)

⁵³⁹ <https://web.archive.org/web/20020603194643/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/Mail-4-24.htm> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 09.)

It is also noticeable on the diagram where the next change happens regarding the flow of the plot: right in the middle of the e-mail thread, at the 8th message out of 15,⁵⁴⁰ the VUP encounters the first coded message and the first migratory cue that breaks the series of edges that were all built on causal-sequentiality. After a minor puzzle that involved reformatting a non-conventionally spaced text file (Putting_it_all_together.txt), Laia's message "Help us please" became apparent – a digital plea for help.

I don't know how much longer I can take this. I realize now that for weeks I've been trapped in a dream: but now I'm finally waking up. My halter top is sticky and dirty. It got sweaty when I was piling things in front of the door. I have these bursts of clarity four times a day, I think it's related to the quaternion. Between them I don't sleep -- that would be suicide --but I get dull. I forget things. Yesterday evening I almost opened the door to my apartment. Like father, like daughter! Luckily Mephista warned me. Actually she knocked me down. She can do that, in an emergency. I hit my cheek on the doorknob when I fell. I've got quite a shiner this morning! It would be funny except that when you make a cavity, things will fill it up. They fill it up. Also, now I can feel the moths. I don't know how many people in the building are still alive. Obviously everyone in the corridors is gone, and the boathouse. There may be a few other air pockets left. I rocked my refrigerator back and forth until I could tip it over, and then pushed it in front of the door so I wouldn't kill myself in a moment of thoughtlessness. Then I dragged out my hope chest and stacked it on top. Genuine spanish walnut. Then the kitchen table. Then my clothes. I taped them around the door to strengthen the seal. The worst part is the moths, which are in my throat. This is better--far better--than letting them get out, but still. It's not painful, exactly: but the bump and flutter of their wings--it's maddening, it's like an itch, a tickle. The pressure builds and builds & builds. The first one was in my little finger. I got a knife from the kitchen and let that one out. When I saw what it was I screamed, but the Salla women have iron in them and I managed to kill it while its wings were still too wet to fly. I hacked and hacked and hacked. My whole body was shaking. When it was over I took the pieces and was going to throw them over the balcony but M was watching out for me and she kept the door closed so I scooped the pieces up with a saucer and shook them into the toilet and flushed and then I took the saucer and put it in the hope chest and I locked the chest and I put the key down the toilet and flushed that too. Obviously I haven't been able to eat. I can't open my mouth or the moths will get out. I'm weak but clear-headed and in good spirits. I haven't felt hungry since Sunday night. Thirst is the real problem. I cut a strip of water - proof cloth out of one of my coats and rolled it into a straw. When the thirst gets bad enough I put a little water in a wine bottle and then the straw and then I hold my lips very tight to the bottle and I suck up the water as fast as I can. Then they come flying up my throat and I have to swallow hard. I can feel them washing down like little struggles of wet paper. I was working on a plan to let them out, but I started to get dull again before I quite figured out the details, and when I'm not in clarity I can't concentrate through the bulging in my throat. I need to be in clarity. Clarity. Also there are spots of blood all over my apartment. I think someone is trying to scare me. Let them try. I'm a resourceful girl and I'm on to them now. I'm very close to figuring it all out. If the bulging in my throat wasn't maddening, I would have put it all together by now. I'm sure of it. so

I realize now that for weeks I've been trapped in a dream: but now I'm finally waking up. My halter top is sticky and dirty. It got sweaty when I was piling things in front of the door. I have these bursts of clarity four times a day, I think it's related to the quaternion. Between them I don't sleep -- that would be suicide --but I get dull. I forget things. Yesterday evening I almost opened the door to my apartment. Like father, like daughter! Luckily Mephista warned me. Actually she knocked me down. She can do that, in an emergency. I hit my cheek on the doorknob when I fell. I've got quite a shiner this morning! It would be funny except that when you make a cavity, things will fill it up. They fill it up. Also, now I can feel the moths. I don't know how many people in the building are still alive. Obviously everyone in the corridors is gone, and the boathouse. There may be a few other air pockets left. I rocked my refrigerator back and forth until I could tip it over, and then pushed it in front of the door so I wouldn't kill myself in a moment of thoughtlessness. Then I dragged out my hope chest and stacked it on top. Genuine spanish walnut. Then the kitchen table. Then my clothes. I taped them around the door to strengthen the seal. The worst part is the moths, which are in my throat. This is better--far better--than letting them get out, but still. It's not painful, exactly: but the bump and flutter of their wings--it's maddening, it's like an itch, a tickle. The pressure builds and builds & builds. The first one was in my little finger. I got a knife from the kitchen and let that one out. When I saw what it was I screamed, but the Salla women have iron in them and I managed to kill it while its wings were still too wet to fly. I hacked and hacked and hacked. My whole body was shaking. When it was over I took the pieces and was going to throw them over the balcony but M was watching out for me and she kept the door closed so I scooped the pieces up with a saucer and shook them into the toilet and flushed and then I took the saucer and put it in the hope chest and I locked the chest and I put the key down the toilet and flushed that too. Obviously I haven't been able to eat. I can't open my mouth or the moths will get out. I'm weak but clear-headed and in good spirits. I haven't felt hungry since Sunday night. Thirst is the real problem. I cut a strip of water - proof cloth out of one of my coats and rolled it into a straw. When the thirst gets bad enough I put a little water in a wine bottle and then the straw and then I hold my lips very tight to the bottle and I suck up the water as fast as I can. Then they come flying up my throat and I have to swallow hard. I can feel them washing down like little struggles of wet paper. I was working on a plan to let them out, but I started to get dull again before I quite figured out the details, and when I'm not in clarity I can't concentrate through the bulging in my throat. I need to be in clarity. Clarity. Also there are spots of blood all over my apartment. I think someone is trying to scare me. Let them try. I'm a resourceful girl and I'm on to them now. I'm very close to figuring it all out. If the bulging in my throat wasn't maddening, I would have put it all together by now. I'm sure of it. so

Figure 15: Reconstructed and archived version of Laia's plea for help (see: footnote 474)

This is visualized and felt as a tipping point in this character's story. From this point on, the sites gradually move closer to the central parts of the network, both topologically and thematically. This reconnection finally happens in Laia's 12th e-mail,⁵⁴¹

⁵⁴⁰ <https://web.archive.org/web/20040305130802/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/mail-5-29.htm> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 09.)

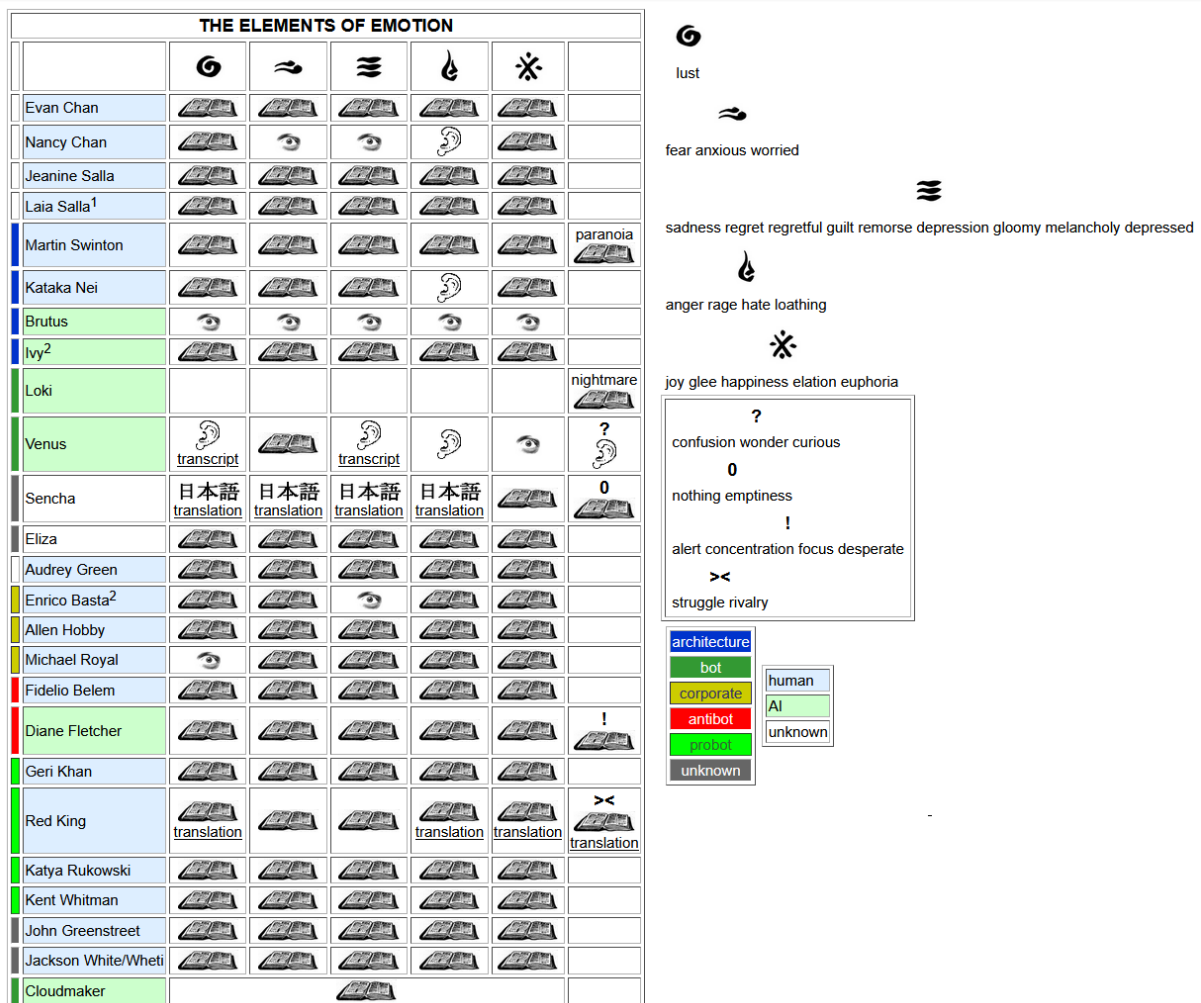
⁵⁴¹ <https://web.archive.org/web/20030213091643/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/Mail-6-26.htm> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 09.)

which expresses her suspicions that her new hacker acquaintance, the Red King, might be captured. As a request for help, she attaches a picture of a restaurant receipt for further help from the VUPs. This medial change instantly provides direct cues for a phone number to call.

It turned out that the phone number belonged to Mike Royal, an employee of a fictional security firm, Statue Security. He was on duty on June 26th when Laia wrote her next plea for help, and her suspicions were confirmed after the VUPs started to call Mike's character. After multiple real-life talks with him, it was discovered that he indeed witnessed the Red King's kidnapping and transfer on a boat. Moreover, his name was also added as part of possible combinations on the Sophia's Temple webpage.

This page takes a central position in the storytelling network, serving as a special kind of informational hub for the VUPs: the main page of Sophia's Temple contains two eyes, representing the two text input fields with the labels "Nickname" and "Secret." As one moves forward in the narrative, more combinations may become known for them. After a successful input pair, these inputs navigate to pages that provide a transcript, an e-mail, a picture, or even a sound recording. The screenshot below shows the ARG creators' diagram for more straightforward navigation.⁵⁴² It shows the number of possible combinations of names and emotions (that turned out to be the requested terms for the "Secret" field).

⁵⁴² <https://web.archive.org/web/20070704225325/http://aleph-naught.cloudmakers.org/Emo-grid.htm> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 19.)



Update Trail:

June 2 00:34 EDT originally by Ian MacIntyre updated by Dan Fabulich, redesigned and remastered by CCharles.

June 12 4:45PM PDT Katy Westerman added in John Greenstreet and Jackson White

June 13 1:05AM EDT Dan Fabulich corrected some of the Jackson White links and reposted as Emo-Grid.htm

June 29 11:15AM PDT Dan Fabulich added Mike Royal.

July 22 Dan Fabulich added Cloudmaker, noted Jeanine/Allen Hobby dead.

The usage of Kate Nei's symbols for the elements is an artistic device, and does not indicate a MuppetPastor plot.

¹Post-human, really.

Figure 16: Diagram of possible combinations and destinations in the Sophia's Temple site (see: foot-note 476)

As the number of characters in the first column shows, Sophia's Temple must be well-embedded and well-connected. This recognition points us back to the initial argument that Laia's 12th e-mail, with the direct cues for Mike Royal, unambiguously channels the flow of narrative information toward the central nodes.

This reconnection of the peripheries with the central areas also continues with the next message, even though it is a less extensive e-mail with a more indirect cue or uses Barthes's intertextual code to account for:

From: "laia" <laia@familiasalla-es.ro>

Subject: me

Date: Tuesday, July 03, 2142 11:13 AM

Nothing from me today. Sorry. PACO just called.

Oh God.

*L*⁵⁴³

In this short message, Laia informs the VUPs that she just got a call from PACO (the Pan American Coroners Office) about something surprising or terrible. The readers of this e-mail are probably aware of the fact that in the storyworld, PACO is "the only legal forensic medical source for public law enforcement agencies in the United States, and it's also a privately held, for-profit corporation⁵⁴⁴" – which renders it as another hub of official case files on deceased characters (such as the previously discovered documents on Evan Chan). This triggered a migratory cue cross-referenced with a transcript published close to the day Laia sent her email on Jeanine Salla's university page, which implied that something had happened to Laia's grandmother. The VUPs found out that, indeed, there was a newly created file for the autopsy of Jeanine Salla in PACO's database. Thus, channeling back in another case, the narrative flows towards the central regions of the network – as PACO can also be seen as one of the informational hubs of the storyworld.

⁵⁴³ <https://web.archive.org/web/20020603201351/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/Mail-7-3.htm> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 09.)

⁵⁴⁴ <https://web.archive.org/web/20020802064140/http://www.cloudmakers.org/guide/#paco> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 09.)

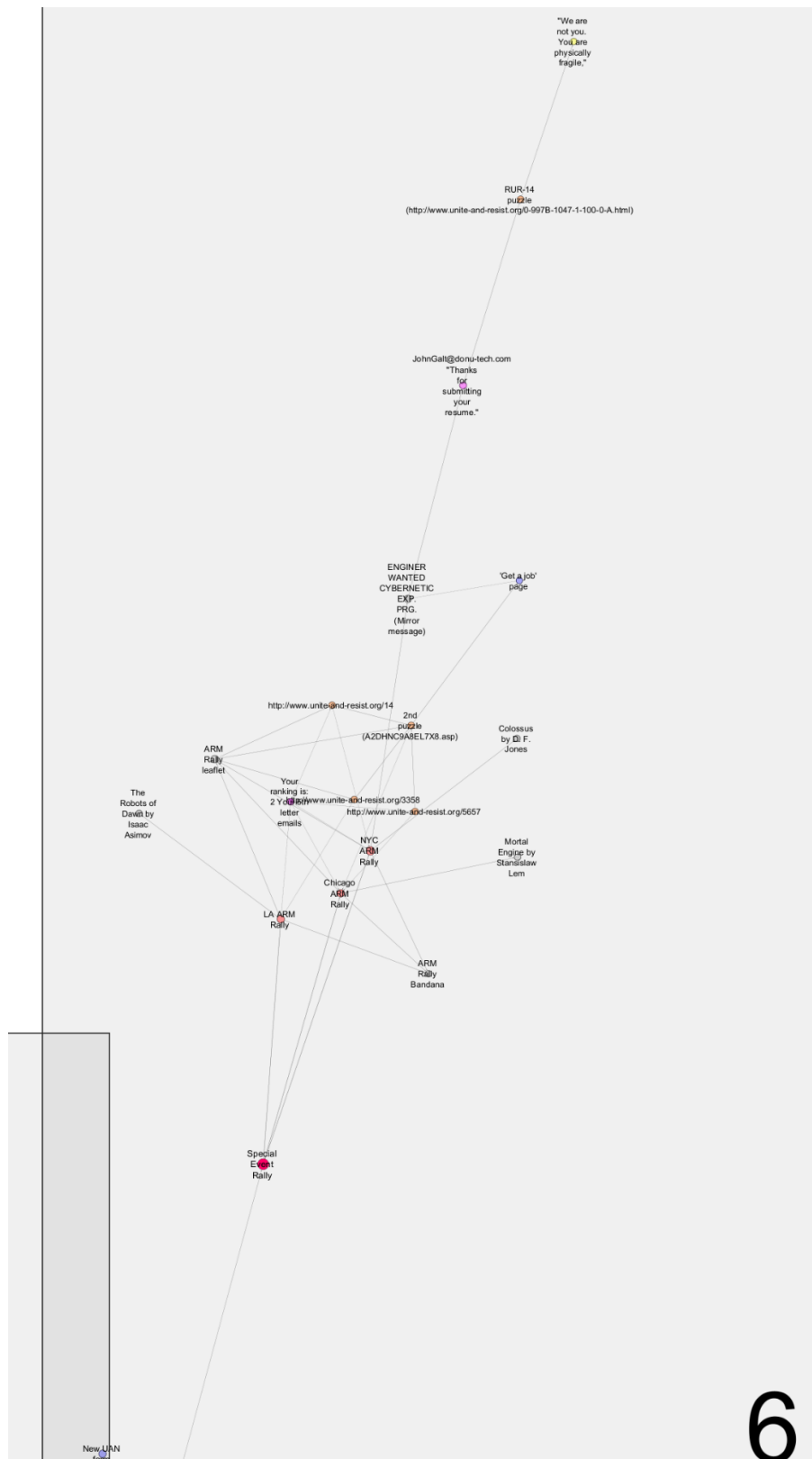


Figure 17: Close-up view of Zone 6.

Similarly to identifying Laia's story arc, one could isolate another group of narrative fragments in the scarcely populated zone number 6. Looking at the connected sites of this community, one can identify a gateway towards the center of this segment: a webpage called Special Event Rally, which forks into three specific real-life events

that took place in Los Angeles, New York, and Chicago. The trailhead was directly embedded in the homepage (unite-and-resist.org) and the central hub of another fictional faction of the narrative, the Anti-Robot Militia (ARM), where if the VUPs had the right answers for a small questionnaire, they were welcomed by a Members Only page that contained the dates and locations for the ARM rallies.

The rallies were, in fact, real-life but in-universe events on May 6th at 10 PM EST. The participants met in restaurants and clubs, and they received fragments of a larger jigsaw puzzle (both literally and figuratively) that they could only solve if they worked together in a cross-sited manner in sync with each other. It might be interesting to note that this mechanic directly represents the abstract structure of these trans-media narratives – the VUPs became nodes that established connections between each other through migratory cues.

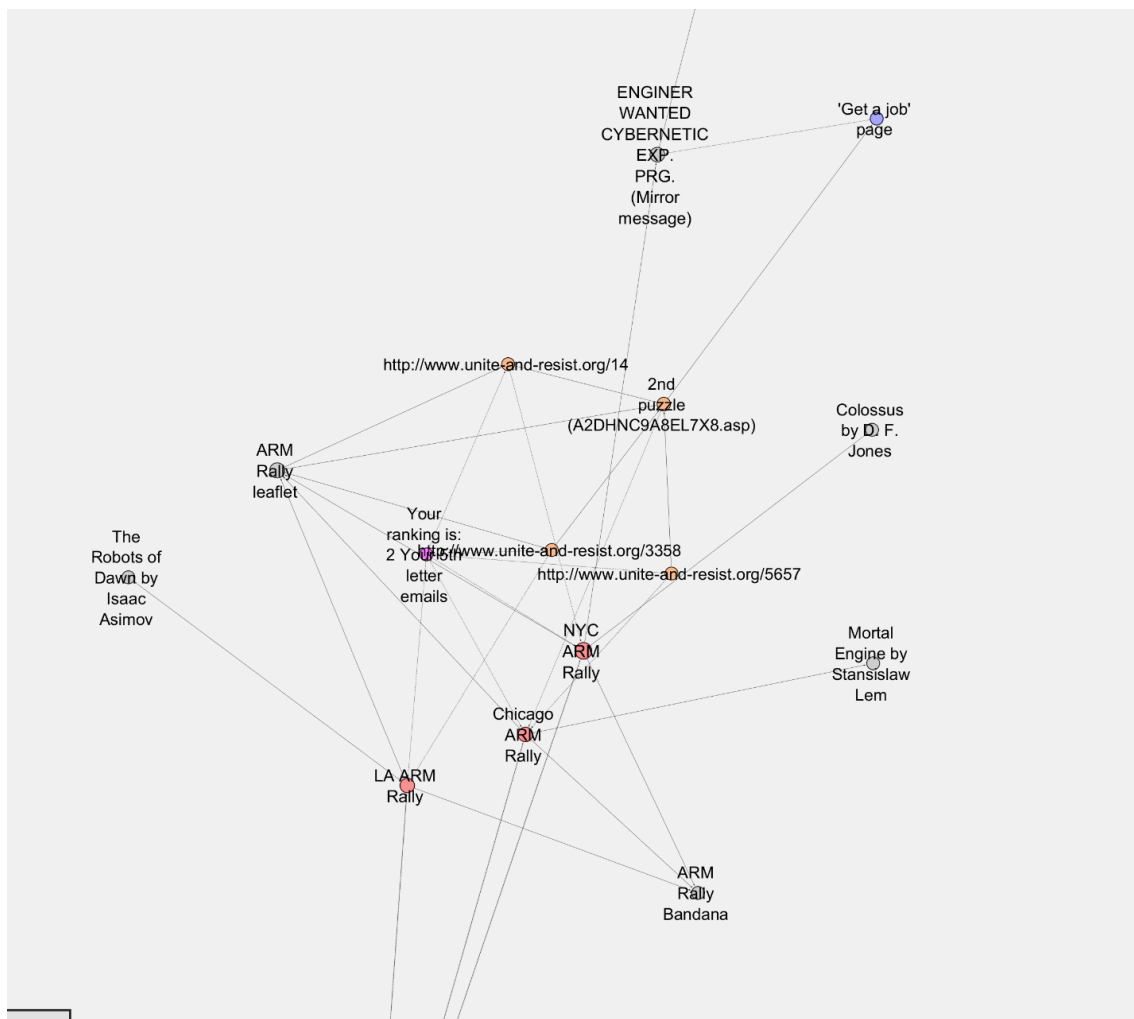


Figure 18: Close-up view of the ARM Rallies' subnetwork.

However, let's look at this unit's narrative structure in the network visualization. Although the collaboration was reportedly quite intensive because they managed “to set up a very efficient network of ‘ARM operatives’ and ‘datasphere miners’ so that

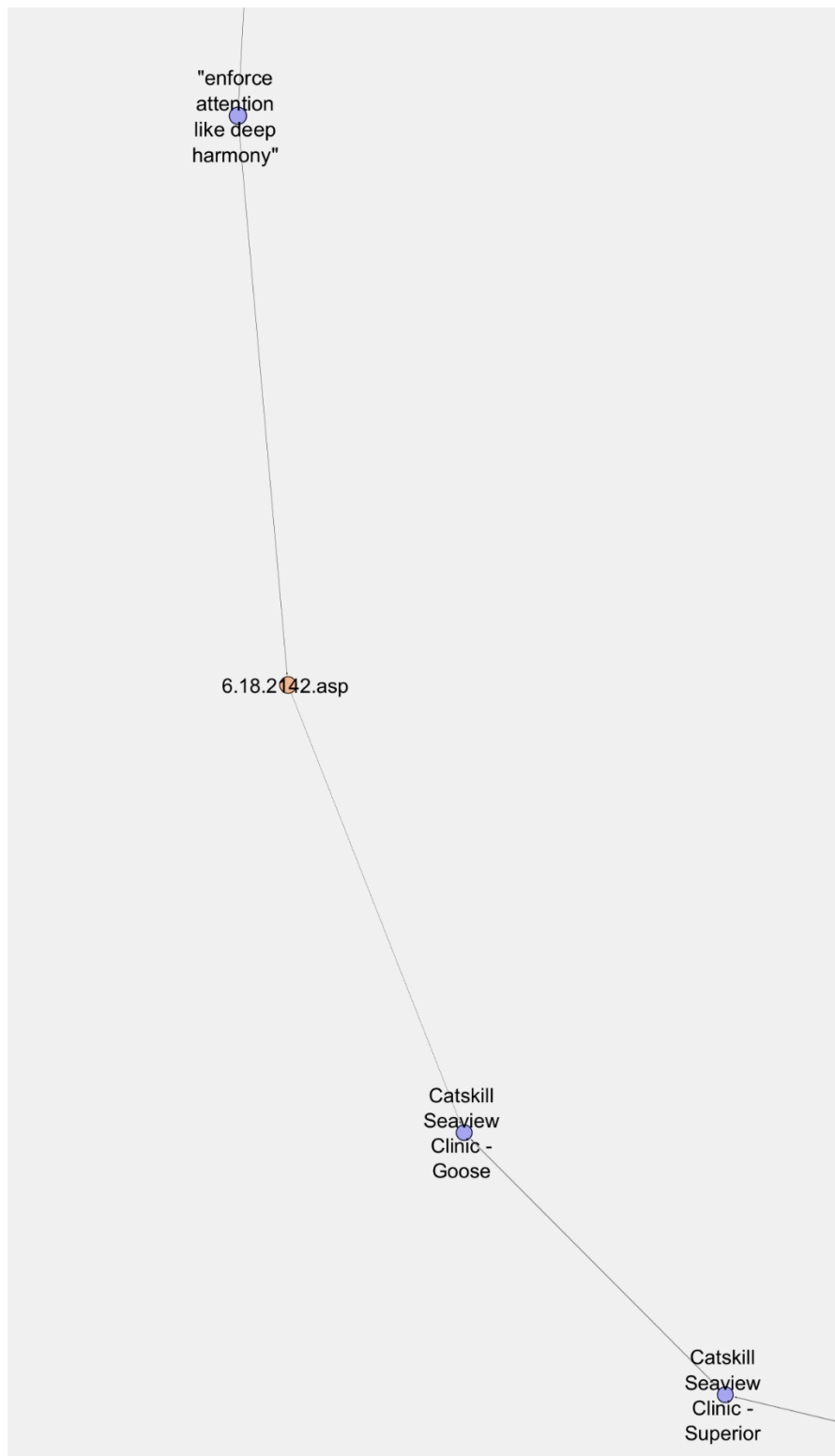


Figure 20: Close-up view of the sites bridging the narrative gap between Catskill Seaview Clinic and Martin Swinton.

Zone number 3 primarily serves as an unambiguous bridge between Martin Swinton and Catskill Seaview Clinic – or between him and his mother. The site labeled “enforce attention like deep harmony” and the subsequent 6.18.2142.asp page (which contains two images, one of them uses the filename “mayi.jpg” which directly refers to the starting point of the series of interview fragments between Jane Sutter and

Monica, the other one uses “goose.jpg” that connects this site to a specific fragment of the interviews), imply a direct connection between the nodes of Martin Swinton’s diary and the clinic.

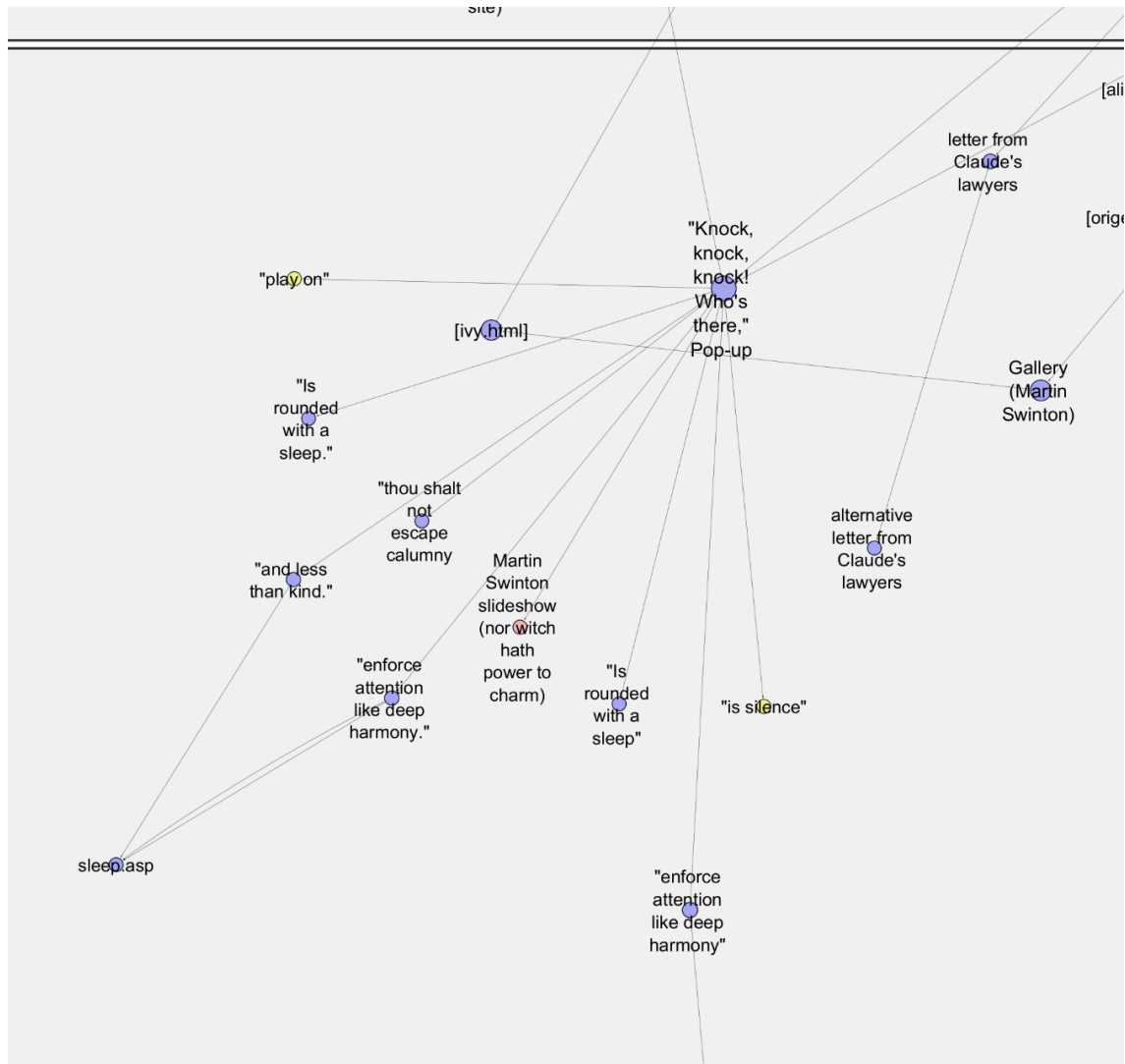


Figure 21: Close-up view of the “Knock, knock [...]” pop-up’s subnetwork.

All of this should be traced back to one constantly changing pop-up window⁵⁴⁷ on Martin’s webpage,⁵⁴⁸ which is completely hidden until the VUP clicks on either the sun or the moon displayed on the corners of his site. This window constantly changed during the ARG – different prompts were displayed, and different text inputs were needed to proceed and discover the relevant story fragment, a small part of Martin’s diary. These bits are loosely connected to the main storyline and are mainly there to enhance the VUP’s understanding of his character. However, one of them serves as

⁵⁴⁷ <https://web.archive.org/web/20070704230103/http://martinswintondesigns.cloudmakers.org/entry.asp> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 14.)

⁵⁴⁸ <https://web.archive.org/web/20020925051639/http://martinswintondesigns.cloudmakers.org/> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 14.)

the connecting tissue between the diary entry fragments and the Catskill Clinic and, as an extension, Monica. Again, similarly to Laia's character and the central parts of the narrative, this identification provides an instant understanding that (and how) Catskill Seaview Clinic is connected to Martin Swinton – two groups of sites seemingly far away.

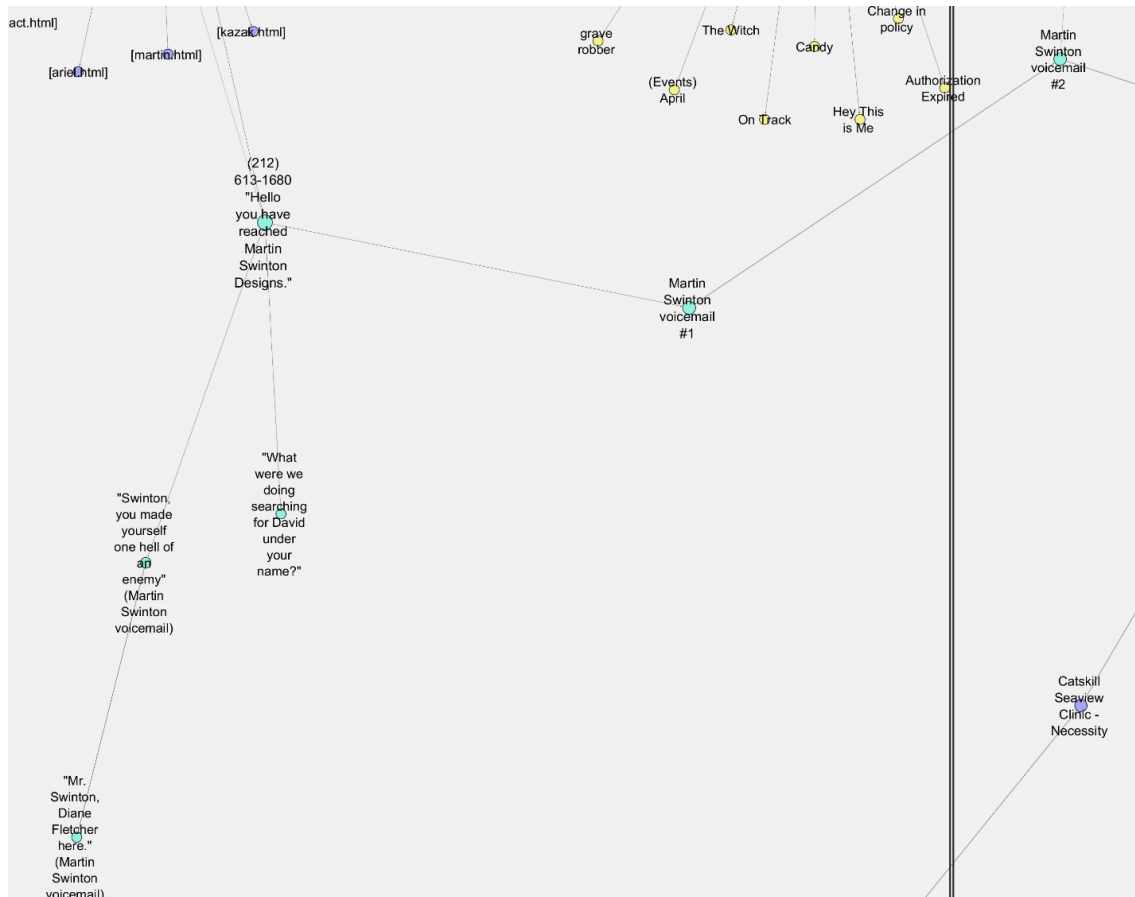


Figure 22: Close-up view of the subnetwork of sites representing the voicemail of Martin Swinton.

A third prominent group of story fragments can be identified as the voicemail messages of Martin Swinton. After calling the phone number on his website, the VUPs needed to enter a password, which could be found in a document attached to one of his diary entries. From there, the VUPs could access particular voicemail messages either instantly after discovering the site or – the ones on the left-hand side – had to wait until further updates arrived in the storyworld. It is worth noting that all four of these voicemails present in zone number 3 relate to Martin's relationship with David, the protagonist soon to be introduced by the movie. Interestingly enough, from the second archived voicemail, the messages elaborate on Martin's relationship with his mother and the Catskill Seaview Clinic, thus further strengthening the thematic demarcation between zones 3 and 4.

Differentiating between the periphery and the central regions of the transmedia network revealed the storytelling regions where the fragments either pointed outward toward external narrative entities or independently significant real-life events. However, moving on to zones 1 and 2 presents an almost undecipherable complexity as these segments contain the main storytelling hubs. Looking at these more central

nodes, one can immediately tell that the prefuse force-directed simulation positioned the sites, demonstrating higher betweenness centrality in the system. To reiterate, a higher betweenness centrality value is attributed to those nodes in a network that serve as an intermediary element between two other nodes. In the case of a transmedia storytelling network, a site thus has a higher betweenness centrality if this particular site is essential to create a connection between two story fragments.

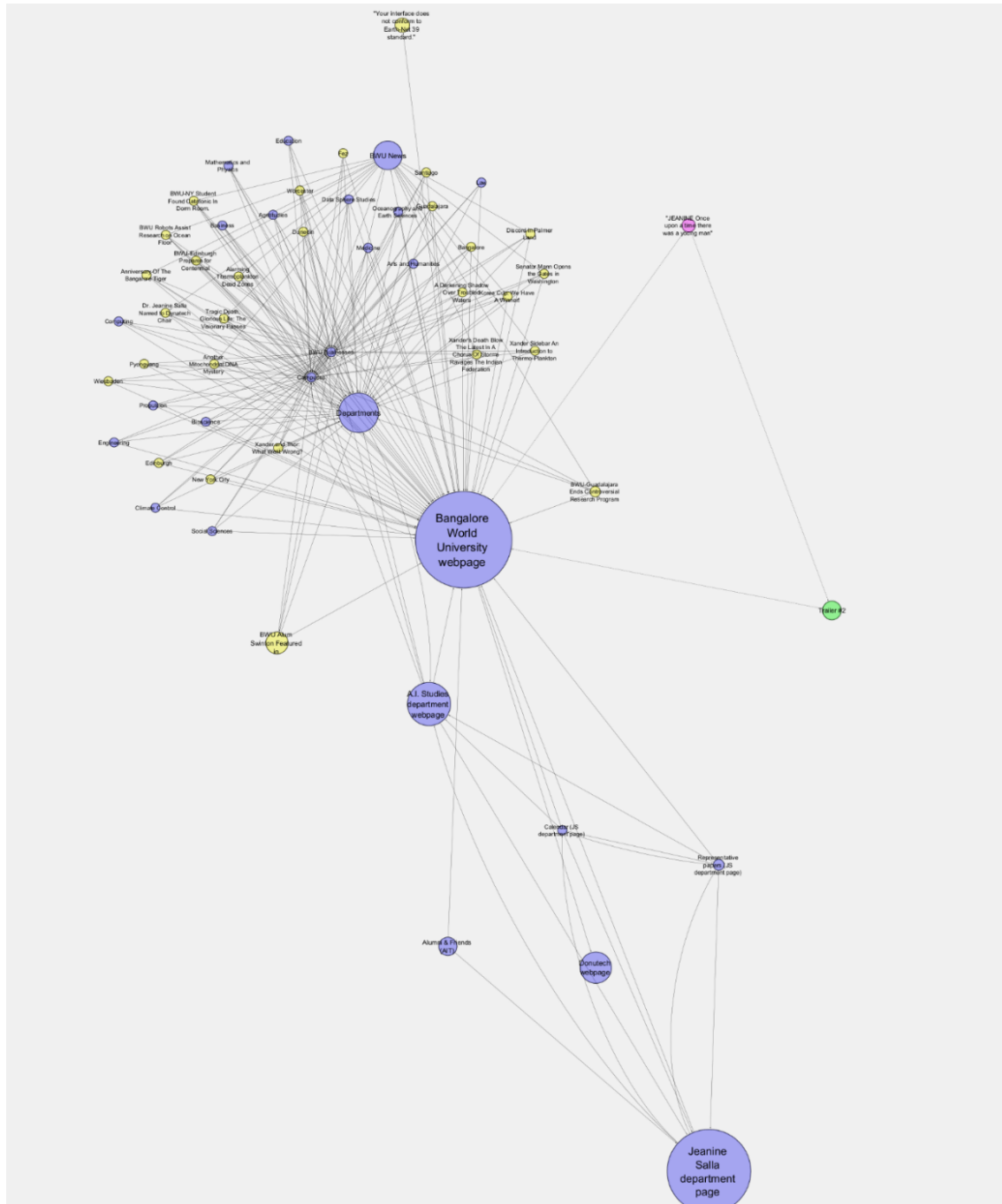


Figure 23: Close-up and isolated view of the Bangalore World University webpage's subnetwork.

In zone number 1 and the whole network, the Bangalore World University webpage has the largest betweenness centrality of the system (35,297). This would mean that from a data-analytical standpoint, this node is present in the center of the two-node interaction. This is essentially true; however, after closer inspection, one can discern a huge disparity between the in- and out-degrees of BWU's website. Of its 68 edges, 61 can be counted as in-degree and only seven as out-degree. That means there are only seven paths a VUP can take to other sites.

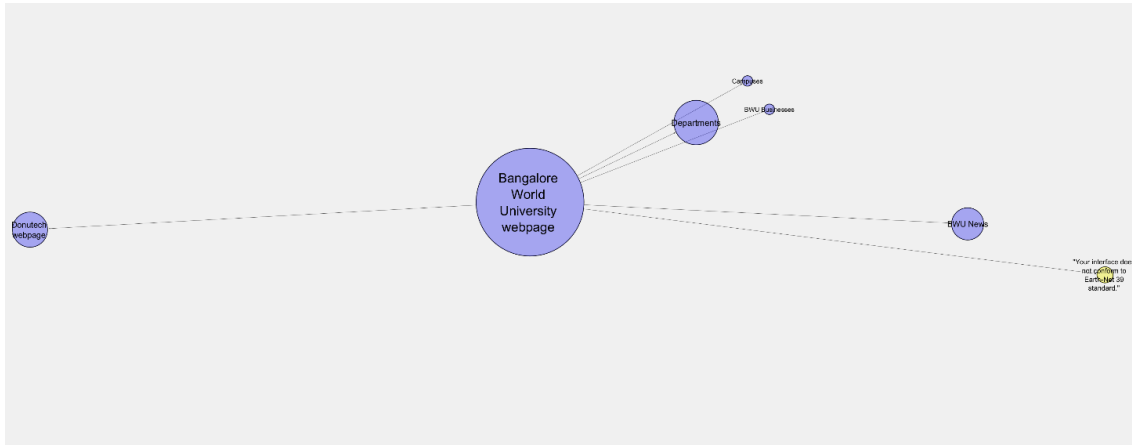


Figure 24: Isolated close-up view of the sites connected to the Bangalore World University webpage with an edge directed toward them.

I argue that this specific node's betweenness centrality is amassed through the massive number of sub-pages (articles) that point back toward the university's central page, confirming with every possible click that this should be recognized as an informational hub in the system. With the virtual movement of the VUPs, this dynamic of the recipient affirms and reaffirms the centrality of the BWU webpage both in the system and in the narrative.

Finally, I also argue that presenting a higher value of betweenness centrality in a storytelling system can also prove to be an indicator of the site being a trailhead, a “rabbit hole,” or a gateway towards a certain sub-narrative that couldn’t be easily accessed through other avenues. It was, for example, recorded in the collaborative document created to log the journey of the community of VUPs that the entrance to the storyworld, although through different paths, but in both cases, it was considered to be the Bangalore World University’s website.⁵⁴⁹ Jeanine Salla’s department page was especially important during the first leg of the storytelling, as her name was the first clue that prompted that “the game is afoot.”⁵⁵⁰

5.3.1 Topological Structures of Transmedia Networks

Apart from analyzing the narratological significance of different network properties of the specific elements of a network, other theorists were interrogated on the topological implications (or at least their possible visualizations) of complex storytelling systems as well. In *Avatars of Story*,⁵⁵¹ Marie-Laure Ryan was already looking into representations of interactive and traditional narratives. She proposes different alternatives to visualize plots in a storyworld in her text: 1) as a state-transition diagram, 2) as the interplay between actual and virtual events, 3) as interwoven destiny lines, and 4) as traversal of the storyworld.⁵⁵² She also accounts for narratives where the temporality of the plot is less important to represent than the actual flow of information or communication between the narrative elements. Ryan also refers to the model of networks as a viable tool for efficiently recognizing structures that affect the narrative discourse.

Here, she accounts for the network's “architecture,” the vector with side branches, the sea anemone, and the track-switching.⁵⁵³ As she explains:

The network is the most common pattern for discourse-level interactivity, but it is not the only one. [...] the vector with side-branches, takes the reader through the story sequentially, but every episode offers an opportunity to branch toward external materials or optional activities that enrich the story. The radiating structure of [the] “sea-anemone,” allows information to unfold recursively from a main menu into a variety of submenus. From each point on the diagram, the user can return to the main menu in one jump. Widely used in informational Web sites, the radiating pattern has no special affinities for narrative but [...] it can be put in the service of what Raine Koskimaa calls “archival narratives”: stories that the reader reconstructs, not through random travel through a network but by consulting a well-organized database of documents. [Track switching] shows how a braided narrative such as [the plot as interwoven destiny lines] can be made interactive through a track-switching system.

⁵⁴⁹ <https://web.archive.org/web/20020802064140/http://www.cloudmakers.org/guide/> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 17.)

⁵⁵⁰ Antero Garcia and Greg Niemeyer, eds., *Alternate Reality Games and the Cusp of Digital Gameplay* (Bloomsbury Academic, 2018), 225.

⁵⁵¹ Marie-Laure Ryan, *Avatars of Story* (University of Minnesota Press, 2006).

⁵⁵² Ryan, *Avatars of Story*, 101.

⁵⁵³ Ryan, *Avatars of Story*, 103.

*Every strand is linked to every other strand at certain decision points, but the links follow the temporal flow of the story and never take the reader back in time.*⁵⁵⁴

Of course, Ryan argues that these patterns and structures can be combined to create stories of higher complexity. In this work, however, she does not account for transmedia storytelling networks; instead, she looks for analytical methods for traditional and interactive forms of monomedial storytelling, such as hypertext novels. This means that although the structures closely resemble the architecture of a transmedia network, Ryan, in this text, does not build these models with sites of storytelling in mind but either from events in the plot or storyworld or from lexias⁵⁵⁵ of a hypertext work.

However, I argue that even if Marie-Laure Ryan did not mention transmedia systems, the connection structures in a transmedia narrative can be read similarly to the networks she analyzed. On the other hand, Marc Ruppel further expanded the methodological framework for the structures of narrative networks in his dissertation, pointing out basic topological forms that need to be addressed during our analyses.

Ruppel introduced the “dyadic” and “triadic” relationships between the sites of a transmedia work through his case study of *Skeleton Creek*.⁵⁵⁶ The former refers to the simplest topological structures in a transmedia network, where the unidirectional movement between two sites creates a one-to-one connection, establishing a source-target link that is vulnerable to dissolution in case one of the vertices is compromised.⁵⁵⁷

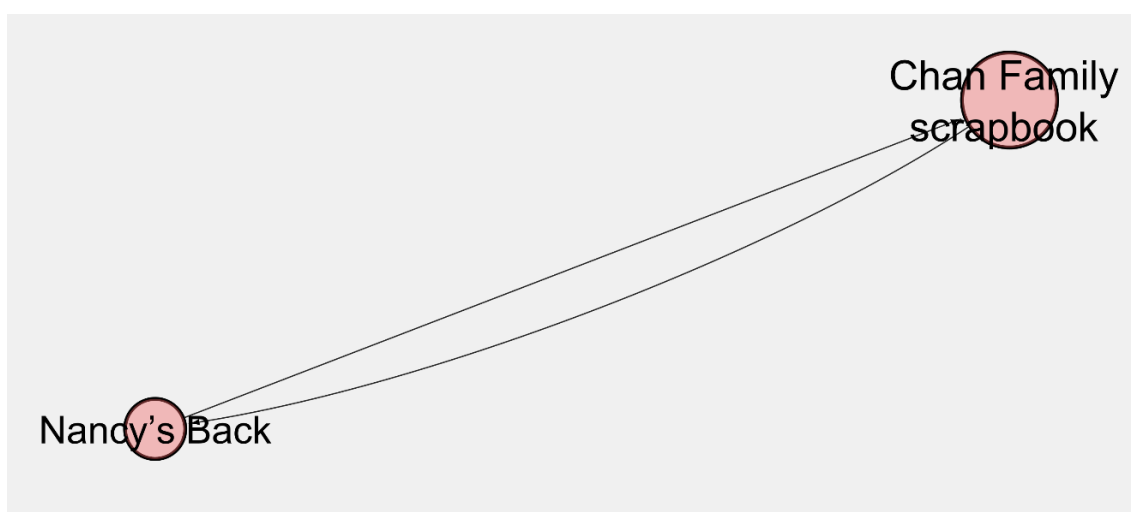


Figure 26: Isolated close-up view of the dyadic relationship between two sites in the network.

⁵⁵⁴ Ryan, *Avatars of Story*, 103–4.

⁵⁵⁵ N. Katherine Hayles, “The Transformation of Narrative and the Materiality of Hypertext,” *Narrative* 9, no. 1 (2001): 22, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/20107227>.

⁵⁵⁶ Patrick Carmen, *Skeleton Creek* (International Literary Properties, 2016).

⁵⁵⁷ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 170–71.

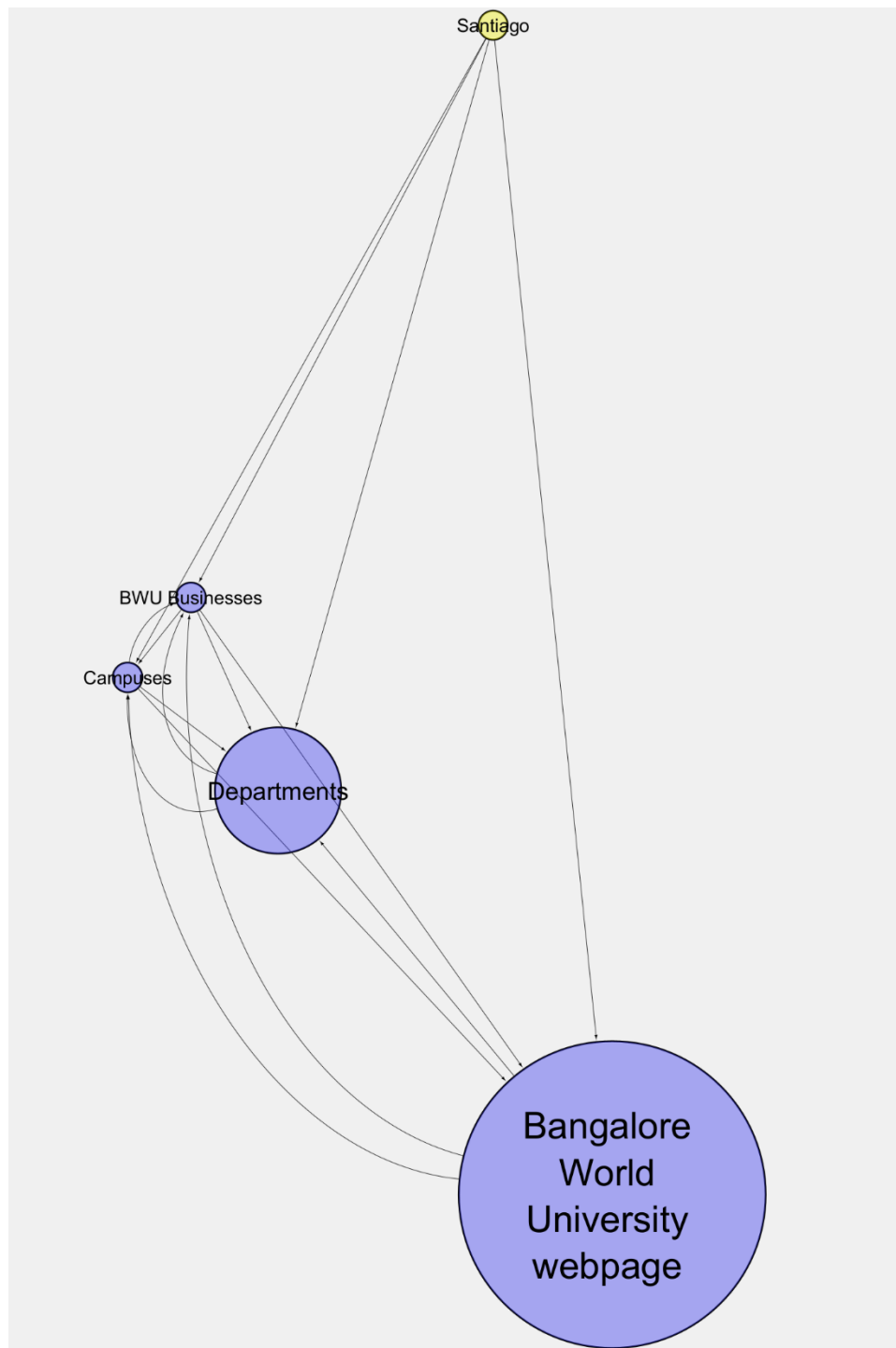


Figure 27: Isolated close-up view of a subnetwork demonstrating a triadic relationship between sites.

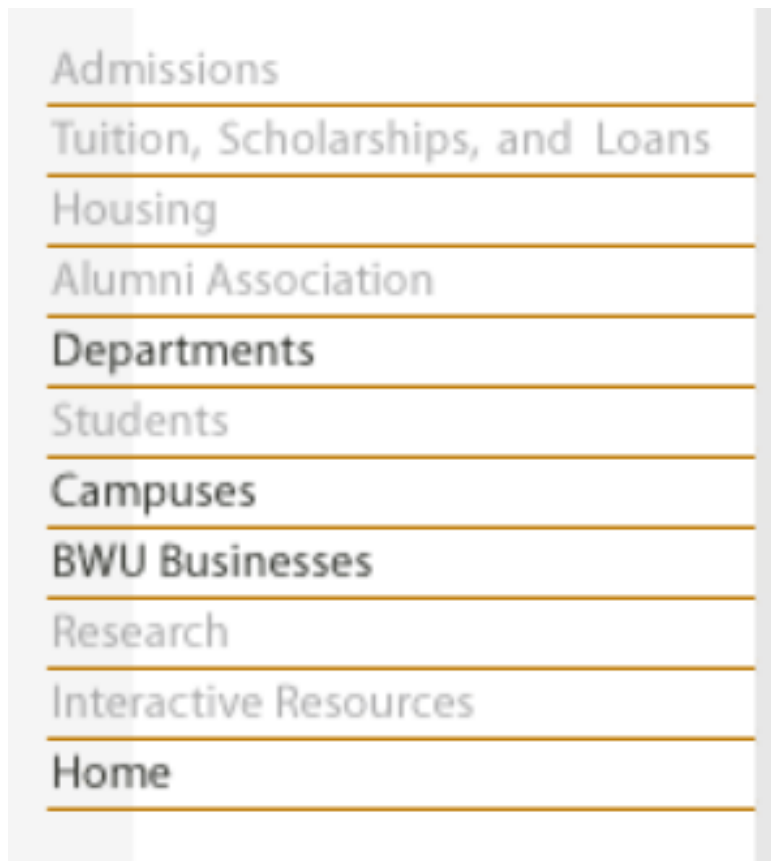


Figure 28: Cropped screenshot of the navigation sidebar on the Bangalore World University website.

In the case of *The Beast*, there certainly are examples of dyadic relationships in the network; however, these structures do not dominate the network, as with *Skeleton Creek*.⁵⁵⁸ *The Beast*, a heavily web-based ARG, establishes reciprocal dyadic structures in the cases of primary sites and their sub-pages. For example, the enlarged versions of the photographs uploaded to the “Chan Family Scrapbook” site are positioned this way. Still, it is also worth noting that it bears little to no narrative significance. On the other hand, there are more complex structures in the transmedia system where dyadic structures can be identified. However, the site in question is not so vulnerable to disruptions because, as in the case of the “Campuses” site (which is a sub-page of the broadly defined platform of BWU), we can reach it via the “Departments” site (and vice versa); however, it is not exclusively tied to that specific sub-page, as it can be accessed through the BWU main website as well thanks to the navigation sidebar. As simplistic as this argument may seem, it is essential to note that online navigational structures such as this enhance the flow of narrative information.

Ruppel argues, “the dyadic relationship the dyadic relationships of networks form the minimal conditions through which a network can be formed (i.e. a link and two vertices), the dyad is in itself not a network but, rather, only a unit through which a network can begin, a relationship between two sites that can then extend outward,”⁵⁵⁹ and thus he builds upon⁵⁶⁰ Georg Simmel’s work⁵⁶¹ (among others) to define a more

⁵⁵⁸ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 175–76.

⁵⁵⁹ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 178–79.

⁵⁶⁰ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 180.

⁵⁶¹ Georg Simmel, *The Sociology of Georg Simmel* (Simon and Schuster, 1950), 153.

substantial structure in transmedia works, the triad, which – in sociological context – introduces a “broker” in a relationship between two nodes of a network. From another perspective, a “dyad shows how a vertex affects another vertex”⁵⁶² while the “triad, then is the ‘basic essence of a network’ that allows for behavioral analyses in that it is three unique vertices and two unique links.”⁵⁶³

It is also pointed out that this condition would create an “open” triad in a network of A, B, and C where the edges are AB and AC, but we cannot identify the edge BC. In this case, we have a triad at hand. However, we do not have a final link between the two nodes that would close the informational circuit, rendering vertex A as a node of higher importance.⁵⁶⁴ From a sociological standpoint, these are the profitable gaps to close. Still, from the approach of transmedia storytelling systems, the sites creating these gaps are worth looking at as these are essentially non-accessible from inside the storyworld.

Keystone Sites

In transmedia storytelling networks, we can identify another peculiar structure that is most easily identifiable by applying a network-conscious analysis. These are the sites or nodes with zero edges pointing towards it but at least one pointing outwards toward another site. I call these structures “keystone sites” as points in the story that are unique to a system and keep archways open (or supports) toward further fragments of the storyworld. These are not necessarily trailheads nor the very edges of a narrative; however, I argue they all present unique opportunities for the VUPs to engage with the storyworld. In the case of *The Beast*, the network accounts for four separate sites that don’t have in-degrees, only out-degrees. They are referred to as:

1. Jeanine Salla business card,
2. Beelzebub email,
3. Catskill Seaview Clinic – Lode,
4. Teddy sound file / call.

The first is an entry in the form of a physical object distributed among the audience members who had the opportunity to participate in a talk between *A.I.*’s producer and leading actor at MIT on April 30th, 2001. As the Cloudmakers’ community guide explains:

⁵⁶² Thomas Y. Choi and Zhaohui Wu, “Taking the Leap from Dyads to Triads: Buyer–Supplier Relationships in Supply Networks,” *Journal of Purchasing and Supply Management* 15, no. 4 (2009): 263, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.pursup.2009.08.003>.

⁵⁶³ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 180.

⁵⁶⁴ Ruppel, “Visualizing Transmedia Networks: Links, Paths and Peripheries,” 181.

One side is in English, and tells us nothing new - her job position, phone number, website. The other side is in a language called Kannada (a dialect spoken in Southern India, i.e. Bangalore). The translation of the Kannada side is as follows: Instead of Cybertronics/Dynatech Chair in Computational Psychology, the text on the right translates as “God/Queen Proud Throne.” Instead of Bangalore World University we have “Bangalore World Factory.” Instead of New York City we have “New Hell.” And, instead of the URL at the bottom, we have “Old Spanish Dust.”⁵⁶⁵

On one hand, the business card is directly connected to Jeanine Salla’s department page at Bangalore World University. New recipients or VUPs who are not yet familiar with the storyworld might directly try to find some sense regarding the information presented in English, thus finding out about the BWU and successfully entering into the elaborate transmedia network through this trailhead. On the other hand, the Kannada text guides the rest of the community and the VUPs with higher involvement to a yet unknown site in the system (<http://www.bangaloreworldu-in.co.nz/salla/old-spanishdust>) with story elements that serve as a new addition to the whole. This triad thus serves a double purpose: 1) as a rabbit hole and 2) as a potent site (in the sense that it almost unambiguously presents itself as a puzzle) that grants access to new narrative knowledge.

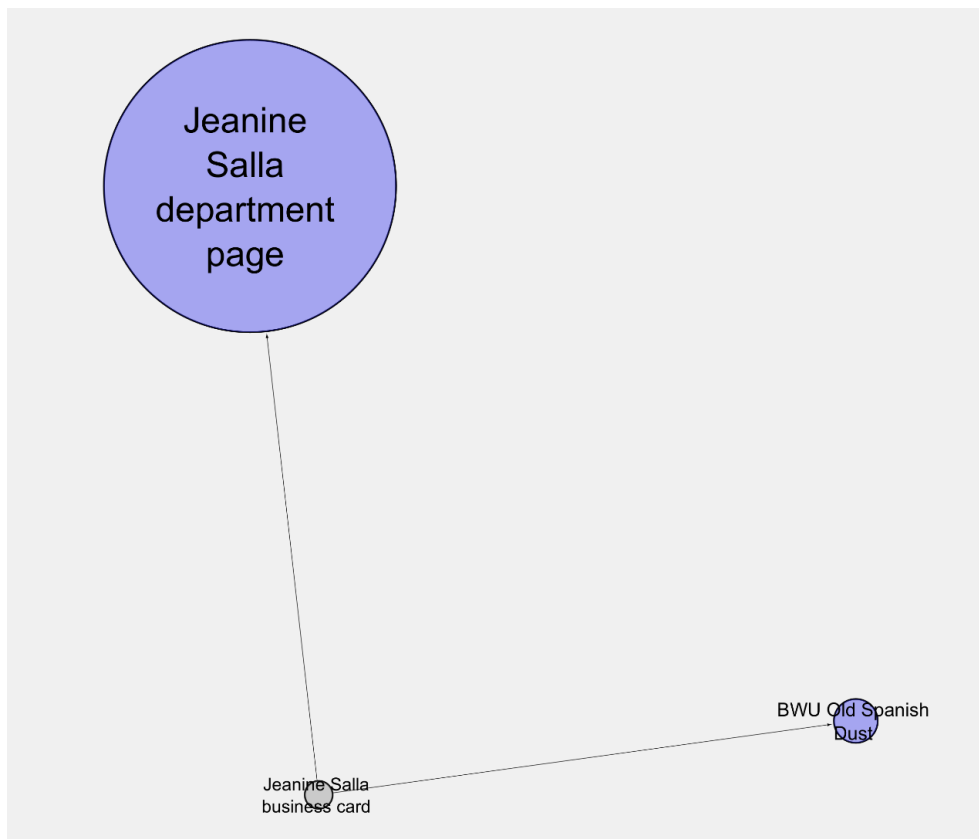


Figure 29: Isolated close-up view of sites directly connected to the Jeanine Salla business card key-stone site.

⁵⁶⁵ <https://web.archive.org/web/20020811182355/http://www.cloudmakers.org/guide/index2.shtml#3.0loki> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 24.)

The second keystone site is the Beelzebub email, a cryptic message sent to a particular circle of VUPs during the ARG. Adrian Hon, author of *The Guide X: A Tale of the A.I. Trail*, explained that they figured it was sent to contributors who solved the so-called BWU Mowz puzzles very well.⁵⁶⁶ The e-mail⁵⁶⁷ was sent with the subject line “Help.” It contained quotations from one of Uncle Remus’ tales, “*The Tar Baby*,” and some hidden texts and pictures that all lead to the pages Cloudmakers.org and Spherewatch.net. As this dissertation has referred to quite a few times, the former was the most significant community around the ARG, while the latter was a fan site dedicated to puzzle-solving and roleplaying. According to the community, this message might point to the storyworld wanting these highly involved VUPs to take a more active role in resolving the fictional conflicts. However, there were no further links or such direct internal migratory cues as a reference to a new website or another site of the storyworld. As the act of the unique keystone site, this gesture drew the community of VUPs (moreover, it was targeted at the most involved individuals) closer to the storyworld, further acknowledging their existence as acts that are part of the diegesis.

⁵⁶⁶ See: <https://web.archive.org/web/20020811182355/http://www.cloudmakers.org/guide/index2.shtml#bwumowz> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 24.)

⁵⁶⁷ See: <https://web.archive.org/web/20020811182836/http://www.cloudmakers.org/guide/index3.shtml#8.0beel> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 24.)

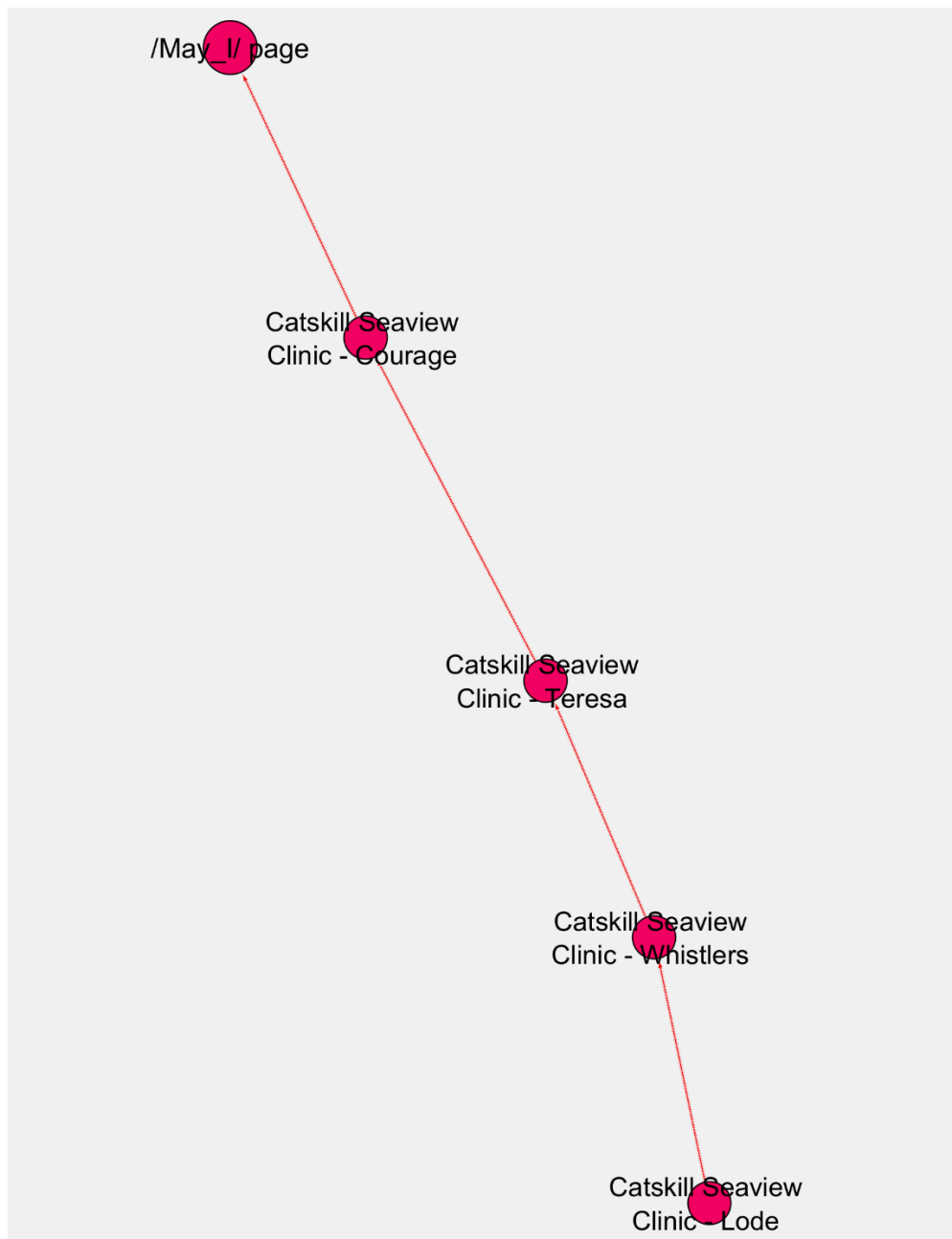


Figure 30: Highlighted and isolated sites near the Catskill Seaview Clinic – Lode keystone site.

The third keystone is the network's Catskill Seaview Clinic – Lode site. It is positioned as the point of origin of the sequential fragments of a transcript that records an interview between Jane Sutter and Monica Swinton. This dissertation partially discussed these textual fragments when zone number 3 was under scrutiny. This time, it is essential to notice that if a VUP pieces together these interview segments, [catskill-seaviewclinic.org/lode](http://catskillseaviewclinic.cloud-makers.org/lode/)⁵⁶⁸ would be the first sequence of the puzzle. Moreover, although some of the slugs of these fragments directly come from internal migratory cues embedded in other sites (e.g., *goose*, *may_i*, etc.), “lode” specifically has no such reference. The VUPs had to access this page through trial and error with the only contextual clue of noticing the recurring theme of “mother” in the more accessible

⁵⁶⁸ See: <https://web.archive.org/web/20020812112221/http://catskillseaviewclinic.cloud-makers.org/lode/> (last accessed: 2025. 02. 24.)

“goose” and “may_i” pages, figuring that *mother lode* could be another viable slug to explore. This high degree of trust in the VUP community renders this discovery an exceptional narrative moment in the system.

This analysis accounts for the fourth and final keystone site, the network's Teddy sound file/call node. It is a real-life phone call from a toy in the storyworld, Teddy, who plays a vital role in a subsequent puzzle, which the community calls “Eliza’s Tearoom.” When the VUPs first encounter this site, they must navigate through a series of questions to receive clues and internal migratory cues toward the Catskill Seaview Clinic, where, as one would find out, Eliza was employed as the first AI therapist in-house. This specific call, however, comes to some VUPs on July 6, 2001, which proves to be a reference or request to return to Eliza’s Tearoom at least 3 months from the community’s first encounter with that site. This node proved an efficient and direct call-to-action for the VUPs late in the narrative, serving as another imported gateway towards new narrative fragments.

In conclusion, the keystone sites are proving to be elements of a transmedia storytelling network where one could experience an elevated and concentrated VUP involvement. These narrative segments require special actions to uncover new sites and new knowledge about the storyworld. However, they do not have internal migratory cues to access, so they can be described as nodes without in-degree and at least an out-degree of 1. These sites are either activated and opened up by the puppet masters (like in the case of the Teddy call) or accessed by chance, trial and error, or by a problematic discovery process.

Hubs and spokes

Identifying larger structures than dyads and triads of a network can point to narratologically significant groups of sites that serve their specific functions in the storyworld. We can consider those sites hubs with more connections to other sites in the system; however, this on its own may not be enough to be considered a center of a concentration of sites. Barabási argues that scale-free networks contain several hubs and several higher-importance nodes that serve as the pillars of a robust network that provides high connectivity between its members. However, this serves as the Achilles heel of these structures while continuing to be their most substantial property.⁵⁶⁹

Similar to Barabási’s argument, vast transmedia storytelling systems, such as ARGs, also present these hubs for investigation. Few papers provide a framework for identifying centers of hubs from an analytical standpoint;⁵⁷⁰ however, for the sake of clarity, I propose a heuristic approach: if we take those nodes that have an unnormalized betweenness centrality higher than one (ensuring that the node is on at least one shortest path between two nodes), while, on the other hand, it has a degree of 3 or more (ensuring that we are not talking about a dyad or a triad with degrees of one and two respectively).

⁵⁶⁹ Barabási, *Linked*, 103, 113, 117.

⁵⁷⁰ One of them might be M.E. O’Kelly et al., “Hub Network Design with Single and Multiple Allocation: A Computational Study,” *Location Science* 4, no. 3 (1996): 125–38, [https://doi.org/10.1016/S0966-8349\(96\)00015-0](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0966-8349(96)00015-0).

In the case of *The Beast*, this heuristic analysis narrowed the points of interest to 80 sites, which all can be regarded as central nodes to a group of sites. From this pool of nodes, the higher a member's betweenness centrality is, the easier it is to designate as one being a central hub for their local spokes in the system, where spokes can be defined as the first (or, in some cases, even second) degree neighbor of the hub node. In a web-based ARG such as *The Beast*, it is unsurprising that most of these hub nodes are home pages or landing pages of narratologically significant websites.

Going one step further, one can identify two distinctively different types of hub and spokes structures in transmedia networks. The first can be described as the star structure, where the neighbors of the hubs are not connected, or the flow of narrative information is far from seamless between them. The second can be referred to as the hub-and-mesh structure, where the spokes are interconnected; thus, despite being sites of lower importance, the flow of narrative information is secured through established routes.

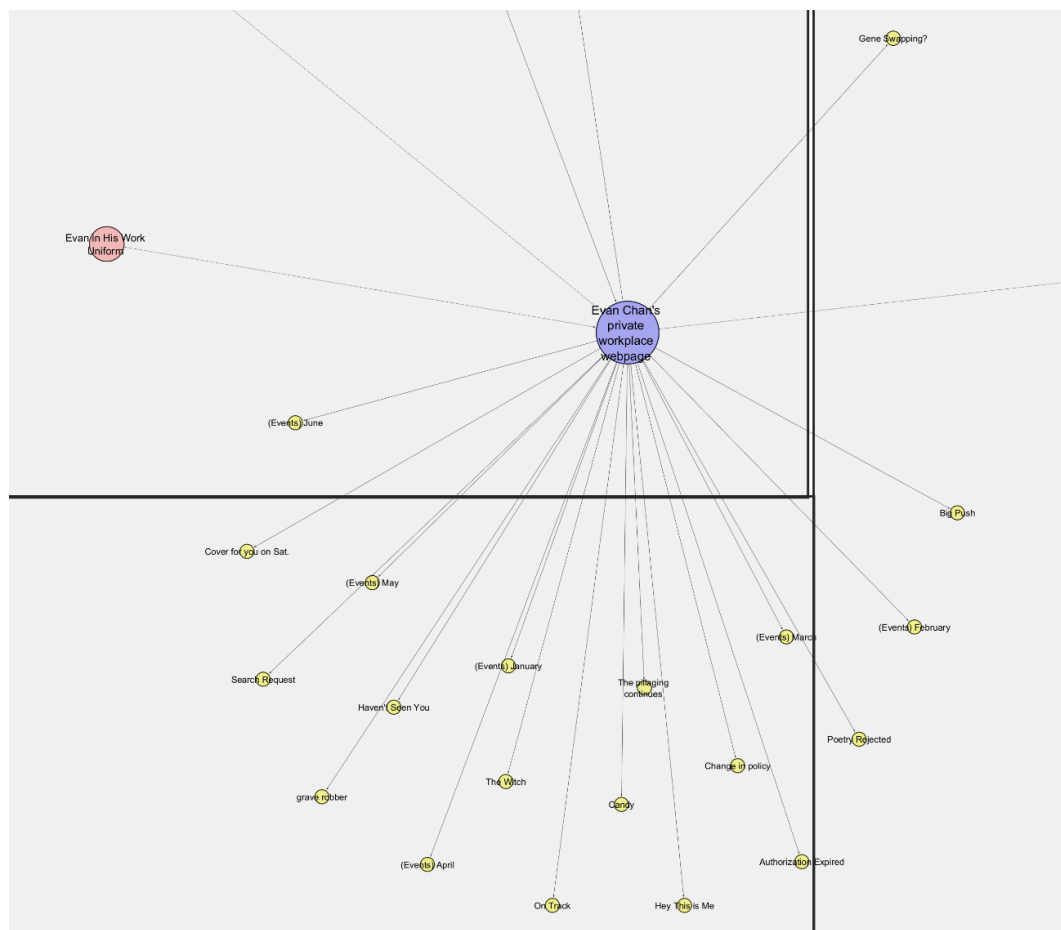


Figure 31: Isolated close-up view of sites directly connected to the Evan Chan's private workplace webpage.

An example of the star structure is Evan Chan's private workplace webpage, through which the VUPs can primarily access various e-mails sent to Evan Chan's workplace address, among other sites. If we take the e-mails predominantly under scrutiny, as the most prominent sites connected to the hub, one could argue that as this structure is less robust, if one of the nodes becomes corrupted, there is almost no way to

rebuild it using narrative information of the other sites. This elevates the significance of the individual points of the story, propagating deeper engagement with the specific site while reducing the sense of interconnectedness. It can be more of a tool for building the plot rather than the wider fabula.

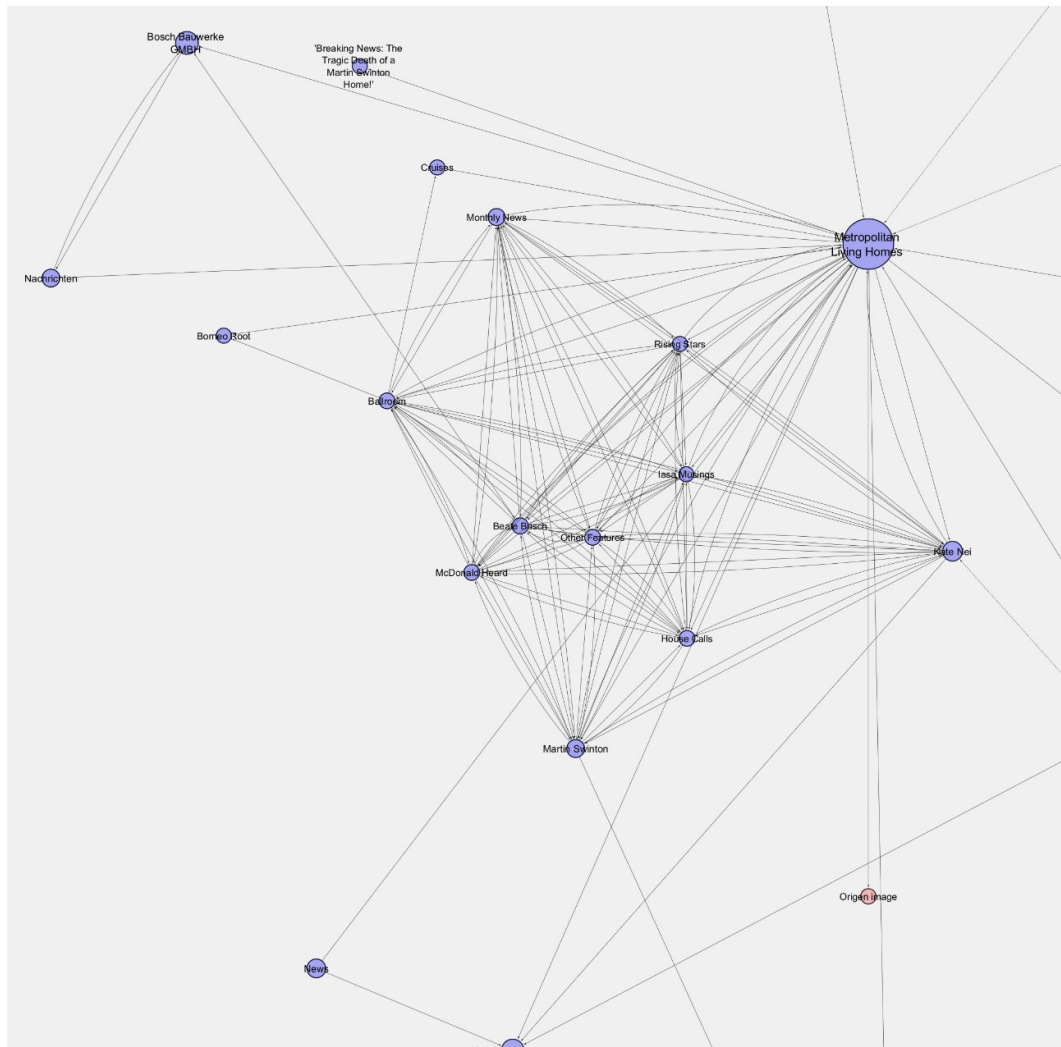


Figure 32: Close-up view of the Metropolitan Living Homes subnetwork as an example of the hub-and-mesh structure.

The Beast provides the Metropolitan Living Homes site as an example of the hub-and-mesh structure. In this case, we can witness another usual form of relationship structure between sites on the Internet: a topological order where the sub-sites, or the spokes, remain accessible. Most of the time, these structures emerge from using a navigation bar; other times, they emerge through the extensive number of hyperlinks (a usual practice of online journalism, for example) between them. Metropolitan Living Homes contain an almost always present menu bar to enhance the ease of navigation between its sub-sites, and this is the strategy that creates the structure of the mesh between the individual fragments of the narrative instead of keeping the sites isolated, in a way, from each other.

This mimicking of the mesh of online journalism cannot even be regarded as a far-fetched concept since Metropolitan Living Homes defines itself as a journal with at least 600 published issues. Unlike Evan Chan's e-mails, these sites are connected by the menu, creating a sense that something is shared between these sub-pages. If a site becomes corrupted, one could at least have solid ideas about what it was about: establishing that the sites with names (e.g., Kate Nei, Martin Swinton, Beate Bosch) are all describing architects of the storyworld, so if one could not access Kate Nei's site, there could still be quite a few narrative information to be inferred from the neighboring sites. I argue that these structures propagate the survey of the sites, taking a walk in a narratological landscape; they prove to be more successful in establishing or expanding the storyworld, the fabula of the transmedia narrative.

Spools and Threads

A final crucial topological structure of the transmedia networks should be accounted for, which is not to be identified on the micro level (such as the dyads and triads) and is not structured as the hub-and-spokes subsystems. These are the bridges and connective paths between parts of higher site density in these networks: the structure of threads and spools.

I use these objects as metaphors to illustrate the description of functions of the sites that consist of these structures: the spools should be considered as the anchor point for a series of connected sites, points in the system that keep the thread organized and tethered to the more central parts of the network. Threads, therefore, are linked narrative fragments that are only connected but are not directly related to other parts of the transmedia story.

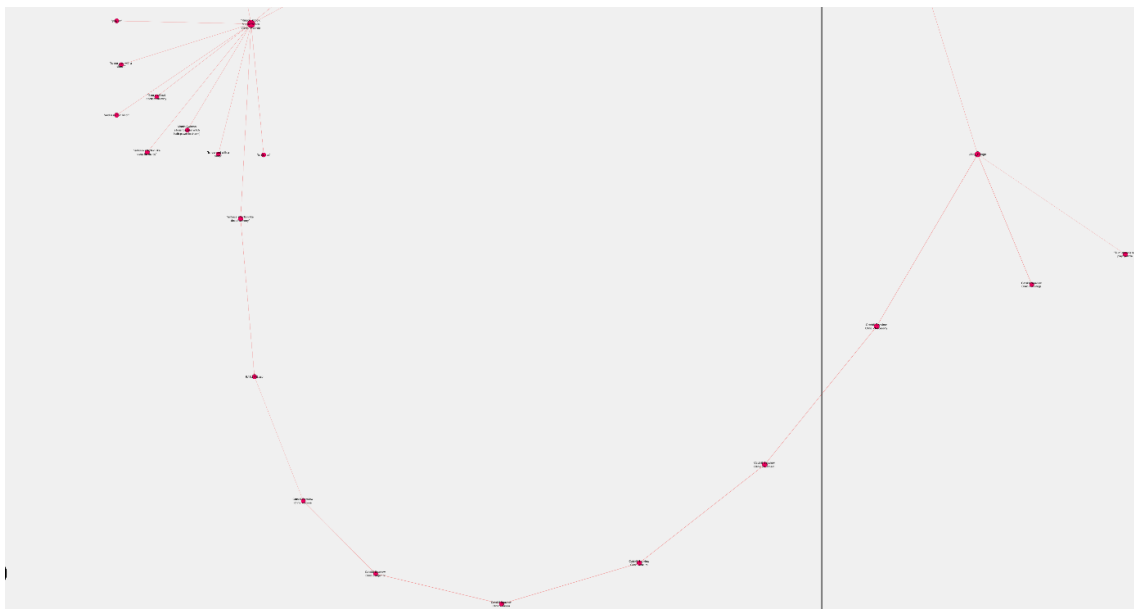


Figure 33: Isolated, highlighted, and close-up view of the network's bridge-type spool and thread structure.

In the case of the previously cited work of Broder et al., one of the first visualizations of the internet was accounting for specific continents that in some way resemble the first, heuristic, visual segmentation of transmedia storytelling networks as well. This work, besides identifying a dense, central component (SCC, or *strongly connected*

component), the IN continent (nodes of the world wide web that were using links to websites of the SCC without reciprocation), the OUT continent (which was the inverse of the IN continent), tubes (or connections between the nodes of the IN and OUT continent that did not “touch” the SCC), disconnected components, they also pointed out the existence of the TENDRIL components, that contained pages that could not reach the SCC, and could not be reached from the SCC either.⁵⁷¹

These TENDRILS are similar to the threads of transmedia storytelling systems in their position in the network. Although threads and spools can be discovered in the middle of the densest segments of the transmedia visualization, looking at a subsystem level, these threads always behave as autonomous parts of the system, rendering them primarily interpretable independently. Metaphorically speaking, TENDRILS behaves similarly to this.

These identifiable parts of a storytelling system can be defined as a series of at least three nodes, from which at least one and a maximum of two (but unconnected nodes) have a degree value higher than two (thus more complex than a triad) with a direct connection to at least one site that has a betweenness centrality value higher than zero.⁵⁷² At least one node has a degree value of precisely two (thus a dyad). This definition allows three types of spool and thread structures to form: tendril, bridge, and loop.

Tendrils consist of one spool (a site with a degree higher than two) with at least two further sites arranged into a thread structure. These structures can be single lines of thought, a series of websites linked to each other with a dead end rounding off the sequence, or visualizations of spinoff stories without proper connection to the origin story.

⁵⁷¹ Broder et al., “Graph Structure in the Web,” 310.

⁵⁷² It is important to specify this extra clause in the definition, as from a narratological standpoint, we cannot identify a site as a spool (the site that anchors a series of narrative fragments to the center of storytelling) if it has a higher-than-two-degree value; however, it is only connected to a single dead end.

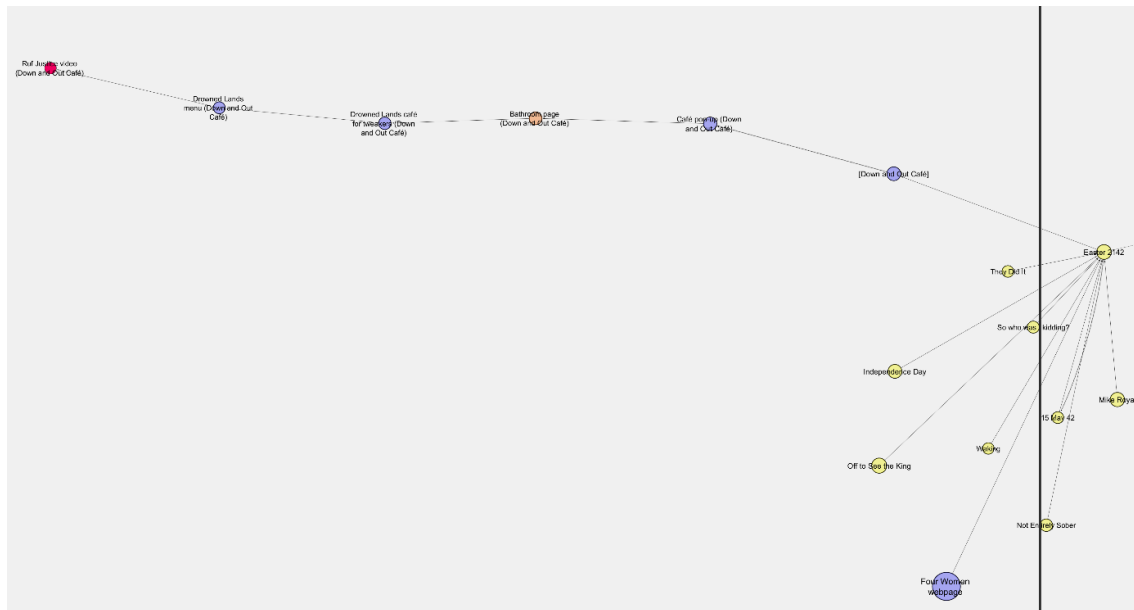


Figure 34: Isolated and close-up view of one of the network's tendrils-style spool and thread structure.

In *The Beast*, many examples of tendrils exist – one is the series of puzzles around a fictional café, the Down and Out Café. The establishment was first mentioned in one of Laia's writings (*Easter 2142*), and according to the Cloudmakers' testimony,⁵⁷³ after a series of trial and error, the VUPs could find its website.⁵⁷⁴ Through a series of sites, the recipients were required to click on specific items on a series of webpages, which in the end guided them to a footage that gave the narrative information to the VUPs about the disabling of a robot (Diane Fletcher) that was hired to track down other rogue robots. Uncovering this truth is not essential to understanding the main storylines. However, it enhances the transmedia experience. Hence, it is arranged in a tendrils-type spool and thread structure where the spool is the *Easter 2142* site, and the thread is the series of subsequent websites.

Bridges consist of two spools with at least a single dyad between them. These structures are storylines that deliver narrative information from one part of the transmedia system to another. They are the parts of stories that help the VUPs understand how one segment is connected to another. Using these pathways, interpretations around the proximity of one spool can be completed or enhanced with the knowledge gathered from the proximity of the other spool: an easily understandable example could be a simplification of *The Matrix* franchise for our illustration's sake. The connection between the animated short film *Final Flight of the Osiris* and the second movie *The Matrix Reloaded* can be fully embraced and understood if a VUP plays the video game *Enter the Matrix*.

The previously but hastily mentioned “Knock, knock, knock! Who's there,” pop-up site can be accessed directly from Martin Swinton's website, a hub in its own right. It can guide the VUPs through the site “enforce attention like harmony” into a series of

⁵⁷³ <https://web.archive.org/web/20020811182845/http://www.cloudmakers.org/guide/index4.shtml#10cafe> (last accessed: 2025. 03. 02.)

⁵⁷⁴ <https://web.archive.org/web/20020811182845/http://downandoutcafe.cloudmakers.org/> (last accessed: 2025. 03. 02.)

dyads, the other end of which can be identified as the /May_I/ page or the Catskill Seaview Clinic by extent. This is one of the examples of bridge-type spool and thread structures in *The Beast*. As discussed in the previous chapters, it creates a narrative connection between Martin Swinton, the clinic, and his mother. The connection between these two story elements would still be established in this case. However, I argue that this bridge enhances redundancy and elevates or emphasizes the importance of the link between Martin Swinton and the Catskill Seaview Clinic.

Loops start as tendrils, but the last member of the series of sites connects back to the point of origin – the spool. One could identify every triad as loop-type spool and thread structures, though, their potential and impact on the storyworld because I would argue that as the VUPs are navigating from dyad to dyad along the thread more and more narrative information is gained by them to arrive back at the spool finally, and to apply all these knowledge to this original and the proximity of this site. So, if the thread is longer, there are more opportunities to gain narrative information, and a snowball effect starts to form. Loops can be, on the one hand, seen as structures to reframe parts of a transmedia narrative: the VUP starts to follow a storyline, a narrative thread that emerged from a specific site, as they move forward, they gather narrative fragments that are indirectly connected through a series of dyads to the spool which started off this journey, and when they are finally directly linked back to the point of origin, they know more about this site's content, or at least, they see it in a different light. On the other hand, however, these loops can also serve as a group of sites emphasizing iterative practices, focus, and contemplation – going around and around until the VUP gathers enough knowledge to move on. These sites connected into a closed loop are propagating repetition, emphasizing the need to linger more and further studies.

One of the most significant loops in *The Beast* is the series of pictures linked to each other through hidden hyperlinks on their respective websites. The VUPs needed to revisit the site *Another Stone* (another iterative practice) to access this loop.⁵⁷⁵ There appeared a yet unknown hyperlink navigating to the page and site 1.htm – this serves as the spool of the thread. From here, one may jump from page to page (1.htm to 7.htm) to return to the origin point after the last site. These sites were web pages containing pictures of Jeanine Salla with their specific parts cut off. It was later figured out that the images represented different letters to the word “Jane Doe,” which provided further cues for the VUPs.

⁵⁷⁵ <https://web.archive.org/web/20020810181042/http://familiasalla-es.cloudmakers.org/anotherstone.htm> (last accessed: 2025. 03. 03.)



Figure 35: Archived image that was shown on the 5.htm site.

The previous chapters pointed out that transmedia narratives can be interpreted and visualized as networks. They also demonstrated that this novel approach is not alien to complex systems, such as these vast storytelling systems. However, apart from a few experiments and explorations, it remains an underdeveloped direction. Identifying the underlying structures, sub-networks, and key constituents of these narratives, understanding their relations to each other, and how specific network properties can enrich our interpretations and analysis is invaluable if one would like to tackle such complex structures as ARGs or other contemporary narratives with multiple interconnected sites.

Transmedia practices, intentionally or not, are becoming increasingly common and permeating our everyday lives, much like Barabási's observation that networks are now everywhere. Thus, it becomes increasingly important to formulate a wide range of questions and a set of tools to brandish against these systems of content. On the one hand, understanding how these narratives function as information systems can reveal unseen connections and potentially harmful (or even malicious) initiatives within the contemporary media landscape. On the other hand, however, having a grasp of the behavior of these structures – for example, what stories can benefit from a hubs-and-spokes dominated network, or when and where we should utilize the potential of keystone sites - all contribute to our success in designing powerful fictional or non-fictional narratives. It gives us a way to understand and take control of our culture. Of course, the methods, structures, and tools provided above cannot be regarded as absolute or final. The aim of this dissertation, and this chapter in particular, was to bring the argument to the forefront of narratology: we need to seek more advanced models of understanding if we wish to describe and comprehend the fast-moving storytelling landscape of our contemporary world.

6 CONCLUSION

The dissertation has traced the theoretical, methodological, and analytical pathways through which transmedia networks can be understood as complex narrative systems. Beginning from the premise that narrative has expanded into networked, participatory, and intermedial domains, this dissertation has examined how textuality, reader engagement, and multi-platform structures reshape the very conditions of storytelling. The combination of close reading, narratological modelling, and network analysis has sought to illuminate not only the mechanics of such works, but also the experiential and interpretive frameworks they invite.

Several interlinked findings emerge from this inquiry. First, transmedia networks cannot be adequately described solely by the logic of adaptation or media convergence; instead, they are best understood as dynamic configurations in which nodes, platforms, and audiences co-constitute narrative meaning. The analytical chapters have demonstrated that such configurations often resist linear causality, instead privileging distributed authorship, interpretive multiplicity, and the continual renegotiation of storyworld coherence. These qualities place transmedia works in productive tension with traditional narrative theory, demanding methodological approaches that can address both the structural and the performative dimensions of networked storytelling.

Second, the reader's role – whether as reader, player, or co-creator – is not a fixed category but a mutable position within the network. Across the case studies, the audience's interpretive labor emerges as a primary driver of narrative expansion, with meaning being constructed through iterative encounters with dispersed textual units. The adoption of reader-response theory, phenomenological perspectives on inter-medial reception, and ludological attention to player-agency has underscored how narrative in transmedia contexts is as much an event, a performative phenomenon, as it is a text.

Third, the network perspective enables the mapping of narrative not simply as a sequence, but as an ecosystem. This view foregrounds the interplay of narrative nodes, thematic motifs, and recipient practices, revealing patterns that might otherwise remain obscured in linear analysis. By visualizing and quantifying these relationships, this study has provided a model for integrating computational and qualitative methodologies in transmedia research – an approach that remains underdeveloped in the current state of the field.

The implications of these findings extend beyond the specific works analyzed. As narrative practices continue to evolve in increasingly hybridized media environments, the theoretical and methodological frameworks developed here can be adapted to other domains, including participatory culture, social media storytelling, and emergent forms of interactive performance. Such adaptability is vital in a media landscape characterized by rapid technological change and shifting audience expectations.

Ultimately, this dissertation has argued for the value of narratology as a dynamic, evolving field. One capable of engaging with the complex, fuzzy realities of transmedia networks without reducing them to either romanticized creativity or pure data flows. The challenge ahead lies in sustaining (and institutionalizing) this dialogue between theory and practice, between narrative's long history and its unfolding futures.

In conclusion, transmedia networks invite us to rethink the fundamental premises of narrative theory: what a story is, where it begins and ends, and who has the authority to tell it. They remind us that stories are not merely told – they are enacted, shared, remixed, and lived. By recognizing and analyzing these processes, we gain not only a richer understanding of contemporary storytelling but also a deeper appreciation for the collaborative imagination that sustains it.

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